

Psych 410 Maps of Meaning

Numbered Transcript

PSYC 410 • Dr. Jordan B. Peterson

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Lecture 1: What Is, What Should Be

At a glance — Peterson contrasts the two fundamental ways of seeing the world: what is, and what should be.

- 1.1 So it turns out that there are two fundamental ways of looking at the world. And in the modern Western world, we've decided that one of them is primary, and I think we picked the wrong one. So what are the two ways of looking at the world? You can think about what the world is made of. Say, you can think about that from the perspective of experience, or as a materialist, you can think about what the world is made of, or you can think about how to act in the world.
- 1.2 And since you're alive, figuring out how to act in the world is arguably of primary importance and perhaps of primary reality. Now, action is more than how you navigate in the world, moving, let's say, because your perception is also action-predicated. So, for example, when you look at the world to find out what it is, you have to direct your attention. And that happens many ways.
- 1.3 It happens unconsciously. There's all sorts of mechanisms in your visual system, from your eyes back into the neurological systems that control vision, that are moving your eyes constantly. When you look at something, you're not a passive observer; you're an active observer. There's no perception without action. There's no primary sense data about what the world is without action. You're locked in a framework of action, even at the level of attention.
- 1.4 Now, you know this to some degree. If you're in a restaurant even, forget about vision, well, if you're in a restaurant and you're sitting with your guests, you pay attention to them, perhaps the waiter and the waitress, and not the rest of the people in the café, generally speaking, unless something strange happens. There's many things you could look at, but you direct your attention to what? To what's of import. So, you're focusing always on what's relevant and what commands center stage. And so, the question is, what commands center stage, and why?
- 1.5 Now, in order to act in the world and to attend to the world, you have to frame your perception. And the reason you have to frame your perception is because there's an indefinite number of things to attend to. So, if you were painting this wall, let's say, if that's a great choice. Perhaps it's not. This is a very featureless wall. Although if you attended to it very carefully, you'd see that there were gradations of shade and light and color.
- 1.6 If you were going to be a photorealist who is attending to anything in this room, a photorealist painting, you'd find out that, although it's easy to consider the curtains behind us, black, for example, that there would be a very large number of color variations. There's an infinite amount of detail around you. There's an infinite amount

of detail in a face, in an array of faces, in a crowd, in a place. You drown in detail. You have to focus your attention.

- 1.7 The question is, or a question is, what structure do you use to focus your attention, to sequence the actions that underlie your perceptions in relationship to a goal? That's a good way of thinking about it. So what I've got here first is a simple frame of perception. It consists of three parts. Wherever you are, you have a sense of where you are. You're situated somewhere because you're a navigating creature. You're headed somewhere as well. And then you have to strategize and organize your attention and your action in order to move you from the place you're at to the place that you're going.
- 1.8 Now, the framework that you use to evaluate your attention and action has that structure. So, who's figured that out? Cybernetic theorists, starting with Norbert Wiener back in the 1940s. He worked on missile control systems in World War II. He was a founder of computation. And if you're trying to shoot down a missile, you have a beginning place. You have a trajectory of the missile; you have a predicted trajectory. You have to organize the machinery so that it decreases the gap between the projectile and the target, till the target is hit. That's a cybernetic viewpoint.
- 1.9 Phenomenologists, phenomenologists, starting with Husserl and then Heidegger, two famous philosophers. Husserl, in particular, at least to begin with, was unhappy with the materialist, reductionist, atheist view of reality. And he hypothesized that our fundamental sense of what was most real had gone astray, especially after the dawn of the scientific revolution, with its concentration on its insistence that the material substructure was the most real phenomena.
- 1.10 Phenomena means to shine forth. It's from the Greek word 'phainesthai'. So it means, in a way, what presents itself. The burning bush in the story of Exodus, that's a phenomena, something that grabs your attention, that captivates you or compels you to listen or watch or consider or follow or imitate. That's a phenomena.
- 1.11 As you make your way through the world, things shout out to you, command your attention, and make themselves relevant in relationship to your aims. So, if you're planning a pleasant interlude with a family member and they throw a curve ball into the affair, then that phenomenon stands forth in your field of experience as relevant and negative. And it's negative because it deviates you from your intended goal.
- 1.12 If you're out for a fight, you might be perfectly happy that something negative happened. So, that's a foreshadowing of something we'll talk about more deeply later. Emotion is experienced in relationship to a goal. Positive emotion indicates you're moving towards the goal. Negative emotion indicates that something has gone astray.
- 1.13 You can think about the cybernetic system that I described earlier. The anti-missile missile is unhappy as it deviates from the course. Your emotions are trajectory adjustment systems. Positive indicates forward movement and validates the frame of

perception, and negative emotion indicates deviation from the path or failure of the frame. OK, so keep that in mind.

- 1.14 Now, cybernetics, phenomenology. Perceptual psychologists began to sort this out in the 20th century as well, not least with the observation that there was no perception independent of action. Imagine that you're blind and you're using your fingers to put together a composite sensory picture of someone's face. That's exactly what you do with your eyes. Spot, spot, spot, spot, spot, composite.
- 1.15 There's a foreground that's fovea-dependent. The fovea is the center point of your eye. It's the high-resolution part of your vision. It requires much more neurological processing than the periphery. If your entire retina was foveal, you'd need a cortex that was many times larger to process it. You maximize the use of available neurological resource by pinpointing the fovea and intensely concentrating on the particular point of interest.
- 1.16 Around your fovea, which is very high resolution, the world becomes lower and lower and lower resolution until, out here, you're seeing in black and white, and back here, there's nothing, not even the sense of absence. So, center point focus on what's relevant and important in relationship to a goal, surrounded by a periphery that disappears into, what? Into, you could say, the void, if you're using poetic terminology. That'll be relevant as we start to understand the structure of stories. That's a cybernetic frame. It's a phenomenological frame.
- 1.17 Now, the phenomenologists, Husserl and Heidegger, redefined reality itself. And the reason they were doing that, there were two reasons. They were concerned that the divide between object and subject that had been set up as a consequence of the scientific and Enlightenment revolution prioritized the objective and left the subjective in a, what would you say? In an abyss of uncertainty and meaninglessness, in part because it was defined away; the subjective became epiphenomenological on a more fundamental reality.
- 1.18 Now, that's an existential problem because we can't live in a universe that's devoid of all meaning but suffering, let's say. And it's perverse because there's no perception without a subjective observer. And if you contemplate the situation scientifically, even, let's say, the basic sense data that the empiricists believe that the world is made of, is dependent for its existence on perception. And perception is dependent on action, and action is dependent on goal. Goal is dependent on value.
- 1.19 And so, the notion that there's some objective substrata of existence in the absence of a perceiver who's embedded in a world of value and meaning is not tenable, even from the scientific perspective, partly because we know that perception is action-predicated. Now, the phenomenologists tried to solve that subject-object-divide problem and the nihilism or valuelessness that emerges in the scientific worldview by prioritizing not objective reality, but experience as such.

- 1.20** So, you're sitting in this lecture theater. You have a focus of attention. That's why it's a theater. It's built to hint to you, when you make your entrance, how you're supposed to conduct yourself. The chairs are all facing in a particular direction. They converge on a point. The point is the point of the lecture. The point is the point of your attention. The point is the goal of your attention.
- 1.21** That all organizes your perceptions. It foregrounds some things, at least in principle, when you're not thinking or distracted, what I'm saying or the slides that I'm using. And that renders everything else increasingly irrelevant as it diverges from the central point. And so, there's a foreground.
- 1.22** Generally, when you're interacting with someone, the foreground of your attention is their face, and even more specifically, their eyes, and even more specifically, their pupils. And you do that so you can see what they're pointing to because you can tell what they're interested in. You can tell what they're compelled by. You can read emotions through the eyes. Our eyes are adapted. Evolution has adapted our eyes to make them maximally visible, colored black against a white background, so that when we interact with people, we can see what their point is.
- 1.23** Having seen their point, we can inhabit their frame of reference. We can infer what's meaningful to them. We can adopt their emotions. We can mimic those emotions on our own body, and that's how we understand them. Our face is a value display system, right? And when you're concentrating on someone, you almost always look at their eyes. We're very, very good at that.
- 1.24** Even from a distance, you can detect small deviations in someone's eye gaze direction because understanding the object of their intention and attention is the most important thing you can derive. You're focused here on what I'm saying. You're watching my face. You're watching my eyes. The world constructs itself around that.
- 1.25** Husserl's fundamental point was that all perception is intentional. It's associated with a goal. It moves towards a point. And that point is related to the insistence that I put forward at the beginning, that our perception is action-oriented, that our problem is navigation. How do we get from point A to point B, from what is currently to what should be? We're always somewhere, moving somewhere else.
- 1.26** And then there's a gradient, which is why, in this diagram, there's a slant upward. What's the gradient? Well, if you're aiming up, the gradient is upward, the gradient is uphill, the gradient is from a lesser place to a greater place. Why would you move from what is to what should be, if the place you're headed to wasn't better than the place you're at, assuming that you're not engaged in some form of counterproductive self-destruction?
- 1.27** So there's a value gradient in perception itself that sets up the landscape for a motion. If you're moving from point A to point B, the value of the movement is the distance between the two points in relationship to upward aim. Now, the longer the distance,

the harder the journey. So, that's an energy expenditure problem. You want to foreground a goal that's valuable in relationship to where you are, that doesn't require more energy than you have at hand. Now, you can sequence goals, and we'll get to that.

- 1.28** OK. What's this frame? It's a cybernetic frame. So, cybernetic pioneers and many of the developers of computational systems, especially the robotics engineers who started to understand that you couldn't do robotics computation without embodiment, the phenomenologists, the psychologists of perception, have all converged on a notion that we inhabit a frame of perception that organizes the world around us, that has a goal in mind.
- 1.29** The last thing you need to know about that to begin with is, that's the story. That's a story. So, the postmodernists insisted that we inhabit a story. They dispensed with the notion that there was a central unifying story that was common to all places and all times, let's say. But they insisted, and correctly so, that even the scientific enterprise is nested inside a story.
- 1.30** What's the scientific story? We're making things better. Otherwise, it's an evil scientist's story, and there's plenty of them, too. And we might say that the true science is the science that serves, what? Mankind, the good of mankind, and it's an upward journey—and that's not built into the scientific enterprise itself. It's the a priori frame that the scientist has to inhabit so that they aren't a threat. That's the case, you could say, for everything that you do. If any of your actions are predicated on an ultimately downward aim, then you're an agent of chaos. Right? At minimum.
- 1.31** A story. What's a story? A story is a description of a frame of perception. Now, if you think about this, when you go to a movie, think about what you're doing. So you see a sequence of subplots. And in the subplots, you see the characters in motion. You see them directing their attention. You infer their goals from their speech and their patterns of action. You put that together as a pastiche across multiple instances, and you draw your conclusions about the aim and direction of the character.
- 1.32** Having done that, you can adopt that frame. Having adopted the frame, you see the world through the perspective of the protagonist, and you experience his or her emotions. You do that to experiment with a frame of perception with no risk. Some emotional risk. There's enough enthusiastic impetus in the imitation so that, even if you're watching a horror movie that would expose you to phenomena that normally would be aversive, placing yourself in the fictional frame and experimenting with the exposure is sufficiently motivating in the positive direction so that you'll pay for the privilege.
- 1.33** Why is fiction so important? Why are we so compelled by stories? Because a story is a description of the manner in which we frame our perception, our attention, and our action. So, there's a viewpoint that makes the story not secondary, not laid upon

another more fundamental reality, but a priori. Now, there's obviously an interplay that has to occur between our understanding of how the world is constituted and how we should act in it. But the notion that there's a simple primacy of material being seems, at minimum, seems half true and rife with conceptual flaws.

- 1.34 The simplest frame, the simplest story. You ask a toddler, a kindergartener, "What did you do today?" "I went to school with Mom." Started at home. I went to school. That was the sequence. "I went to school with Mom and, on the way, a scary dog jumped at the fence and barked, and I got afraid. And we thought about going home, but we decided not to, and we continued forward."
- 1.35 That's a little hero's story. That's a disruption of the frame by an unexpected event, and then its reconfiguration, even at a higher level, because the kindergartener in that instance, in principle, discovers a courage to move forward into the unknown that he didn't know he had. Right. That's a micro-hero narrative. And that's a variation on the basic frame.
- 1.36 The simplest story is, "I was here, I went there, and this is how I did it." A more complex story is, "I was here, I was going there, and the bottom fell out. And then I went somewhere else and put myself back together, and I got a new frame, and away I went." Right, and that's a story about how a story transforms. That's a meta story. And most great, all great stories are meta stories. OK.
- 1.37 So, here's a more behaviorist version of the same idea of frame. What is subtitled? The unbearable present. Why? Because now isn't good enough. Because if it was, you wouldn't be doing anything. You're always—this is the phenomenological, the philosophers, the phenomenological insistence that your experience of the world is pitched always towards the goal of your attention and action, that that imbues the frame of your experience with significance.
- 1.38 You can imagine sitting, not doing anything, imagining, which is a form of action, running variant possibilities through your mind, experimenting with a sequence of different aims, evaluating the manner in which the emotional landscape shifts as you portray different fictional outcomes in an attempt to experiment with determining what course you should chart before you implement it in the real world. That's a dream. That's what dreams do.
- 1.39 The more radical and improbable and incomprehensible dreams shift the elements of your framework of perception so dramatically that you can't necessarily explicitly understand the transformation. We'll talk more about that. You start at what is, with its insufficiency. You move towards what should be. That's the value proposition. Why expend energy if the goal doesn't have value? If you expend energy towards goals that have no value, you die.
- 1.40 Honeybees, when they go out and find a flower bed, they come back and they signal to the other bees the navigation pathway to the flower bed, indicating, by their level of

enthusiastic movement, the richness of the store of value. That's exactly what people do when they get excited when they tell you a story. They signal by their willingness to expend energy in the telling that the destination is worth the effort. That's a stable means of representing value, treasure, all the way from insects to human beings.

- 1.41 If you see a speaker who's pouring out energy in the exposition of their story, then you understand that they believe that the destination is worth the investment of energy. And that's compelling to you because your proposition would be, how could he possibly continue to expend energy if the destination wasn't of sufficient value? So that's why enthusiasm, which is positive emotion, and also the state of being possessed by the divine, "en theos", is enthusiastic.
- 1.42 Which would imply that the ultimate goal is the goal that fills you with enthusiasm. Which is a way, actually, of determining, within the confines of your own framework of experience, what it is that has intrinsic meaning to you. Because if you posit a goal, you see a goal, a possible future, and you frame your perception in a manner that produces no forward-moving impulse, which is positive emotion, then you have no heart for the adventure.
- 1.43 One of the ways that you investigate the structure of your own psyche or your own unconscious or your own being or being itself is by evaluating frames that switch goals until your emotions signify to you that the pathway is worth walking down. Now, it's more complicated than mere acquisition. There's going to be some risk along the way, which you want. You want that risk because you want to pick a goal that not only provides you with something that you recognize deeply as significant, but that transforms you as you pursue it, so that your capability to posit and pursue better goals increases.
- 1.44 That's what you do when you play. You don't want it easy. You don't want it impossible. You want it challenging. You want it adventurous. You want it difficult. How difficult? That's what you're to determine. As difficult as possible while maintaining maximal enthusiasm. That's what children do when they play. That's what you do when you're playing. That's what you do when you engage in a game.
- 1.45 If you're proficient at generating frames of play or story, then you maximize enthusiasm and developmental transformation simultaneously. That's a good deal. That means that you're playing a game that's worthwhile, that gets better as you play it. Right. That's an upward, that's a Jacob's ladder, by the way. That's a stairway to heaven. Right, exactly. That's a stairway to heaven. A spiral upward that moves into the ineffable good, that communicates with the Earth, that lays out a pathway upward.
- 1.46 And your nervous system itself is tuned— this is an indication of the fundamental reality of these frames your nervous system itself is tuned so that what you experience within that frame of reference, when it's optimized, is meaningful motivation.

- 1.47** Right, now, let's think about this scientifically. How would have you evolved the capacity to specify a pathway forward, emotionally and motivationally, so biologically, if that wasn't real, right? If reality is what selects from among the variations that compose life, and reality has selected us to have an experience of deep meaning when we encounter the pathway that leads us upward and transforms us, how is that not real? Right.
- 1.48** Simple story. "I was here, I did this." What is, what does it mean to do? It means fundamentally to move, right? That's where the rubber hits the road. Words make their embodiment in action. And so, you can set a frame abstractly, but you act it out. And when you're acting it out, it's not abstract anymore, right? Because this is a solution in part to the mind-body problem. You can formulate the frame and the goal abstractly, but when you implement it, you're moving. The movement, that's not abstract.
- 1.49** So consciousness, abstracted consciousness, grounds itself in embodied movement. That's the incarnation of the spirit in the corporeal world. That's a way to think about it poetically or religiously. You take your abstract conception of the good, or depending on what you're pursuing, and you bring that down and that's the breath of the spirit by God into man. That's a symbolic representation of that, or the idea of incarnation, that's the same thing. Your goal, your frame, is an active agent. You could think about it as a spirit. You bring that spirit down to Earth and embody it. And that's how consciousness transforms itself into action.
- 1.50** You can infer the abstracted goal of a character by watching their action. What's he up to? I'll watch him and see. I'll see how he directs his attention. I'll see towards what he moves or what he avoids. And then I'll—or what he thinks is relevant and what he thinks is irrelevant—I'll infer the frame. You do this to yourself, by the way, and this is something to understand. You have proximal knowledge only of your frame of reference.
- 1.51** You're here today, for example, so you deem that valuable. You put in the time and effort to come here. But why? Why are you here? And then you could tell me, and I could ask, well, "Why is that important to you?" And you could tell me that, and I could ask, "Why is that important to you?" And that will make a chain up to where you don't know how to answer the question. And that's where your conscious knowledge of your own aims and motivational structure disappear, the psychoanalysts would say, into the unconscious. It's into the implicit, right? And we'll describe how that works as we progress.
- 1.52** How is the frame framed? Well, psychologists study perception, attention, emotion, cognition, motivation. Psychologists had a proclivity to describe motivations as drives. And drive theory came from the behaviorists. The behaviorists believed that, attempted to demonstrate that, our actions, and the actions of animals, were deterministic chains of reflexes.

- 1.53** If you put your hand on a hot stove, you'll jerk it back. There's a feedback loop from your sensory nerves to the spine to your motor nerves. It's very fast because it's short. And if you encounter a particular noxious stimuli, one that would damage the receptive surfaces, that's a good definition of noxious, then you'll withdraw, which is an action, obviously, in the absence of any conscious intent and extremely rapidly.
- 1.54** The behaviorists tried to generate a model of motivation that chained reflexes together in increasingly complex manners to account for the kind of sophisticated behavior that animals were capable of, but ultimately failed. B.F. Skinner, who was an outstanding behaviorist, could train— he trained pigeons to direct guided missiles using photographs. And he essentially did that using a process that looked, in a sense, like reflex chaining.
- 1.55** If he was going to train a rat to climb a little ladder and then maybe walk across like another ladder that was horizontal and then down, he'd make the rats hungry first. He starved his laboratory animals to 75% of their normal weight so that they were maximally motivated by food. Then he would watch them. And when they moved around the cage and got close to the ladder, the base, he'd give them a food pellet. Then they'd start hanging around the bottom of the ladder.
- 1.56** Now and then, they'd put a paw up. Then he'd give them another food pellet. And pretty soon they were doing this. And then he could get them to climb up the ladder and to dance on top and to go down the other side. Behaviorists trained rats to run down runways. Let's call that reflex chaining. But then some smart behaviorist, and I don't remember who it was, tied the back legs of a rat up and put it on a cart, and it managed to go down the maze runway with no problem, even though it had never encountered that particular problem before.
- 1.57** Animals, human beings with sufficiently complex nervous systems, interact with the world in a manner that can't be accounted for by mere deterministic reflex chaining. Motivations are not drives. It's complicated. Now, I'll see if I can unpack it. What a motivation—hunger is amotivation. Thirst is a motivation. You can think about a motivation as independent as an emotion from an emotion.
- 1.58** There's overlap because emotion and motivation aren't exactly scientific categories right? They're folk categories. But for the purposes of our discussion, we'll define a motivation as an instinctual goal. That's a better way of thinking about it. So you're hungry. OK, you're working at home and you start to become hungry. You notice. How do you notice? Because a new story pops into your head. What's the story? It would be a good idea to go into the kitchen and find something to eat in the fridge.
- 1.59** And then that, as you become more hungry, that becomes more insistent. It attempts to take a grip of the perceptual structure within which you frame your attention, your action, and your emotions. You start thinking, "It would be a good idea to go get something to eat." That's a tag of positive emotion. It's starting to become, "My hunger

is starting to become unpleasant." So you can see there's a competition between the frame of reference that you're using, let's say, to organize your work and this emergent motivational state.

- 1.60 At some point, things switch. Are you in a deterministic state then? No, you're navigating under the influence of a biological system whose goal is to satiate your hunger. Is that deterministic? It has deterministic elements. The more ancient a motivational system is, the more it's associated with behavioral patterns that are, if not instinctual, at least very easy to learn.
- 1.61 Right, so you can imagine that the longer across evolutionary history a motivational state has existed—pain, for example—the more it comes equipped with a panoply of relatively at-hand behavioral and attentional mechanisms that it can put into play when it grips you.
- 1.62 A toddler is a sequence of motivational states, an unintegrated sequence of motivational states. What are some motivational states? Hunger, thirst, sexual excitation, pain, play. Those are some of the basic motivational states. Exploration, defensive rage, although anger is also arguably an emotion because you can feel it in relationship to a goal, but it can also signify a target. That's why motivations and emotions aren't exactly a clean category.
- 1.63 The older and more profound the motivation, the more ancient the neurological system that mediates it. Many of the fundamental motivational states that set goals are hypothalamic. The hypothalamus is a brain area that sits on top of the spinal cord and provides the first-order abstract integration of increasingly complex spinal reflexes. The hypothalamus mediates hunger, thirst, temperature, excretion, defensive aggression. That's one half, and the other half mediates exploration.
- 1.64 The hypothalamic system that mediates exploration is the root of the dopaminergic system. The dopaminergic system is the biochemical system that underlies positive emotion in relationship to a goal. That's how old it is. That's how old exploration is. Pain is in its own little world, as is anxiety. Those are also very primordial brain systems, but they're not hypothalamic.
- 1.65 So, this frame of perception is susceptible to grip by motivational forces. And it's useful. The frame, it's a cybernetic frame. It's a phenomenological frame. It's a perceptual frame. It's a story. It's also a spirit or personality. It's all of those things at the same time. Think about what you're like when you're angry. It's a complex system. It's simplified compared to what you're like in a state where you're not dominated by a singular motivation. But you have many options at hand when you're angry. And the world takes on a particular kind of phenomenological reality when you're angry. Things tilt very much in the negative direction.
- 1.66 For example, if you're arguing with someone that you hypothetically love, almost everything that will come to mind when you're angry is negative. And all the things that

you might hope to enjoy in a playful manner with them disappear in favor of dominance and defeat. The motivational state that grips your goal makes everything that interferes with it irrelevant, including your memories. And maybe you'll snap out of that, hopefully, and you'll think, "What the hell possessed me?" And that's a useful question.

- 1.67** Nietzsche, after he announced that God had died in the 1850s, suggested that the consequence of that high-order disintegration would be roughly threefold. Descent into nihilism, it's a kind of fragmentation. Proclivity to move to alternate totalizing belief systems, ideology. He was particularly concerned with potentially the rise of nationalism, but also with what eventually became communism. Or he thought we could create our own values.
- 1.68** The psychoanalysts came along and said, "What makes you so sure you can create your own values? You're not even the master in your own house." So you can think about yourself cycling through a sequence of possessions. That's very useful to ask yourself, "Just what is the nature of this spirit that possesses me?" And you can reduce it to a biological drive, but motivations aren't drives. They're sub-personalities.
- 1.69** And they have not only a viewpoint in terms of goal, in terms of how the world lays itself out, the whole phenomenological field, the story—they also have a history, social and biological. And they have a, what would you say? They have a mythic nature. Many archaic gods, Ares, Eros, are personifications of motivational states—Ares being, for example, the god of war.
- 1.70** Just like real-world mobsters are said to act like Hollywood mobsters, you, when you're angry, imitate the culturally patterned personality of anger that has called out to you to imitate in the course of your life, and that's what possesses you. A constellation of possession by negative motivational states, you could think of something that's approximating the demonic. Right. It's very useful to know that these things are alive with will.
- 1.71** "Every drive attempts to philosophize in its spirit." That's Nietzsche. Very smart. So it's not, I'm not angry in a driven way; I'm angry in an entire world-constructing manner. It transforms my perceptions. It transforms my goals. It transforms my patterns of attention. It changes my memories. It brings different words to the forefront. It brings different fantasies to the forefront. It lays out an entirely different world of options in front of me. And God only knows what it is at its base.
- 1.72** So the psychoanalysts came along, especially Jung, but Freud, to begin with, who noted our id. He was the formulator of the concept of id, right, that panoply of biological drives. Freud concentrated most on sex and aggression that had their proclivity to have their way with us, rather than the reverse, right? And so, can we create our own values? Try it and see.

- 1.73** So, that was Eve's temptation, which is a story we'll get back to, right in the Garden of Eden. God tells man and woman that they have full freedom to explore and use, except they're forbidden to incorporate the fruit of the knowledge of good and evil. The fruit of the knowledge of good and evil is the essence of the world of value. Eve falls prey to the temptation to make herself like God by creating the world of value that surrounds her.
- 1.74** And as that story was elaborated across the centuries, the spirit that tempted Eve to rebel against the intrinsic moral order and to establish her own was associated with Lucifer, who's the spirit of the overweening and prideful intellect, whose fundamental motivation is to usurp. Right. Follow the moral order. Find the moral order. Abide by the moral order. Do not create the moral order. Right. That's the fall. Pride goes before a fall.
- 1.75** The fall. Garden, chaos, reintegration. That's the biblical story. That's a meta-narrative. That's a hero story. That's a story about how a frame collapses and transforms. Right. Those are the stories that compel us most particularly. As we not only encounter obstacles to our goal-directed pursuit, we encounter obstacles that are so profound that they force us to transform our pursuit. Right, so, and out of that failure, you might say, which is not only a failure of strategy but a failure of frame, growth can make itself manifest. Death can make itself manifest, but so can growth.
- 1.76** Then the question is, how do you avoid the transformations that culminate in death and invite the transformations that culminate in growth? And how do you conceptualize your meta strategy so that that's your highest value? That's a good way of thinking about it. What should you pursue? How about a pathway that improves the probability that you will properly specify what you pursue? That's wisdom, right? There's a way of doing things, right?
- 1.77** So, no matter what you attempt in your life, if you push yourself while you're doing it so that you're challenged in an adventurous way, then you put yourself on the edge of development and you facilitate your vision and you increase the capacity of your intent. Right, and that's signified, once again, that's signified, as you would expect, by a sense of deep intrinsic meaning.
- 1.78** How could it be that the meaning that orients us could be anything but aligned with the process that compels us or invites us to develop? What sort of creatures would we be if our deepest instinct for enthusiastic orientation wasn't in line with the pattern that made us more than we are? We just fail. So, one of the advantages of the phenomenological view, the cybernetic view, the narrative view, is that it makes what matters, rather than matter, primary. Right, right.
- 1.79** Husserl. The world you inhabit is constituted by your goal. The world you inhabit, the world of experience that you inhabit, that's—now, Heidegger, after Husserl, Heidegger decided that, if the world of experience was intentional and there was nothing more

primary than the world of experience as it makes itself manifest in consciousness—so that's your experience— then there was no difference between experience and being itself. And that was Heidegger's transformation of Husserl's thought.

1.80 So, being, in the manner that we're going to use it, is, being is necessarily being towards an aim. The question then arises, what's the proper aim? The word sin— which is "hamartia" in Greek—means to miss the target, to miss the aim. It's misaligned aim. If the world is making itself manifest to you in a manner that's unacceptable with regards to the reality of the meaning that you're experiencing, then perhaps your aim is misaligned.

1.81 Then you confess that. You repent and you atone. Atone, at-one. You replace the misaligned aim with something higher. That's the developmental pathway. I slipped off. I made a mistake. Where did I make it? How can I rectify it? How can I use what I learned when I investigated my error to reconstitute my aim, so that the misalignment vanishes? Implying that there is an aim that's not misaligned. Right.

1.82 That's partly what we're going to investigate, is: how might you define an aim that's not misaligned? How would you put aims in sequence? How would you hierarchically arrange them? How would you construct a set of frames that extend optimally upward in a manner that improves as you implement them? More to that. That incorporates the future, your future. That incorporates other people in some harmony, so that you're not at odds with your future self or with the other people that you're cursed and fortunate to spend time with.

1.83 The psychophysicologists of motivation broke fundamental motivations into two rough categories. Self-maintenance: thermal regulation, thirst, hunger, elimination. And self-propagation: affiliative desire, because we're social beings, sexual desire. It's just a way of categorizing these underlying, what would you say?

1.84 It's like a society of subordinate, sometimes superordinate, personalities that have to be organized into a wise council and put in their proper place so that you can move forward in a manner that's upward, sustainable, and social. Very tight set of constraints. Very tight. Nothing arbitrary about it. Nothing relativistic about it. There's very few parameters that—there are very few solutions that fit that set of parameters.

1.85 Has to work for you so that you thrive. Has to work for you so that you thrive now and in the medium run and in the long run. It has to work for you now so that it works with the other people around you, so they thrive in the medium to long run. So you all do that together, so that it improves, so that you're enthusiastic, so that your negative emotions are properly regulated. A very tight set of constraints.

1.86 Children attain that, according to Jean Piaget, when they're playing. So that's a good thing to know with regard to your life. If you're doing something right, you're playing. Right, right. Fragile motivational state, an integrated motivational state, but one that signals the proper element of integration. And I already defined proper for people who

are thinking relativistically. It has to sustain itself in the medium to long run. That's life eternal, by the way. It has to improve as you play it. It has to incorporate other people. That's a hard set of constraints to manage.

- 1.87** That's what I think music models, by the way, that harmonious interplay of multiple patterns. You think about people dancing to music. You have the patterns that are laying themselves out. They're all harmoniously integrated. They're all moving towards an end. Everybody is aligning themselves with the harmony of multiplicity that the music represents. And that's a play. That's why we play music.
- 1.88** OK, back to the basic frame, the basic story, the ground of experience, the phenomenological reality, the cybernetic frame, and the manner in which we structure our perception. I'm going to elaborate on the nature of the frame, so that you can see what the constituent elements of the world are. And we'll start on the surface.
- 1.89** We're doing the same thing in the domain of experience that the materialists did in the material world when they took things apart to find out what they were made of at their micro levels. Well your experience has layers, it has depths, and it has elements. And one of the things that the phenomenologists did, the psychologists of perception, was to attempt to define the affordances, the relevant objects, rather than merely the objects, the relevant objects of your experiential world. That's the basic frame.
- 1.90** Point A, point B, the strategy for movement forward. It grounds out in action. So it's not an infinite regress. So that's a good thing to know. It stops being abstract when you act. And your action is the indication of what you believe. That's the basic frame—what is, what should be. That's the basic story when you describe it. The frame isn't a story. The story is the description of a frame. Right.
- 1.91** OK, so what do you see when you're moving from point A to point B? We know this, by the way. I'm doing my best to tell you things that I know are valid from a narrative and a mythological perspective and from a scientific perspective simultaneously. OK, so part of what I'm drawing on here, with this particular image, is work done by a man named J.J. Gibson, who wrote a book called *A Visual Approach to—An Ecological Approach to Visual Perception*.
- 1.92** He never defined himself as a phenomenologist or a cyberneticist, but it doesn't matter because the thinking is isomorphic. So, and his insights, especially with relationship to emotion, were elaborated by a neuropsychologist named Jeffrey Gray, another one named Jaak Panksepp, who were the greatest neuropsychologists of the last half of the 20th century, by a lot.
- 1.93** Gray integrated 1,800 scientific papers into his book. It's about a six-month read, this book, because you have to master psychopharmacology, brain anatomy, behavioral literature, and cybernetics to understand it. That's a hell of a task for one book, but it's deadly; it's a deadly book. And Jaak Panksepp— both of these men knew a lot about animal experimentation.

- 1.94 And the animal experimentalists who were behaviorists had an oversimplified, higher-order framework of interpretation. But man, they were good at nailing down the details of behavior and perception and aligning that with what we know about neurochemistry. That's all been quite nicely integrated. And so what I'm going to provide you with in the next few slides is all informed by that massive corpus of work.
- 1.95 OK, when you see, when you perceive, you do that in relationship to your aim, however momentary. That's, let's say, point B. How do you get from point A to point B? How did I get from point A to point B? The story, the framework of my perception. OK, if I want to walk to the chairs that are behind you, you people are now obstacles. You've switched your reality. And if I'm impelled by emergency to beeline to a destination immediately behind you, you're in my way. You're an obstacle. You're targeted with negative emotion.
- 1.96 You know that when you curse someone when you drive. Right? Everyone does that. And why? Because you experience emotion in relationship to a goal. And you do that in a pretty simple and heuristic manner. If you're busily going somewhere, and an old lady with a walker crosses the street, that's annoying. And you might think, well, "What the hell is wrong with you?", which is a good question. But the brute reality of the situation is that: if it's in your way, it causes negative emotion. If you can use it to move yourself forward, then it produces positive emotion.
- 1.97 So your emotions are calibrating systems, like the error-detection mechanisms on a cybernetic system, that tell you when you're on track and moving towards the goal and when you're deviating. That's a good way of thinking about how emotions work. And that also describes, to some degree, the danger of them, because if you're operating in a narrow frame of reference, something immediate, you can subordinate higher—I shouldn't treat you like an obstacle, no matter what. Well, no matter what.
- 1.98 If I'm rushing to the hospital to save my child, are you an obstacle? Well, that's a moral question, isn't it? How do you balance the realization of someone else as valuable in relationship to a higher-order goal, when you're pursuing a lower-order goal where they're an impediment? To understand that, we'll have to understand how stories are nested, which is something we haven't yet discussed.
- 1.99 What do you see in the world? This is so cool. What do you see in the world? So how does the world make itself manifest, phenomenologically? Aim, first, target, destination. Remember, we're hunting animals. We exist on a throwing platform. And that's age-old. That's been the case since we were bipedal. And so, we're great at targeting. We're great at cybernetic minimization of distance between the present reality and the goal. Our emotions arrange themselves around that.
- 1.100 And so, what do you see, phenomenologically? Pathways. That's the first thing. That's the storytale. That's the golden road. That's the Wizard of Oz. That's the adventure. That's the journey of the troop of the Lord of the Rings. That's the pathway forward. So

this is a good thing to think about. It's like: What do you have to aim at so that the pathway forward beckons? So this is how you consort with your soul. You ask yourself, "What do I have to aim at, so the pathway forward beckons?"

- 1.101** This is a negotiation, a dialectical negotiation. Remember in the Pinocchio movie, when Pinocchio's conscience first shows up. Jiminy Cricket, J.C., Jesus Christ. Jiminy Cricket was Southern US slang for Jesus Christ, J.C. Why would J.C. be a bug? Because some things bug you. They get under your skin, right? They irritate in a direction. And you can ignore that and you can suppress it, which is what Jonah did before he ended up in the belly of the whale, like Geppetto, by the way. You can suppress that or you can engage in a dialectic.
- 1.102** In the Pinocchio movie, Pinocchio engages in a dialectic with Jiminy Cricket. He starts out, the cricket, as a tramp with no home. And the first advice he gives is cliched and sloganeering. Slogan, from the Welsh, "sluagh-ghairm", battle cry of the dead.
- 1.103** When Jiminy Cricket shows up, he's generic. He's like an overbearing superego. He's not attuned to the specific realities of the time and place that the puppet who wishes to be free inhabits. He brings a collection of tried-and-true homilies that are shallow in consequence of their overuse to the initial dialogue.
- 1.104** But the puppet persona possessed, pulled by strings that aren't under his control and not real, engages in a dialogue with the conscience, and both transform. At the end of the movie, Pinocchio realizes himself, and the cricket ends up in a tuxedo replacing his tramp clothing, and he wears a star that's 24-karat gold that reflects the stars.

Lecture 2: Pathways and Obstacles

At a glance — Pathways and obstacles — the spiritual journey forward.

- 2.1 Pathway forward. What beckons? That's what you have to ask yourself. And that's a spiritual journey. It's like, you have to start from a perspective of humility, meaning you don't know who you are, seriously, just like you don't know who anyone else is. You really don't. And so you have to listen and you have to investigate and you have to negotiate.
- 2.2 It's like, well, what would make you satisfied? Do you want to be satisfied? Are you a person who wants to be satisfied? There's a question. That's a hard one. The clichéd answer is, "Obviously." The real answer is, "Seldomly." You have to orient yourself quite carefully to actually prioritize your own higher-order harmony and satisfaction. You have to be willing to subjugate virtually everything to that.
- 2.3 So are you easy to get along with for yourself? Probably not. That's the first question of conscience. Would you accept peace and abundance if it came your way? And the answer to that is, probably not. And that's worth some investigation, and to see what the obstacles in the pathway are. How are you your own stumbling block?
- 2.4 When Adam is thrown from the garden after the fall, he's cursed to toil. Life becomes work, and work becomes toil. And when does work become toil? How about when you're pursuing the wrong thing? How about, you're pursuing the wrong thing for the wrong reasons? How about, you're pursuing the wrong thing for the wrong reasons because you're a prideful usurper who has violated the moral order? How about that? That's how history begins in the biblical text. That's literally the fall into history. It's prideful pursuit of burdensome aim.
- 2.5 Right. So then you negotiate with yourself and think, "What would satisfy a creature like me, actually, if I admitted what I wanted, if I allowed myself to understand what actually impedes me, if I looked at my reality instead of my self-delusion?" Right. Just like trying to negotiate with someone you love, a marriage, a very close relationship. What do you want? Well, you have to listen. Just like you have to listen to yourself, you have to see where you're prompted.
- 2.6 How are you prompted? By enthusiasm. That's calling, by negative emotion, by anxiety, by pain. That's conscience. Conscience tells you when you're not on the optimal pathway forward. And calling invites you forward or transforms your aim. Right. Those are two manifestations of the divine, historically speaking. That's the pillar of light in the darkness and the pillar of darkness at night that guide the lost Israelites through the chaos in the desert, forward to the Promised Land. Conscience, the voice of negative emotion. Calling, the voice of positive emotion. If you listen, they align you, but you have to listen.

- 2.7** Pathways forward. An unimpeded pathway forward produces positive emotion, although that's complicated by the other factor we described, which is, you don't want too easy a route. Why? Because it doesn't compel development. So think about it. Think about a child playing one-on-one basketball. Who does he want for an opponent? Someone who never scores a basket or someone who's as good as him, that puts him on the edge of development, challenges him? Or maybe someone who's slightly better, so that he really has to work to win and can imitate to improve his skill?
- 2.8** So, if you're looking for a pathway forward, you want one that's optimally tilted upward so that the pathway not only gives you some reasonable probability of attaining the goal, but compels your development along the way. If you're a good mentor, that's the sort of goals that you set people. If I set you a goal that's trivial, you're going to feel insulted first because I have no faith in your developmental capacity and underestimate you. But there'll also be no challenge in it.
- 2.9** And that challenge, that meaning, it's not merely a matter of positive emotion, because you want some—imagine you make a rat hungry and you train it to run down a runway to get a piece of cheese. It's motivated by the knowledge of the goal to run for it. Now, imagine you take the same rat and you put it in its enclosure, and the goal is in front of it, and you use a ventilation system to introduce some cat odor. That rat makes a beeline down the runway much faster.
- 2.10** And so you might ask, well, how would you put yourself in a situation of optimal motivation? You could be running towards something extremely valuable, and you could be running away from something extremely terrible. And then that's a metaphysical landscape, because that's the metaphysical landscape of the abyss and the stellar, or hell and heaven. You want to be running away from something terrible towards something good, right. Optimally motivating.
- 2.11** So, pathways, tools. So when we see the world, we don't see objects. We see pathways, and we see objects of relevance, and the positive objects of relevance are tools. A chair. Is a chair an object? Is a stump a chair if it's at the right height? Well, the answer to that is, can you sit on it? Is a beanbag a chair? If you can sit on it. Do they share any features in common except relative size? Pretty much, no. They're defined by their functional utility.
- 2.12** So the things we see in the world are defined by their functional utility. I mean, the objects—we don't see objects. We see tools. We see pathways. We see obstacles. Tools, positive emotion. Obstacles, negative emotion. Pathways, depends on their gradient and their complexity. Pathways, tools, obstacles. There are social tools, friends and allies. So you could think about the material world, tools and obstacles. You could think about the social world, friends and foes. Same notion.
- 2.13** What's a friend? A compatriot, someone that you can walk down the same path with, someone you can be of mutual aid to, someone who shares your frame of reference

and your goals, someone who's playing the same game with you. If they're a good friend, you can play multiple games. That's how a child establishes a friendship. They play once, the game goes well, they make another date for play. If the recurrent play is productive and develops them, they have a friend. Right.

- 2.14 A friend is a tool for the acquisition of proximal goals, but also a compatriot in the adventure and a means of transformation across time, if that's a good friend. Foes, well, they're in your way. Pathways, tools, obstacles, friends, foes—agents of magical transformation. That's fun. What's an agent of magical transformation? How is their magic in fiction?
- 2.15 When you're playing a game, you're playing by a set of rules. That's what defines the game. You could think about those as principles. They're not exactly borders or boundaries or restrictions; they're enabling principles. When you're playing basketball, you can't play chess. And you might think about that as a limitation. But the rules of the game, which are enabling principles, allow the game to exist. So to think about rules as impediments is foolish. Although they have their boundaries, the rules are actually enabling principles.
- 2.16 You can conduct yourself radically different on the perceptual, emotional, attentional, and action front by conducting yourself according to different sets of principles. And then you could imagine that there are terrible games that no one wants to play. There are games that degenerate when you play them. There are games that people enjoy. There are games that improve as people play them and enjoy. There are games that improve as people play them and enjoy and incorporate more and more people. That's a very good game.
- 2.17 Now, imagine that those games are sequenced in a hierarchy of value. Poor games at the bottom, great games at the top. And that's stepped. And as you become a more accomplished and wise player, you play a better and better game. Imagine someone who's a good sport, who's a great athlete. Imagine someone who's a great athlete and a poor sport first. OK, so at one level, they're playing the game properly. They've mastered the skills. This is very common in athletics. It's like the basis of virtually every sports movie.
- 2.18 Some kid who's a hotshot, who's mastered the basics of the game, and who is perhaps head and shoulders above the rest of his team in terms of his raw ability, but he's terrible. And what does terrible mean? It's, everything's about him, except blame. And the blame is about everybody else. And does he do anything to facilitate the growth of his teammates? No, he just complains and carps when they either don't appreciate his stellar qualities or fail to deliver on command. And the wise coach comes along and says, "You're pretty damn talented, but you have a lot to learn."
- 2.19 And then, as the plot progresses, you see the narcissistic but highly skilled young person realize, often through a sequence of painful encounters— those would be self-

imposed obstacles—that there are higher-order games than mere victory in the moment and also than selfish self-aggrandizement, no matter the level of talent. That's a plot, obviously, a plot with character development. That's a feel-good movie.

- 2.20** Well, why? Because we like to see people transform upward, right? Because implicitly, if not explicitly, we believe that that's possible. And we hope, to the degree that we care for ourselves and for others, that that pathway exists and that we could walk it. And we go to that movie and we watch so that we can imitate it and learn. Right, and so the skill is important.
- 2.21** So that might mean that if you think about the hierarchy of games, the simplest level would be mere knowledge of the rules and then increasingly expert application of those rules until you're an expert player within the confines of a single game. But then there's a tournament of games, right? And then there's a tournament of games where you have to develop your teammates, and then there's a tournament of games where you have to develop your teammates in a manner that generalizes to other games.
- 2.22** And then there's the set of all those other games that you could generalize from, that you could apply to your life. Right. That's a hierarchy. That's Jacob's ladder, right? So if you're playing that highest-order game, where you play—every game you play, you play in a skilled manner as a good sport, such that you facilitate the development of yourself and people around you, such that people notice, and your reputation grows, and you're invited to play a never-ending sequence of games.
- 2.23** That's what you want for your child. And that's why you tell them, it doesn't matter whether you win or lose, even though it does. It matters how you play the game. Well, why? Because the game isn't the game. The game is the metagame, and you don't subordinate the metagame to the game. That's part of the divine order. You don't invert that because it makes you shallow and weak and prideful and a usurper. And that's a bad idea.
- 2.24** What's an agent of magical transformation? Someone who resets your aim. So you're in this game. That's your world, the principles that you abide by. But it's narrowing you. You've exhausted it as a place of potential. And maybe you know that because your soul aches. The enthusiasm is gone. The horizons are no longer wide enough. And someone comes along and says, "There's a better game afoot." Well, that's what happens in the Lord of the Rings. That's what happens in the Hobbit to Bilbo. Bilbo first. Frodo is in the Lord of the Rings, I believe. Bilbo in the Hobbit.
- 2.25** Bilbo. He's like Pinocchio. He's a little guy in an ordinary place. That's the Shire, right? It's bounded. It's a good place, but it's very isolated. There are great things going on in the outside world. Great battles of good and evil. But the Shire is protected. It's protected, by the way, by these Striders. Aragorn is one of them. Striders are camouflaged descendants of ancient kings who attend the boundaries, unbeknownst to the inhabitants within, the keepers of the tradition and the principles, that all that

naive stability depends on. Outside the realm of the boundary guardians is the realm of the battle of good and evil.

- 2.26** And Gandalf shows up to invite the hobbit to transform. Oddly, he becomes a thief first. Well, why? Because he's too— Nietzsche said, "Most of what people regard as morality is their own cowardice." There's a big difference between being too afraid to break the rules and being too good to break the rules. And if you're too afraid to break the rules, the best way to maintain any self-regard is to classify yourself as too good to break the rules. Highly improbable.
- 2.27** So, when the hobbit transforms, he transforms down in a way first. He breaks the frame of morality that defines his current state of being or his game. He expands his purview of accessible skills. He incorporates, from the Jungian perspective, he incorporates shadow elements. You want your aggression on your side. You don't want to sequester it off in isolation. You don't want to repress it in the Freudian sense. You want to bring it on board and put it in its place.
- 2.28** That's what Adam is called upon by God to do. Name and subdue everything in its proper place. Sexuality in its proper place, aggression in its proper place, rage in its proper place, everything in its proper place—in relationship to, well, to what? Well, that's what Gandalf, that's what Gandalf points at, right. Now, remember, the battle there is dragon and treasure. That's the oldest, that's really the oldest human story, the dragon-treasure narrative. We'll see why.
- 2.29** It's because there's opportunity wherever there's challenge. There's opportunity wherever there's danger. And you can take the stance of a prey animal and freeze, which is what the victims of the basilisk do in the second volume of the Harry Potter story. Remember, there's a great serpent that lives underneath the magic castle. And if you gaze upon it, then you freeze. Why? Because that's what a rabbit does when it sees a wolf. And what does the hero do? Breaks some rules to face the dragon in its lair, to transform.
- 2.30** In the phoenix story, it's the phoenix that comes along after Harry's wounded and revitalizes him as he frees Ginny. The dragon hoards virgins and gold. That's the age-old story. And the phoenix dies and is reborn and is the avatar of that spirit, and that's a death and resurrection story. And that's a consequence of one game disintegrating and being replaced by another. And that pattern is the death and resurrection pattern.
- 2.31** Things fall apart and then they reconstitute. Things fall apart and then they reconstitute. Hopefully, they reconstitute at a higher and higher level with each collapse. Well, otherwise the collapse can be a spiral downward. That's a trip to Dante's Inferno.
- 2.32** There are positive agents of transformation. The degree to which they're magical is proportionate to the distance from your current game. So, if there are higher-order

agents of magical transformation, you don't understand them at all. And they might be utterly terrifying because their mode of world construal violates all of your principles.

- 2.33** It's very difficult to distinguish between a savior and an enemy because of the degree of radical transformation that's required. And so, that's why all the hobbits in the Shire, and Bilbo, too, are terrified of Gandalf. He's respected and admired, but the respectable people, they're not so sure what to do with them. It's because they've already pridefully defined the proximal space that they inhabit as the pinnacle of moral virtue. That's what keeps them little.
- 2.34** So, pathways, tools, obstacles, friends, foes, agents of magical transformation—that's pretty much the world. That's the world of conscious experience. And it's very useful to—and then in terms of agents of magical transformation, let's look at a couple here. We've got, well, that's Galadriel. And so, they come in male and female versions.
- 2.35** And then there's downward agents of magical transformation, too. And those are, you could call them messengers of the abyss or messengers of hell. And they put forward a temptation to play a downward game. And there's no limit to the upward game because it ascends into the heavenly, the ineffable. And there's no limit to the downward game because hell is a bottomless pit.
- 2.36** Remember, and you may remember, you may know, story of Jacob's ladder. Jacob is a very bad man in the biblical account. He's a reprobate. He's too close to his mother. He betrays his brother. He betrays his father, eventually so badly that his brother determines to kill him. Jacob leaves and, on his way to visit his uncle to start a new life, and on the way, he vows to do better. And he builds an altar aiming upward, and he makes a sacrifice to indicate that he's willing to let go of the things that are impediments to his progress.
- 2.37** And he falls asleep, and he has a dream of a ladder cycling upward that has angels descending upon it from heaven to earth with God at the pinnacle, but not visible. That's the ultimate upward aim that recedes as you move towards it. And that's the upward pathway to the heavenly city on the hill that requires diligent sacrifice or work.
- 2.38** Dante's Inferno, that story of a descent into hell, is a poetic representation of a journey through the realms of experience defined by misaligned aim, hierarchically sequenced. Dante put Satan at the core of the inferno, frozen in place, immovable, consequence of overweening pride, surrounded by those who betray, the worst sin in Dante's estimation, because betrayers invert love. Right?
- 2.39** So, agents of downward transformation tempt towards the abyss, and they're magical agents as well. And they might offer power, or they might offer pleasure. And that's also an insubordination, because if power is dominance, and dominance is associated with aggression, it has its place. Integrated aggression makes you implacable and immovable and a force to be reckoned with.

- 2.40 But aggression serving power, when power is elevated to the highest place, that makes you—what did Lucifer say in *Paradise Lost*? "Better to rule over hell than to serve in heaven." Yeah, well, the biggest devil in hell is the worst loser. Right, and so power games are a very bad idea. But that's the temptation.
- 2.41 When Christ is tempted in the desert after his baptism, 40 days in the desert, the spirit of Satan comes to him with three temptations— to be given what he doesn't deserve, to be saved from what he does deserve, and to rule the world with power. All misaligned and inverted aims. So, that's an agent of magical transformation in the negative direction, once you know that that means the reconfiguration of aim downward. So the frame of reference shifts and changes. You play a worse game.
- 2.42 And so that's the landscape of good and evil—a sequence of games, you could say, stretching from hell to heaven. And that's a ladder that—I've seen people. Douglas Murray. You know Douglas Murray? He's been in many war zones now and has seen some terrible atrocities. And his conclusion from that was that there is great evil in the world. And the inevitable conclusion that you draw from understanding that there's great evil in the world is that the opposite of that obviously exists, at least insofar as whatever the greatest good is, as far away from that as you can get.
- 2.43 Right? And so that's, I suppose, some advantage to the encounter with the dragon in its darker forms, is that once you're convinced of the reality of evil, then you're alert to the possibility of good and maybe motivated to pursue it. Yeah. That's a form of harrowing of hell, I suppose.
- 2.44 Back to the frame. What is and what should be? How we should act. That's a value frame, right? How we should act. Well, it's defined in relationship to the aim, obviously. Should is what moves you forward towards the aim. A bigger question on the value front is, what then might the aim be? And we'll answer that to some degree. We have investigated that to some degree. We'll answer it a bit in more detail now.
- 2.45 OK, so let's take a look at the structure of this frame. We talked about tools, obstacles, friends, foes, pathways, agents of magical transformation. OK, so that's one way of looking at it from a perceptual perspective. That's what you see; that's what you experience. Let's look at it from an emotional perspective. OK, so what is is insufficient. It's got a neutral or negative tone. You want to improve it. It's least defined as negative in relationship to the destination. There's a polarity there, and that polarity is really what gives you your impetus to move forward.
- 2.46 You want to optimize that polarity. If you have a little kid, you don't give them a task that they can't do, and you don't give them one that's too easy. You set the bar in the proper manner. This is something you really want to learn to do with yourself. It's like, if you find you're not doing something, one thing you can do is set the bar slightly lower. Because you can play and see, OK, here's the thing I'm planning to do, but I'm not doing it.

- 2.47** What if I aim to doing half of it? Then you can see, will I do it? If the answer is no, well, try a quarter. And maybe you'll see that you'll get some forward movement. And what that means is, you've now met yourself where you actually are. Now, it may be that the aim is wrong, and that's a different issue. But I wouldn't draw that conclusion immediately. If you set up a frame, you might as well play within it and see how you can adjust it in accordance with what you need before making the radical move of shifting the aim.
- 2.48** If you can't adjust the aim so that you will move forward, well, then you have to take the more revolutionary move of reconfiguring the aim. But this is an element of behavioral therapy. If you're trying to help someone progress, you define the direction of progression, usually dialectically. What the hell do you want? What do you think might be a pathway out of this problem, now that maybe we've conceptualized the problem?
- 2.49** Hypothetically, if you were playing, what do you think might constitute some improvement? So then you define it. I say, well, go back for a week and just try that out. Here's some tasks. You don't impose the tasks as the interlocutor, as the investigator. You negotiate them. What about trying this? Come back in a week and tell me what happened. You come back and you say, "Well, that was easy. I did it right away." It's like, "Great. We probably didn't set the bar quite high enough, but congratulations."
- 2.50** Or you come back and say, "I did nothing." It's like, "OK, maybe we construed the problem wrong or the solution. But maybe you asked too much of yourself." "Well, it wasn't much. I was going to clean up my room. I didn't do it." Well, this is maybe someone who hasn't done it for 15 years. It's like, "OK, organize a drawer. See if you can do that. If you can't do that, organize half a drawer."
- 2.51** Usually what you'll see is that, in the Pinocchio movie, when Pinocchio goes to the depths, he encounters this whale, Monstro, that lives at the bottom of the abyss. And the first time he sees the whale, he turns tail and runs. That's a very common mythological trope. It's the flight of the hero at first sight of the chaos of the villain, because the magnitude of the task is greater than it appears.
- 2.52** And Pinocchio turns around, guided by his conscience, and eventually determines to face the fire-breathing whale. It's a fire-breathing whale. It's obviously a dragon, fire-breathing whale. And he goes into the depths and finds his father and revivifies him. He brings the tradition back to life by going down into the depths.
- 2.53** When someone is first about to embark on a minor task, but that minor task signifies a transition from descent to ascent, then it's a revolutionary move, even if it's small. And so, if you're aiming up and that's new, and you might take flight at the fact that you've determined to aim up and the weight that that places on you, and find that you're impeded even in your ability to do something small because it's not small.

- 2.54 And I had clients who lived in their high school bedroom till they were 45 and hadn't cleaned it up in 30 years, and that's not a small problem. And so even when we decided to turn it around just ever so slightly, the surface of the problem was, let's make some organization in your junk drawer. But the essence of the problem is, just how much has your mother been doing for you for the last 45 years? And just exactly why? And just exactly why did you go along with that? And what are you going to do about the fact that that's four and a half decades?
- 2.55 Right. So that's what you're confronting behind the façade of the—I had a client who I was introducing to an elevator. She had agrophobia. Agrophobics don't like elevators because they're trapped. And when they're trapped, they can't get to a hospital. And if they have a heart attack in the elevator when they're trapped, then they die. And if there's other people in the elevator when they're trapped while they're dying of a heart attack, then they make a fool of themselves while they die. And that's shameful.
- 2.56 So the elevator isn't an elevator. It's a place of confinement, death, and humiliation. And when I had my client in front of the elevator doors, and they opened, she said, "That's a tomb." And that was so interesting because you could see the, got a glimpse behind the veil. It's like, why would you be afraid of an elevator? It's like, you can die anywhere. And you can die a humiliating death in panic anywhere. And an elevator is as good a place as any.
- 2.57 And you don't know that, when you're going on to an elevator, you're bravely confronting death. But you would learn that if you stopped being able to do it. Right, and so then you teach the person that, even though that's what they think, they can still move forward. Then they get a lot braver. Yeah. So, OK. Tools, obstacles, friends, foes, pathways, magical agents of transformation. Let's abstract that a little bit away from character.
- 2.58 What do you see in the world? Where you are, where you're going. What happens when you move forward? You act. What are the possibilities? Things you predict. OK, what does it mean to be able to predict something? It means that the way that you're perceiving the world puts the world in alignment with your aims. You go out, you start your car, and it starts. Great. That's a predicted outcome. Or maybe you go out and you start your car, and it grinds to a halt.
- 2.59 Or maybe you're driving on the freeway, and the car ceases to function on a very busy highway. And you're not that popular at work, and one more late arrival with a halfwit excuse and that's the end of your job. It's a rattrap of an old vehicle, and you're, like, 35, and you're thinking, "What the hell is wrong with this car?" And that's a big question because why do you have that car, exactly? And why is it such a rattletrap? And maybe you hate your job, and it's pretty damn convenient that the car has breathed its last gasp.

- 2.60 And what's the problem with the car? Well, that's another one of those situations where the car is just the proximal covering for a slew of problems. Maybe if you had your act together, you'd have a car that actually worked. And maybe you're old enough so that you should have one. And then maybe you'd have a job. Then maybe your wife wouldn't have left you. Maybe your kids would still see you. Maybe you wouldn't be in hell regularly. And that's what the hell is wrong with your car.
- 2.61 And so, that's that layered structure that's underneath everything. Everything. That's why, so often when you're arguing with someone you love, some trivial thing will come up. And then things explode around. It's because that trivial thing is an indicator of unplumbed depths below the surface that go all the way down, often to a betrayal. And untangling that is one brutal journey.
- 2.62 If you do it, you can redeem the dead, so to speak. You can revivify your relationship; you can maybe solve the problem. But it's definitely a trip downward to the bottom, which is extremely demanding. And then, with any luck, an emergence on more solid ground.
- 2.63 Moving forward, you have a predicted outcome. Well, if you've laid out the plan, you encounter the tools, the pathway forward and the tools that will move you to your destination. You're predicting that. It's like the definition of a good plan. A good plan is one that gets you to your destination in a predictable way.
- 2.64 OK, you can encounter obstacles, and then you can imagine obstacles of different sorts. There's obstacles you understand. If I'm walking there, you're in the way, that's pretty easy. I just do that. I don't have to change my frame of reference, except in a micro way, and I can continue merrily on my path.
- 2.65 The gentleman we talked about earlier, whose car breaks down on the side of the road and who no longer has a job, that's a lot bigger obstacle. That's an unpredicted event. You could think about an unpredicted event, like a radically unpredicted event, as a hole in your plan that you fall—that's the rabbit hole that Alice falls down. That's a rabbit hole. It's like, oh, there's some things that are going on in the world that I didn't take into account. And it's down the rabbit hole we go. And God only knows what we're going to discover there.
- 2.66 Like the gentleman who has to figure out why he's 35 and has a car that doesn't work. It's like, he could probably spend a year thinking about that and rectifying what every single micro decision he made in the last 30 years that led him to that point. And that's a dragon. All those little biting reptiles of past failures that aggregate into a monster that comes flinging forth or springing forth and devours. That's an ancient story as well. I'll tell you a story like that as we progress.
- 2.67 What happens when you encounter something unexpected? Well, it sets you back. It stops you in your tracks. Why? Well, you have to recalibrate your strategy, right? That's a trivial problem. Maybe you have to recalibrate your aim. That means everything's up

in the air. Maybe you have to recalibrate your aim at a deep level. That's even worse, because the game you're playing depends on other games, and it's nested in even higher order games.

- 2.68** And maybe you're not wrong in a trivial way that means you can just dance out of the oncoming traffic, let's say, but that you really have to reconfigure every bloody thing, not only that you experience emotionally and conceptually, but even that you perceive. Right. So, look out.
- 2.69** And this is also why people fall prey to willful blindness. They don't want to look. They don't want to look. "There are none so blind as those who will not see." It's no wonder. It's no wonder. And the more you're willfully blind in the face of the unexpected, the bigger the monster you won't look at gets. Right? Brutal, brutal. Then it comes leaping out at a moment's notice when you're least prepared, and that's the end of you.
- 2.70** Unpredicted outcome. What happens emotionally? If I see an obstacle, it's frustrating. It produces negative emotion. It can produce anger, can produce anxiety, all those emotions. The negative emotions all cluster. Novelty also produces negative emotion. And it's proportionate. The negative emotion novelty produces is proportionate to the number of rule games it violates. So if it just blows the game into bits, then it's terrifying. If it violates one presupposition, well, then it's less intimidating.
- 2.71** But it can be—an anomaly can be an agent of magical transformation. In fact, that's what an anomaly is, a novelty, something unexpected. It's an agent of magical transformation. It's going to force you to change. It's a dragon and a treasure at the same time. It's a dragon because who the hell knows where you are? You thought you were somewhere; you're not there. And where are you? You don't know. Maybe you're somewhere better, if you could conduct yourself properly. So it's reasonable to take stock.
- 2.72** That's a stumbling block. I tripped over this. Well, what is it? Is it an impediment? Or is it a portal to somewhere new? It can be either. It can be both. It produces a mix of emotions. Fear freezes, but it also elicits curiosity. Now, those usually work; it depends on the magnitude of the novelty, as I said. If it's just a minor novelty, mostly what it elicits is curiosity. If it's a medium-sized novelty, then it freezes you first.
- 2.73** This is what an animal does; it freezes. And then it waits. Maybe it'll move its eyes and maybe it'll sniff, and it's detecting to see what implications the unexpected thing happened. And if nothing else happens, it'll unfreeze and it'll start to explore. And so, and that means that the emotion has turned from anxiety mediation to dopaminergically-mediated exploration. And so, that's a dragon in a treasure, in conjunction. And so, down the rabbit hole to explore. That's the realm of the novel.
- 2.74** The novel—this is so interesting—the novel is everything you didn't take into account in your game. So you play a game and it defines a little world. And as long as the game is going well, you can stay within that little bounded world. It's a walled garden, that

bounded world of the game. But the world isn't a basketball game, even if you're a professional basketball player. And the game, if you're a professional, the game can be dominant enough so that you make your living with it. But there's a whole world outside the game.

- 2.75 Now and then, the world comes crashing into the game. That's the serpent in the Garden of Eden, by the way. That's the world come crashing into everything that's bounded. It's always there. No gardens without serpents. Why? Because you can't exclude everything. You lay out your game, you lay out your perceptual frame, but all the things you ignore, they're still there. And now and then, they come crashing through. And then you have to take them into account.
- 2.76 And that can be a good thing if it ups your game. But it can be a cataclysmic thing, especially if you're not prepared for it, if you haven't practiced it. You want to practice. That's why it's so important for children to practice losing. You have to develop resilience. You have to be able to take the punches. You have to be able to roll with them and keep going and persevere in the face of obstacle and difficulty. You have to explore because you want to win the metagame, not just the game.
- 2.77 And you can lose 50 times and then win, and you win. That's the story of most entrepreneurs who are hyper-successful. Many entrepreneurs, they fail multiple times before they succeed. And so, you need that ability to dance with what's novel, and to have faith in your ability to persevere when something new comes your way, and to understand that there are games outside the game that you're playing and that this obstacle might be a portal to a better game, especially if you conducted yourself properly.
- 2.78 Now, part of that proper conduct is voluntary exposure. So this is what you do in behavior therapy to people who have anxiety disorders. You identify what they're afraid of and avoid, and you encourage them to adopt an exploratory stance towards them. And they become expert at the exploratory stance. And that doesn't make them less afraid; it makes them braver. And so then they can prevail in the face of their anxiety because now they understand that they're the thing that can face things, instead of the prey animal that has to freeze or retreat.
- 2.79 That's what you want your kids to practice. You want to have them on the edge of disaster, so to speak, on the edge of chaos. Always, that's where maximal play is. Men understand that in particular. Men play rough with little kids, really from the time they're babies, throw them in the air and bend them around and flip them. And the kids are enthralled by that. They're desperate for that because they want to be put on the edge always. That's the place of maximally exciting play.
- 2.80 And that's a real place, right? It's a phenomenological place. And you know you're there because you're engaged and it's deeply engaging and it's playful and you're improving. And maybe with that on your slate, you look forward to the day, even if you're not

doing so well. So, you can encounter a tool and an obstacle and a friend and a foe, and you can encounter something you don't expect and can't define and can't even really perceive. What's going on here?

- 2.81** You know, this often happens in the—in interpersonal relationships where you're conducting a conversation, something goes astray, right? Very common occurrence in marriages where there's a disjunction in communication. And the outcome you expect as a consequence of your utterance fails to make itself manifest. It's like, what's going on here? Did I say something? Did I make a mistake? That's a good place to start. It's like, was I misunderstood? Or is there some fundamental disagreement about first principles here?
- 2.82** And you can skate over that. Maybe you should if it only happens once, because what the hell? But if it's a recurring pattern, it's time to go down the rabbit hole and adjust the axioms of the game and see if it can be reconstituted so that that discontinuity vanishes. That's a constitutional crisis, you might say, and a difficult thing to negotiate. Down the rabbit hole, that's what novelty looks like. It's half promise. That's the treasure. It's half threat. Just look the hell out.
- 2.83** And whether it's promise or threat depends to a large degree on how you conduct yourself. Is fire useful or dangerous? Well, it's useful and dangerous, like everything. That's that weird perversity of the so-called object, right? A beer bottle is a weapon in a bar fight, right? Is it really a weapon? It's like, well, once you're dead, you can answer that question. It might be more, really, a weapon than a beer bottle in the right circumstances. It depends on who's playing what game, really.
- 2.84** And so, every object has a distribution of possibility around it. So there's the object and then there's the possibility of the object. And that realm of possibility can be explored in different games. The beer bottle is a good example of that. It's like, smash. Now it's a knife. Is it really a knife? If death is the arbiter of reality, then yes, it's a knife.
- 2.85** And so, then one question that arises is: Is there a stable pattern that you can make manifest in the face of the uncertain that increases the probability that you will prevail? That's the religious question. How do you deal with what's unknown in the world? How do you adjust yourself so that you're maximally situated to improve the game as you play it? There's an element of courage in that. There's an element of faith. There's a tremendous amount of attention. There's a tremendous amount of intention. There's practice. There's wisdom. There's guidance from tradition.
- 2.86** The novel, I think, is the biggest of the anomalous, is the biggest of categorical problems. Because when you play a delimited game, when you're looking at one thing, there's an infinite number of things you're not attending to. When you're playing one game, there's a never-ending array of games you could be playing. So, there's a massive difference between the landscape that you've configured proximally and every possibility.

- 2.87** And so, it's the fact of that unlimited landscape of possibility that's the cardinal issue of life. And you could say that the determination of how you encounter the radically unknown, that's the most important skill, meta-skill, that you could possibly learn. That's what you're teaching your kids when you're teaching them to be resilient and to develop. How do they stay on the edge and prevail continually? And that's a meta-skill.
- 2.88** I would say, again, that's the religious meta-skill. The religious landscape is the landscape of heaven and hell, but it's also the landscape of, it's the landscape of possibility. The water that the spirit of God hovers upon at the beginning of time in the story of Genesis is the landscape of possibility that your consciousness confronts when you awake in the morning and consider the multiplicitous ways that the day might progress. That's chaos. Chaos contains possibility.
- 2.89** And then, a question is: What attitude should you embody to make the order that's good or very good out of the chaos of potential? And the Genesis insistence is that that's the pursuit of truth aimed at love. Right. And that's the ultimate aim for the forthright confrontation with what's continually unexpected. That's how you draw out of it what's the best.
- 2.90** Imagine that—one of my security guys told me the other day a story. He was in a rough part of San Diego. I think the first day he worked for me, he went into a convenience store, and there was a guy came up and tried to rob him with a knife. Now, my security guy isn't the kind of guy that you can easily rob with a knife, especially if you don't know what you're doing with a knife. And he could tell that he didn't know what he was doing with the knife. So he laughed at him, and the guy burst into tears, and my security guy took the knife and then bought him a drink and a meal.
- 2.91** Right. That's pretty good. That's a high-order example of dealing with something, what, malevolent, chaotic, radically unknown? Right. That's a sign of mastery, that. So, know there's a notion that because human beings are made in the image of God, that there's no upper limit to their potential. Christ tells his followers that they will do, they and those who follow will do greater works than he. There's no obvious upper limit to upward striving or to mastery.
- 2.92** And that means, in principle, that there's no pit so deep that it can't be confronted and climbed out of or perhaps transformed. That's the harrowing of hell in Christ's three-day journey through death and hell, the encounter with what's radically abysmal as a precondition for full life. And it seems to me to be correct because I can't see how you could live fully without having the courage to confront death and malevolence.
- 2.93** You have to shy away, otherwise. You have to shy away from anything that's deep. You have to shy away from anything that's frightening. And then who knows how much development you forego because of that, because maybe you didn't have to. Maybe you could have been radically more than you are.

- 2.94** And so, novelty, dragon and treasure. So that's part of what starts us on our journey to enter the mythological landscape, because I laid out the characters, the pathways, the friends and the foes, the agents of magical transformation, the difference between good and evil. That puts us in the mythological landscape.
- 2.95** The mythological landscape describes the story. It's the structure. It's the underlying structure of the story. It highlights the fundamental elements of every story. And the more, the deeper it is, the more, the larger number of stories that pattern undergirds. Because all great stories have a pattern. That's what makes them stories. They wouldn't be stories, if they didn't have a pattern; they wouldn't fit a category. The more fundamental motifs are the root structure of the plethora of the largest number of stories.
- 2.96** Romance, that's one category, meta-category of story. Adventure, that's another. The proper admixture is romantic adventure. That's the story that everyone wants to see, male and female alike, an optimized, playful, romantic adventure. And that's the story that imbues life with the maximal meaning.
- 2.97** OK, so what happens when something unexpected occurs, when a rabbit hole appears? How do you respond, physiologically? It's an anomaly, which means it's—something unexpected isn't allowed to exist by the rules of the game you're playing. Because if your rules were complete, everything that happened would be predictable, and you'd be on your way to your path. So when an anomaly emerges, you either have to restrategize or you have to recalibrate your aim.
- 2.98** OK. How do you do that? Well, in a complex sequence, the first reaction is emotional. And it's the disinhibition of emotion. So it's partly anxiety and it's partly curiosity, but it's more than that. It's like the opening of a floodgate of potential emotional responses on the positive side and the opening of a floodgate of potential negative responses. You can imagine that. If something particularly hair-raising occurs, a flood of possibilities goes through your mind. And so that's a journey through the at-hand possibilities of reaction that are rising up from within you.
- 2.99** Neurologically, if you're playing a game, let's say, there's a set of circuits, so to speak, a network, a spirit, that inhibits all the competing games. So you see this with athletes when they're playing a high-intensity game. They can even break a limb and continue playing because the motivational significance of the proximal frame is so intense that it just shuts everything else down, even including pain. Now, when they stop playing the game, the pain will come roaring back. But technically, it's inhibitory, which is also why you're only focusing on a narrow range of things, instead of all the multitude of things that you could be focusing on.
- 2.100** That's disinhibited, by the way, with psychedelics. Psychedelics remove that focal frame and make everything relevant. Everything is too much, far too much. Anomaly does the same thing. In fact, the neurochemical consequences of psychedelics are an

exaggeration of the brain's response to anomaly. It's the same thing. It's a biochemically induced stress response. And stress re-novelizes things. Well, why? Because what you were paying attention to was wrong, or you wouldn't have encountered something unknown.

- 2.101** So what should you pay attention to? Who knows? Something outside of what you were paying attention to. What's that? That's a lot. Right. So that's overwhelming. Now, it's also an entire universe of new possibility. But, well, that's the dragon-treasure conundrum. How much possibility do you want? You see the specter of divorce lurking behind every argument. Right. That's a bit more possibility than you want.
- 2.102** Disinhibition of motivation and emotion is the fundamental response to novelty. So it's —all the things you could do come closer to hand. So that's what anger does. Anger primes you to react aggressively more rapidly or defensively. Fear primes you to freeze or to run away. When you don't know what's going on, what should you be primed to do? Everything. OK, that's exciting in small doses, especially if it's self-administered, but it's unbelievably stressful in high doses. In fact, that's a very good definition of what stress is.
- 2.103** When you're stressed, it's because you're preparing to do everything at once. To do that requires a tremendous amount of psychophysiological effort. Essentially, what you do is, you rob your future stores of energy and resources and burn them up in the present. If you do that long enough, you die. And so stress ages you.
- 2.104** Right, and so this is another reason why you want to keep your room clean. You want to keep everything that you can in order because, if something radically unexpected occurs, maybe you'll get through it, if there aren't too many things clinging to you. But if everything around you is in disarray, and maybe you contract some illness that's quite severe, maybe you could get through the illness, God willing. But if it's the illness plus 100 other things, it's like, maybe that's the end of you.
- 2.105** And so, you prepare for the worst by attempting to be pristine in your conduct. And then your store of resilience is greater. And so it's good to take pains to set things right and to address the micro-anomalies as they arise so they don't aggregate. So that's the rabbit hole. That's the structure of the rabbit hole, right? You're trying to go from point A to point B, but there are things you don't understand in the road, and the whole thing just goes down the hole.
- 2.106** It isn't that you don't get to point B. That's not the problem. It's that the way you thought of point A and the way you thought of point B and everything you saw and all your motivations and your emotions were potentially wrong. So it's not mere failure of strategy. It's a failure of game, and worse, or, God it can be worse than that, because the game you're playing might be dependent on another game. And underneath that, yet another game.

- 2.107** Like, the relationship you have with the child is dependent on the integrity of your marriage, and the integrity of your marriage is dependent on your vow of chastity, let's say. And so, there are dependencies in nested games. And now and then you make a mistake at a high level. Something occurs at a high level that stops that game, but that indicates that something's gone wrong way down at the bottom. That's lipstick on the collar.
- 2.108** Right. Which is, well, which is what? That's the question. Which is what? The marriage game is over. The future is completely different. It's not what you envisioned. The person you're married to, that isn't the person you thought you were married to. That means all your memories are wrong. Going back, how long? Does that mean that your perception of every person that you've ever been in love with is wrong? Is your whole perception of the relationship between people wrong?
- 2.109** It's like, in all those memories you had of your past, how many of them are real? You wouldn't think the past can change, but it can. And so, that's a black hole. That can be a black hole. And there's definitely a dragon at the bottom of that. So, that's a descent into chaos. So, you could think about tears of emotional upset. There's the emotional upset that necessitates a small course correction. That's just a minor annoyance, a petty annoyance.
- 2.110** There's the upset that forces you to reconstitute the game. There's an upset that forces you to evaluate the hierarchical structure of all your games and to see where the error occurred. That's a rough one. That's a life-changing transformation, assuming you lived through it. Much more likely to live through it if you've explored the depths voluntarily to begin with, so you're not caught unaware, down the rabbit hole.
- 2.111** So, you know, the Daoists believe that the world is made out of order and chaos, yin and yang. Why? Because that's what the world is made out of. Places you can predict, places where things occur as you expect, places where the game you're playing remains valid, and the place you are when all of that disappears. And what's that chaos? Well, it's terrifying. It's unstructured. It's potential. It's raw potential. It's everything the world is that you don't know. It's all the things you could be if you were other than you were. And that's chaos.
- 2.112** And that's the landscape of possibility that the spirit of God extracts the world of order from, not only at the beginning of time, but at the beginning of all things, always. That's the beginning of things. The encounter with what's new, the exploration of that realm of possibility, the adoption of an attitude towards it, and then the casting of it into predictable order. And you do that every time you do something. You do that at a micro level every time you move your eyes.
- 2.113** So, and when something goes involuntarily wrong, it's down the rabbit hole into the realm of chaos. That's what a baptism is, by the way, except it's done voluntarily. That's a return to the pre-cosmogonic chaos. That's a radical renewal and a return to the

beginning. That's how everything is revitalized always. And the question, again, to bring this issue up is, what's the nature of the attitude that best enables you to prevail when faced with the cataclysm and the opportunity to recast chaotic possibility into order? Right.

Lecture 3: Sacred Balance

At a glance — Sacred balance and an enduringly useful representation of order and chaos.

- 3.1 This is an absurdly useful representation, which I suppose is why it's been around for several thousand years. Those are serpents back to back, by the way, the yin and yang symbol. Yang and yin, what does it mean? Well, these are central concepts in a cloud of meaning that, like the visual field, shades out into, what would you say, alternative conceptual territory.
- 3.2 Words occupy, every word occupies the center of a cloud of denotations which are very close and connotations which are farther apart. When you hear the word, the connotations echo. So, witch's cauldron and swamp and darkness and cat, right? All those things come together in that concept, and witch is the central, is a central component of that cloud of meaning.
- 3.3 Yang and yin are like that. If you understand them as order and chaos, you're getting close. Now you know what that means, too. It means determinate order and possibility. That's what the world's made of, and that is what the world's made out of. It's right. That's what your consciousness deals with. Mostly your consciousness deals with the realm of possibility. All things that are predictable become unconscious. They disappear from view.
- 3.4 Your consciousness is literally the faculty, the spirit, that encounters what is yet to be. Right. As you practice something, it automatizes. You know that. When you first learn to drive, you have to pay attention to every movement of your hands, every movement of your feet. You can't concentrate on the road. You look right in front of the car. As you become expert, all of that disappears. You look half a mile, no, a quarter of a mile down the road, eighth of a mile, because you can still stop when something's that far away.
- 3.5 You plan your destination. You run all these automated routines underneath. That's not in consciousness, unless something goes wrong. Consciousness is an error detection and correction system. Now, that's not all it is, but it's definitely that. It interacts mostly with the realm of possibility. The structure is invisible.
- 3.6 Yang is also masculinity and yin is femininity. I've got a lot of negative comments about that idea. The first thing I'd like to say is, that's not my idea. This is a very, very, very, very old idea. In fact, it's one of the most fundamental of old ideas. If the feminists, let's say, are allowed to characterize the masculine as the patriarchy, which is order, pathological though it may be, then what's left for the feminine?
- 3.7 Well, one answer to that is, the role of patriarchal usurper. That's what Eve does in the Garden of Eden. The other option is that there's a separate realm. Right. And that's, well, what did we say already? Why is the unknown feminine? There's a lot of reasons.

Number one, women are the biggest stumbling block to any implementation of patriarchal order. What do I mean by that?

- 3.8** Imagine that you embody an element of the patriarchal spirit as a man, and you act that out in the world while you're dating, and that's unsuccessful. Right. That's chaos. That's chaos. It's a rebuke to everything you are, not only conceptually, but biologically. It's the ultimate rebuke to that establishment of order. It's also the ultimate potential renewal.
- 3.9** Do you know the movie Groundhog Day, by any chance? Bill Murray. It's a great movie. You could watch that. It would help you with this course. He's a narcissistic weatherman who is compelled to live the same day over and over until he gets it right, which is what we're all compelled to do, by the way. And he falls in love with this beautiful woman who's kind, who's everything he's not. And he has to undergo a transformation so radical that I think he tries to kill himself 250 times, something like that. It doesn't work because he wakes up the next morning, at 6 in the morning.
- 3.10** But he has to reconfigure who he is so that he becomes attractive. Well, that's a rebuke to a stale order. And so that's part of the reason that femininity is chaos and possibility. Let's see. Here's another example. Sleeping Beauty, the Disney movie, is a good example of this. It's quite a common motif. There's a scene where the evil queen traps Prince Philip in a dungeon and tells him that he's going to be held there until he's old. And then she laughs madly away.
- 3.11** And so she's the devouring Oedipal mother in that situation. She's the mother whose tyrannical love is so complete that it exhausts the masculinity of her son who's never allowed to leave because she loves him so much. So that's a major rabbit hole. And why does that make itself manifest as a mythological motif? Well, Freud was alert enough to know that humans have the longest dependency period of any creature, 18 years. That maternal bonding is incredibly intense and absolutely vital.
- 3.12** And even in many ways, the precondition for adult romantic relationships, because evolution is a conservative business, and much of the circuitry that's involved in mother-infant bonding is also involved in pair bonding, which is why we might refer to someone we love who's an adult female as "baby," for example.
- 3.13** Something, the highest spirits go most dreadfully wrong when they invert. So Lucifer is the prideful intellect, right? Because in Milton's portrayal of the battle between good and evil, Lucifer is the spirit created by God who flew the highest and went the most wrong. He's the lightbringer. He's the intellect, the prideful intellect, who believes that it can dominate and determine—instead of being subordinated to the proper upward-oriented harmony—that can impose its will, in which case it becomes not the highest of all possible spirits, but the most pathological.

- 3.14** Marx is a great example of that, as far as I'm concerned, and many of the postmodernists, this unbelievably nihilistic, prideful, egotistic, hedonistic, self-centered intellect that wants to recast the entire world in its malevolent image.
- 3.15** The maternal instinct. Well, if it goes astray, look the hell out. And it's a very tricky thing to balance because my daughter, when she was about three, my son was a year and a half and he was starting to walk. And she had taken a lot of care of him and had bonded very tightly with him. And we had stopped referring to him as a baby, and she was still referring to him as a baby. And so we said, "He's not a baby anymore."
- 3.16** Then she had a dream, and I was writing Maps of Meaning, and she came and told me the dream. So I wrote it down. She dreamt that a tree in the forest next to us moved into our backyard and burnt down and left a hole, so that's a tree of life. It burnt down and left a hole. And then Julian crawled into it and there was water in it and he was reduced to a skeleton; and there was a bug in water and the bug pulled his skeleton out and then he reconstituted.
- 3.17** And so she told me that dream and it just flattened me because she's like three years old. She told it and the way babies, or the way three-year-olds talk, was pretty simple. "And then a bug pulled him out." I remember her saying that. And yeah, "Julian drowned and then he turned into a skeleton, and a bug pulled him out. A tree came into our backyard and burned down and left the hole."
- 3.18** Well, what's that? Well, that's something living, right? It's a fully formed entity that disappears and leaves a hole with water in it. A possibility. And then there's a renewal. Well, what was she modeling? Well, what was he, if he wasn't a baby? And she was playing with this terrible conundrum. She loved this baby, and now it wasn't a baby. It's like, what the hell? And that's every mother has that problem. Every mother has that problem.
- 3.19** And it's continual, right? Because on the one hand, you have to, especially an infant before nine months, it's like, you have to do everything for an infant. An infant is always right, right? You just do whatever an infant wants. But then about nine months, when the baby starts to become ambulatory, then it has to guide its own behavior increasingly, and it has to be encouraged to move out, and it has to be subjected to the restrictions of real mobile life and social life.
- 3.20** And so, the mother has to transform from an agent of complete care to an agent of encouragement of departure, which is why it's a very good idea for a mother to also have her own life. Because seriously, that's a necessary thing. And so, as the impediment to independence, an inverted maternal love is an agent of catastrophic chaos—and that's the evil queen in Sleeping Beauty.
- 3.21** She locks the prince away. Now, what happens to the evil queen? The positive fairies come along; they're feminine, and they free him. So that's the positive feminine possibility that says, "Go after the princess." And so he gets on his horse and he leaves,

and then the evil queen finds out. And then what does she turn into? A dragon. And no one minds.

3.22 So you're sitting there watching in that movie, and there's an evil queen, and you think, "Yeah, well, of course, there's evil queens." And then she turns into a dragon, and you don't bat an eye. You think, "Well, of course she turns into a dragon." It's like, really? That's just a matter of course, is it? It's like Geppetto ending up in the whale. It just makes sense. And now does it?

3.23 Well, it does because it's actually the case that the most brutal impediment to life and the pursuit of a mate that a man faces, if he has an Oedipal mother, is the terrible dragon that's her insecurity that will devour him and fate him to isolation and death. And in order to face that, he has to—what would you say? He has to see the terrible dragon in her protestations of love. Brutal.

3.24 There's a documentary I would recommend called Crumb. It's about this underground cartoonist named Robert Crumb, who was a big, was a major figure in the underground movement in San Francisco in the 1960s. And that was his family. If you want to understand serial rapists and killers, you watch that documentary and you'll understand them. And that's not a pleasant undertaking.

3.25 So it's the only documentary I've ever seen that got this right. And the reason it happened is because the man who made it was a friend of the family. And so he got access in a way that would have otherwise been impossible. It's brutal. His brother, one of his brothers, Crumb, Crumb makes it. He's very unpopular in high school. He's one of those boys who was in the category of "dates aren't even an option under any circumstances whatsoever." So all the women he drew were like bird-headed monsters, very physically powerful and very judgmental. That's his view of women. And so he's very resentful.

3.26 Now, he becomes a very acclaimed artist and quite successful. And his relationship with women in some ways flips around. He gets married, he has a child, he has a life. Good for Robert Crumb. He came from hell. His father threw him across the room when he was five and broke one of his limbs and was tyrannical. His mother was hooked on amphetamines. It was a brutal, brutal story.

3.27 His brother would go—very brilliant. These are all very brilliant men. Genius-level IQs. They're three brothers. The brother, the other brother, the second oldest brother, he became a serial sexual molester and would go down to the financial district in San Francisco, basically naked in a loincloth, and sit on a bed of nails just as a protest. Resentful, resentful beyond belief to the core. His older brother never really left his high school bedroom, died at about 50, six months after the documentary, by drinking furniture polish. It's rough, but that's the evil queen. That's chaos.

3.28 Here's another story. Snow White. You remember the new movie? Yeah. Well, so let's walk through the real Snow White. OK, so Snow White has an evil—I think it's a

stepmother. Why? Because you're 100 times more at risk for abuse if you have a stepparent. A hundred times. Right. So, well, why? Because you're likely to be viewed as a biological impediment and an obstacle to time with the person who's actually the target of affection. That doesn't always happen, but it happens a lot.

- 3.29** Snow White has the evil queen. OK, who's the evil queen? The evil queen wants to be the beauty, but it's not her time to be the beauty because she's 40. Well, it's her time to do whatever 40-year-old women do, which we'll return to. That beauty that drives Snow White towards the prince, that's young woman destiny. That's her place in life. And the evil queen wants to maintain that beyond its due date.
- 3.30** And she does that by engaging in a sequence of behaviors the evolutionary psychologists call fertility suppression, which is the machinations of women, but older women in particular, with regards to younger women, to knock them out of the mating game. So in Islamic countries where female genital mutilation is the norm, it's generally administered by the old women. Right. And so, yeah, no kidding. Rough.
- 3.31** OK, so, the evil queen in Snow White wants to be the fairest in the land, and maybe that would be fine if it didn't come at Snow White's expense, but it does. And so Snow White has to contend with this reality. And so she has to leave because it's too dangerous. And so she goes out into the forest, which is the unknown, right? City, walled, medieval. Outside of that is chaos. She's out in the forest. And there she's protected by dwarfs.
- 3.32** Now, in the Grimm Brothers' fairytale, the dwarfs don't have names. And they're not little funny guys that are useless with a messy house like this new Snow White. The dwarfs keep a very clean house and they're very hard-working. They're ordinary men. They're ordinary men. And that means that they're the foundation of the patriarchy. That's a good way of thinking about it. Just the basic competence that keeps things going. And they protect her from the evil queen, right, but not completely.
- 3.33** And so, the evil queen comes back in disguise. And the first thing she gives Snow White is a bodice, so, like a corset. OK, so what does a corset do? It exaggerates waist-to-hip ratio. And so it's a way of artificially enhancing fertility symbols, but in a manner that's life-threatening. So the bodice is so tight that Snow White just about dies. And that happened in Victorian times when women were wearing corsets that were very, very tight. And so the evil queen entices the young woman into a display of beauty that nearly costs her her life. Now, the dwarfs can rescue Snow White from that.
- 3.34** And then the evil queen comes back and she gives her a poisoned comb. Same thing, more narcissistic self-aggrandizement. And the dwarfs can protect her from that. But then the evil queen feeds her a poisoned apple. OK, well, that goes all the way back to the story of Adam and Eve. To ingest something is to incorporate it, to take it in.
- 3.35** There's no difference between food and knowledge. OK, why? Took me, like, 10 years to figure this out. Because you trade knowledge for food. So knowledge is meta-food.

So knowledge is worth more than food. If your car doesn't work, you take it to a mechanic. He knows what to do. You pay him, he eats. Right, so we substitute knowledge for food. To incorporate is both to eat in the physical sense, but also to incorporate a meta-food. "Man does not live by bread alone." Same idea.

- 3.36** OK, so the evil queen in Snow White feeds Snow White a pathological doctrine, and the dwarfs cannot protect her from that. Right, and so you could give that some serious consideration in the presence of an absolute collapse of birth rates around the world. Right. So, why is femininity, yin, chaos, possibility? Well, here's another reason, if that's not enough.
- 3.37** In the story of Adam and Eve—these are complex stories—both Adam and Eve are proclaimed to be made in the image of God, which is really something, right? Because the typical critique, say, of the biblical corpus is that it's patriarchal and oppressive, which is an anti-truth. It's a literal inversion of the truth. It's a very old text.
- 3.38** And really, one of the first proclamations it makes about human beings is that both men and women are made in the image of God, which is as egalitarian a sentiment as you could ever hope. It's not just egalitarian, it's also elevating. That we partake of the same essence as the spirit of God that sits on the realm of chaotic possibility and conjures order out of the void. That's a definition of consciousness, and that that characterizes men and women equally.
- 3.39** And then Adam is given a task, like his role. His role is to name, specify, specify, and position. And that's a patriarchal structure. It's a hierarchical structure. Say what everything is. God brings things to Adam to see what he names them. The name is the thing. It's the functional utility of the object, let's say. And then to subdue, to put everything in its order—that's to build that ordering structure.
- 3.40** And Eve means "ezer kenegdo," kenegdo. It's partner in combat. It's something like optimal adversary partner in combat. You could think about it as partner in play, I think is the best way to get that, because what you want in a marriage is an optimized challenge. You don't want a pushover, you don't want a tyrant, you want someone to contend with that facilitates mutual development. And so that's the way that the relationship between men and women is conceptualized.
- 3.41** And Eve is drawn out of Adam in this representation. So her role is, it's outside the boundaries of his role. And I think the reason for that is the same reason that it's Eve that's tempted and eats the fruit, I think it's because women have to stand for those things that are not included in the current structure.
- 3.42** So, for example, if you're married and you have a baby, then the baby is a newcomer into the order of the little society that constitutes the marriage. And it's the woman who has to be the mediator between the baby and the man. She has to pay attention to how the baby's needs aren't being served. So she's serving the—it's like Mary in the

Gospels. She's serving the outsiders. That's a good way of thinking about it. She's serving and she's the voice for what's not included in the order.

- 3.43** And that gives her a protest function. And so, I don't think it's fluke at all that in the universities now, the major protesters on the behalf of the oppressed are female. It's an inversion of the maternal order. These are usually women between 18 and 34. So, childless women between 18 and 34 stand up on behalf of the oppressed. It's like, really? So the feminine is the beneficial antithesis of the current order, and speaking for the manner in which it needs to be transformed and expanded.
- 3.44** And that can become a usurping function. And that's what happens with Eve. And then Adam, the way the story lays itself out is that Eve eats first and then she offers the fruit to Adam, and he just eats it because there's nothing to him. He should have not done that, but he's weak. His weakness is equivalent to her sin. It's the same thing.
- 3.45** And then it's worse because they realize they're naked then. They've overreached. They've bitten off more than they can chew, and their vulnerability makes itself manifest to them. And now they're terrified. They realize they're going to die. They realize the difference between good and evil. It's a complete bloody collapse. The next day, God comes along and asks Adam to walk with him in the garden. And Adam hides behind a bush and refuses to show himself.
- 3.46** And God, which is a comic, that's a comic interlude, it's like, God can't see through bushes? It's really not very bright. It doesn't shine a great light on Adam and his wisdom. And God says to Adam, "What are you doing? Why aren't you walking the proper path?" And Adam says, "You know that woman you made for me? She knocked me off the path." And that's brutal. It's so pathetic. It's ungrateful, first of all. Second, he takes no responsibility. Third, he blames the woman. And fourth, he calls God out on his mistake for offering him a partner.
- 3.47** So Eve doesn't get a great rap in Genesis. But Adam's like, no, he's no admirable figure, that's for sure. Well, and that's when history starts, right? That's when the fall makes itself manifest. And so, I don't know. See, the thing is, it's, in that story, it's Eve that's the first target of the temptations of Lucifer, who's the prideful intellect that usurps. And I think it's got to be something like the fact that the maternal is so good in its fundamental essence that it has this profound temptation to overreach.
- 3.48** Because the usurping idea, the Luciferian idea, is an extended meditation that goes across centuries about the nature of evil. And it seems to be something like the insistence that the worst evil is the best spirit gone most astray. So Lucifer is the intellect for sure, because human beings are remarkable for our conceptual capacity. And obviously the evil scientist trope, or the evil magician trope, is, or the evil king, evil brother of the king, it's the same trope, is very, very old and indicative of that prideful intelligence.

- 3.49** You see that in Scar in the Lion King, too, who's smarter than Mustafa, but a much less well-developed character. Very common motif, and for good reason. So the intellect goes wrong, and that's the Luciferian spirit. And the maternal goes wrong. It's got to be something like perverse pride in— see, you shouldn't take pride in what you're given.
- 3.50** That's why intellectual pride is such a cataclysmic mistake. If you're blessed with an IQ of 160, that's not your doing. That's a talent that you've been granted and you have an ethical responsibility to it. It's not something you brandish like a flag of pride. It's something you watch carefully for and be grateful for and put into the service of the proper order.
- 3.51** The same goes for the maternal. And because it's such a highlight of ethical, of what's admirable ethically when it serves its proper function, when it's serving an infant, for example, it's got to be a temptation to overgeneralize from that, to take pride in it and to make it—because even in our culture now, it's compassion is the highest virtue. It's like, sorry, that's evil queen territory. It's too much. Whatever is at the highest place is not, it's not compassion. It's much more complicated than that.
- 3.52** OK, so this is very useful to know if you're reading stories, watching stories, reading mythology, when you know that landscape. That the fundamental landscape is chaos and order, that the moral universe is hell to heaven, right, and that's good and evil; that that's a hierarchy of aim, that the landscape itself is pathways and tools and obstacles and friends and foes and agents of magical transformation, and that that's how the world is constituted, right, as this dialectic between the order that's predictable and fruitful and the chaos surrounding it.
- 3.53** That's a town in the middle of a forest. That's a country in the middle of barbarians. That's the flag planted in a new territory. That's often a crucifix or a country flag. If it's the English flag, for example, in North America, it has a cross on it. There's a reason for that. That signifies the instantiation of a domain of order that turns the chaos of that new place into an ordered cosmos and establishes a game that can be played there in a mode of perception that will dominate. And that's taking possession of chaos.
- 3.54** And you're doing that all the time. You're doing that all the time. You learn to notice. Chinese doctors, they diagnose an imbalance of yin and yang in a household. Well, I went to the houses of many of my clients, and I could diagnose an imbalance between chaos and order. You can walk into a house, and there are boxes everywhere that haven't been touched for 30 years. They're everywhere.
- 3.55** And you open a box, and there's everything you can imagine in the box. There's pens, there's money, there's scissors, there's photographs, there's no order. It's just chaos. And every one of those boxes is a container of 100 decisions that had been avoided. And then the whole place is full of boxes like that. And everyone there is sick, and the targeted person is in therapy. And you walk into the house and you think, well, no wonder you're all ill. You're so stressed.

- 3.56** Why? Because all the order around you is turned into chaos. And we already know what happens when you confront chaos involuntarily. You're stressed. And what happens when you're stressed? Your immune system is suppressed. And then what happens? Well, you're prey to all sorts of physical illnesses. Or if you get something like cancer, it's going to go astray very rapidly. And not only that, you're depressed and anxious and without hope because you're burned to a crisp by the stress. You've got no clear pathway forward. And the Chinese doctor would come and say, well, there's too much yin here.
- 3.57** Or you go into a house. I've been in houses like this, where you're a guest and you put a cup on the little table, the little \$25 table, and the hostess runs over with a coaster and puts it under the cup and gives you a reproving look. And that's hospitality. And all of the carpets are vacuumed so that there's lines in them. And heaven help you if you happen to put a footprint and disturb that. And there's just order everywhere, so much order that no one gets to step out of line even a little bit. And people are just as stressed in that situation as they are in the utterly chaotic household.
- 3.58** So what do you want? You want a balance between chaos and order. And what signifies that? Play. What signifies that? Meaning. An inviting pathway forward. The spirit of hospitality. In the Old Testament, there's virtually no virtue that's more elevated than hospitality. Right. Why? Well, if everyone made everyone as welcome as possible wherever they went, everyone would be as welcome as possible wherever they would go. Right. So you practice that. And how do you do that?
- 3.59** Well, what do you want in a situation of hospitality? You want some play in the system. You want some excitement. You want some adventure. You want some order. You want some challenge. You want to engage in a game that moves upwards. Well, that's a healthy place. That's a completely different way of contemplating pathology than we contemplate it normally with our materialist outlook in the West, although it's in concordance with what we understand materially—too much disorder, too much stress.
- 3.60** Right. Well, we know the psychophysiological consequences of that. It's overpreparation for action. It destroys you. It ages you. And so, you want it balanced. You want it balanced. And then you're comfortable there and alert and hoping that something interesting will happen. And there's more to it.
- 3.61** In the story of Abraham, who's the father of nations, the spirit of the patriarchy, there's a vignette where strangers come to his dwelling, and in his encampment, and there's three of them. And the story insists that they're either angels or God himself. It's ambivalent. And he makes—he's hospitable to them, extremely hospitable to them. He's had his adventures by this time and is quite wise. And so he's very hospitable to them. And then he finds out that they're angels or emissaries of God, or God himself.

- 3.62** So what does that mean? Well, it means that the more hospitable that you are to people in the proper manner, the more opportunity will shine through those people in your relationship with them. The more possibility will open up for you, of adventure even. And that's what happens to Abraham. The angels tell him that God is about to destroy Sodom and Gomorrah for their impropriety, right, their deviation into chaos, it really is. And their lack of hospitality. That's the major sins of Sodom and Gomorrah. There are others, but those are the cardinal sins.
- 3.63** And Abraham mediates with God, telling God that it would be unfair to destroy the cities because there might be some good people there. And God says, "I don't think there is anyone good there." And Abraham says, "Well, I'll go there and I'll see if I can find anyone good. What if I find 50?" I think he starts with 50. And God says, "Well, if you find 50 good people in Sodom, I won't destroy the city." And Abraham is bargaining with God and says, "40." And God says, "OK, 40." And Abraham, who's pushy, says, "30," and then "20," and then "10."
- 3.64** And God signals, I suppose, to Abraham that maybe he's pushed his luck far enough. And so Abraham and the angels go to Lot's house. Lot is Abraham's nephew in Sodom. And the inhabitants surround the house and tell Lot that they're going to rape the visitors. And Lot offers his daughters. And that's very stark and outrageous by modern lights.
- 3.65** But in those times, if you messed with the wrong stranger, then an army would come to your city and kill everyone. Right. So peace was maintained between dwellings and the possibility of trade by the inviolable vow of hospitality. The person under your roof was under your protection. Right. So there weren't police. There was no centralized authority. So trade and stability between settlements depended on hospitality.
- 3.66** What happens to Sodom? Ten good people can't be found. So what's the moral of that story? Ten people who abide by the proper path in a corrupt city can save it from perdition. And the deeper moral is, you're supposed to be one of those ten. Right? So that's rough, that's rough. OK, so that's probably a good place to stop, I think. We could take some questions.
- 3.67** As humans, we don't know what goal maximizes enthusiasm by nature until experience points us in the direction. How effective is it when someone else's experience is what guides us, say, like, the Bible?
- 3.68** So one of the things I learned as a clinician, and as a professor, when I was facing young people who were confused and aimless, the question would arise, what do you want in your life? What would you like in your life? It's a very complicated question because it's a question of totality. And so, I had to break the question down to something like, where might you look for guidance when you're trying to find your way?
- 3.69** OK, so here's a rule of thumb. If you don't know what you're doing, do what other people do. Right, so then what do other people do? I tried to formalize that. I have a

program, the future authoring program that's a formalization of this. How would you broadly conceptualize your life? Let's say you have to get the central tendency right. It's like that abstract conscience that Jiminy Cricket is to begin with. It's generic, but it's a lot better than nothing. And so then maybe you can tailor the generic to your own purposes as you refine.

- 3.70** But you might as well start with the generic unless you want to start from scratch, which I wouldn't recommend. You don't have that long to live. And some other people might have something to tell you, since here you are, and they lived before you successfully. Well, what do people do? Well, they have some form of keeping body and soul together on the material front, some vocation or some job. A vocation might be preferable to a job, but a job is a lot better than nothing.
- 3.71** They have an intimate relationship, a marriage. They have friendships. They pursue their own edification. They pursue their education. They avoid the more egregious temptations—alcoholism and sexual misbehavior, I suppose, being first and foremost among them. That's not an exhaustive list. There's lots of shoals of rocks you can capsize your ship on. But those are two good ones. They serve their community. They attempt to optimize their functioning physically and mentally.
- 3.72** Well, there's eight things. It's like, try doing all those or some of them. Not none of them. How about not none of them? And maybe flesh out a vision and assume that, look, maybe you're Picasso, or part of you is, or you've got some really creative impulse. That's rare, by the way. People think that everyone's creative. That's not true. It's a personality dimension. It's openness. And lots of people are very, very low in openness.
- 3.73** We tested people's lifetime creative production. OK, so here's how we tested it. We took 13 domains of potential creative contribution—dance, literature, music, architecture, cooking, etc. Literature, innovation. I don't remember all 13, but you get the picture. And then we developed a scale that was graduated of eight levels of attainment within each domain, with zero meaning "I have no training or skill in this domain," and eight being "my productions have met with international recognition of one form or another."
- 3.74** So, the maximum score would be something approximating 13 times 8, although you could have repeated eights if you were particularly outstanding. Now, the distribution wasn't a normal distribution, with most people in the middle and some exceptional people and some low people. It's a Pareto distribution, which meant that some people had scores of 110, and they were way over here, sorry. This was everyone. Zero. 70% of people scored zero. And the next most common score was one. And that would be something like, "I've taken a music lesson."
- 3.75** But like, well, how many novels have you written? How many plays have you written? How many original pieces of music have you written? How many buildings have you

built? You know what I mean? It's rare. Now, there are micro elements of creativity, but we tried to measure them, too. Anyways, maybe you're exceptional. Perhaps you should pray you're not. If you are, have at her.

- 3.76** Even if you're exceptional, mostly you should be bounded within convention. If you are exceptional and you go out on a limb, you might want to have a place to retreat to that's kind of stable and ordinary. So it's good to—and so then where might you find guidance? Well, that's what mentoring is for, right? It's like, do the things that people do. If you're miserable and you don't know what to do, start there.
- 3.77** And then you can refine, you can refine. And that's fine. That's part of that process, that dialectical process, between conscience and calling. Get the target sketched out. And then maybe you can concentrate in a bullseye. And if you don't know where to look, look where everyone else looked, and be happy that you have that opportunity.
- 3.78** And also, that's the dwarf scenario in Snow White. Snow White serves the dwarfs, and then she finds a prince. Right, in that order. She's grateful for the ordinary man, and she serves them, and they protect her from the evil queen. And that's not nothing. And then the Prince comes, right, in that order. That wasn't the Disney version, by the way, the new Disney version. Another question.
- 3.79** My memory is not precise about this, but I think you wrote Maps of Meaning back in the '90s sometime.
- 3.80** Published in '99. I wrote it from '85 to '99.
- 3.81** So you've had a lot of years to think about it in the meantime. What's changed in your thinking?
- 3.82** At the end of the book, I was looking for markers of the pathway forward. The end of the book, Maps of Meaning ends with a chapter called "The Divinity of Interest." And so I figured out calling as a marker of orientation. What beckons to you? What grips your interest spontaneously? Which is something to really watch for because there are things that you're not interested in at all, and it's very hard to force yourself to be interested in them. And then there are things that you find so interesting that you can't help pursuing them.
- 3.83** Well, that's your calling. And that's the conjunction between your systems of exploration and the world. It's a divine parallel. It's a very strange thing. That's the burning bush in the Moses story. Remember, Moses investigates the burning bush. It's this living phenomenon, that it's life exaggerated because a tree is alive and the fire is metabolism. And so it's this intensely burning phenomenon that calls to him, and he investigates it deeply, deeply.
- 3.84** And that's a good thing to know in your life, is to pursue one thing as deeply as you can, because you get to the bottom of it. And then the spirit that lies at the bottom reveals itself. And that's what transforms you. That's what transforms you into a leader. Moses

is a shepherd. He's like a dwarf. He's an ordinary good man, which isn't all that ordinary. It's something. Because a shepherd keeps the wolves and the lions at bay and protects the innocent. That's a good definition of masculinity.

3.85 But his intense pursuit of what calls him off the path—because that's what the burning bush does—his intense pursuit of that shows him a deeper vision of the world. And then the spirit that's at the bottom of things speaks to him. And that's what makes him able to stand up against the tyrant, to specify the promised land, and to lead his people out of captivity. That's a psychological story, as well as a sociological story.

3.86 OK, so I had that part right, although I didn't know the burning bush segment at that point. I knew that calling was one of the pathways the divine uses to reveal itself, so to speak. But I didn't understand the role of conscience as well. I knew then that you had to be careful with your words. You shouldn't lie. I knew that people like Solzhenitsyn, who rebuked the lie, were transformative figures, but I hadn't formalized it. I didn't know that the divine pathway is marked by a dialectic between conscience and calling. And so I figured that out over the last couple of years.

3.87 In the Old Testament, Elijah, who is the prophet, he's taken bodily up to heaven. He's the only prophet who's taken bodily up to heaven. It happens with Christ. So it's a very rare occurrence. And he is the first person who identifies the divine with conscience, the still, small voice. He foregoes nature worship. He's an enemy of the prophets of Baal, who were nature gods, nature god worshippers, like the environmentalists of today.

3.88 And he realizes that God isn't in the fire, the conflagration, the forest fire. He's not in the hurricane. He's not in the earthquake, in these awe-inspiring manifestations of the natural world. That whatever the divine is, is more akin to the voice of conscience that calls to us in stillness. That's Elijah's proclamation. It's a revolutionary idea. It's like Socrates and his daemon. It's a revolutionary idea that the divine makes itself manifest in that still, small voice. And that's how Jiminy Cricket defines his role, by the way, as the still, small voice. It's very, very interesting, these weird mythological echoes.

3.89 But the Disney animators of that time were geniuses. So it's not surprising that they had the connotative knowledge that a genius would have. That's a calling, too. Can you imagine them piecing that story together, thinking, "Oh, that works. Oh, that fits." Do they know why? No, not really. Fits. Like the fact that Geppetto ends up in the whale, and they managed to integrate that into the narrative. It's so unlikely, but it fits the pattern. So that was a further elaboration that was important.

3.90 Most of the rest of it is just further elaboration of the central themes. I read the audio version of *Maps of Meaning* and recorded it not long ago. Well, five years, something like that. And I just wrote a new introduction. There is a 25th anniversary version coming out with quite a lengthy new introduction where I actually answer that question in detail.

- 3.91** So, most of the insights that I developed in that book have stood the test of time. And I think the reason for that, I know the reason for that, is that I didn't write down anything I couldn't buttress with at least four or five different dimensions of evidence. All the things I'm telling you today, they work in many different scenarios. They're not single evidence. I'm not deriving them from single points of evidence. They have to work, mythologically and scientifically. That's a tough one to begin with.
- 3.92** And then there's various scientific and philosophical modes of conceptualization to unify cybernetic theory and phenomenology and the psychophysiology of perception and pharmacology with the mythological structure. And to relate that to narrative, that's a lot of cross-referencing. The probability that the convergence of those seven things, say, six things, is wrong? I don't think so. Pretty hard to come up with a solution that fits all those constraints.
- 3.93** So, mostly it's been a matter of continual elaboration and deepening of understanding. But I missed the role of conscience. I knew it then, too. I thought, there's—see, I never liked Campbell, Joseph Campbell's, "follow your bliss" idea. I thought, yeah, no. Where's the malevolence and the suffering? Follow your bliss? Little too naive Californian Buddhist for me. There's got to be a constraint function to keep you on the straight and narrow. And enticement is one thing, but a slap on the side of the head now and then is also pretty damn useful. And you probably need both.
- 3.94** So, that dialectic makes—that's, what did Jung say, too? It's analogous. The classical conception of God was that he ruled with two hands, mercy and justice. Mercy alone, that's compassion, let's say. It's pathological. Justice alone, it's like, who could prevail? You need that balance, right? Because you need to be held to account, but if it's too stringent, then everyone is unforgivable. But if it's all mercy, well, "you can do anything you want, dear, and I'll still love you."
- 3.95** It's like, you don't really love me if that's—that's Joe Biden with Hunter. Really, God, so, so appalling. There's nothing I can think of that would be worse to do for my son than to provide him with a presidential pardon. If you really wanted to just destroy your son, that's how you do it. It's like, so brutal, so brutal. So, that was the biggest. I knew that was missing. I knew there was something missing, but it took me a long time to figure out what it was. All right.

Lecture 4: Conceptualizing Reality

At a glance — Conceptualizing reality from the phenomenological standpoint.

- 4.1 We've established in principle what the world's made out of, from the phenomenological or the cybernetic or the narrative perspective, or the perspective of identity, or the perspective of conscious experience, or the perspective of goal-directed pursuit. That ties in with the cybernetic and the phenomenological approach.
- 4.2 The basic idea that is presented within those systems, but then in the narrative and mythological representations of, let's say, our frameworks of reference, is that the world as experienced is made out of the domain of order, which is where things that you want happen when you do them, and the domain of disorder, which is whenever anything goes wrong.
- 4.3 And the domain of disorder, that's the domain of chaos. In the Daoist scheme, that's the domain of yin and the domain of order, which is essentially predictability, predictability in relationship to a goal. That's a good way of thinking about it. It's a little more complicated than that because the fact that predictability exists, say, not only indicates that you're on the way to the goal, but it indicates that the principles by which you're framing your perception, so the rules of the game that you're playing, are valid.
- 4.4 It's got a twin meaning, and that's problematic if you stumble or fail to move forward because you don't know if it's a strategic error, which means you just have to modify, as we said yesterday. As we said previously, you have to do a normative adjustment, or if it's time, serious time for a new game. It's more significant emotionally when the game itself collapses because everything that existed within that game now becomes of dubious reality. Certainly dubious validity, but also dubious reality.
- 4.5 It's a hard thing to distinguish, right, because if your marriage falls apart, was the reality that you remembered when it was stable real or not? Or is that a failure of a game? It's very difficult to distinguish those things.
- 4.6 So, with this, you step from the merely abstract conceptual world where we talk about things like starting points and goals, emotions and motivations, tools and obstacles, very practical conceptualizations, to the realm of symbolic representation. Because what we're going to discover and what we'll talk about in this lecture, in this sequence of lectures, is how the world we described yesterday is represented in narrative, how it's characterized because it's characterized. And so, now we have to be introduced to the characters.
- 4.7 Once you understand what the characters are and what they represent, and how they're related to the perceptual frame, then you have the key to understanding narrative itself. But more importantly than that, you have a key to understanding the deepest of narratives, which are the patterns of narrative, the patterns of perception

and direction of attention and action, that all stories are based on. And that gives you access to a genuine understanding of the religious domain.

- 4.8 Now, you can describe the religious domain technically, as far as I'm concerned, is that there are tiers of dependencies in our conceptualizations. So we know this because sometimes you have a shallow conversation with someone, and sometimes you have a deep conversation, and sometimes something shallow occurs in your life, and sometimes something deep occurs. And so, what does that mean, shallow and deep?
- 4.9 Well, a profound experience changes the way you see everything. Right, that can be a traumatic experience, but it can be a very radically transforming experience as well. Whereas a shallow experience requires a minor adjustment, if any. And so that implies the idea that there's shallow and deep, which we certainly understand in terms of conversation, in terms of story, in terms of art. The deeper a subject is, the more other things depend on it.
- 4.10 In a marriage, typically, one of the fundamental principles that a marriage depends on is the vow of fidelity. It's what stabilizes the interpretation of the interaction and the environment. There's more than that, but that's one of them. If that's violated, that's a profound challenge, because the entire framework of interpretation that allows you to specify the meaning of everything that was involved in the relationship, past, present, and future, falls. That's a deep problem.
- 4.11 Now, you might say, how do you account for the elapse in a marriage, let's say, or a betrayal in a relationship? Well, that's a chaotic element, but that's not a sufficient explanation, because it's not merely chaotic, like your car failing to operate when you most need it. There's an intent behind it, and the intent, the chaotic intent, has a malevolent element to it, because it's an immoral act. And so, that domain of chaos is not only, consists of what's unexpected in its deeper structures, it consists of what's malevolent. And that's important to note.
- 4.12 If you're a naive person and you encounter your own malevolence or someone else's, there's a reasonable probability that you'll emerge traumatized, which means your view of what human beings are, what you are, what other people are, what safety is, what danger you're in, all of that transforms. And if you don't have a framework within which to put that, you're done. Then you're chronically stressed enough because everything has fallen apart and you don't know where you are, so that you'll experience the neurological devastation that accompanies post-traumatic stress disorder.
- 4.13 Events that occur at a profound enough level, that's the religious level. This is a definition I'm putting forward. I'm not asking you to believe anything. There's a hierarchy of dependency. The closer you get to the bottom, the more you're starting to tread on sacred ground. This is completely independent in a way of your explicit religious beliefs.

- 4.14 One of the things I noticed in my clinical practice was that people who had been really badly hurt, which generally meant something terrible had happened to them at the hands of someone who intended for something horrible to happen, even for them to discuss those issues, they tended to lapse into narrative structures that were religious in connotation.
- 4.15 Because if you're hurt very badly at the hands of someone, including yourself, who's intent on that damage, there isn't a language other than the language of good and evil that encapsulates the phenomenon. There's no other way of telling the story. And so, well, you can decide for yourself what that means with regards to the reality of such things. But this is a technical description.
- 4.16 Now, you could say, the more profound the principle that's violated by the anomaly, the more destabilizing that is, so that produces negative emotion. But also, the more promise makes itself manifest because there's also the possibility of a radical transformation. And so it's an ambivalent occurrence. Even if it's profoundly negative, you can come out of an encounter with someone malevolent a lot wiser than you were. And so, that's what it means to get to the bottom of things.
- 4.17 OK. So, we'll review briefly what we mean by a frame of perceptual reference, a perceptual frame, a story. "Dasein", that's the phenomenological term from Heidegger, German. It means something like the place of being. So that's his description of the phenomenological frame. That's the world as you experience it. So that's reality as it makes itself manifest to the conscious awareness.
- 4.18 This is a technical representation of that frame. It is an attempt to unite that vision with what we know about the neuropsychology of emotion. And we know a lot. And so this is a solid way of representing it. You're somewhere, you're trying to get somewhere. You're goal-oriented in your perceptions and your actions and your intention. Your emotions, your motivations feed into the goal and into the current state.
- 4.19 Because, for example, if you're hungry, the current state is that you're hungry. The desired state is that you're satiated. The motivational state doesn't just establish the goal, it establishes the reference point and determines your perceptions. When you walk into the kitchen when you're hungry, you see the world as a place to procure food. That's what foregrounds out of everything else that you could be considering.
- 4.20 OK, so what can happen along the way? Well, you can implement your plan properly, in which case you proceed without incident towards the goal, in which case you satiate yourself. The frame of reference flips, a new goal and a new starting point emerges, and that would be a new episode in your day or in your life. Or unexpected things could happen. The fire alarm could go off. A burglar could leap into the house, something could break, something could catch on fire, or worse.
- 4.21 People have heart attacks. People get bad news on the phone, and their world falls apart. A tax form that is so much trouble, you can't imagine it, ends up in the mail and

you open it while you're downstairs trying to get something to eat. So, what happens? Well, we know that you see a pathway to your destination. You see the tools and obstacles that would help you or interfere. You see the friends or the foes that would guide you on your way. You see the agents of magical transformation.

- 4.22 But you see things that are unexpected, too. That's anomaly. Now, the thing about what's unexpected—this is a very interesting thing to understand— is that your perceptions bound the world so that you take everything there is, hyper-complicated, and radically simplify it. You simplify by ignoring most of it. Whenever you're doing one thing, there's an infinite number of things you're not taking into account and you're not attending to. Those things still exist, and they can pop their ugly little head up at any time, in any of them, inside your frame of reference and disrupt it.
- 4.23 That, I believe, is represented by the eternal serpent in the garden. There's a theological question in relationship to the narrative that begins Genesis, which is, why would God create a garden and put a snake in it? The answer to that seems to be something like, no garden's without snakes. It's not possible. Because to make a partial enclosure, you have to exclude. But the exclusion is imperfect, and it can always come welling back up.
- 4.24 You could protect your children, but that doesn't mean they won't get access to someone's phone and fall into the world of violent pornography. And believe me, that's the world swelling its way back into the walled garden. That's what paradise is, by the way, a walled garden that you're trying to create that produces security and an optimally playful adventurous place that has everything that's malevolent and terrible excluded. Right, and so, every place you go has that possibility of the unexpected and the anomalous.
- 4.25 And so, partly what you want to do is, you want to master how you operate in any given game. But more importantly, you have to operate in the space between games or in the space that is composed of those events that transform games. You can think about that as a metagame. What's the problem? How do you do what you know you should do? Well, that's a problem. How do you act when you don't know what's going on? That's a very different problem.
- 4.26 Now, if you can solve that second problem, as well as the first problem, then you're at home on explored territory, and you're at home in unexplored territory. And since the world is made out of order, which is explored territory, which is the territory that you inhabit when things are going according to plan, the world's composed of that. And unexplored territory, chaos, the domain of the unknown and the anomalous, if you can master both of those, then you're at home in the world.
- 4.27 Now, that's the most meaningful path of being, because your emotions are actually optimized when you're practicing both. So if you're playing a game, for example, with a partner, with a team, the game is optimally engaging when it's going according to plan,

which is, everyone's playing by the rules and everyone is aiming for the goal, so the game has the same structure as the phenomenological frame. Everyone's aiming at the goal.

- 4.28** You want to be engaged in the game in a manner that ensures that it lays itself out predictably, but you want to be pushing yourself to your limits on the edge of chaos, so that while you master the skills that are at hand in the game, you're also expanding your repertoire of skills. And that's when the game will be maximally engaging. It doesn't matter what you're doing. It doesn't matter what the frame is; that holds constant.
- 4.29** If you're bored by an enterprise, your attitude towards it is wrong. You haven't got the thing, you haven't got the lens that you're using to examine the phenomenon optimized, because if you did, then it would grip you. And so you can change what you're looking at. That's the typical pattern of people who at least are willing to change. But you can also change the way you're looking at what you're looking at.
- 4.30** One of the things I learned, for example, in my clinical practice is that, if my attention started to drift when I was speaking with one of my clients, so what happens then? Let's say my goal is to communicate with you towards an end, and the end would be the exchange of information so that you emerge more integrated, and perhaps I learned something along the way. You could say that's the therapeutic frame. We're working in what we mutually agree to be our mutual best interests. We've established that by negotiation.
- 4.31** If I'm listening to your account of your problems, your starting place, and your goal, and my attention drifts, what's happening is that that frame is being challenged by other frames of reference that my attention is toying with, these other motivational states that might be—one of the things I noticed, for example, is, I hated to start a clinical episode if there was something wrong with my computer, because when there's something wrong with my computer, it makes me obsessive till I fix it.
- 4.32** And so, if a client had to be misfortunate enough, unfortunate enough, to come in just when I was dealing with some idiot computer problem, I would flip continually. I'd listen, and then I'd think about the computer problem. So, you can see, when you're listening to someone, that there'll be competition for the way you're framing your attention. That can cause you a lot of trouble on a date, for example, that particular phenomenon.
- 4.33** In any case, what I learned was that, if the conversation I was having with my client wasn't sufficiently engaging to chase away competing frames, then I wasn't listening hard enough. I wasn't paying enough attention. And attention has this—the Egyptians, the ancient Egyptians, they worshiped attention. They believed it was the highest god. Their god Horus, Horus is the eye, the famous Egyptian eye, with the open pupil. Horus

was also a falcon. And the reason Horus was—like Zazu in the Lion King, who could fly up and see everything from a height—he was the eyes of the king.

- 4.34 Horus is the open eyes of the king. That's another mythological representation in ancient Egypt. The Egyptians determined that attention was the revivifying spirit of the dormant or pathological state. And they worshipped that as the highest god, the open eye, the ability to pay attention. And attention, see, attention oriented upward is really indistinguishable from love. That's another good thing to know. That's why children are so desperate—everyone, by the way—children are so desperate for love.
- 4.35 Attention is a currency. All the corporations fight for it. So attention is—you could say in a way that attention is the foundation of the world. That's not an overstatement, and that's very much worth knowing. And the focus of attention has a revivifying quality. One of the things you'll notice if you ever get a new apartment or a new house is that any part of the house that you haven't attended to, cleaned, ordered, deeply observed, it's not yours. It'll still feel—
- 4.36 You know, there's a difference between a house and a home. The difference is attention. A home is a house where everything has been attended to. And that turns it from chaotic possibility that's alienating into territory that's secure and a place of play. Everything works on that principle. So, attention. All right.
- 4.37 Now, how do you pay attention to what you don't understand? That's a complicated problem. How do you deal with what you can't comprehend? That's a complicated problem. It seems impossible, in a sense. It seems counterintuitive that that could even be a possibility. But if the world is made out of chaos, order, where things are secure, maybe a bit dull, if it's made out of order and chaos, then you need to be able to maneuver in both. But chaos, by its definition, is unstructured and incomprehensible.
- 4.38 So, how is it that you can adopt a stance towards it that works? That is essentially the religious problem. And you can imagine why. If the world is made out of chaos and order, the deepest problem is obviously how you deal with chaos and order. Now here, and you might think, well, that's all well and good, but it's merely symbolic. It's like, we're going to find out it's not merely symbolic. Your brain has two hemispheres. Right. And one is specialized for order and the other is specialized for chaos.
- 4.39 And that's a biological mechanism that evolved. And the selection mechanism for evolution, that's reality. And so if reality has selected us to have a bicameral consciousness, which is the case, then how in the world can you state that the attributes to which those hemispheres are adapted aren't real? It's the very definition of real. Real is what selects. Real is what kills you. Real is what allows you to live, if you do it right. That's real.
- 4.40 And that bifurcated consciousness doesn't only seem to be a necessary mechanism of living nervous systems. Even artificial networks appear to need a module that maintains stability and a module that deals with exceptions. If you meld them, the systematic

element collapses. And there's a famous example of this. I can't remember where I read it. Train a neural network to identify fish, and train a neural network to identify birds, and then throw it a penguin. All fish are birds. That's the conclusion. It can't handle the exception, the marginal case.

- 4.41 So there's something very deep about the necessity for this dual system approach to reality, which would make sense if reality has this bifurcated aspect, which is possibility and actuality. That's another way of thinking about it. Or concrete and as-of-yet undetermined.
- 4.42 That's what you face in the morning. You wake up in your orderly environment, but that's not what you face. You don't pay attention to your covers and your bed. I mean, you might want to make it, but the concerns that make themselves manifest to your consciousness are the possibilities of the day. And that might be overwhelming, especially if you're depressed or anxious. Too much, too much chaos, too much unstructured possibility.
- 4.43 Optimally, you'd be raring to go because you could see the treasure in the dragon. But your consciousness concentrates on what has not yet been formalized. And that's the spirit that creates the world. That's the image of God in man and woman. You're moving from where you are to where you deem better. That's an upward movement.
- 4.44 You see the phenomena that we described yesterday, the tools, the obstacles, the friends and foes, et cetera. And there's the rabbit hole, the unpredicted event. And so, we're going to delve into that to see more particularly what it means to fall down that rabbit hole, what's in there, but also to understand as well, and these things have to be done in parallel, how one game is related to another.
- 4.45 OK, so what are—I'll give you an example of this in literature, the Quidditch game in Harry Potter. It's a weird game because two things are happening at the same time. There's the ordinary team playing an ordinary game, which is basically soccer, basketball, just a typical game, which is hit the target, collectively, according to a set of principles. That's a game.
- 4.46 But there's a metagame going on at the same time. Remember, the seekers play that. The seekers play that. Right. So that is the game that seekers play. It's not the ordinary game. It's a game on top of a game, or it's a game underneath the game that's foundational. It's more crucial. It's more real. Now, in the Quidditch arrangement, if the seeker catches the snitch, then they get usually enough points to win the whole game.
- 4.47 Now, the snitch is a very weird thing. It's a gold ball with wings. It turns out that that's a representation of an alchemical symbol called the round chaos. And the round chaos was regarded by the alchemist as the container of primordial matter, of reality itself. And so the seeker who wins the game is the person who pays enough attention to find the container of what's ultimate.

- 4.48 It's exactly what happens to Moses in the encounter with the burning bush. He pays attention, and then more attention, and then more attention, and he gets right to the bottom of something. And that's when the divine reveals itself and transforms his character. He moves from shepherd to leader. Then he can speak truth to power, and he can lead the slaves to the promised land, and define the promised land, and speak in a manner that's compelling, such that people will listen and tell the stories that motivate—because he's taken something seriously.
- 4.49 That's a good thing to know, practically, in your life. Take one thing seriously. Get to the bottom of it. It doesn't matter where, because the bottom of everything is the same place. It doesn't matter where you start. You see this with scientists and you see this with people who have great intellectual careers. They often start as specialists, and that takes a lot of discipline, and it's a narrowing process in a way to become a specialist. There's so many things you don't study.
- 4.50 But as your ability as a specialist expands, because everything is associated with the complexity of everything else, the more you study one thing, the more you see how it's connected to other things, and then other things, and then other things, and then other things. And that's how you get to the bottom of things. So you can achieve wisdom—this is a useful thing to know, too—you can achieve wisdom through any upward-aiming disciplinary pursuit.
- 4.51 And so it doesn't really matter what calls to you. And there'll be idiosyncrasies in that. You won't be interested in the same thing that you'll be interested in. And you might think, well, even though the interest is the same, the target is different, but not exactly. Because you could say that the ground of being is attempting to make itself manifest through all of its proximal manifestations. And if you pay enough attention, you'd figure that out. So that's very much worth knowing.
- 4.52 And so, a call can come to you. That'll be something that grips your interest. Now, you have to have sorted yourself out well enough so that you're not being drawn to something pathological because your aim is misaligned. But given that, if something calls to you or bothers you at the level of conscience, if you take it with sufficient seriousness and pursue it, then it'll lead you to the bottom of things. That's very much worth knowing.
- 4.53 Get great at one thing, and that'll generalize. That's an apprenticeship. That's an apprenticeship. You emerge from an apprenticeship as a master. You have a masterpiece. That signifies that you're now maybe even capable of transforming the discipline that you've apprenticed within. But you have to subjugate yourself first. That's really what socialization is. And so, it's a narrowing and then a broadening. But there's no second broadening without that initial focus, focused attention.
- 4.54 OK, something unpredictable happens. Disinhibition of emotion. You encounter this realm of novelty. That's yin. That's Chaos. It's all that which exists outside the frame

that you've been inhabiting. It could be the universe of all potentially playable games. That's a good way of thinking about it. So, for better or for worse, down the rabbit hole.

- 4.55** Disinhibited emotion and motivation. Why? Because you don't know what to do. So what does your body do? Prepare to do everything. And that puts you on edge and ready, but in doses that are too overwhelming. It's physiologically devastating. So you have to contend with that, so that you can benefit from that state of preparation without exhausting yourself. All right.
- 4.56** If the rabbit hole is sufficiently deep, if the unexpected thing that emerges is sufficiently problematic, that all your pathways forward are blocked, then what? Then you die, or is it time for a new game? This is the thing that's so remarkable about human beings. Now, it's not an overstatement to say that an animal who has all its pathways forward blocked will die. A human being who has all his pathways forward blocked will find a new aim.
- 4.57** That's a radical transformation. That's a creative transformation. Time for a new game. Well, what does that mean? It means time for a new story. It means time for a new world. It means time for a new character. It means time for a new spirit. A new pathway, new friends, new foes. Everything transforms. But you can do that. You can become a new person.
- 4.58** This is represented fairly consistently in the Old Testament texts. You see this in particular in the story of Abraham. He undergoes a series of transformative adventures — and so they would be different frames or different games—and accrues skill, like you do in a video game, with each adventure, until he transforms so completely, God grants him a new name. Same thing happens with Jacob, who becomes Israel. So the idea is that, if you climb Jacob's ladder in this succession of adventures, you can transform your character so completely that it's as if you become a new person.
- 4.59** And then what person should you try to become? Well, our initial hypothesis is one who's the master of order and chaos. So that's the question. How do you do that? Down the rabbit hole. Why is it chaos? Well, because if your pathway is blocked forward sufficiently so the game is in question, everything's up in the air.
- 4.60** One of the mythological representations of that, interestingly enough—Mircea Eliade, Romanian historian of religion, documents this extraordinarily well, particularly in a book called *The Sacred and the Profane*— every collapse is a return to the beginning of time. Now, this gives you a notion of what the beginning means in the narrative frame.
- 4.61** The Genesis beginning isn't the scientific materialist beginning. It's how everything begins. It's the beginning of everything. It's the beginning in the past, it's the beginning now, and it's the beginning in the future. It's how everything emerges, out of chaos. That's the word of God floating on the primordial waters.

- 4.62 The primordial waters are a very common symbol of chaos. Why? You don't know it's in the water. Dark water, deep water, sharks, carnivores, the unknown place that you can draw things up from the depths at a deeper level, the place where life itself emerged. So the primordial waters are the birthplace, an intermediary birthplace of the world as such. The spirit of God that rests on the water, broods on the water, dwells on the water, is the ordering principle that confronts possibility and casts it into order.
- 4.63 More specifically, the injunction in the Genesis text is not only into order, but the order that's good or very good. So that begs a question, too, which is: What does your aim have to be to encounter the realm of possibility in a manner that's meaningful, in a way that transforms that possibility into what's good or very good? There's an aim that is a precondition for that magical process.
- 4.64 That, in Christianity, that question took thousands of years to answer because it wasn't really answered until the gospel account in John, where John posited that the spirit of ultimate voluntary self-sacrifice—that's Christ—was the same spirit that operates at the beginning of things, if what's extracted from possibility is the order that's good or very good.
- 4.65 So, what would that mean? Well, you can think about it concretely. How much love should you have for your children if you wanted to situate them optimally? Would you lay your life down for them, in principle or in reality? Well, the answer to that has to be yes. And so, to establish the most profound relationship with someone, in the attempt to make that relationship everything it could be, you bring everything to bear, everything.
- 4.66 And so that's the spirit that has to exist at the beginning of things for what emerges to be good or very good. You can imagine encountering it with the spirit of power and what would be extracted in consequence of that, or the spirit of hedonistic self, immediate hedonistic self-gratification. Those are two very common competing spirits, you might say, or the spirit of hopelessness and nihilism. You're going to extract very different forms of order in consequence of your aim.
- 4.67 Right, so aim up. That's the rule. Aim up. That begs the question, what do you mean by up? Right. Well, at minimum, you mean not, not toward the abyss. At minimum, you mean that. OK, so your pathway is blocked. It's time for a new game. So everything is made new again. That's a reversion to the state of possibility that exists at the beginning. It's not exactly the beginning of time. It's a deeper notion of beginning than that. The beginning of everything.
- 4.68 Everything collapses into possibility. That can freeze you with apprehension. That's the kids in the Harry Potter, second volume, who encounter the basilisk that is the great serpent— that's another symbol of chaos—that lurks under everything, which is why it's in the pipes under the magical castle. It's the unstable chaos that makes itself suddenly present in all imaginable circumstances. It's always there as a possibility.

- 4.69 Now, you remember that Harry determines to go into its lair. And so that's a hint about the appropriate pathway to take, to master the chaotic domain. OK, so now it's out of this game. That's the collapse of a relationship. That's probably where people experience that most self-evidently in ordinary life, right? Because you orient yourself to a large degree around a set of fundamental relationships. And when they collapse, then, well, then what? Then where are you? Then who are you? Then what do you make of your past?
- 4.70 But also, what new possibilities does that open up for the future? Well, those are the questions that emerge. And the instinctive reaction to that is preparation for all things. OK. That's a beginning story. That's the story of the fall. So the way that history begins in the biblical accounts is that Adam and Eve incorporate something that they were—what would you say? Where there was a strong suggestion that they forswear from that endeavor.
- 4.71 What does that mean? It means they bit off more than they could chew. So there's an issue there of pride. You want to encounter something that's challenging. You want to encounter what's unknown, but you don't want to prematurely claim that you're the master of all things, and then attempt to establish the preconditions of the moral order itself.
- 4.72 And that's what Satan, that's that chaos dragon, that's the temptation that's put forward to Eve. She bites off more than she can chew. Then Adam bites off more than he can chew. And that's a sin of pride and usurpation. And that's the fall. That's when history begins in the biblical sense. And so, what does that mean for—and that's the land of toil and trouble and thorns and thistles and things that go wrong.
- 4.73 Well, why? Prideful misalignment turns the world from paradise to the place of fallen man. That's right. That's right. So that's an anomaly story. Like, the serpent is the prime symbolic representation of the deepest of anomalies. Why? Why a serpent? Why a reptile? Well, human beings have been—mammals have been fighting with reptiles for 100 million years, a very long time. Wherever there are primates and poisonous camouflaged serpents, the primates have more acute vision.
- 4.74 You remember in the Genesis story that the snake provides Adam and Eve with vision. We're also very good, by the way, at seeing camouflaged patterns in the lower half of our visual system. We're better at that than in the upper half. Why? Well, most snakes are on the ground. So snakes definitely sharpened our vision.
- 4.75 So we've been in a battle with, well, a battle with what? What does the serpent represent? Definitely a predator. But also an inhuman predator, a predator that you can't make contact with. Like a Komodo dragon is a more terrifying entity, even, than a tiger. Because a tiger, you can kind of understand. But a Komodo dragon, it's a lot more that you're not merely the same species.

- 4.76 And poisonous snakes have been a formidable enemy of primates and of mankind for a very long period of time. Our earliest tree-dwelling relatives were preyed upon. What's a dragon? Preyed upon by birds of the air, that's the wings; by serpents of the ground, that's the scales; by fire, well, why? Well, what's a threat if you're a tree-dwelling primate? Fire, right. What's a dragon? Winged, clawed, fire-breathing bird. Right, so, the dragon idea is the idea of dangerous predator itself. It's an amalgam.
- 4.77 Predator is lion, tiger, bear, Komodo dragon, shark. That's a strange category because there's no features in common across those animals, apart from the fact that they'll eat you, which turns out to be a very cardinal reason for the categorization. Dragon is the imagistic equivalent of the concept of predator. And that's a deep rabbit hole as well, because you might say that there are few anomalies more compelling than a predator. But then that begs a question, as well— what is the worst of all possible predators?
- 4.78 There's a strange, emergent idea that develops, as I said, over thousands of years from the foundation of the Genesis narrative, the fall. Eve is tempted by a snake, but that snake is represented eventually as Satan. Well, why? Well, what's the worst predator? Thing that'll eat you. Thing that'll poison you. A thing that will poison your heart. The serpent in the heart of your enemy. The serpent in your own heart.
- 4.79 Those are steps of predation. And those are, what would you say? They are investigations into the depths of what it is that poses the most fundamental threat. The great catastrophes of the 20th century were not caused by predators, not of the natural kind. They were caused by what? Spiritual predators? OK, was that the Nazis, or was that the weakness in the hearts of people that allowed that spirit to possess a nation and then the world? Same question applies on the communist front.
- 4.80 And that means if it's the weakness in the hearts of the people who allowed themselves to be possessed, and that happened to virtually everyone, then what does that mean about you and your capability to withstand that temptation if it comes along? So that would be the temptation of power, let's say, or a kind of usurping nihilism in the case of the bloody communists.
- 4.81 And so, what is the most profound manifestation of chaos? That's a religious question. And the answer to that is, it's an answer that Milton, Dante, attempted to provide in a poetic form. It's like, what's the horror that's at the bottom of the worst horrors? For Dante, as I said yesterday, it was betrayal, because that's the inversion of love. For Milton, it was the usurping quality of the prideful intellect. And so, those are characterizations of the spirit that rules over hell.
- 4.82 And what's hell? The frame that aims down, or the structure of the frames that aim down, to the lowest possible point, which is the bottomless pit that's hell. And that's an eternal place, too, because it's, well, first of all, if you're there, then it feels eternal, but it's always there as a— it's always there as a possibility. It's a possibility. It's always under things. That's another way of thinking about it.

- 4.83 You know, it's small. This has been observed when countries, when societies go wildly astray. The pathway to perdition is a multitude of very small sins, usually avoidance, usually stepping back. You might be called upon to resist the transformations in an ideological direction. To fail to do that merely means that you turn a blind eye. And every time you do that, it seems like nothing. It seems like the safe thing to do, the secure thing to do, the sensible thing to do. But one step at a time, you end up somewhere you seriously don't want to be.
- 4.84 And so, the question that begs is: How much attention should you be paying? Well, there's an insistence that the spirit that dwelled on the water when the order that was good emerged was not only love, but the truth that will set you free. So what does that imply? It implies that— and the word, that's the logos. The word incarnate is the spirit that dwells on the water properly at the beginning of all things.
- 4.85 What's the word? Certainly the truth that will set you free. What does that mean? Don't state falsehoods. Right. Because you, you know this. It has to be true. If you're trying to produce a reality that's robust, as a consequence of your encounter with chaos, and you cast falsehoods on the water, you'll produce a reality that's false, obviously. And how can a reality that's false stand? It's preposterous.
- 4.86 You build something alongside something you know to be true and take shelter in that? How is that going to work? Well, temporarily. And so, why do people lie? To get something they don't deserve now and to avoid something they do deserve now. And it's a bad medium- to long-term strategy.
- 4.87 Here's a definition of faith. Faith is the proposition that whatever happens if you state the truth is the best thing that could happen, no matter what it looks like to you. Right. That's a foundational determination. Are you going to have faith in the truth? What does that mean? It means exactly what I just said.
- 4.88 So that's the underlying structure of a story. It's this collapse into chaos that, in any adventure story, in any romance, you see the emergence of a stable state to begin with, and then the introduction of a complex problem. And the complex problem requires a magical transformation. Otherwise, the story has no depth. The deeper the transformation, so the more levels of upward endeavor involved, the more profound the story.
- 4.89 And so a shallow story would involve a transformation that's sort of at hand for everyone. And a deep story would involve a transformation that remakes the character so completely that it's as if they're another person. And it's much harder to enjoy, I would say, a deep narrative like that. It requires serious attention and contemplation. So it's much more than mere light entertainment. But even if it's merely light entertainment, which means it does engage you, it inevitably portrays a transformation.

- 4.90 You can see that happening in a romantic adventure where someone has a relationship and, because of their own character or logical faults or bad luck, things fall apart, and they're in a state of disarray. And then they find someone new. And to attract that person, they have to make changes to how they relate to the world and they grow in consequence. And they come together and they live happily ever after. And that's a romantic comedy.
- 4.91 And an adventure story has the same structure, although in the tool and obstacle world, you could say, instead of in the relational world. The tool and obstacle world, by the way, that's the world that men are more comfortable in and more particularly enjoy inhabiting. And the relational world is the world that women are more likely to be interested in.
- 4.92 Interest is the biggest differentiator between men and women that we know. Women are more interested in people than men are. On average, it's quite a large difference. And men are more interested in things. And that's quite a large difference. There's echoes of that in chimpanzees, even. You can see some sex differentiation in toy choice, for example, among chimpanzees. So it's a deep division. And the world of adventure, that's a world that has more to do with, well, the tool-obstacle world.
- 4.93 Now, if you have an extremely well-balanced narrative, you have a romantic adventure. And that's a good way of contemplating the proper structure of your life, is that, if you're fortunate, ultimately fortunate, then it's a romantic adventure. And that's a challenge. It's a challenge on the social front to keep the romance alive. It's a challenge on the tool and obstacle front to keep the adventure moving forward. You have to dance attentively to make that happen.
- 4.94 And the reward will be a life that's rich and meaningful. That's an echo of life eternal. And if you embody that pattern optimally, then you trod the path of Abraham and become the embodiment of the spirit of the father of nations, if you're a man. That's right.
- 4.95 This is a complicated idea. When things collapse, what collapses exactly? And how do you characterize the potential that remains? Well, I attempted to portray in this diagram that anomaly even demolishes the boundary between spirit and matter. What do I mean by that? See, if you encounter a new situation, a new person, a new set of circumstances, you don't know what's going on. And so there's an inchoate, unstructured possibility in front of you. And then what you do is, you divide that into spirit and world—matter, let's say, or what matters, for that matter.
- 4.96 Why? When you establish a relationship with someone, you learn who they are. So let's call that the material side, so to speak, because you're learning about something external to you. Or if you investigate a complex piece of machinery, you learn about the machinery. But you also learn about yourself. And so, in that encounter with something

new, you pull out spirit, which is personality, and you expand and develop that, and then you also generate the world around that.

4.97 And so, a deep enough anomaly intermingles them so that what you're encountering is the possibility of a new world that you could establish in consequence of investigation and transformation, but also a new you, a new value structure. So, psyche and matter are extracted from something more primordial, which is this realm of possibility, which is the intermingling of everything that makes itself manifest to you when your provisional frame collapses.

4.98 Right. OK, so let's simplify this to some degree. I tried to show here how the object transforms with the frame. So, I think the best way to think about an object apart from tool and obstacle, let's say, is that an object, let's say a tool, something that you sit on like the chair, is something that has a penumbra of possibility around it. So I used the beer bottle example yesterday.

4.99 You can stand on that chair and use it as a ladder. You can use it as a prop in a play. You can take it apart. This is what Pinocchio does in the belly of the whale. You can take it apart and build a fire, and that helps you escape from the dragon, which is obviously what fire did for us, by the way, since it kept the predators at bay. Pinocchio was a master of fire in that representation, and that's what freed him from the belly of the whale.

4.100 So, the phenomenon, the chair, whatever it is that you're apprehending, has the function that's specified by your aim and a wealth of potential possibilities around it, and that's all part of the object. OK, so how might you construe this? Well, imagine I said the thing in itself there. Imagine that that's an orchard viewed from the air. OK, so how do you represent that?

4.101 Well, the simplest representation is object one. It's a rectangle. That's a pretty useful representation if you want to know how to go around the orchard. You saw when Google Maps started to map out the world, its initial maps of buildings, of places, were empty squares. The detail fills in. You see icons. You see low resolution representations of what's there.

4.102 That's why you can watch the Simpsons or South Park. This primitive animation where everything's circles and squares, moving the way people move, that's enough. It's a placeholder for reality. Your object perceptions are like that, too. They're icons. I only see the front of you. I can't see beneath the surface. I certainly can't see down into your molecular structure. I can't see up into the social structures that you're a part of. You're a thin slice in time and in space and very much perspectivized. And so, is that real?

4.103 You know one of the things Picasso was doing with those strange paintings of people from the front and the side? Well, his hypothesis was that that's more real because there you are. Don't move your head. And there you are. And why wouldn't I paint both

of those at once? If I was trying to portray you, what makes the head-on vision more real? It's less real. So there's many ways to look at something.

- 4.104** Well, I laid some out here. The simplest one is a square. If you wanted to zoom in and adopt a higher resolution representation, you can represent four squares or four rectangles with pathways through them, or an even higher resolution representation is object three. That would enable you to plot a trajectory through the trees. The object four is an amalgam of one and two, and then object five is almost as high resolution as this so-called thing in itself.
- 4.105** Why would you use an icon? Look, if you're doing graphic work on a computer, do you use the highest resolution file? No, you use the lowest resolution file that works for your purposes. Right, that's exactly how perception works. You use the lowest resolution representation that suits your purposes.
- 4.106** Here's proof. There's a series of experiments that were done. They started at Harvard. Dan Simon was the professor who was integrally involved in this research, although he didn't establish the field, if I remember correctly. So here's an experiment. You're walking through a university campus as a tourist, and an undergraduate comes up to you with a map and asks you for directions. All right, so you start interacting.
- 4.107** While you're doing that, workmen who are relatively rude come walking between you with a door. There's two of them. The person you're talking to grabs the door. You don't see him because the door is here. He continues, and one of the people holding the door takes the map and keeps talking to you. 70% of the people don't notice the switch. Right.
- 4.108** Here's another experiment. Why? All undergraduates who are asking for directions in the university yard are interchangeable. Why? Because you don't need to know anything about them, apart from what's relevant to the task at hand. You don't even see it.
- 4.109** Here's another famous experiment. There's three people dressed in black and there's three people dressed in white, and they're playing basketball, bouncing a basketball between them. The black-dressed people to the black people, the white-dressed people to the white people. Your job is to count how many times the white people bounce and pass or throw the basketball. You have about 45 seconds. You do that.
- 4.110** During this—now, so these people fill the screen, the video screen. It's not a distance shot. Everyone's clear. While that happens, a man dressed in a gorilla suit comes right into the middle of the camera and beats his chest for five seconds and then leaves. 70, 80% of the people don't see the gorilla. Why? Because you see what's relevant to your aim. And so that's change blindness. There's a whole perceptual field that studies change blindness, how opaque we are to the transformations of the world.

- 4.111 So what do you see? You see any change that interferes with what you're doing. Right, so that's what you become conscious of. So, the pathway, you walk, the things that you use or that interfere at hand, if something emerges that is an impediment, you see it. Otherwise, it's invisible.
- 4.112 And I would recommend, you can consider this, go online. Try some of these change blindness experiments. You will not believe how blind you are. And learning that's extremely useful because a question when you're in trouble always is: What am I missing? What presuppositions led me here? What do I have to shed or sacrifice to transform my viewpoint in this situation? What am I not attending? An infinite landscape of possibility.
- 4.113 Now, so that's a compression of reality into the icon and into the absolutely invisible. That's how we simplify the world so that we can exist in it with our limited capacity for comprehension. A word is a second-order compression. So, object one. Rectangle. So what does rectangle mean? Rectangle is a sound that represents an icon of a phenomena. And so, when I speak, what happens in the background of your imagination is the word is unpacked into the icon that represents the thing. That's how we communicate.
- 4.114 I don't know if this has happened to you. When I was a kid and I would read fiction, I could really see the characters in my imagination. I was often less than thrilled when I went to a movie because the characters didn't match my imagination. As I got older and kept reading fiction, although I did less and less of that as I got older, I found that my imagination had almost ceased. I'd just read and I could still understand, and I think it was because I had automatized the image, comprehension so completely that it became unconscious.
- 4.115 I was just reading directly from the words with no intermediary of imagination. Gain in efficiency, a loss in richness of experience. Very frequently the case with gain in efficiency. That's how we compress the world to communicate. The world's complex. Compress it into an icon, a tile, a placeholder, the simplest representation that suffices for the task. It's computationally less intense. That's why you use thumbnails on a computer, instead of full resolution images. You don't need them. The detail is irrelevant.
- 4.116 Why is the detail irrelevant? Because you can get where you want to go with a simpler representation, and you certainly want that. A word simplifies even more. It compresses the world even more. There's real power in that, because you can refer to so many things with words that aren't there.
- 4.117 But obviously, the reality that's portrayed by the words is less rich than the reality that would be portrayed by an image, or certainly by the phenomena in question. There's images that I'm going to show you that have literally taken thousands of years to

unpack. There's so much information in one image that it's almost inexhaustible. Of course, the thing it represents is far more inexhaustible than that.

Lecture 5: Hierarchies of Being

At a glance — Hierarchies of being, opened with a personal story.

- 5.1 I'll tell you a story. When I lived in Montreal in the 1980s, I was typing away on my computer. So what does that mean? Well, I was kind of aware of the keys, although I'm a pretty accomplished typist and was then. And so, mostly I was paying attention to the words that I was writing, and mostly I was paying attention to the screen or a focal point on the screen, and mostly to the words and maybe the phrases. Then I'd bounce up and down from word and phrase to sentence and to paragraph. But that was my field of apprehension.
- 5.2 The computer died. That happens. It's very annoying. That's an anomaly. OK, so what do you do when the computer dies? What the hell do you know about computers? I don't know, maybe you know a lot. I didn't know much. This was in 1986. Computers were relatively new. What did I know? Turn the computer off and on. Maybe it'll work again. Reboot it. Reduce it to its beginnings and start again. It's a very comical thing that computers work the same way. Back to stage one, they reemerge. So I did that, but the computer didn't go on.
- 5.3 So then I went to get a light to see what the hell was going on. But then when I plugged the light in, the light didn't work. And so then I thought, "Must be a fuse." So I went to the fuse box, but all the fuses were fine, but none of the lights in the house worked. So then I thought, "Maybe there's a blackout." So then I went outside, and there were no lights. And then I found out there were no lights in eastern North America.
- 5.4 And then I found out it was because the sun was unstable. So there was a solar flare. Every 100 years, there's a solar flare of sufficient magnitude to destroy everything that works electromagnetically on the surface of the planet. So if you want to worry about something, you could worry about that. The last major event happened in 1880, something like that. It lit telegraphers on fire. Right.
- 5.5 It produces electromagnetic pulse. It travels through the electronic equipment and devastates them. That's what happens when you explode an atomic weapon in the air, like a hydrogen bomb. One sufficiently powerful hydrogen bomb exploded over North America, everything electronic is dead. So in any case, I didn't know that the reason I couldn't type the next word was because the sun had become unreliable.
- 5.6 That's a good example of nested dependencies. It's like, this is predictable. Well, it's predictable if the electrical system is working in the house. Well, what's that dependent on? Well, is the grid working? Well, what's that dependent on? Well, is the sun doing what it's supposed to? Generally, generally, but not always, the answer to that is yes. Thank god. So you zero it out as a constant and you don't attend to it, except when you have to. And I think the power was out for a long time. That was one of the worst blackouts that had ever occurred. We're not very resilient against such things.

- 5.7 But that's a very good example of the complexity of things, right? Of how much that you take for granted has to stay constant under the surface for the things that you attend to, to maintain their viability. Now, obviously, an apocalyptic movie, an apocalyptic catastrophe, is a description of how the world goes astray when something very fundamental goes wrong.
- 5.8 There are mythological representations of the way things go wrong. One of them, classic one, is that the evil queen, so that would be the negative element of chaos, makes itself manifest. That's a natural disaster. That's a good way of thinking about that.
- 5.9 Another prodrome to a catastrophe is the malevolence or blindness of the king. That's Scar in the Lion King. Remember, when Scar takes office, a drought emerges and everyone starts to starve. Is that a natural disaster or is that the insufficiency of the king?
- 5.10 Here's an example. When the hurricane hit New Orleans, it was a catastrophe. Why? Act of God. Really? The Army Corps of Engineers built the dikes to withstand one storm in 100 years. The Dutch build their dikes to withstand one storm in 10,000 years. Right. So when there's a storm in Holland, it's like, it's another storm. When there's a once-in-a-century storm in New Orleans, then the city is flooded.
- 5.11 So, then what's the problem? Well, how about the corrupt municipal administration? How about the millions of dollars that are siphoned from proper maintenance? How about the corruption in the individuals who engage in that fraudulent and dangerous behavior? So then is the stability of the world dependent on the integrity of the individual? Right. Is that what keeps the natural catastrophe and the evil king at bay? Well, that's a question we'll continue to investigate.
- 5.12 When your car breaks down, and you have to figure out why and what to do, well, let's see. What do you do? You have your car. What's your car? Four wheels, a motor, transmission, the doors, the body. No. Your car is a conveyance to move you from point A to point B. It's a tool. It stops being a car when it doesn't move you from point A to B.
- 5.13 What is your car when it stops moving you from point A to point B? And you might say, well, it's still a car, but it's not a car, because a car is defined by its functional utility in relationship to a goal, even at the perceptual level. If you keep looking at your immobile car like it's a car, you're not going to get anywhere. So, what do you do? Well, maybe you think, "I'm not buying another one of those junky Chinese cars." Why? Because the geopolitical situation is unstable, and the Chinese Communist Party isn't reliable. How about that?
- 5.14 So is that the right level at which you solve the car problem, or do you go down? Do you think, well, was there a flaw in the subcomponents? Is there a mechanical flaw? Do I get a mechanic to look? Well, what do I know about cars, and how do I know the mechanic won't rip me off? And I'm a fool in that regard because I don't have any

assertiveness and I can't make my case known. I'm a real target for rip-offs. And so now my car has collapsed into my, what would you say, malleability at the hands of unscrupulous mechanics.

- 5.15** And that's a much broader problem because maybe you should straighten the hell up and figure out how to deal with it. And so, the reason I'm telling you this is because, when the frame collapses, when the predictable no longer makes itself manifest, there's a search up and down the hierarchy of being to find the proper level of analysis to solve the problem. You see this when you have arguments. You'll see this if you're married or if you get married.
- 5.16** Part of what you're doing in an argument in a marriage is specifying the simplest possible level of resolution. And that's hard because it's very easy, especially when tempers rise, when anomaly occurs, something unpredictable makes itself manifest, to immediately move to the foundation and throw the whole arrangement up in the air. "Maybe we should just get divorced." It's like, don't start there. Don't start there. Go there with caution.
- 5.17** Simplest possible solution is the best initial attempt. You analyze the situation and see, well, there's a fundamental attribution error that social psychologists observe that people generally make. If someone cuts you off while you're driving, you'll curse at them. Why? Because you assume, iconically, that there's something wrong with the person. In all probability, unless they're particularly pathological, they were just responding to the demands of the situation, and you would have done the same thing.
- 5.18** It's much more complex to do a situational analysis than to cast aspersions on someone's character. One of the things you can do in the confines of a marital dispute or dispute with anyone, even yourself, is think, OK, what's the broader context? What were the determining factors for my behavior? How much did they play a role in setting the situation in the direction that it went?
- 5.19** And so, all the things we see exist at multiple levels, simultaneously. So there's an element of your being that exists at the quantum level and at the subatomic level and the atomic level and the molecular level, the level of organ, and then the level that's phenomenal, the level at which you experience and I can see.
- 5.20** But then you're embedded in a family, and the family is embedded in a community, and the community is embedded in a state, and that state is embedded in the nation. And the nation is embedded in a biological, you see, ecosystem. And the biological ecosystem is nested in what? A cosmological enterprise. And so on up, as far as we can imagine.
- 5.21** It turns out that human beings are kind of midway up that ladder, that we're, if you go by powers of 10, which is a logarithmic scale, we're kind of in the middle. We're about as much bigger as the quantum level as the cosmos is bigger than us. Now, that's not exactly right, but it gives— we're a little bigger than that, as it turns out. But that gives

you an approximation of how we're situated. It's an immense complexity downward, an immense complexity upward.

- 5.22** And where the problem is, isn't obvious. And this isn't irrelevant. A mutation caused by a cosmic ray can give you cancer. An alteration, the wrong alteration at the subatomic level at the wrong time means you're not there anymore. And the same thing occurs at higher levels, is that, I don't know how much of your attention you should pay to politics because it would be lovely if the political was stable enough so you could concentrate on the local.
- 5.23** But now and then, you probably have to climb the ladder somewhat and see things from a broader view because the problem you're having with your children might be the school that they're in. And then what are you going to do about that? What are you going to do about that? Are you going to complain or are you going to do something about it? Are you going to notice that, as well as being an individual, you're a member of a complex polity and that you have responsibility to attend to its function or else?
- 5.24** Right. And so you do exist at all those levels. And generally, that's irrelevant because they're all functioning if you're lucky, and it's a rare situation. But you have an indeterminate responsibility to keep the order established at every single one of those levels. And what would I say about that? To keep the order. That's mental health. We're very foolish in our conceptualization of mental health because we think it's something you carry around inside you. It's mental.
- 5.25** Try being—what did my neighbor say to me once? "A mother's only as happy as her most unhappy child." Right, so does that make mental health subjective? It's like, how about you're mentally healthy in a highly dysfunctional family. Seems improbable. Right, so you could think of mental health as a subset of health per se. And then you could think of health as the harmonious functioning of every single one of those levels. When things are optimized, that's what's happening.
- 5.26** I think that's what music represents, because music is made out of micro elements that are aggregated, many things playing their role. When they're all playing their role properly, you get this sense of harmony, and it compels a kind of rhythmic movement that you can adjust yourself to. And that's a representation of how things should function if you are paying sufficient attention to all the levels at which you exist simultaneously.
- 5.27** And I would say, if you're inclined to do that, that will keep you busy enough so that you won't be wondering what your life means. You'll have plenty to do, plenty to do. What do you do when you search up and down a system to determine whether the reason your computer broke was because you're an idiot and you bought a cheap brand because you have no idea how to spend money, or because you bought a cheap Chinese knockoff because you're not paying enough attention to geopolitics?

- 5.28 You look for this level of resolution that allows the simplest solution to the problem. That's a problem, too, because maybe you want the simplest solution that also improves you enough so that you don't run into the same stupid problem again. So, what am I saying? Things fall apart when something unexpected occurs. And there are a lot of parts. There's a lot of parts.
- 5.29 And part of what's daunting when things fall apart is, what exactly am I looking at? What is my car now that it isn't moving? Is it an expensive problem that's going to plague me for the rest of my life? Maybe I don't have enough money for a new car. Does that mean I don't go to work? We talked yesterday, or in the other lecture, about what that might mean with regards to reflections on your own character development. And so, the landscape of possibility that's opened up by a serious anomaly is very, very wide. And so, how do you negotiate it?
- 5.30 OK, let's continue. Let's continue unpacking this. So here's another way of thinking about an object. So what do we have here? This is a map of an object. Phenomenological structure at its center. What does that mean? That's what you see. So what's underneath that? Well, we talked about this. The subcomponents of the system. Well, that's obviously germane in the case of us because we have all sorts of subcomponents, and they can go wrong, and they do.
- 5.31 And we've become increasingly aware of them as a species and as individuals as we've progressed, and we can repair some of them, and thank God for that. And we've moved pretty much to the bottom of things, the quantum level. There is a smallest length, by the way. That's the Planck length. It's very small. It's a very small length. There's a unit of time that's the smallest unit of time, too. We have some conceptualization of that. We have some conceptualization of what exists on the largest possible scale.
- 5.32 But everything that is partakes in all of those levels simultaneously. And so that's a useful thing to know. And there's a specific reason I'm telling you this, apart from trying to alert you to how complex the problem of anomaly is. Anomaly is the world revealing itself in the midst of your simplifying presuppositions, in the midst of your game.
- 5.33 So what is that world? Well, it's all these things at the same time. It's all these things everywhere at the same time. And it's the past and the present and the future as well, all amalgamated into whatever it is that's making itself manifest in front of you. So, downward subcomponent structure, molecular, atomic, subatomic; upward, cultural subcomponents, natural subcomponents. All these things that surround us.
- 5.34 I think that's what's represented by tree of life images. I think the Scandinavian, this is Yggdrasil, which is the Scandinavian world tree. And it's the same tree, you might say, as the tree of life in the center of the story of Genesis. I think what it represents is this branching upward from the micro realm to the cosmic realm, because this is a cosmic tree. That's its technical—it's an ash tree, but it's a cosmic tree. This is the structure of reality, as far as the ancient Scandinavians were concerned.

- 5.35 At the bottom, you see, there are snakes. Same as in the Christian concept, there's snakes at the bottom. They gnaw away at the roots of the tree, but the tree is replenished as they gnaw. And so that's the chaos that's at the bottom of things. And then that branches up into this domain of order that's circumscribed there in the center. See, there's a serpent that's biting its own tail, surrounding the mountain.
- 5.36 That's like Pride Rock in the Lion King, the center of things, the place where the staff of tradition is planted, the place where the king rules from, the place where Odin, who's the highest god in the Scandinavian pantheon, rules. And so that's a structure of order. It's a pyramid. It's a hierarchy. That's the patriarchy that's at the center of the circle. That's part of this tree. That's the phenomenological circle.
- 5.37 I showed you in the previous diagram that there are levels of things, and one of those levels is naturally apprehended by you. Well, that's what that's representing, is that there's a level in this structure that reaches up from the foundation to the cosmos that is the domain, well, in this case, of gods and man. That's a phenomenological representation, because it's a representation of the world as it's experienced.
- 5.38 There's a center that you constitute, that the world is circumscribed around. And there are centers that are constituted by your home, for example. You, in your home, in your town, in your state, in your nation—those are concentric circles of stability that rest like the discs in this representation on this structure that stretches upward from the void at the bottom to the cosmos at the top. And so, that's the tree of life. That's Asgard. That's the rainbow bridge, if I remember correctly, stretching up from the gateway on the left. So, that's a tree of life representation.
- 5.39 OK, so back to the frame. Well, we'll just reorient ourselves, right? We have the basic story. I'm here. I'm heading there. I have strategies of behavior and attention that I'm implementing. OK. I told you a little bit about the story of Jacob's ladder. Jacob's a bad guy. He starts his life as a twin. He's the second-born. And he's already fighting with his brother for dominance. So he's a usurping spirit like Lucifer, like Cain. He's already battling for power with his brother in the womb. He comes out clutching his brother's heel, like a fighting move.
- 5.40 And that's the origin of his name. And Jacob's father, Isaac, and his mother, Rachel, their family is fractured. So Esau, who's Jacob's older brother, allies himself with Isaac, and Jacob allies himself with his mother, Rachel. Now, Esau is a very masculine personality. He loves to be outside. He's a hunter. He brings his father venison. That's part of the reason that his father favors him. He's covered with rather thick hair. He's not particularly civilized. He's kind of impulsive. He's a man of the wild, you could say.
- 5.41 And Jacob is a tent-dweller. He's a mama's boy. He cooks. He stays at home. And he conspires with his mother to take what's his brother's due. In those archaic societies, the firstborn had double the inheritance share. And there were reasons for that. If you're an agriculturalist or herding people, you don't want to divide your resources

among all your children across multiple generations, because everybody ends up with one square foot of land and half a goat, and then they all die.

- 5.42** So the rule was that the firstborn took the lion's share, and the other children had some inheritance, but mostly they were required from day one to fend for themselves. And everyone knew that. So the firstborn had this priority, this right. Jacob and Rachel conspired to steal that inheritance.
- 5.43** One day Esau comes back from a hunt and he's famished, and Jacob is cooking up some lentil stew in the kitchen over the fire. And he asks his brother, Esau asks his brother if he can have some food. And Jacob says, "You have to trade your rights of inheritance to me." And Esau, who's a little impulsive and a little wild, as we saw, impulsively says yes and assigns his rights to his brother, which is a treacherous act, even though Esau stepped into it.
- 5.44** And then Isaac, who's getting old at this point, gets wind of that, and he's not happy about it. And he's preparing to die, and he wants to deliver a blessing to his sons as a final act. And so he prepares a special double blessing for Esau to console him for his loss and to replace it with a new advantage, say. But Jacob conspires with his mother, and he dresses in goatskin and presents himself as Esau, and then he gets the inheritance and the blessing. And so Esau is not happy about that, and he shouldn't be.
- 5.45** OK, so that's a fractured family, right? There's misaligned aim, the mother and the father, husband and the wife. They're not on the same page. And the brothers fragment, and that exacerbates their sibling rivalry, and they become enemies. And Esau is angry enough after the last betrayal to want to kill Jacob, so Jacob leaves. And so that means he leaves; so that's a new beginning. And he leaves maybe because something anomalous happened. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 5.46** But it looks like he also determines—he gets away from his mother. And so maybe that's an OK thing. Now, so it's a catastrophe that his family collapses and he has to leave, but it's also a place of new beginning. And it appears that, on the journey to his uncle's place, because that's where he heads to, he decides that he's going to be a new guy. And so now he's got this opportunity in transition.
- 5.47** And so he builds an altar. And an altar is this upward—it's a place of sacrifice, an altar. What is a sacrifice? A sacrifice is what you give up to accomplish an aim. I used to ask my students in my Maps of Meaning class—most of them were children of first-generation immigrants, many of them—said, "What did your parents sacrifice so you could be here?" Well, the Asians, in particular, they knew the answer to that, believe me, because their parents had let them know quite frequently just exactly what they sacrificed to provide them with that opportunity.
- 5.48** What does it mean to sacrifice? It means to let go. It means to dispense with. It means to work. Why? Because when you work at one thing, you sacrifice everything else you could be doing to that work. You sacrifice time, you sacrifice energy, you sacrifice

attention. Why? You sacrifice upward if you're wise. So, to build it now, people had to act this out before they understood it, because they're trying to get a grip on the structure of reality itself in the human form.

- 5.49** What's the human reality? Upward, voluntary sacrifice. It took people—we don't understand that consciously now. It's been represented in action, the building of an altar. It's been represented in story, the description of sacrificial processes. The Bible is replete with that. Once you understand that sacrifice is the foundation of existence, that you give up things to attend to anything, the question emerges—what is the highest possible form of sacrifice? That's the only question.
- 5.50** What is the most effective work? Cain, the first man, Cain and Abel, the first real human beings, because they are born after the fall in history, Cain makes sacrifices that are not acceptable to God, and fails, and becomes bitter and resentful in consequence, and then murderous, and then genocidal, and then the flood comes. Right. So, right at the beginning, there's a juxtaposition of two patterns of sacrifice, one false that's rejected, one predicated on pride.
- 5.51** Cain complains to God, says, "My brother Abel, everything he does works." And God says, "If you did well, you would be accepted." And so it's so remarkable. It's such a sophisticated psychological account. Cain's claim is, the reason he's bitter is because he's rejected. God's claim is, Cain is bitter because he's not bringing his best to the table, and it's unacceptable.
- 5.52** OK, so now Cain pushes back against God, making the claim that the cosmos itself is structured improperly, such that Cain's work is rejected. So he throws the accusation back on God, "What the hell kind of world is this, where my brother does so well, and I fail?"
- 5.53** And God says, "You think your misery is a consequence of your failure. But that's wrong. Here's the real story. You didn't bring your best to the table, and you refuse to learn in the aftermath of your error. And in consequence, something came to visit you. Sin. Sin crouches at your door like a sexually aroused predatory animal, and you invited it in to have its way with you. And that's why you're bitter."
- 5.54** And it's a description of the emergence of resentment and malevolence that's unbelievably sophisticated, because the economic account, the Marxist account, is that failure breeds resentment, let's say, low status, oppression, the proletariat against the bourgeoisie, the oppressed against the oppressor, that the causal pathway is privation to resentment.
- 5.55** The biblical account is no. There's a variety of interpretations of failure to hit the mark. One is that you weren't aiming for it. The other is that you're not making the right sacrifices. Another is, you have something to learn; there's things that you could change. Another is, God's created order is insufficient because I'm failing. That's Cain's interpretation.

- 5.56** But worse, this sin that God speaks of is a personified spirit that offers itself as a temptation. "I'm going to give you the easy way out of your problems. You're a victim. Everything that's happened to you negative, that's not your fault. Everything that anyone else has attained as a consequence of their efforts, that's arbitrary. It should be yours. And the world's unfair because it isn't." And you have to open the door to that and you have to invite it in, which is what Cain does.
- 5.57** And then the sexual metaphor, sexually aroused predatory animal, something that will consume you. But why sexually aroused? Because it screws with your head, how about that? That's the least blunt interpretation. What does that mean? You watch someone go sideways, seriously sideways. So what happens? They invite something in. They're not sure what it is. It's very, very tempting. And then they dwell on it and dwell on it and dwell on it and brood on it and fantasize about it.
- 5.58** You wonder how people go from ordinary high school kid to high school shooter? It's like a few thousand hours of fantasizing is a necessary precondition for taking that final step. So something comes in, that you invite in. Remember vampires, right? You have to invite them in. So that's what God accuses Cain of, invites a spirit in.
- 5.59** OK, Jacob does the opposite here. He sees his catastrophic pattern of failure, and he removes himself from the situation, and he thinks, "I'd rather aim up. I'd rather aim up." So he builds an altar, and he indicates his willingness to make the proper sacrifice. A sacrifice is an offering of something valuable upward.
- 5.60** The archaic accounts are very concretized, right? Because, so, Abel, for example, when he makes a sacrifice, he takes the best animal of his flock and he butchers it, and then he takes the choicest cut, and then he burns it. He immolates it; and then the smoke rises, and it rises upward. And that's where God is, hypothetically, and God can detect the quality of the offering by the smoke. Well, that's very concretized, right?
- 5.61** But it's trying to represent something. It's acting out something. It's like play-acting. And we understand things by acting them out first. That's how children understand things. That's why they play. They imitate first, they embody first, and then maybe they abstract. And they can engage in rule-governed games without knowing the rules, right? They just know the pattern. They know the behavioral pattern, like animals.
- 5.62** And so human beings, they were struggling with the notion of how we should orient ourselves in the world. And the drama became the notion of upward sacrifice. Offer your best to the highest possible aim. Well, what's your best? And what's the highest possible aim? Those questions still remain in, what would you say, shrouded in mystery.
- 5.63** Well, what's the definition? God is the highest best. That's a definition. What's your sacrifice? Whatever is necessary to put you in sync with that highest aim. So that's still not very concrete, but it's a start. And the story of Abel, it's a very foundational story, indicates that Abel is the spirit who is willing to bring his best to the table. And the

insistence in the story is that the first question of conscience should be, are you bringing your best to the table?

- 5.64** Right. And that's what Cain fails to do. He externalizes blame. He takes no responsibility. And that embitters him. His countenance falls. He's depressed and angry. Then he's jealous and resentful. Then he's murderous. Then his descendants are genocidal, because that spirit propagates, that spirit of bitterness and resentment, till it permeates the whole society. Then the flood comes.
- 5.65** And I learned that. I learned that by reading Solzhenitsyn, for example, in his description of how the Soviet Union decayed, when everyone went along with the lies. Everyone went along with the lies. Everyone turned a blind eye. Everyone allowed themselves to be possessed by this resentful notion that anyone who had anything had stolen it. That's a pathway to poverty. Property is theft. When you hear people saying that, it's time to head for the hills.
- 5.66** OK, so, Jacob, he doesn't do what Cain does. He reappraises. He thinks, "OK, it's time for a change. It's me. It's time for a change." And he builds this altar and he indicates his vow to offer up whatever is necessary to make peace with the spirit of reality. And then he has the dream. That's Jacob's ladder. And that's the dream of this structure that spirals upward into what's ineffable, incomprehensible. At the pinnacle of that is God. That's a definition.
- 5.67** So here's a way of thinking about it. Imagine the set of all good things. What are they unified by? Well, they're unified by their goodness. Well, do you accept that there's a set of good things? Do you accept that the notion of good is a viable notion? Well, you pursue what's good and you avoid what is bad or evil. So, you orient yourself and your attention and your behavior in keeping with a hypothesis of comparative value.
- 5.68** All good things are alike in that they're good. What's the essence of good? That's God. That's a definition. And it's a very archaic definition. For St. Augustine, God was the "summum bonum", which was the sum of all that's good. I don't think that's a precise formulation. It's not a sum. It's more like, it's like the essence of what all good things share in common. Right.
- 5.69** So, the question, "Do you believe in God?", is very much like the question, "Do you believe in the good?" Now, you might say, well, it's more complex than that because God is presented as a personality. It's like, not exactly. In the Old Testament, in particular, God in the final analysis is incomprehensible. I'll give you an example of that.
- 5.70** So, Moses is a faithful servant of God. And as a reward, God says he'll show himself to Moses. Now, he does that to some degree in the episode with the burning bush. We already talked about that. Moses takes something seriously and gets to the bottom of it. He finds something divine at the bottom, because what's the foundation is divine. That's the definition. But he gives Moses later in his life a vision of himself, of God. But

there's rules, because you can't just see the infinite spirit of all things. You're not equipped for that. It's too much.

5.71 So, God puts Moses between two narrow cliffs, so he can just see out a crack. And then he says, "You can get a glimpse of my back as I pass by." So he gets just this fragmentary vision of the divine, which is all he can tolerate without being destroyed by the experience. And so, there's a continual insistence in every religious literature, I would say, that what's at the pinnacle is not comprehensible. It's outside of the categories of time and space, and it's outside of the categories of being itself.

5.72 And so, you conceptualize it as a personality, I suppose, because it has those aspects in a sense, but also because that's the most effective manner in which you can establish a relationship with it. Is the relationship real? Not if you're talking about the relationship you have with a chair. It depends on what you mean by real. When you ask a question, "Is God real?", well, first of all, God is beyond the categories of real and unreal. The question doesn't even make sense.

5.73 But it's also a foolish question because you're taking something fundamental, the essence of good, and you're saying, you're trying to draw an equal sign to real. But to do that, you have to presuppose a definition of reality that's more fundamental than the thing you're trying to interrogate. You don't get to do that. When you ask a question that fundamental, both parts of the equation are up for grabs.

5.74 What do you mean "real"? How about, reject the reality and end up in hell? How's that for real? You think, "I don't believe in hell." It's like, pray you never go there. Seriously. So there's plenty of places you can encounter hell on Earth. And if you're fortunate, you won't, especially unprepared. So, be careful what you regard as real, and maybe watch. You avoid suffering. You pursue meaning. Is that not a definition of real—how you orient yourself, what you pursue? That's a definition of real.

5.75 Now, you can substitute a definition. You can say, what's real is the objective material. It's like, fine, go ahead; see what happens. That's a game. And it has a structure and it has consequences. Nietzsche outlined the consequences of that game. What's the advantage? Technological mastery of a sort, with its attendant dangers. What's the cost? Nihilism, susceptibility to ideology, the delusion that you can create your own values, a kind of anomie and aimlessness. Is that an indication of the insufficiency of the concept? That's what we're trying to figure out at the moment.

5.76 OK, so now Jacob dreams of this ladder stretching upward into the infinite good, the reverse of a vision of hell. And that's after he makes the vow. And so, what it means, really, is that, with Jacob's decision to transform, he's accepted the reality of the existence of a metaphysic of good and evil. He was an evil man, self-admittedly, and now he's decided to be a good man. And so he's lifted his eyes to the stars. He's established a relationship with the essence of what's good.

- 5.77** And he sleeps, and he has a vision of this structure that unites heaven at the pinnacle with Earth, and that there are messengers coming up and down this structure. Revelations, inspirations. People say, "Well, I was inspired." Well, what does inspire mean? It means, a message comes to you from a higher source. What does that mean? You get a revelation of a new state of being that's superordinate to the one that you occupy. Is that a divine voice? It's a matter of definition. It partakes in that structure.
- 5.78** Sometimes you can get an intuition, a revelation that's of life-altering consequence, which will strike you at minimum as the commandment of the divine. And sometimes that comes in the form of a prod and a warning, and sometimes it comes in the form of an invitation. And it's a rare person who isn't— well, everyone experiences that at a certain level, because the mere fact that things attract your interest or bother your conscience is an indication that you're subordinate to some moral structure.
- 5.79** Now and then, a voice from on high appears and makes itself available to you, or a temptation from the depths. And those are rare occurrences in life, but it's a rare person who hasn't had that experience, especially in times of duress.
- 5.80** So how could we take apart Jacob's ladder? Well, I tried to do this in a very formulaic manner here in a way. I want to show you how these frames of reference are nested. OK, so here's an example.
- 5.81** Imagine you're trying to teach a child to set the table, and you say to them— they are three—"Set the table, or clean your room," and you come back in 10 minutes, and nothing's happened. The room is exactly the same. And one of the reasons for that, apart from the fact that it's difficult, the child might avoid it, or perhaps not, because maybe he or she is very inclined to please and likes to work, they don't know what that means.
- 5.82** So how do you teach them? Well, you can do it by example because they can copy. But here's how you do it. Say, "OK, kid, you see that teddy bear?" OK, so that—parents tend to interact with their children at their level of comprehension or slightly above, slightly above to pull them along to increased comprehension. Parents naturally talk to their children in a language that slightly exceeds their current level of apprehension. "See that teddy bear?" "Yes."
- 5.83** OK, so what have you established then? The child has organized his psychophysiology by that point with sufficient sophistication, so that the microstructures of looking at the teddy bear, knowing what that sound means and looking at the teddy bear, are there. That's a lot of work, right? To do that, the kid had to learn to crawl and then learn to walk, and then learn to use his hands, and then learn to decode language, and then to associate words with concepts, and then to associate that abstraction with movement done voluntarily under a command. That's a lot of pre-preparation.
- 5.84** But you test it out. You say, "Can you find the teddy bear?" It's like, he looks. OK, now you know that he's got that. Now you want to scaffold that. You say, "See that space on

the shelf? Do you know your toy box?" You can point to that. The point establishes the aim. The kid says, "Yes." "Pick up the teddy bear." He's got this mastered. "Pick up the teddy bear. Open the container, put it in. Good work." And then you do that with 150 different things. And you say, "That's how you clean your room." And all of that other complexity had to be established to make that happen.

- 5.85** So he's setting the table, and he's two, and he has to reach up on the table because he's too short to see the surface. And you say, "Go over to the drawer with the knives and forks, and find a knife, hopefully not too sharp, and pick it up, and then carry it to the table, and put it on top." So the kid goes over, does that, goes to the table, puts it on top, and you give him a pat. You're decomposing the icon, set the table, into its constituent elements.
- 5.86** That's what behavior therapists do. It's like, if you have a problem, and the therapist attempts to address it behaviorally, the goal of the therapist is to break down the new aim into tasks that are implementable at your level of development. And then that's tested. It's like, I talked to you yesterday about the task of getting someone to clean up their messy environment if they haven't done it for 30 years. It's like, shrink the task, shrink the task, until the person does it.
- 5.87** This is how you get yourself to do things. It's such a useful thing to know. It's like, if you're not doing it, well, consider your aim. Maybe it's not appropriate, but maybe you're biting off more than you can chew because you're prideful and you need to get on your knees and think, "Jesus, I'm a lot more useless than I thought. And so, I thought I could do this, but I'm not. So maybe I could do half of it or a quarter or an eighth or a sixteenth." How do you know? Because you do it.
- 5.88** Now, the upside of that is, once you start, it isn't linear, it's exponential. So even if you have to start on your knees, pathetically, improvement accelerates rapidly. That's the structure of the world. "To those who have everything, more will be given. From those who have nothing, everything will be taken away." What does that mean? This is the trajectory of life. Down? No, down like that. Up, like this? No. Up, like this. Why would we assume it was linear?
- 5.89** OK, so, now let's say, you don't want your child to set the table. You want your child to be a good child. OK, so that's much higher up on the ladder. OK, so this is an attempt to lay out the structure of being a good person, a good parent. OK, so what does it mean to be a good person? That's the highest level. That's fairly high up the abstraction hierarchy, fairly high up the ladder to the sky, to be a good person.
- 5.90** OK, well, we could decompose that. You have a number of different relationships. You're good in each of those relationships. You have a number of roles and functions. You're good in each of those functions. OK, let's decompose one of the functions. You're a good parent. What is one of the things you might do if you were a good

parent? You take care of the—you have a good job. Well, you could imagine parsing that out into micro-routines.

- 5.91** You take care of your family. OK, how do you take care of your family? You complete a meal. Well, how do you complete a meal? You cut the vegetables, you set the table, you do the dishes. Now you're starting to run out of abstractions at that point, right? Because making a meal is an abstraction, but cutting the vegetables is a movement. And so, it grounds out there, right? That's where, that's where heaven hits Earth, in the realm of action.
- 5.92** And that's how you teach people. You teach them, roughly speaking, you teach them from the bottom upward, especially if you're training children. Now, sometimes you can do a conceptual shift at a higher order if you already have those micro skills, but you haven't been using them. But that's Jacob's ladder. And so, well, one of the elements of being a good kid is being able to set the table when you're asked to. And it isn't just the mechanical element either, because what you'd also want is the right attitude.
- 5.93** It's like, one of the things I tried to do in my household was to make sure that the kids thank their mother when they were fed, because it's actually hard to feed kids. It's annoying and it's difficult, but it can be very good. But not if they're whiny, resentful, nasty little ungrateful brats. And so they weren't. And that was very helpful because then they knew how to thank people properly, and they were much more likely to be served in a hospitable manner, without generating a lot of consequential hatred in the kitchen, which is an element of chaos in a household that makes everyone ill. So, there's a spiritual micro-routine that would go along with the skill, as well as the motoric aspect that's chained.
- 5.94** And so, this Jacob's ladder idea is that any moral action—putting a knife on the table to set the table, so that people can eat, so they can eat together, so they can nourish themselves, so they can enter into a certain amount of dialogical communion, so they can catch up with each other, right, so they can encourage self-revelation, so they can develop themselves skillfully, so that they can flourish in the social world, so they can accomplish great things, so they can stand up against tyranny, so they can lead the slaves from perdition, so that they can serve their nation, so that they can serve what's good—that's a ladder. That's a ladder.
- 5.95** And so, that's the vision of Jacob. And when he decides to be good, he's trying to figure out how to climb that ladder, and attending to the messengers. And what are the messengers? Well, they come to you in two forms. They entice you forward because the opportunity beckons, and that's a new pathway to a new aim. And they torment you with conscience, because you're not all you could be and you know it. And so, those are the cascading messengers from the upper echelons of the heavenly realm, so to speak, with something that we don't understand.

- 5.96 See, the ancient Jews, they hypothesized that whatever was at the top of that hierarchy of good was equivalent to the spirit that existed outside of time and space. That was the origin place of being as such. Now, there's a reason for that. And part of the reason is, see, God is portrayed in the Genesis account as the force that interacts with possibility and makes the order that's good or very good. That's a definition.
- 5.97 And so, there's an attitude that is a precondition for that. You're not going to—look, you go to a job interview. Well, what should your attitude be? This is worth thinking about. It's like, are you going to knock it out of the park? Well, do you want the responsibility? Do you want the opportunity? Do you want to challenge yourself? Or do you want to delight in your resentful misery as a victim of circumstances?
- 5.98 It's like, do you buy a new suit? Do you pay some attention to what you're wearing? Do you remember what you're there for, which isn't to be a resentful victim of evil capitalism, begging an overlord for a position, but maybe someone who's offering something so valuable that anyone sensible would say yes?
- 5.99 Maybe you remember that the person who's hiring you is more afraid of you, if they have any sense that you are afraid of them. Because there's nothing worse for an employer than to hire someone who is really not good for the job. And so, do you have some sympathy for the person that's hiring you? And are you there to make yourself available in every possible way that's reasonable, assuming that you're dealing with a reasonable person? Are you going to put it all on the line?
- 5.100 Once my sister matured, she is a very adventurous person, and she paid a high price for that when she was first an adult. Every single job she ever applied to, she got. Why? Because she went in there and told them that they could rely on her, and that was the truth. And so, it was a foregone conclusion. And so, that's a lot more common than you think.
- 5.101 And so, how do you have to orient yourself to make that happen? Hm, that's a good question. The question is: What attitude do you have to bring to bear in a field of new possibility, so the probability that things will swing your way is optimized? Well, that's worth thinking about. You might think, what do you want? If you're treating yourself well, you went to that interview and you knocked it out of the park, what details would you have to attend to? What attitude would you have to bring to bear?
- 5.102 And then when you went to work, if you made yourself radically useful, radically useful, how fast would you move? I've talked to hundreds of young men now who decided to do that, who were maybe down on themselves. They were working as a waiter, working at some menial job. There are no menial jobs, by the way. And they decided that they're going to do the best job they possibly could.
- 5.103 Well, I can tell you one thing. They weren't in those low-level positions long, because people are desperate for competence. And if you manifest some, it's like, sometimes people won't notice or they're jealous. Leave. Find another job. But if you're working

somewhere that's real, there's someone there who's running it, who keeps the place going, who's desperate for people who would help, that they could rely on.

- 5.104** You put 10 percent more time at work, 40 percent more salary return. That's the return, right? 15 minutes early, 15 minutes. You come 15 minutes early and you leave 15 minutes late. And the boss, someone quits, and the boss is casting about for a replacement. Who's going to come to mind first? Right. So when an opportunity beckons—there's an idea in the Old Testament. The firstborn is consecrated to God. Why? Because the decision that initiates the enterprise determines the frame in which it occurs.
- 5.105** So maybe before you go to your job interview, you think, like Jacob, "I've done a lot of stupid things in my life, and I would really like to do things better. And this person doesn't know who the hell I am, and I'm really trying to aim up. And I could try to remember that while I'm talking to them and see what happens." Well, then, maybe you've set yourself up for success instead of failure. And maybe if you actually set yourself up for success, you would succeed.
- 5.106** So, that's Jacob's ladder. So, that's fun to know. That took me a long time to figure out, the concordance between that vision and that structured hierarchy. So, here's another way of thinking about how things are nested. OK, there's a different representation. I was trying to figure out what I was doing when I was writing. What are you doing when you're writing? It's a complex thing because you think, are you paying attention to the word, or are you paying attention to the idea?
- 5.107** Or are you paying attention to the letters because you can't spell? If you can't spell, you pay attention to the letters. But if you can spell, you pay attention to the word. But if you can really read, you attention to the phrase. But if you're a great reader, you pay attention to the sentence and the paragraph and the chapter and the book and the purpose of the book in this nested process. And you're doing all that when you're reading, all of that.
- 5.108** And so, a book is a really interesting phenomenon because the multiple levels of reality are very evident in a book. Because you understand the sentence in the context of the chapter, obviously, which is why you can take words out of context and they have a different meaning. The context matters. And what's the context? The book, the chapter, the book, every book you've ever read, everything you know, that's also the context. The whole structure is the context. Right.
- 5.109** OK, so what was I doing when I was writing? Well, I was debating with myself, trying to find a firm foundation, sketching out the sentences, hacking away at them, trying to produce a manuscript, a research paper, a book. Why? Well, this is when I was a professor. I was a scientist, and that was part of the practice of science. And so, practicing science as a researcher was part of my professorial role. So that was nested

inside that. And why did I want to be a professor? Well, I wanted to be a productive citizen. And outside of that, maybe a good person.

- 5.110** And so, what does it mean to be a good person? Well, it means to embody the valid traditions of your society and to boldly go into the unknown. And then that starts to, that starts to touch on the mythic, right? Because that's the domain of adventure. And then it's upward adventure. And then it's transformative sacrificial upward adventure. And all of that's happening when you write one word, if it's the right word.
- 5.111** And if you're writing, if you're thinking, if you're speaking, and you get the word right, it snaps into place, and it's exactly appropriate for the situation. And that's because you're taking every single one of those levels into account at the same time. And you can practice that with everything you do. And that means that you're in contact, as much as you can be, with those messengers that come down from on high and speak the words that resound to you, through you. So that's Jacob's ladder. So that's pretty cool.
- 5.112** That's William Blake's vision. And it's so cool. So, you see, Blake has the ladder stretching up into the sun, right, against the blackness of the cosmos. OK, why the sun? Consider a gold coin. The gold coin is the sun. The head on the gold coin is the king. That's a symbol of value. Why is the sun value? Because it illuminates, because it speaks of light, because light is associated with consciousness and new beginnings and the dawn.
- 5.113** And so, Blake's image portrays the ascension of the ladder upward to the source of illumination itself. And he uses the sun as a concretization of that. And that works for us, because our consciousness springs into being with the dawn of the sun. And the sun is gold, like the standard of value that's a gold coin. The silver, that's the moon, by the way, the silver coin. And the head of the sovereign is the position of the symbolic head of the nation under the cosmic order. And that's a symbol of value. And that's all dramatized in coinage.
- 5.114** Blake was a mystic and made many illustrations of this sort. And many of them are iconic, like this one, very famous image, of this infinite ascent upward. And that's the path of life. The story of Sisyphus—you roll a boulder up a hill and it rolls back down and you roll it up again—that's a very nihilistic view of fate. Sequence of hills, each higher than the last. You roll the boulder up to the top, and then there's the next one and then there's the next one and then there's the next one.
- 5.115** And you think, "That's a never-ending cycle." But then you think, "It's a never-ending cycle of increased opportunity." And why would you want it to exhaust itself? Why would you want it to come to an end? You accomplish something, the first thing you want is something next to accomplish. Your goal isn't satiation. Your goal is expanded adventure. And that's a sequence of accomplishments.

- 5.116** But the proper structuring of the game is, the games expand as you play them. And you wouldn't want that to end. And that's not Sisyphean; it isn't the same bloody thing over and over, unless you're seriously in a rut. And so, on to new horizons, right? That's the adventure. And then that just spirals upward. So, that's part of the meaning behind this image.
- 5.117** Here's another representation. Father and husband at the core, middle-class businessman, the capitalist personality, the American personality, the humanistic Western personality, the Judeo-Christian personality, the exploratory hero. That's why you can go to a mythic adventure story and identify with the protagonist, because your proximal identity overlaps with that mythic identity at the periphery. And you need to know that. You need to know.
- 5.118** That's why, remember in the Lion King, Simba is a useless adolescent, and he's out with his idiot friends, and they're pursuing the pleasures of the day. Pumba is all stomach, if I remember correctly, right? Very low-level, immature motivation. And then Nala shows up and shames the adolescent male into self-reflection. And then the shaman shows up and smacks him on the head, that's conscience, and invites him forward, but forward where? Down, right, into the depths. That's an initiation.
- 5.119** And he finds a reflecting pool that enables him to delve into the depths. And then he sees the reflection of his father in the sky with these cosmic elements behind. And his father says, "Remember who you are." And then the animators change his face, so he's no longer a deer in the headlights, but someone who's intent on purpose because he's incorporated the spirit of his father. And he goes back to the center, like Moses, and takes out his evil uncle, a classic mythological story, and the rain falls.
- 5.120** And that's his investigation into the depths to find out who he is. The purpose of a religious education is to take you away from the proximal and to put you in contact with the eternal. And that's the eternal in you. There's a reason that the United States is predicated on the assumption that every citizen is responsible and valuable. Made in the image of God. That's the foundation.
- 5.121** Well, is that true or not? And if it's true, then what does it mean that it's true? And what are the implications of that? And not least for your own self-conceptualization, particularly in terms of aim and responsibility, if not you, then who? And there will be times in your life where that's a crucial question. I saw this in the universities, over and over. Weakness of an absolutely appalling sort. No willingness whatsoever to take a risk, even in favor of the enterprise itself. Corrupted systems. And that's, 10 people could have put a stop to that, had they aggregated 10 people.
- 5.122** So, this is a fractionation. A society can be—each of those little discs is representing a frame. A society can be united at one level and fractionated at another. So you could think about this as the division between the Catholics and the Protestants in the West. They're united in their—for centuries, they were united in their subordination to the

foundation of Judeo-Christian ethics nested inside the notion of the redeeming hero. But below that, they were fragmented. And so there's conflict.

- 5.123 For a society and a psyche to be unified, there has to be unity of purpose at every single level. And I don't even know what that means, how far down that goes. If you were oriented properly, fully, my suspicions are, that would resound through your psychophysiology.
- 5.124 Here's an example. If you shy away from a challenge, that sets up one pattern of nervous system activity, hormonal activity, stress hormone activity, emotion. If you confront it voluntarily, it sets up an entirely different pattern. There are molecular changes in your genetic structure as a consequence of which pattern you make manifest. So, one of the things that happens if you take on a new challenge is that you absorb the new information of the situation.
- 5.125 But another thing that happens is that new genes come online to serve the function that you're pursuing and transform you psychophysiology. And so, what that means is that, if you practice a given aim, the unrevealed genetic potential that lies dormant in you will make itself manifest and transform you physically into the avatar of that aim.
- 5.126 Right. So that's worth thinking about for the rest of your life. And it's worse than that even, because there's some evidence that those transformations can be passed to your children. So that's a Lamarckian hypothesis. And there's a whole emergent field called epigenetics that assesses the manner in which acquired characteristics can be passed on. So, that's also worth thinking about.

Lecture 6: Agents of Transformation

At a glance — Agents of transformation and how societies are organized.

- 6.1 So, what's the organization? Well, here's how society is organized. So, in ancient Mesopotamia, the highest god, Marduk, had 50 names. Why? Well, in all likelihood, he was an amalgam of all the tribal gods that had aggregated when this civilization started to emerge. And so, each of those tribes had their own deity structure, and then they would come together, and then they'd have a war about whose god was on top.
- 6.2 And that war was partly, sometimes, a war because men are the playthings of the gods. But it was also often a debate and a conceptual debate and a rearrangement and an amalgamation, so that the positive aspects of this god would be associated with the positive aspects of that god, and a new abstraction would come forward. And then maybe there's collaboration between 50 different tribes.
- 6.3 And this is what happened in Mesopotamia. A god emerges from the panoply of gods that's the highest god. And in the Mesopotamian case, that was the god Marduk. And Marduk had eyes all the way around his head. So he was kind of like Horus, the Egyptian god, because he could see everywhere and would. And he spoke the magic words that would transform day into night. So there's an early representation of the doctrine of the word there, the creative word.
- 6.4 But what's the point? Pay attention. That's one point. And then speak the words that redeem. The Mesopotamians figured out, in their panoply of gods, that that was the god that dominated all other gods. And that was a major step towards a sophisticated monotheism, like a genuine monotheism. What should rule? What should rule over everything else?
- 6.5 In the Lord of the Rings, it's the ring of power, right, on the dark side, and that's exactly right. But on the good side, well, for the Mesopotamians, it was multifaceted attention and the ability to speak transformative words. That's pretty good. That's pretty good. For the Egyptians, Horus, it was the eye that was awake that could see the corruption of the king that was aware. It wasn't, well—
- 6.6 The Egyptians formally realized that the state corrupts. So the king becomes anachronistic and subject to overthrow by his evil brother when he becomes anachronistic and willfully blind. Closes his eyes instead of attending. Horus is the redeemer in the Egyptian pantheon, and he redeems by paying attention.
- 6.7 And so, societies come together by hammering on a structure of value until all of the pieces are nudged and tapped into alignment, from the very bottom of things all the way to the top. And then, the people who inhabit that unified structure are unified in their psyche, as well as being unified socially. And that's the right way of conceptualizing mental health. There's no sanity in an insane society.

- 6.8** So when the Buddha reaches enlightenment, he reaches enlightenment after a multitude of trials, a multitude of sacrifices, a multitude of disciplinary rituals, including starvation. He starves himself, the story goes, so intensely that a grain of rice would stick out in his neck. Intense yogic exercise, intense discipline, and then meditation under the Bodhi tree.
- 6.9** And then invitation into the domain of the gods to nirvana, and then rejection of nirvana because everyone else was not ready to receive it, and a return to the world to spread the news, to pull everyone along, because there's no individual redemption without redemption of the whole. That's the idea, right? And that's part of that self-sacrificial ethos that the proper state is founded on.
- 6.10** That's why Christ is a universal savior, is that the pattern of voluntary self-sacrifice is the redeeming principle of psyche and state by necessity. It's the definition of society itself, because if it's about you, it's not society. And so then the question is: How do you establish that harmony? And the deepest religious idea is something like, exhaustive service in the service of what's highest.
- 6.11** Well, what kind of society would you like to inhabit? If people took that notion seriously, then everyone would be striving to make everything as good as it could be all the time. That seems to be—What would the alternative be? Power? "Do what I say, or else." Well, that's a principle, and you can organize for a while on it. Everybody gets what to do, what they want, all the time, no matter what. Well, you can do that for a while, too, but not for very long. And the consequences aren't good.
- 6.12** And so, you know, if you're in a marriage, what do you do? You serve the spirit of the marriage. If you're a parent, you serve your children, now and in the future. And if you're a family, you serve the community. And the community serves the state and so on, all the way up the hierarchy. And then your life has meaning, because why? Why? Why? Well, it's difficult, it's challenging, it develops you.
- 6.13** So here's something very interesting. Psychologists did statistical analysis on word groupings to determine personality categories. So, for example, if you're extroverted, you tend to be assertive. You tend to smile a lot, you tend to be happy, you tend to be outgoing. And so all those things clump statistically. So if you're one of them, you tend to be all of them. That's positive emotion dimension.
- 6.14** Negative emotion, the same way. If you tend to be angry, you tend to be sad, you tend to be in pain, you tend to be anxious. All the negative emotions have a common trunk. That's neuroticism. That's the second personality dimension. Empathy, warmth, compassion, versus competitiveness, brusqueness, harshness, and what would you say? Judgmental discrimination. That's agreeableness. That's another dimension.
- 6.15** Conscientiousness. Orderliness and industriousness. Patriotism goes along with that. Reliability. It's the best predictor of workplace performance outside of IQ. Openness. That's a creativity dimension. You can be open in the realm of art. You can be open in

the realm of ideas. They correlate, but they're somewhat segregatable. Those are five dimensions.

- 6.16** Self-consciousness loads on neuroticism so strongly that they're not distinguishable. In fact, one of the cardinal measures of the Big Five personality dimensions, which is called the NEO PI-R, has self-consciousness as a facet of neuroticism. What does that mean? Think about yourself and suffer. Right. Now, that is something worth knowing.
- 6.17** So one of the things I used to tell my clients who had social anxiety, these are ones who had the social skills. I had clients who were socially anxious because they had no idea how to behave. They didn't know how to shake hands. They didn't know how to say their name. They couldn't talk on the phone. They didn't know how to introduce themselves. They never had any friends. No one ever paid any attention to them.
- 6.18** So they were built from the bottom up. It's like, "here's how you shake hands." Look at the person. Use a grip something like theirs. Match their tempo. Pay attention. Ask them their name, tell them yours. Practice that 25 times with me, so you know what you're doing, because you can't even get the ball rolling. So that's behavioral, building it from the bottom up.
- 6.19** I had other clients who were socially anxious because they, well, they'd just lose their social ability because their anxiety would overwhelm them. They'd go to a party and they'd think, "What are these people thinking about me? Now, how are they evaluating —am I coming—what am I doing here? What are people thinking about me?" Maybe they smoke, maybe they drink to quell their anxiety. What's the problem?
- 6.20** They should have been trying to make the other people feel at ease. Right. Because that's what you do if you're socially skilled. And if you fall down that pit of self-consciousness, it's nothing but misery. And so that's so much worth knowing. If you're on stage, you're lecturing, and you start thinking about how you are doing, you're done. You'll get self-conscious, you'll turn red, you're naked on the stage, you'll stumble. Same with any performance.
- 6.21** And it's because your aim is wrong. It's not about you. It's not about you in that narrow, local sense. If you're lecturing, if you're on stage, and it's about you, well, first of all, you're never going to have an audience. And second, it's just going to be a matter of misery, right? You should be serving the function of the performance, whatever that happens to be. And that's the same with whatever you do. So if you're self-conscious, you should ask why. What desire is possessing you? And you can replace that by service. And that's very effective. So that's really worth knowing.
- 6.22** So, as a society integrates, as a psyche integrates, the disjunctions between the aims are eradicated, and the whole system is tapped into a kind of integrated purpose, stretching from the bottom all the way to the top. As you mature, your purview of that increases. Because when you're young, you can only see what's obvious. And it takes wisdom to start to understand what's higher and what's subordinate and to see the

whole picture. But the whole picture is always there. And if you're optimizing your function, then you pay attention to the entire structure insofar as that's possible.

- 6.23** OK, this is complicated. It hasn't been complicated so far. You have three memory systems, as it turns out. You have a memory for skill. I'll give you an example. There is a famous patient, H.M., who had epilepsy. And epilepsy often occurs because of a malfunction in a brain area called the hippocampus. And the hippocampus is the brain area that moves short-term attention to long-term memory. So it's crucial. If the hippocampus is damaged, you live in the present.
- 6.24** So H.M. had neurosurgery, and they took out both hippocampi. And so he lived in an eternal present from then on. However, there are certain tasks he could learn, even though he didn't know he learned them. So for example, you remember the child's game Operation? OK, so touch the edges, and it buzzes. Psychological researchers have designed analogs of Operation. The star maze is one of them. So it's a star that's inscribed in metal. The space between the metal edges is about a quarter of an inch.
- 6.25** Imagine a flat metal plate, this engraved star, quarter of an inch wide. Now you have a stylus that's electrified, and you run the stylus through the star, and if you touch an edge, it buzzes. And so if you practice, you can get very good at this and you can zip through it without buzzing. H.M. could learn to do that as fast as a person with memory intact. But every time he saw the task, he thought it was new.
- 6.26** Why? Because the memory system that subserves skill, like movement, is not the same memory system that tracks it in perception. There's actually two of those. There's one that does that with images. So that's the declarative system. Sorry. Yeah, yeah, yeah. Procedural memory. Procedural memory is skill. That's how you ride a bike. That's how you ski. That's how you walk. You can't tell someone how to ride a bike. What do you tell them? Sit on the bike, balance, and pedal. Well, what's that? That's useless, right?
- 6.27** That gives them a very low-resolution, iconic picture. But they have to do it. They have to learn to balance. They have to learn to move. And then that's instantiated in patterns of neural connection and strengths of connection. It's not a representation. It's an embodied, it's an embodied skill. Tennis players hit a ball back before they see it.
- 6.28** I'll give you another example of this. I'm going to do something like this. OK, watch. This is called a ballistic movement. OK, so, the time it takes me to move my arm when I do that is shorter than the time it takes the message to move from my arm and back. So I have to organize that whole movement before I execute. Now, it feels to me like I stopped my hand voluntarily, but that's not what happens. I set up a chain of neurological impulses to execute the ballistic movement.
- 6.29** In some ways, that's what you're doing when you're walking, because when you're walking, you're actually falling forward. You can take people with spinal injuries who are paralyzed, and if you hoist them up over a treadmill, tilt them forward, their legs will walk. It's a spinal reflex. So, skill is built into your body—the ability to walk, the

ability to dance, the ability to ski. You never really forget it because it's really become part of you. That's procedural memory. That was intact with H.M.

- 6.30** Declarative memory, that was gone. And declarative memory is usually what we think of as memory. That's the memory that you can use to bring back a movie from the past or to state a set of propositions that you remember. That's declarative memory. It's got two elements—episodic, that's more like image, an episode; and semantic, which is the translation, you could say, of an episode into words. And so, those are forms of memory. And that's how we represent our knowledge of the world.
- 6.31** So, one form of knowledge about the world is knowledge of how to act, how to dance, for example, how to look at someone, how to modulate your voice, all these complex things that are embodied. Piaget noted that children learn procedure before they learn representation. So, for example, if you take school children, especially young ones, and they're all playing a game—marbles is one of the games that Piaget studied.
- 6.32** And he studied that because he knew that games were a microcosm of society, that society was actually a game. And so, he was very interested in how children learn to play games together, because that's a little society, and how that evolved and transformed and became more sophisticated until they became adults. So that was the reason for that. Very brilliant.
- 6.33** And he noted that, if you got eight, seven-year-olds together, they could play marbles, and the game would go pretty smoothly. It was like the collective of seven kids had the rule structure, but they didn't—if you took the kids out individually and you asked them what the rules were, they got a lot of disparate responses. So the kids would learn to play before they knew how to say what they were doing.
- 6.34** Well, obviously, because a child learns how to walk before he can tell you how to walk. And a child learns all sorts of things at the procedural level that there's no way he has the philosophical capacity to explain—and you're exactly the same way. There's all things, sorts of things you know how to do. You don't know how to represent them. Not at all. That's why we have to think. That's why we have a psychology, right? That's why we're a mystery to ourselves.
- 6.35** Now, the upshot of that is, and this is—see, I tried to figure out. I spent a lot of time in the psychoanalytic literature, learning how to interpret dreams. And dreams can teach you things that you seem not to know. And so then the question arises, it's like: How the hell can you dream something you don't know? Where does that come from exactly? And so, people, archaic people, certainly thought of dreams as a place where the divine revealed itself. And that's a reasonable supposition, but it still begs the question, where does the knowledge come from?
- 6.36** OK, so, when you're communicating with someone, they're rewarding and punishing you continually, by their direction of attention, by the intensity of their gaze, by their connection to what you're saying or not saying, by their dance with you. And

everyone's doing that to you, constantly. And so, they're shaping your behavior in ways that you don't understand at all. And that shaping has a pattern.

- 6.37** You know how it is when you disappoint someone you love? OK, so what is happening there? Well, they have an ideal pattern that you're supposed to be mimicking, that you've drastically deviated from, and that's manifested in their disappointment. The question is, what is that pattern? What are people looking for when they're interacting with you?
- 6.38** Well, one thing they're looking for, for sure, is whether or not you can listen. And that's a magical skill, man. If you listen to people, they'll tell you what they want. And that's really something because then you could, in principle, deliver it. And so, if you want to be popular and successful, listening, that's a hyper-useful skill. Well, what does listening mean? It means attending. It also means attending to them.
- 6.39** If you're a salesman, sales gets a bad rap, and that's because there are crooks who are salesmen, but there are crooks in every enterprise, and you have to sell. Well, if you're a wise salesman, you make relationships because you don't want to sell to someone once. "I sold something to that sucker. And then he figured it out and he told all his friends, and that was the end of my career."
- 6.40** You want to talk to the person. You got to think, "OK, do you have a problem that's bothering you? Is there something that's bothering you? And do I have a solution to that?" And if the answer is no, well, then you had a particularly delightful conversation about what's on the person's mind, and you learn a lot more about their enterprise, and maybe you figure out a solution later. But you want to find out, do you have something to offer? And if you do, well, then you can offer it. But you can't do that until you listen.
- 6.41** And then if the solution that you have works and solves the problem, well, then you've established a relationship that's based on trust and you have a repeat customer. And if you do that with 100 people, then you're phenomenally successful. And so that's a much more effective sales strategy. It's like, do I have something you need that I could offer? Is there something we could do together?
- 6.42** You're wise if you do that, because the last thing you want to do, if you have any sense, is to establish a relationship with someone that's based on an initial falsehood. Because how the hell are you going to make that work? If you're not the customer for my product, you'll only be miserable and unhappy if you purchase it. And all you'll be is a headache, and then you'll tell everybody about it. Right. So, you could listen.
- 6.43** OK, so why am I telling you this? Because people are conspiring constantly to shape you. Right. And that means there are ways that you embody a pattern that's much deeper than you know. Now, this is partly a consequence of us being social. Imagine a wolf pack. The wolves know this comparative status of the members. They really know it. Primates are the same way.

- 6.44 So, if you take green monkeys, I think it was green monkeys, and you take pictures of all the green monkeys in the troop, and you show the monkeys the photographs, they'll look longer at the high-status individuals. It's just like People magazine. It's hilarious. Well, why? Well, because the monkeys need to pay attention to the high-status individuals because: mess with their children, and look the hell out, for example.
- 6.45 And these status positions appear to be quite hereditary and long-lasting. And so, relative position in the social group is an unbelievably important thing for a primate to know, including us. There's almost nothing more important than comparative reputational status. And people will game that. That's what psychopaths do, and con artists; they game the reputational hierarchy.
- 6.46 OK, so what's the essence of reputation? What's the essence of valid reputation? In a functional society, that's what people are hoping for from you. Now, what that means is that there's a pattern that's playing out, that's at the bottom of all your social interactions. And that's the pattern of who people would want you to be, if you were the best that you could be.
- 6.47 Imagine now a wolf pack becomes declaratively conscious of the fact that they have a status hierarchy. Before that, they know. But what does it mean they know? It's procedural. They act it out. So, one wolf will roll over and show his neck when challenged by a dominant wolf. He makes himself into a voluntary prey animal. And then the dominant wolf will act out predator, but forestall tearing out the throat.
- 6.48 Well, why? Well, how about because you need the wolf, you need the lesser wolf to bring down the next moose. So, even if you're a dominant wolf, obsessed by power, you're bounded by the appreciation for the value of your compatriot because you're a collective hunting pack. Very relevant to human beings. So, the wolves act out status, and they act out reputation, they act out competence, they act out forbearance, they act out mercy, they act out cooperativeness.
- 6.49 But they have no concept of those terms. There's no representation of that, right, in imagination. Well, we don't know. They dream, and we don't know how they think; maybe they think in images, if they think. Who knows if they think; they might just act. Highly probable.
- 6.50 We're hierarchical and we represent it. So that means that our dreams are full of the patterns that other people are teaching us. Right. Right. So that's why we can derive information from our fantasies and our dreams. It's like, there's a storehouse of—it's like a large language model. A lot of people have told you who you should be, verbally and non-verbally, not just in direct interactions, but in books, in movies. And there's just a panoply of representations of how you should be.
- 6.51 And there's an essence to that, a coherence to that. And you could say that that essence is a religious image. That's a good way of thinking about it. And you could say that your deviation from that ideal is the voice of your conscience. And anything that

makes itself manifest in your life that pulls you towards that ideal, that's a calling. That's just to say that you're actually a social creature.

- 6.52** Why wouldn't you be pulled in the direction of operating properly in the social environment? It's the very definition of being social. Of course, you have that instinct. Otherwise, you wouldn't be social. You'd be a grizzly bear, out for its own purposes; a solitary animal. That's not us. And so we're called upon to deliver. We have images of what's being requested.
- 6.53** And you can tell when someone acts out that image because you'll go to them for advice voluntarily in a crisis. And that's how elders function, by the way, in most human societies. They're not the top, dominant, chest-beating primate. They're the people who everyone returns to in a time of crisis. They're wise. And so, OK.
- 6.54** So, what does this imply? This is how knowledge progresses. Procedural first, you act it out. Then you dream it. Then you interpret the images. And then you make it explicit. And the procedural domain is way wider than the image domain, and the image domain is way wider than the semantic domain. And so the dream, that would be the realm of art, all things considered, the realm of great images, like the image of William Blake's painting that we saw.
- 6.55** There's an immense realization in that single image. It's taken me six hours to explain part of what that image means. And you can see it in a glance. And religious iconography, great deep art, is full of the images of strategies and procedures that we approximate and act out and abstract, and yet don't fully embody.
- 6.56** Here's another way of thinking about it. Children play house. So there's rules to the game. So let's say a house game proceeds between a little boy and a little girl. It's a very common occurrence. What's the first step? Invitation. The little girl has to want to play. Maybe you should figure that out when you're four, so you remember. Right. So the invitation has to be proffered and accepted voluntarily. That sets the stage for play.
- 6.57** OK, and then there's some negotiation as to role. "You be the mommy, and I'll be the daddy." OK. And maybe you vary that. "You're going to be the cat, and I'm going to be the sister," whatever. The game will change, depending on what role we want to embody, procedurally, act out. OK. So now you might say, well, a child, a boy who's being the father, is imitating the father. But that's not right, because kids are way more sophisticated than that.
- 6.58** If I imitated you, I would sit like that, right? That's imitation. So I'm directly using my body to replicate the stance of your body. But when a child is playing father, he's not directly imitating his father, even in memory. This is what he's done instead. It's so sophisticated, it's mind-boggling. Imagine the father is a pattern across instances of fatherhood. So you see your father interacting with your mother, and you see your father interacting with your sister, and interacting with you, and at mealtimes.

- 6.59 And there's a pattern across all of those instances. And then you see that pattern represented in fairy tales, in what you're being read to and what you watch on TV, and you abstract out a pattern of the father. What's that? That's the spirit of the father. And that's what you imitate. You put that into procedure. You act it out. And so that's what the child is trying to do, is to incorporate the spirit of the father in play. And so that's an embodied and dramatic ritual. It's practice.
- 6.60 That's what the play is for, so that it becomes a skill, like an automated skill, not a representation. Now, the representation might go along with it, but usually not until much later. And so people can act out. Why am I saying this? People can act out things that are deep beyond their comprehension. And they do that all the time. What are you doing at a stadium? You're worshiping the ability to hit the aim. And more than that, collectively, hierarchically, in competition, bounded by a set of principles, in unison with everyone else.
- 6.61 So that when a particularly skillful player, who's also a particularly good sport, performs something remarkable and hits the target under impossible conditions, everyone leaps to their feet like one thing. Right. Do people know that? Well, it depends on what you mean then by "know". They act it out, they wear the jerseys, they worship the heroes. They're obviously compelled by the aim and the goal.
- 6.62 Would they understand it as a general rule at that level of description? No. Would they see the concordance between that and how you conduct yourself in the world broadly or how your perception is structured? No. But it grips them, right? It unifies them. And so, we're obviously wise beyond our understanding because we don't understand ourselves. So there's more to us than we know, by a lot.
- 6.63 And partly, the religious enterprise, the enterprise we're engaged in here, is to lay out the pattern. Because it would be so lovely if who you embodied and how you represented yourself and how you spoke were the same thing. You could think about that as the aim of, the aim of civilization itself is to bring all those things into unity, so that not only do we do, we know.
- 6.64 And so, part of the fracture of the West at the moment is that our religious systems are abstractions of our procedural wisdom, but we don't understand that. And so, we criticize them without knowing what they represent. And then that puts a fracture between who we're called to be and how we understand the world. And then we're houses divided against themselves, and those do not stand. And so, we're weak in the face of opposition and we question the validity of our culture. It's very, very dangerous. We'll be fortunate if it doesn't destroy us.
- 6.65 We need to know what's at the bottom or at the top, and remember. So, how does this lay itself out? Someone does something creative. Everybody imitates it. That's formalized in play. Play formalized is ritual. Ritual can become drama. Drama, aggregated and abstracted, that becomes myth. Myth analyzed becomes religion.

Religion assessed and differentiated becomes literature. Literature and religion assessed becomes philosophy.

- 6.66** So, these are layers and layers of knowledge that, at least in part, manifest themselves from that bottom up. What's the impetus? The original impetus is the imitation of some transformative—some strikingly transformative and courageous operation, procedure. You want to imitate the most daring player in a game. You want to imitate the player who is most skilled, but who stretches their skills to the utmost degree. That's a compelling source of admiration.
- 6.67** Admiration is the grip of the instinct to imitate. Toward what? Toward mastery. Of what? What's known, skill, and what's unknown. Right. You see someone who's a master at that, they're compelling. You imitate. Children do that. And then we've, we've attempted, across the years, in our analytic, the decades, the centuries, to assess analytically the structure of that pattern. And that's what we'll investigate as we move forward.
- 6.68** OK, here's the meta story. So this is the complete story. Remembering that each of these structures has this nested nature. Stable state, predictable routine, established game, emergence of anomaly, collapse, dwelling in the underworld. Now you know what the underworld is. Dwelling in the underworld, picking up the pieces, reconfiguring the body, putting things back together after they've fallen apart.
- 6.69** Reconstitution of a new game. A better game is a game that does everything the previous game did, plus some more. That's the definition of better. It masters more territory. That gives you an upward impetus. The reconstitution of a new game. The reestablishment of a new identity and an improved identity. And so, that's death and rebirth. That's the fall and redemption. That's the fundamental pattern of the meta story. And the meta story is the fundamental pattern of literature.
- 6.70** The story is, I was here and I went there, and this is how. But the adventure is, I thought I was there and I thought I was going there and I started to move, and things fell apart, and it wasn't so good. And I learned a lot, and it was awful. Everything came back together. And now I'm thankful for the catastrophe. Right, right, right. So the meta story is the story of how the simple story transforms and improves. And that's a better story. It's the generative mechanism of stories itself.
- 6.71** We asked at the beginning of this sequence, how do you master chaos? By mastering the process of transformation. An ordinary person inhabits a fixed realm, like the shepherd that Moses is, before he encounters the burning bush. He's mastered a domain, but the mastery is insufficient because the domain can change. So what do you master, if you're a master of masters? You master the process of transformation. That makes you a shaman. That's a higher order mode of being.
- 6.72** That's the seeker in the Harry Potter story. The seeker seeks the golden ball that contains the seeds of transformation. It's a fragment of a soul in the Harry Potter series.

The seeker attends to that which flicks. That winged ball, that's the winged messenger of the gods. That's Mercury, the mercurial spirit, that pulls gold out of ore. That's what mercury, the metal, does. So you seek the phenomena that glitters and gleams, and attend and pursue it. And if you do that, you win all the games.

- 6.73** And Rowling knew that. Her mythological imagination is unparalleled. Everything she put in those books is dead-on accurate. And how do you tell? How do you know that? How do you know that? She's richer than the queen. Right. Why? Because her books filled a religious void. Why she could do that? There's things she figured out, I just cannot figure out how she knew. That image, that image of the golden winged ball, that's a rare image. If you look that image up, the only comment you find, it's called the round chaos, is something I posted. So, I don't know how she knew that, but she knew.
- 6.74** World, underworld, new world, right? Profane existence, hell, paradise, right? Paradise, paradise lost, paradise regained. But that's the whole process. It's not just one movement. And then you might think, well, it's not even the process. It's the spirit that makes that process possible. It's to embody that ability to make that transformation.
- 6.75** This truly is the essence of human beings. This is the thing that differentiates us biologically from all other creatures. We're the only creatures that can transform their first principles. That's why Malthusian restrictions don't apply to us. We're dependent on natural resources. Define natural resource. There's no such thing as a natural resource. We make computers out of sand. Fossil fuel was irrelevant in 1840.
- 6.76** Whenever we hit an impediment, we change the game. That's really what makes human beings different from all other creatures. We can change the game and change the perceptual frame, probably without limit. This is why the economists are optimists and the biologists are pessimists. Biologists are Malthusian, and they're wrong. And the economists understand that we can always change the game. The world is a limitless horizon of transformative possibility.
- 6.77** And this is something that's very important to understand, because otherwise you fall into this Malthusian nightmare of limited horizons and restriction. "We're going to run out of energy." It's like, the cosmos is made of matter and energy. We're going to run out of energy. We're going to run out of matter after that. So, it's preposterous. It's a show of terrible faith. We can make much of virtually nothing.
- 6.78** And it's even more sophisticated than that. Human beings can make the desert bloom. The Israelis have done that. Well, how? Well, you could say that was technological. It's like, yeah, but what's the precondition of the technology? Well, how about a daring ethos? How about a society predicated on trust because people interact in a reliable manner? How about, if you can trust your neighbor, there's nothing you can't change?
- 6.79** Because what can human beings not do if they work together without friction in relationship to a higher order goal? There's nothing we can't master. Holland took its country from the ocean. That whole place shouldn't even exist. And yet it's arguably

the most civilized place on Earth. And no wonder, because if they weren't civilized for 15 minutes, they'd be 10 feet underwater. What's the natural resource? Trust. What's trust dependent on? Integrity. So that's very much worth knowing.

- 6.80** So that's the meta story. Now you know the pattern, and now we can look at its manifestations, and that's what we'll do for the remainder.
- 6.81** Neuropsychologically, is this real? Well, I broached that question earlier. Elkhonon Goldberg was a neuropsychologist who was a student of a man named Alexandr Luria. And Alexandr Luria was a student, if I remember correctly, of a man named Sokolov. These are all Russians, and the Russians were very good neuropsychologists.
- 6.82** Sokolov discovered something called the orienting response. He should have won a Nobel Prize for that. The orienting response is how you react psychophysically when something you don't expect happens. He discovered that there was a physiological pattern of response to the unexpected. Right. Now, he was very mechanistic, being a communist and a Marxist; that was a requirement, being a materialist. But it was a brilliant discovery.
- 6.83** Luria laid out the function of the brain, probably better than anyone, in a masterful book that was published in 1982 called Higher Cortical Functions in Man. His student was Elkhonon Goldberg. Now, many people believe that the left hemisphere is specialized for language and the right hemisphere for non-linguistic function. But that's a second-order differentiation of the hemispheres.
- 6.84** Goldberg, who had been trained in the Russian tradition, which is the outstanding neuropsychological tradition, especially in relationship to emotion, posited something more profound, which was that the right hemisphere was specialized for operation in unexplored territory. It was a novelty analysis system. Dreams make their origin, in many ways, in the right hemisphere.
- 6.85** We're talking about the standard right-handed person, by the way, because there can be mixed. Left-handed person, everything's reversed. Not everything, but there are variations of this. But regardless of where the systems are localized, they exist, and they tend to be localized hemispherically in this manner.
- 6.86** So, how do you conceptualize this? Birds use one eye to see what they eat, and they use the other eye to see what might eat them. Right, right, right. So you want one eye on the target, and you want the other eye on all the other things that might be happening while you have one eye on the target. And that's an order-chaos world.
- 6.87** And your brain is literally structured that way. And the right hemisphere does early novelty analysis. When you first learn a task, your whole cortex lights up, so to speak. It's metabolically active, which is why it's effortful. As you get better and better at it, the pattern of activation shifts to the left and then shrinks and moves to the back. So

you make a little machine that's now specialized to perform that operation, which is now unconscious and implicit.

- 6.88** Beware of what you practice, because you literally build it into your character. Repeat something 50 times, that's you. And then you might say, well, how do you get rid of that? You don't. You can build a new machine to shut it down, but that takes effort. And if you're stressed, the old machine will come popping back. So that's something to know, too.
- 6.89** So, the right hemisphere is an anomaly and novelty detection system. Part of the reason it uses dreams and fantasy and image is because it can explore more broadly the potential implications of the anomalous occurrence. If someone new and compelling enters the horizon of your life when you're searching for a romantic adventure, you might fantasize about them.
- 6.90** Well, why? Well, it's a matter of exploring something that's novel, and you want to take that fantasy and translate it into actual strategic operation that's goal-directed with a point. That's a movement from right to left. When the left fails, it collapses into the right. The left is specialized for negative emotion. So if you have left prefrontal damage, you're depressed.
- 6.91** If you have right prefrontal damage, you're impulsive and psychopathic. Hyper-confident in your left hemispheric orientation. Narrow, goal-directed, specialized. And great. Because it's hyper-efficient, but its weakness is its narrowness. It's wonderful to be efficient, except when you're wrong. Because being efficient in the wrong way is the worst thing you can do. Faster down the wrong road is not helpful. So, this is a remarkable thing to understand because it presents us with this weird inversion of reality.
- 6.92** There's a physical description of material reality, right? The particle description, let's say. Things are made out of sand. They're made out of elements, and the elements are made out of microparticles, and you go all the way to the bottom. That gets a little weird because, at the quantum level, God only knows what's going on. It doesn't look like particle at all anymore. It's particle and wave at the same time, but it's also indeterminate possibility. It's a whole mess.
- 6.93** But that's so far out of our purview that we can think of things as made out of bits, and that works. So that's reality, but that's not how the brain construes reality. And as we said, reality governs evolution. That's natural selection. It's the world that does the natural selection. Sexual selection is a major component, too, and we'll get to that. So, what are you selected for? A bifurcated consciousness, one of potential and anomaly, and the other of certainty.
- 6.94** The best way to think about it biologically is very straightforward. We can lay this on top of the chaos-order dynamic. What's chaos? Unexplored territory. What's order? Explored territory. How do you define explored? You know what's going to happen

there. How do you know? Because you tried out a bunch of different things and you mapped the consequences. So you know what you can do there that works. That's explored territory.

- 6.95** What's outside of that? The barbarians outside of the walled city, right? Outside of the country, outside of your realm of what's known. What deals with that? The right hemisphere, fantasy, anxiety, instinct. The right hemisphere is dominated, by the way, by motivational systems in a way that the left isn't. The left is linguistic, and so it really works in a world of language.
- 6.96** But the right isn't like that. The right is more like the brain of an animal. And when you encounter something new, the motivational systems grip the functions of the right hemisphere in the manner that we described in the other lectures. That produces that cascade of stress responses. And the right alerts the left across the corpus callosum, which unites them, letting it know that an anomaly exists.
- 6.97** There are weird neurological consequences of this. So, for example, if you have right parietal damage, it's about this part of your brain, the right parietal lobe keeps track of things that have gone wrong with your body. OK, now you have a body map that's habitual. You know that, because you know what happens if you chip a tooth or you get a tooth replaced. It's, like, six months of exploring the new place with your tongue until you get used to it. Your body remaps. It takes a lot of work. So you've got a map of your body.
- 6.98** OK, now you have a stroke, and the left side of your body doesn't work, but it's a right parietal stroke. And so you don't notice that your body is half gone. And more than that, you don't notice that the left half of things, whatever that means, exist. So if I get you to draw a clock, you'll draw half a clock with all the numbers on the right side. And if I give you a plate of food, you'll eat all the food on the right. And if I turn the plate, then you'll eat half the food of the semicircle that you now see.
- 6.99** And if you encounter your now-immobile half body in bed by accident, you'll yell to the nurses that someone's arm is in your bed, or you'll try to throw your own leg out. Ramachandran discovered that if you took people with right parietal damage and you poured cold water in their left ear, that that would activate their vestibular system, and the shock of that would hyperexcite the remaining parietal tissue. And the person would realize that the stroke had paralyzed them on the left. They'd have a catastrophic emotional response that would disappear when the irrigation effects wore off, and then they'd forget.
- 6.100** And then, if you tell people, "I noticed that, John, I noticed you're having a hard time moving your left leg." And you'll say, "Well, I really don't feel like moving it." Why? Because you're using the old map. And the catastrophe, that catastrophic emotional response, that's a signal that that map doesn't work. But the right parietal lobe is damaged, and so it doesn't send a signal. So, as far as you're concerned, with your left

hemisphere that's all happy, things are just like they always have been. And so that's the blindness of the left hemisphere.

- 6.101** It's routinized. But if the routine is wrong, it can't transform. But the underlying reality here, the underlying reality here that's so remarkable, is that that's the organization of the nervous system—specialization for the unknown and specialization for the known, specialization for unexplored territory and for explored territory.
- 6.102** And you can understand that. It's one thing to sit around the damn campfire. It's another thing to be out there in enemy territory. Those are very, very different places. Say, "Well, materially, they're the same." It's like, that's what dead people say, right. "They're the same. It's the same dirt." Well, that's not the relevant issue, is it? When tribal enemies might be lurking around every corner, and when you and your Stone Age tribesmen are pretty decent prey for very large bears, so.
- 6.103** This has been studied intensely, right? Iain McGilchrist has written a book called *The Master's Emissary* that lays out a notion of how the hemispheres interact with one another that's very much akin to Elkhonon Goldberg's novelty routinization model, which is a very good model. But I love the model as well, because it fits exactly on top of our conceptualization. What's the world, really? Explored territory and unexplored territory, but there's an intermediary factor.
- 6.104** We'll close with this. So, a little more neuropsychology. The front part of your brain organizes your action. The back part of your brain reports on the sensory world. They're interacting because really what you're focusing on, it's an interplay between the motor and the sensory. It's not quite that simple because, when you look at a glass, a drinking glass, the neurons that would allow you to grip are preactivated. So there's a motoric component to, even to sensory perception, but we'll leave that aside for the moment.
- 6.105** You see the world with the back half of your brain and you act in it with the front half. And so, part of the reason you see the world is so that you can figure out how to act in it. And pretty much what you pay attention to is the consequences of your action. So there's this tight linkage, as we'd said before, between action and perception. And so that's the very back of the brain, that's the visual element.
- 6.106** They're all laid out there. The sensory area is up top, the top two areas in the bottom sensory unit description. Auditory area, there's a primary zone and a secondary zone. As the auditory area overlaps the visual area, that's the part of your brain you use for silent reading. You're using your ears as, you're using your eyes as ears when you read silently. So, the tertiary zone, which occupies the border between the different senses, appears to be the place where we have the integrated experience of consciousness, because all the senses are reporting at the same time.
- 6.107** Now, this is the last thing I want to show you today. It's called a homunculus. Now, if you look at the brain, the motor unit, there's a strip at the top that's called the primary motor zone. If you do brain surgery on someone, open skull—they're awake because

you do brain surgery on awake people, so that's fun to think about—if you probe the motor strip or the sensory strip, people will report sensation in different parts of their body or an impulse to move.

6.108 And so, a man named Wilder Penfield, who worked at the Montreal Neurological Institute in Canada, mapped the relationship between the body and the brain on the sensory side and the motor side. And this is the image that he generated. And so, that's kind of what you're like, as far as your brain is concerned.

6.109 And it's a very interesting thing to contemplate because, well, a lot of you is thumb, a lot, and a lot of you is right hand, and quite a lot is left hand, and a lot is lips and tongue. And you can really see that in babies. Babies are very wired up in their mouth and tongue, and they'll put everything into their mouth with their hand. And so, eyes, which you can move like mad, your face is pretty well represented and very sensitive.

6.110 Will you stand for a second? I want to demonstrate something. OK, so stand here and face there. OK, now I want you to tell me how many fingers I'm putting in your back.

6.111 How many?

6.112 Yeah.

6.113 More than one.

6.114 More than one, yeah. How about now?

6.115 Five.

6.116 Oh, good. You could feel five. How about now?

6.117 Two.

6.118 OK, well, how about now?

6.119 Four.

6.120 Yeah, that's good. Well, you were very good at that. It's very hard for people. You could see how the trunk is represented there. It's not represented much at all. Your back is very low resolution. Well, why? Well, you can't move it, can you? You don't need that much sensory feedback. You concentrate the neurology on your face and your tongue, your mouth, your hands. And so that's what you are like, as far as your brain is concerned.

6.121 OK, well, what is that creature? You think about what that thing looks like. Well, it's doing a lot of things with its hands, and it's talking about the things that it's doing with its hands. Right. It's doing a lot of things with its eyes. We're very visual human beings. We're the most visual creatures, with the possible exception of birds of prey. But as far as hands and eyes go, we're pretty much it.

6.122 Cetaceans, dolphins, they have brains that are about as big as ours in comparison to their body size. But look at them. What the hell are they going to do? They have a body

like a test tube. They're going to, what? Use those flippers and go down to the bottom and what, build sand castles? No, they don't build anything. They're very different from us. And their intelligence, whatever it is, is very different.

6.123 And their cortex is structured differently. The claims of superhuman intelligence among dolphins, for example, that were pretty popular in the 1960s, they really never went anywhere. If you're going to be intelligent, it helps a lot to have hands, so you can do things. Octopi, they only live about three years. They're really smart. Why? Tentacle city, right? Elephants, too, because they have that proboscis that they can manipulate with.

6.124 But we have hands, and we can do a lot of things with hands, and we use our language and our mouth and our tongue to transmit what we do with our hands, and that's how we confront the world. And so then, the reason I showed you the neurology is, right hemisphere is specialized for novelty, left hemisphere is specialized for routine. The motor and sensory systems that are associated with the body give you hands and eyes and mouth.

6.125 Well, that's how you confront the world, right, as an active, engaged explorer. That's a good way of thinking about it. That's the creature, that's the master of the domain of chaos and order. We'll elaborate that as we continue.

Lecture 7: Through the Desert

At a glance — Through the desert — elaborating the narrative structure.

- 7.1 So, we've established some understanding and elaborated on understanding in relationship to the basic frame of perception and consciousness, the basic story, point A, point B, and the behaviors necessary to transform one into the other. And then we shifted to the way those stories could be, simple stories could be disrupted and transformed.
- 7.2 And then we described a meta story, which is that process of story establishment, game establishment, frame establishment, and then disruption by some generally unexpected occurrence or sequence of impediments that are insuperable. A descent in consequence of that into the confusion that necessarily prevails when you don't know what game to play, what's going on here. And then the reestablishment of that stability, God willing, out of that chaos, and hopefully the reestablishment of that stability on firmer ground. That's the progression.
- 7.3 There's a gentleman named Thomas Kuhn who wrote a book called *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions*, and it was published in the early '60s. And its pattern duplicates what we've been talking about, as does the Piagetian notion from developmental psychology of a stage transition. Now, Kuhn wasn't necessarily convinced—people debate about this—that a scientific revolution necessarily produces a theory that's better than the previous one. It can just be radically different.
- 7.4 Piaget, when he was looking at how children develop in their stage transitions, he was a more sophisticated thinker, all things considered, I believe. Although he knew of Kuhn's work as well and approved of it, Piaget pointed out that, as children develop and go through this stage transition process, the new place they land has all the features of the old place they were, but also accounts for the new information that has been incorporated. So that's a developmental progression. Hopefully, when you learn, everything you learn is one of these transformations.
- 7.5 Now, one of the other things we discussed was the fact that these frames are nested. They have micro-details, and they're nested in larger structures. So, you pursue a wife to have some children, to become a father, to be a good citizen, to play your role in the world, to fit into the mythological narrative. That's the nesting upward. And there's nesting downward. We showed how there were micro-routines that were part and parcel, perceptual micro-routines of everything that you do, the micro-skills that a child has to learn to do something like to set the table or to clean up their room or to be a good child.
- 7.6 Every time you learn something, a previous preconception dies and is cast into chaos and is reconstructed. This is why people resist learning. And that's a necessary thing to understand. Why would you stick with your foolishness? Well, it's because, to learn

something new, the amount of pain that's involved in learning something new is proportionate to the magnitude of the disruption of the new information.

- 7.7 Now, if you're careful and alert, you can walk that line properly and you update yourself at a rate that optimizes the relationship between the positive emotion that the transformation offers and the pain that the transformation requires. So this is why you want to stay up to date in your life and pay attention because, if you pay attention, then you can make small changes while the dragon is still this big, instead of waiting till they ball up in a massive accumulation and take you out. And that happens to people a lot.
- 7.8 And your nervous system helps tune that because the thing is, see, if you bite off as much as you can chew, instead of more or less, then it's not so much terror as challenge. And then the challenge is optimized, and then that's engaging. So that sense of engagement, that sense, that emotional element of meaning, is actually a signal from the interaction between your hemispheres, you could say, that the rate of— you've optimized the rate of transformation.
- 7.9 Now you're compelled, and it's an interesting game. So you want to watch for that. And you want to see in your life, practically speaking, you want to see where that's happening. And then you can expand that outward and have that sense occupy more and more of your life. So that's a very good thing to practice. And there isn't anything more interesting than practicing that.
- 7.10 So, you're in a frame, something new comes along, challenges your presuppositions; that produces a collapse of some magnitude, right? There's a turmoil of new information. There's a psychophysiological disinhibition as your nervous system tries to sort out what you should do next. Then there's the reconstitution of the principles by which you're going to operate. And then there's the emergence of a new frame. So that's the transformative story.
- 7.11 And so, there's the simple story and there's a revolutionary story. And so, the revolutionary story is a higher order story because it describes how stories transform. OK, so now what we've examined so far are the conceptual features, the concepts that you need to understand in order to begin to apprehend the symbolic language of narrative and mythology. And we established that conceptually first with regard to the nature of these frameworks.
- 7.12 And then we instantiated it to some degree, neuropsychologically, emotionally, and motivationally. So there's two converging sets of representations there, but they're isomorphic. They map onto each other in a one-to-one relationship. Now, what we're going to see, and this is the clincher in some ways, I believe, is that the structure of narrative itself maps on to this underlying conceptual structure.
- 7.13 Now, for that to not be true, that would mean that the philosophers and the neuroscientists are wrong where they converge, and so is the narrative. The probability

of that, as far as I'm concerned, is zero. There's just no way that all those different ways of looking at things tell the same story without it being true. In fact, that's how we determine what's true. You know what's real because all your senses tell you the same thing, even though they rely on five different measurement strategies.

7.14 Now, you might discuss that with other people, too, just to be sure. But that's generally how you determine what's real. Multiple variable sources of information report the same phenomenon. That's what we're trying to establish here. So now, you can think about these states as you can think about the initial stable state, the descent into chaos, and the reconstitution of new order as states or places or as a pathway. All of those work from a narrative perspective.

7.15 Now, if the characterization is state, then each of those elements, it's given an identity. That's another way of thinking about it. It's given a characterization. We're going to examine the fundamental characterizations that represent this process, and that'll take up the next six hours, essentially. I'll explain it to you conceptually, and then I'll show you how that actually plays out in stories.

7.16 And so what you'll emerge from, hopefully, emerge with, hopefully, is a set of conceptual frames that will enable you to understand the deep structure of any narrative. And so that's great fun, it's great fun, because you can go to a movie, especially a movie that's got a mythic element to it, a medieval adventure story or an animated movie, because they tend to tilt towards the archetypal, and you can enjoy it at the level of the movie, but then you can see, oh, I can understand the underlying structure. I can see exactly what's going on here.

7.17 It does nothing to take away from the aesthetic experience of the movie. It just adds a whole other layer of understanding. That's the utility of deep literary criticism, because in a sense, that's what we're doing, is the deepest of literary criticism.

7.18 Now, Camille Paglia is one of the world's foremost literary critics. She said something very interesting, which she came up with independently of me. And I'm saying that for a particular reason, because she's the only other person I've ever heard say this. So when I was training as a clinical psychologist and when I was operating as a professor, I schooled myself very deeply in the history of religious ideas, in the psychoanalytic tradition, Freud, and more particularly, Jung, and learned that pattern.

7.19 Now, Carl Jung had a student named Erich Neumann, and Erich Neumann wrote two books, great books. He wrote more than two, but two particularly great books, one called *The Great Mother* and another called *The Origins and History of Consciousness*.

7.20 And *The Great Mother* is the source from which I derived much of my symbolic understanding of the feminine. It's a great book. It lays out the positive symbolism of the feminine and the negative symbolism of the feminine. And it does that by comparing representations of the feminine from all over the world. And he had hoped to do that with a masculine, too, but he didn't live to do that.

- 7.21** And then *The Origins and History of Consciousness*, he did what Joseph Campbell did, except in a deeper way. Joseph Campbell wrote a book called *The Hero's Journey*, which was essentially a popularization of Carl Jung's concepts. Erich Neumann was Carl Jung's greatest student. And in *The Origins and History of Consciousness*, he laid out the path of the psyche as it mastered its world. That was the pathway of the hero. And he associated that with consciousness, and he nailed that. He nailed that. It's a brilliant book.
- 7.22** It's the same book, in a way, as *Maps of Meaning*. And it's also the same book as a book Jung wrote called *Symbols of Transformation*. These are all attempts—and *The Hero With a Thousand Faces*; that's another book that's very similar. These are all books that are attempting to get at what I'm talking to you about today.
- 7.23** Now, Camille Paglia said to me that, had the academy, the intellectuals, especially the French, turned to Neumann and Eliade and Jung instead of Foucault and Derrida, for example, and the postmodernists, the whole history of the last 40 years would be radically different.
- 7.24** Because the postmodernists, the fundamental claim of postmodernism, this is a devastating claim, is that there's no uniting meta narrative. Right. And that's a very provocative claim because the monotheistic hypothesis is that all good unites. The scientific hypothesis is that all scientific truths unite, that there's a higher order union, that there's no contradiction between truths. The postmodernists dispensed with that. And there's almost no claim that's more radical.
- 7.25** It leaves you with nothing but fractionated positional conflict and often in the guise of naked striving for power or hedonistic self-gratification. It's really not good. And it's wrong because there is a uniting meta narrative. Well, and you know some of it now. The uniting meta narrative is the story that describes how frames of reference transform. And so it's not a static— it's not a representation of a static situation. It's a representation of a dynamic transformation.
- 7.26** And then the notion is that the more perfectly you embody that dynamic transformation, the better the order your life falls into to, the more opportunity you can extract from chaos and possibility, the better you serve yourself in the medium and the long term, and the more other people you can integrate under the same roof. There's nothing more important than that.
- 7.27** There is nothing more important than the debate, you could say, between the school that was established—Nietzsche contributed, Freud contributed—it was really established by Carl Jung, I would say. Jung was right, and the postmodernists are wrong, and they're wrong right to the bottom. OK, and so what we're going to explore now is the mythological representation of the narrative of transformation. That narrative of transformation is no different than the representation of an adaptation as such.

- 7.28** Now, here's the initial hypothesis. Societies are best united under the rubric of upward transformation. What principle should be foundational? So Nietzsche describes the death of God. Well, what was he afraid would emerge in the aftermath of that to attempt to rule? Power, that was one. Ideology, that was another. Collapse into a fractious and meaningless nihilism. So that's the disintegration. It's like, what principle should rule?
- 7.29** Rule means unite, while the postmodern ethos is no principle unites. It's a foolish conception because all of your perceptions are united by an ethos. If what you see are tools and obstacles, for example, you see union. When I look at you, I don't see parts. You come together as a union. I can look at all of you, and now you're an audience. And you're an audience that's playing the same game as me, at least while we're here.
- 7.30** We see higher order unions constantly. The postmodernist insistence is that somehow that stops somewhere. It's like, where does it stop? Well, for someone like Foucault, who is an appalling person, it stopped wherever it would have interfered with whatever the hell he wanted to do next. It's sickening, and it's dangerous beyond belief.
- 7.31** So, in the aftermath of Nietzsche's proposition that God was dead, that was the notion that the highest unity had collapsed, the question has been, since then, and that emerged out of the consequence of the conflict, say, between the Enlightenment and the religious viewpoint, the question since then has been, what pulls together properly?
- 7.32** Well, for the ideologues, the communists and the Nazis, that was clearly power. Force, I mean, by power, I mean force and compulsion. "Do what I say or else." And that is a uniting principle. It's just, when chimpanzees attempt to apply that in their own troops, they meet a very painful end. And so they might be successful for some period of time. But as soon as they show a moment of weakness, the subdominant males tear them to pieces. And human beings do the same thing.
- 7.33** So power itself, force and compulsion, yeah, you can establish some unity out of that. And it might be better than absolute bloody mayhem and chaos. Maybe the tyrant is better than the failed state. We haven't sorted that out exactly yet conceptually, but it's by no means optimal.
- 7.34** So now the question would be: Is there a higher order uniting principle? And if there is, what does it look like? And what is its central nature and why? OK, so that's what we're trying to figure out now.
- 7.35** So, there's the story. You're somewhere, something happens that strikes you to the core. You have to undergo some degree of collapse. This is what happens to the Israelites. This is a key, and this is, you can see the relation here with the narrative. So Moses goes back to the Israelites, after he is illuminated by his encounter with the burning bush. So he gets to the bottom of something because he pays attention and that transforms him.

- 7.36** And now he's charged by God to use the words that will indicate to the people that the foundation of his authority is more reliable than the foundation of the authority of the tyrant. So that's what you hope to do, if you speak truth to a tyrant. You're attempting to indicate that the foundation of your thought supersedes his authority. It's a hell of a thing to do in a situation like Egypt, where the Pharaoh had the power over life and death.
- 7.37** So, Moses returns to Egypt from his exile, and he tells the Pharaoh to his face to let his people go. That's the famous Civil War cry, "Let my people go." But that's not what he says. He says, "Let my people go, so they may worship me in the desert." He says, Jehovah says, "Let my people go, so they may worship me in the desert." That is not the same thing as "let my people go." It's a vision of a kind of ordered freedom.
- 7.38** So, there's a hypothesis there, which is that it's possible to live in the absence of tyranny, in a form of ordered freedom, that requires subordination to an abstract good. And that's what Moses tells the Pharaoh ten times. And the Pharaoh rejects his claims, and the plagues come. And the reason the plagues come is because, if you're enough of a tyrant, and you don't adjust your behavior when you should, you can be bloody sure that trouble is going to come.
- 7.39** And maybe because you're a tyrant, you'll double down. And all that will mean is that the plagues will get worse, and they culminate in the death of the firstborn. By that time, eight plagues before, the present is devastated. The death of the firstborn, that's the future. So if you're enough of a tyrant, then you destroy the present and the future. And so, now the Israelites are by no means innocent in this game. They're slaves.
- 7.40** OK, so now you might want to ask yourself, if you're looking at the underlying structure of a story like that, what does tyrant and slave mean? Well, you might be a tyrant. Father might be a tyrant. Your mother might be a tyrant. You might have a child that's a tyrant. And if you're in those relationships, then, or maybe you have a boss that's a tyrant. But you can't have a tyrant unless you're a slave. So, what that means is that if you're in a relationship with a tyrant, then you're a slave. And that's always the case.
- 7.41** And so this Exodus story is something that's always happening. And that's what makes it a deep story. You can think about it as a historical narrative, but it's not. It's a story about how tyranny and slavery interact and what the alternative to that is. Well, what's the modern conception of slave? Non-playing character. Right? NPC. What's an NPC? That's a slave. You're not master of your own story. You're a puppet. That's the Pinocchio story. There are forces behind the scenes that are moving you. You have no idea what they are.
- 7.42** So how do you overcome that? You develop a vision of your own destiny. That's what Moses offers the Israelites, the journey to the promised land. What would work for you? What's up? And this works practically. There's a huge literature on this. If you, and I built a program called The Future Authoring Program that helps people do this. If you

get people to sit down and write out a vision for their life, you can have anything you want in five years, but you've got to figure out what it is.

7.43 Now you've got your own vision. You've got your own place to go. And maybe you want to flesh that out. You could think about your friends and your family and your career and your education and all the fragments of your life. But then you can wrestle with that a little bit, like you wrestle with God, and you could say, "OK, what would satisfy me?" Or you could do better. You could say, "What would I have to— how would I have to lay out my life to be thrilled?" That's a good target for negotiation.

7.44 And then it's a dialogue. It's like, I don't know what the hell would make you happy. Many of us are in love with our tyrannical self-imposed misery. It's like, what's your precondition for satisfaction? That's a dialogue with what calls to you and your conscience. And then you develop a vision. You say, "Man, if I could get that to happen, that would be worth it." Well, then what?

7.45 Well, then you're charged with—well, that's a good question. You're charged with enthusiasm, right? "En theos," that's enthusiasm. That means to be charged with the spirit of the divine. Well, why is it the divine? Well, it's upward aiming, right? It's aiming at the highest point. Conceptualize the highest point, right? And then try to bring that to bear in what you do.

7.46 Why wouldn't you do that? Well, it's hard. It requires responsibility. It'll be plenty hard if you don't do it, too. So you can be sure of that. So you might as well pick your load instead of having it thrust upon you. Because if the load is thrust upon you, you're a slave. Right. OK, so the Israelites are laboring under the thumb of the Pharaoh, but they're slaves. Right, and they didn't have to be, because the slavery came about bit by bit.

7.47 Right, and so now Moses invites them to leave the tyranny and demonstrates his authority and power and convinces them that departing is a good idea. They cross the Red Sea. And the Pharaoh's army is chasing them because he has second thoughts after he decides to let them go. What's a red sea? Well, it's a flood of blood and chaos. And what does that indicate? Well, out of the tyranny, you don't go from tyranny to promised land. We already know the story. You go from tyranny to chaotic desert to promised land.

7.48 So that's the structure of the story. And there's a threshold moment, and that's the Red Sea. It's like, there's no going back, folks. And how does Moses find his way across the Red Sea? Well, the story is that he parts the water. It's like, if you're in chaos, you find firm foundation under your feet and you look for that. And God's there to guide the Israelites already at that point in the form of the pillar of light at night and the pillar of darkness during the day, this dynamic play of chaos and order.

7.49 The Daoist conception and the ancient Israelite conception dovetail. Now, what's the chance of that? It's like, and that's the guide. Well, of course it's the guide because the

balance between light and dark, the balance between chaos and order, between night and day, that marks the path. And so then if you're in chaos, and you're in the Red Sea, you're in chaos, what do you look for? You look for that place where chaos and order are balanced, so that you find stability and opportunity.

- 7.50** And that is the deepest—you can think about this biologically. It's the deepest instinct making itself manifest within you. It's the most real thing. So the reductionist, materialist, atheist types dispense with subjective meaning. It's like, that's biologically absurd. You have guides from within. They're real. That sense of meaning, that is the most real thing. It is the most reliable thing.
- 7.51** Now, to interact with it properly, you have to aim up and you have to attempt to live in the truth because the instinct will make itself manifest in a warped manner. The wrong things will call to you. So be careful, because there's a sin the Christians laid out, the sin against the Holy Ghost. It's unforgivable. Why? Well, there's no coming back from it. Well, if you pervert the spirit that guides you, you're done.
- 7.52** So that's probably the most profound reason not to lie. Don't lie, because you'll pervert your aim, and then the wrong spirits will come to you. And you do not—that's the worst thing. And you'll pay for it most when you're most in danger and you most need to rely on your own judgment. And it won't be there. So walk carefully.
- 7.53** OK, so now, Moses, he takes the Israelites out into the desert. Well, why? Well, they're lost. Why are they lost? Well, because they were slaves and the tyrants told them what to do. And now they don't know what to do. And so they're not very happy about that. They squawk and bitch and moan and whine and fight with each other. They're fractionated because their god, who was the Pharaoh, essentially, and deified in that manner, their god died. And now they're in the desert.
- 7.54** And they think, "Jesus, I'm not so sure about this desert. I think maybe the tyranny was better," just like the bloody Russians pining for the days of Stalin, which they do. And so, "the good old days," good God. And so, they try to set up Moses as a new Pharaoh. And he sits as judge because they can't mediate their own affairs. They're fighting with each other all the time because there's no higher order principle to unite them.
- 7.55** And so they ask Moses to be the judge, and he sits as judge from dawn till midnight every day, dawn till dark every day, for who knows how long. Ten years. It takes the bloody Israelites 40 years to get across the desert. It's a few weeks' journey. Why? Because if you're confused enough, you get nowhere, no matter how long it takes. And so that's the meandering pathway of lost slaves. And so, three generations. That's the idea. Forty years, three generations, to shrug off the aftermath of tyranny and slavery.
- 7.56** So they set Moses up. And Moses' father-in-law, who's a good guy, despite being a foreigner, he's a good guy. And he comes along and sees what's going on as Moses is leading his people through the desert. He says, "You have to stop doing this." And Moses says, "Why?"

- 7.57** And Jethro says, "Well, there's two reasons, essentially. One is you just can't do it. It's too much responsibility for you. You've got these hundreds of thousands of people, and they're full of petty squabbles because they're all slaves. They can't regulate, or won't regulate, themselves. And now they bring this all to you, and you're wearing yourself—you're going to die. It's not a good idea. Too much. But worse, you're stealing their own destiny from them and they're going to set you up as a new Pharaoh. Your people need responsibility."
- 7.58** And this is a revolutionary concept because it's literally the alternative to the tyrant and the slave. And it's established in this story. Jethro says, "Here's what you do." You take your people and you get them to divide themselves into groups of 10, and each of the 10 elects a representative. And whenever anyone in that group of 10 has a fight, then he can bring his troubles to that representative and he'll sort them out.
- 7.59** And if the representative can't sort them out, sort it out, because it's too complex, then take a group of representatives, 10 of them, and get them to elect a meta representative, and do that all the way up to levels of 10,000. And then if that doesn't work, then they can talk to you, but not before. That's called a subsidiarity structure. It's a structure of devolved responsibility.
- 7.60** And from then on, the principle in the Old Testament is that Jews, the Israelites, do not need a king. Why? Because there's an intermediary patriarchy, a structured patriarchy, a hierarchy of competence that mediates between the squabbles of the lowly and the highest possible principles. That's how the court system works. It's the same structure, subsidiarity. That's the hallmark of that organization. It had a determining influence on how free and abundant countries structure their decision-making.
- 7.61** Now, the rule in this subsidiary organization is, you push every responsibility down that you can. So the higher you sit in the organization, the less should come your way. You want to push it down. You want to push it down to the lowest level possible. That's partly how you grow an organization, by the way. You wonder how there are people who run hundreds of companies. It's like, well, how the hell do they do that? Well, they don't micromanage the cleaners.
- 7.62** So they set up a hierarchy of responsibility as an alternative to micromanaging tyranny or chaos. So that's the principle of subsidiarity, a fundamental principle of Catholic social teaching in particular, but a determining discovery for the structure of well-run states. And so that's very interesting.
- 7.63** Now, Moses is judging the people for years. So what does he learn? Remember, yesterday we talked about the fact that wisdom is instantiated procedurally first. People act things out. Imagine you two have a squabble, OK? And so now I have to listen to both of you, and I have to figure out what the hell you think is going on. So I have got your frame of reference. Now I have to figure out how you interpret it.

- 7.64 And then I have to put those two things together and I have to make sense of that, which means to bring those things into unity, right? Those diverse perspectives into some sort of unity. Then I have to offer that unity back to you. I have to say, look, it looks to me like this is what he means and what he'd settle for. It looks to me that this is what he means and what he'd settle for. And this is what I think you could offer each other that might work.
- 7.65 And so what does work mean? It means you'll walk away not murderously enraged, and so will you. So the emergent judgment has to satisfy the situation. That's what makes it just. Now, imagine you do that 25,000 times. Well, what happens to you? Well, you build up a repertoire of knowledge. You become an expert. At what? Judgment? Judgment of mediating principles?
- 7.66 Well, that's why Moses gets the Ten Commandments, right? It's like, it dawns on him. Oh, these are the principles by which justice operates. These are the principles by which peace can be established. These are the principles by which collective abundance and cooperation operate. And so that's portrayed in the story. He's up the mountain. He's conferring with God in a flurry of volcanic activity and lightning bolts. Why? Because this is a big deal.
- 7.67 And that's the revelation of the procedural into the imagistic. It's like, oh my God. It's like, the wolf pack woke up and found out what principle is governing it. There's a massive increase in human consciousness, not only in the imagistic way, this thunder and cloud that is held to constitute the event, but the actual casting of the principles into words, the establishment of the law.
- 7.68 Right. So what's the law? Well, it's a semantic representation of the procedures necessary to establish, what? The order that's good or very good? That would be a good conceptualization of an appropriately just polity. It's not like we understood this. Think of where we came from. The evolutionary argument, you know. We emerged from non-linguistic creatures. We had to figure all this out.
- 7.69 What the hell are we doing as individuals? What are we doing as a collective? What are the principles? Well, that's all part of these great old stories. And so the slaves take on responsibility for their own destiny, and that's what stops them from being slaves. Right now, they're still beholden to the abstract principle of divine sovereignty. That's the worship in the desert.
- 7.70 What does it mean to worship? It means to celebrate. It means to elevate. It means to aim at. It means to point at. It means to sacrifice towards, to do that individually and collectively. What does sacrifice mean? To work, to offer something up, to what? To allow something to go in the service of something higher. To work towards and to offer up. And that is the principle. Obviously, that's the principle of civilized comport.
- 7.71 We have abundance because we work. And why is that a sacrifice? Well, you know it's a sacrifice. Work is what you're doing when you're not doing, you could say, what you

want to do. So that's the sacrifice. And what's the sacrifice? You're sacrificing the present for the future. You're sacrificing your whim for your future well-being. You're sacrificing your narrow hedonistic desire or your will to power for the abundance of your family and your community. That's work. That's proper work.

- 7.72** And maybe proper work no longer becomes toil because it's so imbued with significance. That's what would happen if you were pursuing a vision that would actually sustain you. And that's how you escape from being a slave. So that's the story of Exodus. It's the same structure. Initial frame, tyranny. There's a game that the Pharaoh and his court magicians play that the Israelites are tangled up in. It devolves into complete and utter chaos. That's the Red Sea. They're through the Red Sea and then into the desert.
- 7.73** Well, why? Because when you drop your presuppositions, you're lost and you don't know which way is up. Right. This is so important. Not knowing this makes us deluded. For years, for example, our foreign policy doctrine has assumed that a tyranny is made of tyrants and people clamoring to be free. So all you have to do is go in, take out the head, and all the sovereign citizens, upward aiming, clamoring to be free, immediately establish a democratic polity that's productive, and Heaven comes to Earth.
- 7.74** It's like, that's not what happens. You take off the tyrant and all you have left are the slaves. Everything degenerates into catastrophe. It's a very hard journey from the tyranny through the chaos to the promised land. Everything you do is that journey. Every single thing you do. That's why the story is profoundly true. It's always happening. Right. So that's very much worth knowing.
- 7.75** And so now you can see how that maps onto this structure, just like the fall in—in fact, the entire biblical narrative is one of these stories. Paradise, paradise lost, paradise reestablished. How is paradise reestablished? Under the rule of Christ. Right. That's the Bible. Now, there's a reason for that. It's not an arbitrary supposition, not in the least. It's not least—here's a foreshadowing.
- 7.76** Christ's passion, psychologically speaking, the story is the story of someone who foregoes power and self, and what, hedonistic self-gratification, entirely, who then determines to face the worst of all things aimed at the highest possible good. Right. Well, how could that be anything otherwise than the story of redemption?
- 7.77** Because the alternative hypothesis would be, well, you could pursue power and your own pleasure a little bit. And there's lots of things you could shy away from—suffering, death, injustice among them. And then there's malevolence because Christ dies in the most painful possible manner and not only painful, but humiliating. That's the worst fear. That's the fear of an agoraphobic. I will die a humiliating death.
- 7.78** Why is that the worst fear? We don't like to have our vulnerability exposed to public display. We really don't like that. That's terror of the tyrant. You show your vulnerability and get pecked to death by the crows. The corresponding fear on the

biological side is death. The combination of those is humiliating death. That's the worst form of death. That's the crucifixion.

- 7.79 What's it followed by? Descent into hell, the harrowing of hell. Why? Because if you want to live completely, you have to face death and malevolence. And then you think, well, obviously, because the alternative hypothesis is that you get to shy away and succeed. It's like, how are you going to succeed if you shy away? And so, what do you have to face?
- 7.80 Well, what are you going to shy away from? You're not going to master anything you shy away from. Well, you're going to shy away from what's worst. That's the proclivity. Well, that's why that story is an exemplar, like an archetypal, it's an archetypal ultimate. Worst possible death combined with the deepest possible malevolence. Face that and prevail. That's the story. Well, like I said, generate a counter narrative and see how well that goes for you.
- 7.81 We also know, by the way, that the way that you fortify people—this is the way, first of all, the way you learn is by confronting things that challenge you in an optimized manner. So that's literally the pattern of learning itself, is that you step outside of your zone of comfort and you face something, some new anomaly, that's like a fragment of death and hell. That's a good way of thinking about it. And you prevail and then you expand. And so there's a pattern to that.
- 7.82 And then we know in therapy, this is a discovery that all therapeutic schools have converged on. All of them, behavioral, psychoanalytic, doesn't matter. What are you avoiding? Let's investigate it. Maybe we'll expose you to it behaviorally. You're an agoraphobic; you're terrified of humiliating death because that's what agoraphobics are terrified of. You think you're going to die a humiliating death in an elevator. And so we bring you to the elevator and we have you observe that, if you voluntarily confront, you will transform.
- 7.83 Right. So that's the human story. That's the human story. We're not prey animals. We're not prey animals. We're not frozen by the sight of the anomalous. We investigate and take the treasure and we transform ourselves. Right, that's the bread that people—that's the heavenly bread. That's Christ's rejoinder to the Marxists. "Man does not live by bread alone, but by every word that comes from the mouth of God." What does that mean?
- 7.84 It means partly that, if a society is founded on the ethos of voluntary exposure and self-sacrifice, then food appears in abundance. You can starve in the midst of plenty, especially if you're crooked and delusional. And so the meta-ethic that delivers food to the starving masses, that's the pattern of exposure that's characterized by the Christian Passion.
- 7.85 And that's right. That's the right foundation. It has to be, unless you're willing to presume that you can master by shying away. Well, that's a preposterous claim. How

can you master by shying away? Mastery implies contact and expertise. You don't develop that by not being there.

- 7.86** All right, how are these places characterized? So this is so fun. It's so remarkable that this is the case. Well, these are the basic characters of the narrative world. So, let's look at this. The outside, the very container of everything, we'll start with the conceptualization of that as the dragon of chaos. OK, why? Why dragon? We already covered that.
- 7.87** Dragon is equivalent to predation and danger as such. Fire-breathing, carnivorous, flying reptile. It's like, that defines undefined place, but not perfectly, because the dragon is only something terrifying. So you need the treasure. Why? Because the realm of possibility is the realm of the dragon and the treasure. Why? Well, because you might die, but maybe you'll discover a new land.
- 7.88** And that's very paradoxical. How do you respond to that? Because it gives with one hand and takes with the other. So it's an ambivalent—well, the hero story is the story of how you develop the wherewithal to beard the dragon in its lair and take the treasure, obviously. And obviously, that's the narrative of life.
- 7.89** So, chaos as such, in and of itself, that's the representation. Dragon, that's Lucifer, that's Satan, that's the predator; and treasure. And that could be material treasure, it could be heavenly treasure. And heavenly treasure is the treasure that guarantees the treasure on Earth. Christ says, "Store up your treasure in a place that rust cannot attack it and it cannot be stolen." Where is that? That's heaven. Where is that? Stellar reputation. Right. Stellar reputation. That's the basis of social harmony. Right.
- 7.90** So, as hunters, what did we learn? The best place to store excess meat is in the bellies of the people that hunt with you. Right. That's the concretization of reputation. In archaic hunting communities, hunters differ in their prowess. But even the best hunter who's alone often fail. So human beings, the men mostly, because mostly the men hunt, banded together and hunted in groups. And the probability that, as a group, they would be successful was vastly magnified.
- 7.91** Now, even as a group, there might be one hunter who is the best. So then the question is, how's the hunter who's the best in the group to comport himself when a large animal has been brought down? A mammoth, say. Human beings came to North America 15,000 years ago. And by 10,000 years ago, there were zero mammoths. Right, so we're very effective with spears and clubs and weapons of that sort. All the large mammals disappeared. Right. So hunting humans, nothing like that on the planet.
- 7.92** So you're the best hunter. And so what do you do? You get the best cut and you tell all your friends that they'd be starving without you? That's not what you do. You say, "It was nothing. Take the best cut." Why? Because there's always tomorrow. Right, right. So then you think, what's the best hunter? Well, the best hunter is the man who

provides most reliably for his family. Well, does that mean that you're the best hunter, or does that mean that you're best at sharing? Now, there's a question.

7.93 Well, maybe it means both, that you have the skill and you are unbelievably socially fluent, and then you store future provision in your reputation. Right. Right. And that's the heavenly food. And why would that work? Well, even if you're in a community where everything was devastated, and everything was lost, and there were people around who still knew who you were and trusted you, well, you could rebuild out of the ashes. You could reformulate.

7.94 So women look to markers of wealth to identify potential mates. Why? It's not because they're after the wealth. The wealth is a marker of the ability to generate wealth. Right. It's a proximal marker for the ability to generate wealth. Well, why would you want the wealth when you could have the source of the wealth? Right. Well, that's the religious invocation. Why would you settle for the wealth when you could have the source of the wealth? That's the pearl of great price that the wise man would sell everything he owns for. Right.

7.95 OK, so what are the characters? The dragon of chaos. What's that? Possibility itself. Possibility before you encounter it. It's the ground of being itself. There's echoes of older narratives in the Genesis story. In the story of creation, God broods on the surface of the water. The water is another representation of that chaotic condition. But there are other representations of God's creation in the Old Testament.

7.96 He fights Leviathan, for example, overcomes him. In the Mesopotamian creation myth, the hero god Marduk faces a feminine dragon like the dragon in Sleeping Beauty and cuts her into pieces and makes the world. And there's echoes of that under the story of Jehovah. He fights Behemoth, and Behemoth looks something like the monster of the state. Heroes fight dragons of chaos and dragons of order.

7.97 That's a good way of thinking about it. A typical hero will take down a giant. What's a giant? It's a social system gone wrong. And what's a dragon of chaos? It's a chaotic condition that hasn't been ordered. And those are the two basic domains of heroic triumph. Up against tyranny, up against chaos. That's the fundamental division.

7.98 And so, the hero overcomes chaos, that's the dragon in Sleeping Beauty, or tyrannical order. That's what Simba does when he goes back to take Pride Rock, the center of the world, from the Luciferian tyrant. So that's the pattern. Well, why? Because that's how the world is ordered and renewed. That's how the world is created, ordered, and renewed. And so, if you live that pattern, then you're living the pattern by which all other patterns are generated. Right. That's a good trick.

7.99 OK. Chaos and possibility as such. That's the dragon of chaos. OK, then we get the next layer, and this is where the feminine comes in. Why? Why would it be primary in that way? Well, the feminine is what gives birth to. So that's an element of what's primary. And the feminine is what nurtures and destroys. Right. And so, well, why destroys?

Well, because what nurtures in excess can rapidly become what destroys. That's the evil queen. That's the Oedipal mother. That's the pathology of human dependency. There's no force more potent than maternal love and no spirit that can go more cataclysmically wrong.

- 7.100** Why is the feminine chaos and destruction? Because men have to face the feminine. And what does the feminine do? Select. It says yes and no. The evolutionary hypothesis for our emergence from the shared ancestor of chimps and human beings was female sexual selection. Because human females are choosy. Chimp females aren't. They'll mate indiscriminately. The dominant males have a better chance of mating because they chase the subordinates away. But it's not a consequence of female choice. Female humans have concealed ovulation, and they're choosy.
- 7.101** And so, sexual selection and natural selection, that's what selects. And most biologists have concentrated on natural selection. But Darwin knew that sexual selection was a potent force. And that's so interesting. I know exactly why the bloody materialist biologists have only concentrated on natural selection. Because if you concentrate on sexual selection, you have to admit that consciousness shapes evolution. There's no place where consciousness shapes evolution more sharply than mate selection.
- 7.102** Butterflies can detect a deviation from symmetry of one part in a million. That's butterflies. Well, look how beautiful they are and how perfect they are. I saw a butterfly, there's a kind of butterfly, it's so remarkable. When its wings are closed, it looks exactly like a dead leaf. Natural selection. And when it's open, it's unbelievably beautiful. Sexual selection. It's perfect.
- 7.103** And you think about all the choice that went into that, all the choice and selection that went into that display, that display of beauty, to attract a mate. A mystery, that's a biological mystery. It's like, why? Do you know that pufferfish make sculptures? This is insane. These little pufferfish, they've got these little fins. They're not good for anything. They go down to the bottom of the ocean where there's light and where it's sandy. And they make these sculptures. They're, like, 30 feet across.
- 7.104** And basically, they're concentric circles, undulating waves. And they go down there with their little fins and they make, like, hills and they separate them, and then they rise up in the water, like 15 feet above, and they cast one eye down, and they think, "Oh, god, is that going to attract her?" And if they don't, they get down there and they take shells and junk out of the sculpture with their mouth because that pisses them off. And they know that's not going to go anywhere. And then they make these huge sculptures and that's how they attract the mate.
- 7.105** You know what bowerbirds are? Bowerbirds, they're remarkable, too. They go—I believe they're jungle birds, if I remember correctly, jungle-dwelling birds. In any case, they make these artistic displays. They make these bowers, which are kind of like a nest, but they don't have any function except aesthetic. They make these beautiful

weavings, and then they make a front yard, and they decorate it with blue flowers or bottle caps or whatever the hell they can find.

- 7.106** They arrange that very artfully, and they construct an entrance, like a likely way a female will come to visit, to optimize the view of their production. And some bowerbirds will knock another bowerbird out of its construction. But the female evaluates the male bowerbird not only on the beauty of what he's created, but on whether or not he can dance appropriately in that place. And the usurping birds, the thieves, don't have a dance that's well matched to the creation. And so, sexual selection.
- 7.107** Well, why is the feminine nature, mother nature? Mother nature is what selects. And it's a vicious selection process because it might mean "not you, buddy." That's what men face every time they face a rejection from a female. It's like, you could probably live, but you're not going to replicate. Right, right, right. That's nature.
- 7.108** That's part of the reason, by the way, when the evil queen turns into the dragon. So what happens in that sequence in the Disney movie is the evil queen turns into the dragon and she litters the landscape around the castle of Sleeping Beauty with these immense plants that are all thorns. That's right. There's plenty of thorns to fight your way through to deliver the kiss that awakens the princess. Right. Why? Because she wants to see if you could bloody well do it. And if you can't, then it's the evil queen that's in your way.
- 7.109** But it's not really. Like, is it the evil queen or your own insufficiency? And the right response to that for men always is, yeah, it's you. Right. Seriously. Right. So, OK, so that's the feminine. And there's a positive element, Sleeping Beauty. There's a negative element, the evil queen. That's what? Creation and destruction. Right. And so, that's the first, you could say that's the first characters that emerge out of the, the abyss of the dragon.
- 7.110** So that's actually the unknown as you encounter it. You could think of the unknown as such. That's a place. It's the place of possibility. The unknown as you encounter it is whatever's actually in your way. Those are different things, because when something gets in your way, it's not completely unknown anymore. It's at least known as an obstacle.
- 7.111** Imagine the hypothetical place of all obstacles. OK, that's the dragon of chaos. The hypothetical place of all obstacles and all treasures, that's the dragon of chaos. It's abstracted, but it represents the structure of existence itself insofar as existence is constituted by limitation and opportunity. So it's the most fundamental concept. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 7.112** That's the possibility. It is literally the possibility that God broods on at the beginning of all things. It's the ground of being. It's potential, negative and positive. And in its experienced guise, it takes on a feminine character. Now, why? Well, evolution is a

conservative process, and we can tell the difference between male and female. Creatures without nervous systems can tell the difference between male and female. There likely is no more fundamental division than male and female, because any creature that can't make that distinction doesn't exist.

7.113 So, insofar as our conceptual systems are grounded in social and biological reality, the categories of male and female are there a priori to structure everything else we see. And so, you could say that the chaos-order dichotomy is fundamental. But the Daoists immediately place a sexed interpretation on top of that. Why? Because the human imagination uses the a priori categories of perception, male and female, to represent something abstracted.

7.114 Well, of course, that's how it works. It couldn't work any other way, given the importance of that initial biological categorization. And so you see that very clearly in the Daoist view, where you have chaos and order, and you have feminine and masculine as the same thing. And that's reflected in hemispheric structure as well.

Lecture 8: Shields Against Catastrophe

At a glance — Shields against catastrophe — society and culture as protection.

- 8.1** What shields you from the terrors of the natural world? The patriarchy. It's you, society, nature. And woe betide you if your encounter with nature isn't mediated by the social. What's that? You're dropped naked alone into a jungle. Right, right. Then it's you. Well, maybe you can manage. Probably not.
- 8.2** And so, when Adam and Eve fall into chaos, God clothes them with the skins of animals. He puts an intermediation between their naked vulnerability and the world. That's what clothing is. And so, the way that human beings shield themselves, one of the ways that human beings shield themselves against the catastrophes of nature, is by organizing themselves into social groups and using the social group as an adaptation to the natural world.
- 8.3** Well, what does that mean? We're social animals. That's our mode of adaptation. And so that begs a question, too. It's like, well, what's the principle of optimized social organization so that nature doesn't rise up and demolish everything? Let me tell you a story. This is a Mesopotamian story. It's a great story. It's one of the oldest stories we have. So this is how the cosmos begins.
- 8.4** There are two deities, Tiamat and Apsu. Tiamat is a dragon. She's the dragon of the salt water. And she's a she, it's a feminine dragon. And her husband is Apsu. We don't know much about Apsu. The story doesn't talk much about Apsu. It isn't really, as far as I can understand, until you get to the Egyptians, where the father, as a society, civilization has been around long enough that its spirit starts to become represented. You know there's Apsu, but you don't know anything about him, really.
- 8.5** The story concentrates much more on Tiamat. So Tiamat is the creator goddess of the world. But she has a consort, Apsu, and they meld together. So that's a sexual embrace. That's chaos and order in a dynamic. And out of that emerges the world. But the world that emerges in the Mesopotamian story isn't humans. It's meta-humans. That's a good way of thinking about it. It's gods. So the first world is the world of the gods, the primordial characters, the primordial forces.
- 8.6** And so, why? Aries is a god, the god of rage and war. Well, that was around before people. Chimpanzees go to war. Jane Goodall discovered that; it shocked her to death. She was a Rousseauian of sorts who believed that the reason human beings were malevolent was because of the corrupt social order. It's like, uh-oh, chimpanzees go to war, too. Which demolishes that theory in its entirety.
- 8.7** In fact, that wasn't even reported for years because Goodall initially felt that the chimpanzees that would go on raiding parties and demolish the members of other troops had been perverted in some manner by their contact with human beings. But

then the same phenomenon was reported all, in many, many observation sites for chimpanzees in various locales in Africa. Juvenile males band together, patrol the perimeter. If they come across and outnumber members of other troops, they tear them to pieces.

- 8.8** Yeah, so that's deep in us. That's deep in us. It's eight million years old or older, that proclivity. It's not social. And so these primordial forces, they're what emerge first, you could say. And that's how the Mesopotamian pantheon lays itself out.
- 8.9** Now, these gods, they emerge and they don't get along together very well. And they're noisy and they're self-centered, like a two-year-old, like a disunited polity of immature motivational forces. That's a good way of thinking about it. And so they're fractious and disunited and foolish.
- 8.10** The first thing they do is kill Apsu. So this, what's that? Well, that's Nietzsche's death of God. 3,000 years. Mircea Eliade knew this. The death of God that Nietzsche pronounced was a recurring event in history. Whenever the uniting or foundational principle was violated, the desert emerged. The Mesopotamian gods kill Apsu.
- 8.11** What does that mean? They destroy the foundation of being, the social foundation of being. They protest against the patriarchy. That's another way of thinking about it. They don't honor their father. They are ungrateful. They don't understand that there's something they stand on. They don't know that their ability even to exist is predicated on the existence of a priori principles that are implicit, that they don't understand. And so, because they're prideful and foolish, they destroy the ground on which they sit.
- 8.12** So what happens? Tiamat comes back. That's the flood story. It's the same idea. Violate the intrinsic moral order and wait for the flood. Tiamat comes back. Well, what does that mean? Personally, muck about and find out. Make some mistakes. Let them aggregate. Until what?
- 8.13** I used to read my students this great little book called *There's No Such Thing as Dragons*. It's about this kid who finds this little tiny dragon in his room, and he tries to alert his parents to its presence, and they just go about their business. And because they're ignoring it, it eats everything in the house and it starts to grow.
- 8.14** And mother eventually ends up vacuuming the house that's completely full of dragon. She has to lift up its tail and vacuum underneath. But she refuses to admit to its reality because there's no such thing as dragons, which is what she tells her son, who can clearly see the dragon, which keeps growing until it's so big that it runs away with the house. And then Mr. Bixby comes home, and there's no house.
- 8.15** Now, how many men do you think that's happened to? There's a little dragon in the house, and maybe the kids can pick it up because it's not very comfortable there. So that would be a little too much chaos, let's say. But they just ignore it and they pretend that everything's OK. And then the dragon, have you ever been in a house that's just

100% dragon? It's not pleasant. Everything's in disarray, and everyone's one step from bloody cataclysmic disaster, and they're all smiling and blind.

- 8.16** And so Mr. Bixby comes home, and his house has run away on the back of the dragon. And so, well, what's that? Well, that's when you come home, and the locks have been changed, and your wife and kids have disappeared. It's like, "Well, I didn't see that coming." It's like, that's because your eyes were closed. Right. Right.
- 8.17** So, anyways, Mr. Bixby finds his house and admits to the fact that there's a dragon and tells his son, and then it starts to shrink, and it shrinks, and shrinks, and it shrinks down until it's manageable. Doesn't disappear. There's no getting rid of the snake in the garden. You better learn to live with it. And hopefully, you'd adopt the right attitude towards it and you deal with it when it's small. And then they live happily in their house, having admitted to what? The existence of the dragon of chaos.
- 8.18** A great story for four-year-old kids. I used to start Maps of Meaning by reading that book for four-year-olds to my class, to show them the pattern. Pay attention. Exactly. The evil king turns a blind eye. That's Egyptian mythology. Osiris was the Egyptian god of the state. And he was a great hero when he was young. But as he aged, he became anachronistic, so the game is no longer playable. But he sped the process by being willfully blind, closing a blind eye.
- 8.19** Mircea Eliade drew out a pattern of the collapse of societies in mythological representation across the world. Things that fall apart because you don't pay attention to them get old faster. So it's always that dynamic. It's like, you have to update because things transform. So you have to stay on top of the shifting serpent that constitutes the world. You speed the process of decay by your own misaligned aim.
- 8.20** Well, that's exactly what happens in the flood story. It's the sins of men that bring about the flood. What's the sin? Pride. Pride and willful blindness. That's a good way to start. Worship of the wrong gods. That's another way of thinking about it. Feminine, mother. Father, on top of that.
- 8.21** Here's what happens in the Mesopotamian story. So, the gods get alerted to the fact that Tiamat is not happy. Why is she not happy? Because they killed her husband. They try to live on his corpse. That's what the universities are doing. It's exactly the same pattern, is that the spirit that provided the structure that adapted has been chased away, and all that's left is the carcass. And the attempt is to inhabit the carcass and thrive. But all that leaves is bones, and then there's nothing.
- 8.22** This is partly why Pinocchio goes into the body of a whale to revivify the father. He finds the spirit that dwells in the carcass and rescues that. Right. Because the university isn't buildings and books. It's a spirit of intellectual inquiry. And when it's dead, there's a carcass left, and that can be parasitized, and then it's gone.

- 8.23** The Mesopotamian gods are not happy that Tiamat has come rampaging back. And they send out—and she makes an army, like a phalanx, like a hierarchy. And at the head of the army, she put something, a god, a devil, called Kingu, who's like Satan himself. And so, Tiamat brings chaos with an army of malevolence. All these forces at her disposal are monstrous forms. And so, that's what's coming at the careless patriarchs, the gods. And they send out one champion after another, and they all come back defeated.
- 8.24** This process extends over some time, and the gods and the goddesses are still procreating. And one day, a new child is born who's viewed as something qualitatively new. There's echoes of that in the representation of the announcement of Christ's birth to the Babylonian astrologers, who were the wise men, who intuited that a new age was dawning, the age of Pisces, by the movement of the stars, and presumed that a hero would be born to bring salvation to the world. It's the same pattern, the birth of the redemptive hero as the antithesis of chaos. That's King Arthur, by the way.
- 8.25** All of the emissaries that are sent out fail against Tiamat. But Marduk emerges, and everyone marvels at his uniqueness and courage. Now, Marduk has eyes all the way around his head, and he speaks magic words. So he pays attention and he uses his logos, logic, word, in a divine manner.
- 8.26** And the gods turn to him as their redeemer, and they ask him if he'll mount the assault against Tiamat. And he says, "Yes, but from now on, I determine destiny." What does it mean? It means that all these gods, all these primordial forces, have now arranged themselves under the authority of the highest god. It's the movement towards monotheism.
- 8.27** Now, as the Mesopotamian civilization developed, it aggregated states. And all those tribes, all those tribes had their own gods. Marduk had 50 names, and that meant the Mesopotamians, to come together as a civilization, they had to transcend those tribal divides, which are immense. Different languages, different traditions, different deities. They had to find commonalities between the gods.
- 8.28** They had, like Moses, they had to adjudicate between the gods. You have a god, you have a god. Which is the higher god? Or do we fight? Is there some amalgam of the divine that we can both bow to? Well, that was the emergence of Marduk. Out of the panoply of gods, it's represented in the story. There's multiple gods, but Marduk rises out of them. It's a condensation of the process of civilization itself.
- 8.29** So Marduk goes out and he confronts Tiamat and he catches her in a net, a net, a conceptual web. He captures her in a net, and then he cuts her into pieces, and he makes the world. And what does that mean? Well, it means that we make the order that's good out of chaos through attention and logos. That's partly what it means. It also means that we do create the world out of, what? Out of a carcass that's captured and cut up. We're predatory animals. That's how we feed ourselves.

- 8.30** So both of those are operating at the same time. And he makes man, and he makes man out of the blood of Kingu. So that's a rough little twist in the story. And that accounts for the taint of malevolence that characterizes human beings. It's like, human beings they're, characterized by the possibility of evil. It's something that no other creature is characterized by.
- 8.31** You see that arise in the story of Genesis. When Adam and Eve become aware of their own nakedness, they know the difference between good and evil. It took me a long time to figure that out. Why is the knowledge of good and evil dependent on the knowledge of nakedness? It's like, I'm naked. What does that mean? I'm exposed. What does that mean? I can be hurt. What does that mean? Other people can be hurt. Right. And then I can become a master of pain. And that's malevolence. That's for sure.
- 8.32** I've been in torture museums in Europe. I wouldn't recommend that for the faint-hearted. It's like, you take the worst person you could ever possibly imagine and let him loose. So, you know once you know you can be hurt. And you have that power of an animal. A wolf will tear a cow apart, a pack, but there's no malevolence in it. It's just predation.
- 8.33** Malevolence is prolonged predation, or artfully prolonged predation, or sadistically and hedonistically enjoyable prolonged predation. You just stack up the malevolence. And that's another way of thinking about how the mere predator, the snake, say, in the Garden of Eden, becomes Satan himself as the elaboration unfurls.
- 8.34** Mother, father, son, individual. That's the hero. That's the basic story. Chaos, order, hero. And the plot is the dynamic. Now, it's a bit more complicated than that because the realm of chaos has two elements, positive and negative. That's the benevolent mother and the malevolent mother.
- 8.35** The realm of order has the same bifurcated nature. You can have the good king or the evil king. You can have tyranny or beneficial order. You can have a good father or a terrible father. And then the plots start to become the interplay. The good father protects you from the evil witch. The good witch protects you from the tyrant. The hero overcomes the evil witch who's the consort of the tyrant.
- 8.36** All these plots are the multiplicitous variations of this basic underlying structure. Chaos itself: the dragon and the treasure. The feminine or the maternal: destruction and creation. The patriarchal: order and tyranny. And the hero and the adversary. The hero is the anti-hero. The hero is the Joker. The hero is the evil clown. The adversary is the evil clown. The adversary is the Joker. And that dynamic, that's Cain and Abel. That's Christ and Satan. That's Jacob and Esau. That's the hero and the anti-hero. It's the hero and the supervillain. It's the superhero and the supervillain. That's almost elevated to the level of deity.
- 8.37** And part of the reason those stories are so popular is because they take the place of religion, especially for engineers. Atheistic engineers' religion is Star Wars. And that's

not even surprising because Star Wars was constructed in part by Joseph Campbell. So it just partakes of the underlying mythological structure. Say, well, "We don't believe that." It's like, no, but you dress up in the bloody costumes and you buy the movie tickets. So you don't know you believe because it's acted out. All that means is that you're really, deeply confused.

- 8.38** OK. Chaos, feminine, masculine, hero and adversary. And that's the landscape. That's the narrative landscape. And then you can vary those. It can be hero against adversary. It can be hero against tyrant. It can be hero in concert with good king against the forces of chaos. That's the basic plot. And those are the characterological representations. So let's look at some examples because the examples flesh it out.
- 8.39** Well, that's the dragon that eats its own tail, the emissary of chaos. Why? Why does it eat its own tail? Because things go out of control. So one of the ways that a chaotic process begins is in a feedback loop. So when do you become an alcoholic? When you discover that alcohol cures your hangover. So now what? So now the cause has become the cure.
- 8.40** And so you drink too much one night, and then you wake up, and you're just about having seizures because that's what alcohol withdrawal does. And a hangover is alcohol withdrawal. And far more people die from alcohol withdrawal than from heroin withdrawal. It's not even close. And how do you treat alcohol withdrawal? With some alcohol. Well, then what? Then you loop, right?
- 8.41** So maybe you're depressed. And so what happens is, you don't think people want to see you, and so you don't see any people. And so what does that produce? More depression. And then you don't want to see anyone. And then you get more depressed. And it's just like that.
- 8.42** Or maybe you're anxious, you're too anxious. And so, you're still functioning, but then you start to avoid the places where you're anxious, and then you don't go to the supermarket, and then you don't go to the hospital, and then you don't go to your car, and then you don't go in your yard, and then you can't come out of your house. And that's another feedback loop.
- 8.43** And so that's partly why that representation of chaos exists. It's a downward self-propagating spiral. So that's not the only form of chaos. This is an alchemical representation. The alchemists believed that prima materia, that was what the world was made of. Remember, chemistry, science, came out of alchemy. That's the prima materia. Why? Because it's a symbol of chaos and possibility. And the world emerges out of chaos and possibility. And that's a completely different view than the materialist view. It's the narrative view.
- 8.44** OK, so how does this work? Out of chaos comes the great father. Out of chaos comes the great mother. So what is the great father? The king. These are all—imagine these are concepts, and they're all associated with one another, and there's a center. And the

center is what is common to all the concepts. The center is what a child is trying to imitate when the child acts out the spirit of the father.

- 8.45** So there's exemplars of fatherly behavior. They point in a direction. The direction is the center. That's the archetypal core. Here's some examples of the great father. The ancestral spirits, the family, the city, explored territory, culture, the day sky, ruled by the light. You can see and navigate in the day. Osiris, that's the Egyptian god of the state. The dead, the village, the nation, the predictable, the monument. That's a panoply of imagistic, symbolic representations of a core concept, which is the concept of order itself.
- 8.46** On the feminine side, the unknown, the great mother. People have taken exception to this characterization because, oddly, even though the feminists themselves, who are generally the people who take exception to this characterization, characterize the masculine as patriarchal, which identifies it with order, which begs the question, what's left for the feminine?
- 8.47** Well, to usurp the patriarchal order, that's one answer. It's a stupid answer. The other answer is, there's a whole separate domain. Well, why would women be chaos? Isn't that denigrating? No more than order is tyrannical. It's no more denigrating. What's the realm of possibility? Well, it's the realm of all new forms. Well, why would that be feminine? Well, think about it for a minute. Why would the realm of all new forms be feminine? That's a very foolish question. You should be able to figure that out in about a second.
- 8.48** The unknown, the great mother, what are the symbolic attributes of that realm? Positive and negative. The queen. We talked about Tiamat, the foundation of the world, the terrible foundation of the world that comes flooding back if you destroy what you stand on. The material world. Why the material world? Matter. Where does matter come from? The word. Mother, mater, M-A-T-E-R. So the material world, that's a feminine, that has a feminine etymology.
- 8.49** What matters, that's what things are made of. Matter, that's what things are made of. Mater, matter, mother. That's part of that same symbolic realm. And by symbolic realm, I mean something that's really—we've already parameterized now with large language models. A symbol is the, two words that are symbolically associated exist in statistical proximity to one another. That's how large language models make sense of language.
- 8.50** It's like, well, there's this word. What's it most likely to be associated with? What's "witch" most likely to be associated with? How about black cat? How about cauldron? How about not electrical outlet? Electrical outlet has nothing to do with witch. They're both dangerous. They don't exist in the same symbolic category. You hear the word witch, there's an echo of connotations that surround it, that whole complex of connotations.

- 8.51** That's what a symbol is. And there's no doubt that this exists. Like I said, the large language models are proof, existence proof, of the symbolic realm. So in fact, you can ask a large—you can give a large language model a word, and you can say, what are the 10 words that replace this word? And it'll just tell you, these are the 10 words that would replace this word. We did that with the word "god." We found the 10 words that would replace god with 99.97, something like that, percent overlap. I don't remember what they are at the moment, but you can imagine.
- 8.52** The land of the dead. That's not the same as the dead. Dark water. That's a good place for a witch to peer into, dark water. Not clear blue, beautiful water during the sun, but dark, murky, dangerous water in the midst of the night, in a forest that's made out of trees that are—what are they? Creepy because they cling at you when you run. That's a good place for a witch. Everyone knows that. Unexplored territory. Nature, Mother Nature. The night sky.
- 8.53** Isis. Isis is Osiris's wife in the Egyptian story. Isis is the force that rules when the old king dies. And she emerges everywhere like a hydra. The heads are everywhere. When the unity collapses, the heads come up from underneath everywhere. Don't know where to fight because there's too many obstacles. There's too many enemies. That's the rise of the underworld in the aftermath of the death of the uniting concept. The womb, the forest, barbarian lands, anomalous occurrences, and the grave. That's all in the symbolic realm of the feminine.
- 8.54** And you can think, in the Mesopotamian story, there's a void, you might say, and then Tiamat and Apsu spring up, order and chaos, the fundamental bifurcation. And then out of that, there's the multiplicity of gods. And out of that, conflict and carelessness. And then, out of that, union, and then confrontation, and then the created order. And you could say, well, that's how things come about. That's how all things always come about.
- 8.55** Here's another conceptualization. So the outermost container, so to speak, that's the dragon of chaos. And what's inside that? The unknown as you confront it. Things that appear in your realm of consciousness as anomalous. Their source is the anomalous as such. You don't ever encounter that. You only encounter it in, what would you say? Particularized manner as the thing that interferes with your progress forward. But that's a manifestation of something deeper.
- 8.56** You know this, you know this, because you'll encounter stumbling blocks in your friendships, your relationships, even with yourself, where some occurrence pops up to block your pathway forward that you then investigate, and it opens up, it opens up into whatever the hell is causing that problem. And who knows what that is. There's often a psychological factor at work.
- 8.57** There's this great poem that Charles Bukowski wrote called Nirvana. And there's a great reading of it by Tom Waits online. And Nirvana is about this lost kid, Bukowski himself, who was a very dark poet and a lowlife and an outcast. And he was riding a bus, as a

young man, and he drove up a hill, and the bus stopped at a diner, and he went into the diner, and everything was clean, well taken care of.

- 8.58** And the coffee was fresh, and the waitress was pleasant, and the cook laughed a good clean laugh, and the dishwasher made some jokes, and the food came and it was simple, but it was well prepared. And it was a hospitable place, and it elevated his spirits as a lost soul. And he had this notion that if he just stayed there, everything would be all right. Then the meal ended, and it was time for the bus to go. And away he went back to the land of the slaves and the dead, and down the hill, back into what? Whatever hell he had emerged from.
- 8.59** And that's exactly right, that poem, because I used to work as a short-order cook and as a dishwasher for a long time, really. And I can tell when I go into a restaurant, whether it's a—especially a diner restaurant, whether the people who run it hate people or not. And if they hate people, then everything's a little sticky, including the floor.
- 8.60** And they make toast, but they overcook it, and then they let it get cold, and then they butter it with margarine. And the margarine is cold and that just tears out the middle of the toast. And then the coffee is toxic. And the eggs are either too hard or too undercooked or too burned or all of those because that's real mastery. And the bacon has exactly the same quality. Some of it's too crisp and some of it isn't cooked at all. And the orange juice isn't made of oranges. And God only knows what it's made of. And if you have to use the washroom, then heaven help you.
- 8.61** And so where are you, when you're in that place? You're in what? You're in, I don't know what you're in. You're in a nightmare. You're in a nightmare. And so, why? Well, sometimes people get sick and things fall apart, but that begs the question of why they've become ill. And sometimes people run diners because they're sadistic right to the core. And that's how they take revenge on everything.
- 8.62** And then they fail miserably in a Cain-like manner while failing entirely to offer their best. And they curse God, and they hope that the murderous rage and the genocide comes forth. And that's breakfast. Right. God. Really, it's really not good. It's seriously not good. Places like that, oh my God. They're little manifestations of hell.
- 8.63** So, dragon of chaos, the unknown, that's what comes out of that. That's got that feminine, symbolic quality. Out of that comes the known, the protective structure. That's the city in the middle of nature, the walled medieval city in the middle of the wilderness, right? Defended against the barbarians and the force of nature. And inside that, the knower, that's the hero, right? And so, that's the phenomenological world portrayed characterologically in narrative.
- 8.64** And narrative is a description of our frames of reference and our frames of perception and how we orient ourselves in the world. It's a description of the territory through which we're navigating and the characters that inhabit it. And if you don't believe that, well, you come up with your own theory about why people are entranced by stories.

"Well, it's entertainment." That's the typical reductionist psychological interpretation of literature. "Well, it's entertaining."

- 8.65** It's like, yeah, why? Why? Why are you attracted to it? Why would you pay for it? Why will you line up for it? Why will your children clamor for it? "Well, because it's entertaining." That's a stupid theory. It means that, what does that mean? That your instinct for apprehension has no bearing on your development. It's just superfluous. It's epiphenomenal. It doesn't matter. Entertainment is just what doesn't matter. Well, I can't think of—I can't comprehend a theory stupider than that one.
- 8.66** And it's got this terrible anti-religious foundation. Because if you give narrative any credence, and then you understand that there are levels of narrative, some shallow, light entertainment, and some not shallow at all, well, then what? What's the deepest story? How do you characterize that, especially if you're a moral relativist? And you're a moral relativist, why? So you can pursue power and your own hedonic pleasure, obviously. That's the payoff.
- 8.67** It's like, well, does narrative matter? Well, there are levels. Dostoevsky borders on the religious. Why? Because he writes about everything, all the time. Well, if there's levels of depth and that's real, what's at the bottom or the top? Better not go there. That's entertainment. Back to the real world. Pathetic. And that's the postmodernist, too. "No uniting meta narrative." Scum.
- 8.68** Well, it's so terrible because it's immediately—see, this is the conundrum. It's immediately replaced by something. No uniting narrative. OK, how do we organize ourselves? Well, power. That's a good one. Pleasure. That's a good one. The dynamic between the two. I'll tell you a story. This is how things end. It's from the Book of Revelation.
- 8.69** OK, so there's an image in the Book of Revelation of the scarlet beast of the state. Why is it scarlet? Because it's blood. The scarlet beast of the state has multiple heads, and they're on, they're like a hydra. They're like snakes. Well, why? Because it's starting to dissolve into serpentine chaos. There's no uniting principle. And what do the heads do? Well, they don't get along. If you have a lot of heads, you don't know which direction you're going.
- 8.70** So that's the state where the center has collapsed. That's the state of the death of God. Literally, portrayed in an image. This is how things end. The scarlet beast, many heads, fighting with each other. Snake-like as well, because the chaos is starting to emerge. That's the degenerate patriarchy, which has no unifying direction. That's the postmodern reality.
- 8.71** What's on the back of the degenerate masculine? Well, what would you expect to be on the back of the degenerate masculine but the degenerate feminine? What's that? The whore of Babylon. Who's the whore of Babylon? Well, Babylon is the great city that's gone terribly wrong. So part of the whore of Babylon is the pathological

relationship with the degenerate masculine. What does it look like? She's sexually seductive and beautiful, the mother of all prostitutes.

- 8.72** What does that mean? What's prostitution? Prostitution is the commercialization of sexuality. It's the subjugation of female sexuality to the commercial. Why does that happen? Because the patriarchal state has disintegrated. The whore of Babylon emerges along with the disintegrated state. 35 percent of web traffic is pornographic. Right. So what's that the sign of? Well, it's the sign of the end times.
- 8.73** Why? Because the state is disintegrated and female sexuality has commoditized. Why would it commoditize? Because it can't find relationship. Why can't it find relationship? Because the state has, the patriarchal condition has degenerated and is confused. So there's no hero. Well, the hero would require a uniting meta narrative, and we've dispensed with that. So the whore of Babylon offers leavings of her fornication in a golden cup. That's the image. It's a brutal image. And she's the avatar of the commoditization of female sexual attractiveness.
- 8.74** So what happens at the end of the story? Well, the degenerate state attracts, with bread and circuses, with the promise of commoditized sexuality. That's a good way of thinking about it. What happens at the end of the story? The beast kills the prostitute. That's a good thing to know. It's like, the communists offered free love. What did that end up meaning? It means the same thing that the commoditization of sexuality eventually means. No sex.
- 8.75** The people who have the most sex are married religious couples. And the consequence of the sexual revolution has been, what? Women and men are polarized politically like they never have been. 50 percent of women who are 30 and under in the West have no child, and half of them will never have a child. The marriage rate has plummeted, the divorce rate has increased, and the birth rate has fallen far below replacement. Right. Is that the end times? Draw your own conclusions.
- 8.76** See, the pattern in Revelation is how things end. People look at that story and they think, "That will be the end of time." It's like, no, that's the end. That's how things end. Just like Genesis is how all things begin. Now, then, in the future, how do things end? This is the pattern of ending. It's dynamic, too, between—you could think about it as a dynamic between power and pleasure. That's another way, because that's the degeneration of the state. It transforms into a dynamic between power and pleasure.
- 8.77** Watch Cabaret. That's perfect. It's perfect. It's so brilliant. It's a movie done in the '70s. It's about this Cluster B, narcissistic, borderline actress who's self-aggrandizing and selfish to the core, who works with a troupe of transsexuals and brutally commoditized prostitutes in a cabaret in the 1930s, hosted by the master of ceremonies, who's Satan himself, essentially. Joel Grey played him and won an Academy Award for it. He's the transition between stories.

- 8.78** That's what the master of ceremonies—that's Kermit the Frog, by the way, the transition figure between stories. That's a magical figure, right? Because something outside a story is magic. Joel Grey is an agent of downward transformation. The story unfolds. This woman—Liza Minnelli plays it perfectly— entices this relatively naive and sexually immature and confused young academic, which bloody well figures, into a pathological relationship.
- 8.79** She ends up pregnant. She has an abortion. She decides to die like a drug-addled prostitute, which is her final song. And all the while, the Nazis are in the audience, just waiting for their opportunity, invited in by the decadence of the state. That movie nails it. It's perfect. Perfect. That terrible dynamic between tyranny and hedonism. Well, why be tyrannical if it isn't for your own purposes? The only other alternative is just pure sadism. It's like, I want power, so I get to do exactly what my whims want. Right? That's that dance.
- 8.80** OK, so here's a representation on the mythological side of the feminine. So what emerges? This is, what would you say? This is the symbolic domain of Tiamat. Tiamat would be both of these things at the same time, somewhat undifferentiated. Remember that Tiamat in the Mesopotamian story is a dragon and female. It's an amalgam.
- 8.81** Well, the same thing happens in the Sleeping Beauty representation because the evil queen turns into the dragon. It's like, behind evil in its personified guise, male or female, is chaos itself, including the realm of the malevolent. And so when Prince Philip emerges from the dungeon and decides to sally forth, he sees the evil queen as a force of nature with an admixture of malevolence. And that's when she turns into the dragon. That's his true obstacle. And all the proximal obstacles are, they're the surface of that.
- 8.82** And why? Why would you abstract beyond the surface? Because you want to solve the whole problem at once. Life has many problems. OK, problems now become a set. How do I solve all the problems at once? That's a religious question. How do I solve all the problems at the same time? That's a meta explanation. So what's the pattern that solves all the problems across the longest pattern of time that improves, that unites? A very complicated problem. Very complicated problem.
- 8.83** OK, so how do you characterize the feminine that emerges out of chaos, symbolically? OK, so that image, that image is taken from a medieval painting. And the painting is a woman who's in the sky. She's in this, see that shape? That's an almond. It's a vulval shape. It's called a mandorla. It's a very old image. Christ often appears in that image, and so does Mary. And it often represents something like an opening into the beyond, an opening into the source of things.
- 8.84** So there's a sexual connotation to that and a biological connotation to it, but it's a portal. That's another way of thinking, about a portal into the beyond. And in that

beyond, the archetypal figures reside. That's a good way of thinking about it. So there's a sexual representation to that shape. Now, this is, it's Venus. So she's the goddess of erotic attraction. And now, in that image, in the totality of the image, she's in the sky, and these rays are radiating from her, and the rays are magical attraction. Well, and that would be the magical attraction of the female nude form. They call that numinous.

- 8.85** Rudolf Otto wrote a book called *The Idea of the Holy*. He identified a category which was the numinous, and the numinous is what shines forth. And the numinous is what you encounter that you cannot become accustomed to. Fire is one of those things. You can gaze at fire forever. You never habituate. The Australian Aborigines have a category, fire, women, and dangerous things. Perfect category. Perfect. What do they all have in common? You can't look away. That's Venus.
- 8.86** In this image, there are knights, K-N-I-G-H-T, knights, kneeling in front of her, gazing up in adoration. Well, that's the feminine, the judge. And it works in women, too, in many ways, because the perfect female form is the judge of women. And it's a brutal and harsh judge.
- 8.87** So there she is with her wings, exerting her magical force. What does she offer? Promise. Invitation. Threat. Probably not you, buddy. What does the threat produce? I had lots of male clients who were so terrified of women, they couldn't even look at them. Couldn't talk to them. These were men often who'd been rejected. They were friendless, and they'd been rejected pretty much by everyone from day one. And they were petrified, petrified of women.
- 8.88** That's a much more common experience, especially for young men, than you might think. Why? Because there's nothing more final than the judgment of rejection, obviously. And that's magical. You're compelled by it and subject to it. That's part of that symbolic realm of the feminine.
- 8.89** Here's a funny little thing I found which I loved, and it was so, it was so helpful. This is a cartoon that was drawn in the '70s, I believe, and it's an underground cartoon, and I believe it came out of San Francisco. A guy named Gilbert Shelton wrote it. And Gilbert Shelton wrote these ridiculous head comics for stoned San Franciscans about these hippies, the fabulous Furry Freak Brothers, and they're always having drug-fueled idiot adventures. And it was part of hippie culture, this genre of literature.
- 8.90** And they had a cat, Fat Freddie's cat. And at one point, the hippies moved out to the country and they brought the cat. Now, cats hate being brought to the country. I mean, I don't know if you've ever moved a cat, but cats don't like being moved. I used to take my cat and my dog for a walk, my parents' cat and dog for a walk. This is years ago. And the dog would trot around, along right behind. But the cat liked the dog and it liked my dad. And so the cat would come along, but not very happily.
- 8.91** When it first started coming along, it would just slink right along the houses because it had its little territory, the yard. Liked the yard. Knew there was nothing that was going

to eat it in that yard. But then it got outside the yard where the monsters live. And so then it had slink along the houses. And so it would want to go for a walk and it meowed piteously because it was left behind. It would slink along.

- 8.92** And then as the walks became more regular, the cat got more proximal. It would start to walk with the dog and my dad. But if the walk went somewhere the cat hadn't slunk around and investigated, the cat would just sit on the curb and cry because there's no way it was going to go into the unknown, right, not without exploration.
- 8.93** Let me tell you another story. OK, so you got a bunch of rats. They're not isolated, aged rats, which are really unhappy, miserable, cocaine-binging rats. You can't get a rat addicted to cocaine unless you isolate it in a cage. If you put a rat in a social group, it won't addict itself to cocaine. OK, so now, you want to discover what rats are like, you got to build a rat world. So maybe it's an enclosure. The rats go, they have their burrows on one end.
- 8.94** They're living in their little rat families, and they all know each other because they have rat hierarchies. And if you take one rat out of the hierarchy and wash it, throw it back in, the other rats kill it because they don't know its smell. And they're very, very sensitive to smell because we've been poisoning them for 10,000 years. And so they're very good at detecting what is familiar and what isn't.
- 8.95** And so, the rats are all there, and they're living happy little rat lives. And they've learned that they can go out to this area and find some food. So they go out there and they forage. And they like doing that in the dark because rats are afraid of light, like we're afraid of dark. And then, so you get the rats all accustomed to the provision of food, and they're pretty happy about their cage.
- 8.96** And they've gone out very carefully, like the cat, when it's creeping around the houses, to investigate every nook and cranny, to make sure there's no snakes or cats. And rats, they hate cats. They hate cats with a passion. And it's implicit. They don't have to learn. They are born hating cats and cat odor. And so, you train them, and they get all familiarized, and now they're inhabiting cosmos territory, as far as rats are concerned. And they've planted their flag and they've organized their society. Everything's great.
- 8.97** And then you put a cat in the feeding place and you let the rats come and take a look. And what do they do? First they freeze and then they head for home. And then they poke their little beaks out of their burrows and they scream ultrasonically for 72 hours, which is equivalent to you screaming for 15 days. Right. So they're not happy. And that scream alerts all the other rats, as you might expect, and they just stay the hell in their burrow.
- 8.98** And if the dragon doesn't come visit, then the rats start to relax. And when they relax, they start to get curious because they need to eat. And once upon a time, that place that's now the terrible unknown had treasure. And so the more exploratory and heroic rats get out of the cage and sniff to see if that damn cat is anywhere around. And as

long as they keep making slow progress and nothing terrible happens, then they slink around invisibly, like the cat did around the walls, and they re-novelize all the territory, and then all the rats come back out to play. Right. Well, that's a rat hero story.

- 8.99** OK, so there's this cat, and it's got the same problem. The hippies have brought this poor cat out to the country, which is not where the cat wants to be, because what the hell does it know? So it's doing exactly what it should do in the second panel. It's slinking along, sniffing. And that's what animals of that sort do because they're mostly olfactory. We're mostly visual, but most animals are olfactory. They rely on their noses.
- 8.100** And so the cat is sniffing, going farther out into unexplored territory. And then all of a sudden, it panics and it heads for the hills. And so the one hippie says to the other, "Where'd the cat disappear to now?" And Fat Freddie says, "Under the house." And the cat's down there, and it's imagining something. This is perfect. I'm sure that Gilbert Shelton was stoned out of his imagination when he came out of this, when he came up with this conception. But he just nailed it archetypically.
- 8.101** And so you see what the cat imagines. Well, this is what children imagine when they're afraid of the dark. What's in the closet? A monster. What's a monster? Literally, a monster is a chimera. It's something that's made of the parts of things. That's what makes it a monstrous form. So what's the child's imagination attempting to do? Populate the dark with what's terrifying. Why? Well, why do you think? Because he's small and edible. And if he wanders too far away from the fire, then what?
- 8.102** And so what's in the dark? "There are no monsters, dear." It's like, really? There are no monsters? That's what you're going to teach your children? It's like, teach them how to handle monsters. That's a much better idea. That's why the devotees of Christ handle serpents. So what does the cat say? "You'd hide, too, if you'd smelled what I did." So what did it smell? Well, it's got the head of an elk and the teeth of a wolf and the feet of a duck and claws and the tail of a skunk.
- 8.103** So, is there such an animal? Well, that's a stupid question. It's like, what do you mean? What do you mean by that? That's a meta animal. It's animal as such. It's like predator as such. Is it less real than a particular species? You could easily argue that it's more real. What's more real? Bear or predator? Bear is real. Predator? That's more real. Predator who knows your name? That's more real. Monstrous predator that knows your name? Well, now you're starting to get into the demonic, so to speak. You're starting to get down to where the real fun starts.
- 8.104** So, anyways, that's the cat's trip. And so, now it's under there, shaking away, because God only knows what's in the forest. And fair enough, right? That's a live cat. Oh, so this is such fun.
- 8.105** So here's an image of the feminine. This is a Hindu image. You make sacrifices to this, or else. OK, so let me take this image apart. So that's Kali, the devourer, the goddess of death and renewal. So what is she? Well, she's a spider. Eight legs, eight arms. She's in

a web. Why? Because webs and spiders catch the unwary, and they inject them with poison and take their vitality. So that's Kali. But the web is made out of fire. Why? Well, fire is destructive and possible. Are what? Rife with potential. Harnessed properly, it's your greatest ally. Used carelessly, it's the worst thing that can possibly happen. So that's the web, fire.

8.106 But inside that, that's skulls. So she's surrounded by, so the second layer there is skulls, and that's fire and death. So that's a hell image. And so in a sense, you could think of her as queen of hell. Then her headdress is fire because just inhabiting a mandorla fire isn't enough. Her hair has to be on fire, like fiery serpents. And then she has agents of destruction in her spider arms. And then, just to top it all off, she's crouching on that gentleman whom her hollow belly indicates that she just gave birth to, and she's devouring him, intestines first.

8.107 That's Kali. Right. Well, what? What in the world are those Hindus up to? It's like, conceptualize horror and face it. Right. Well, how do you face it? What would you say? Indicate what you're willing to give up to master it. How about that? Attempt to devise some form of relationship with it since it characterizes your existence. Look at it, at least. Well, what happens if you make the right offerings and you attend in the proper way to what's horrifying? Well, this is a real question.

8.108 Why go see a horror movie? People do, right? Especially common among adolescents. Maybe adolescents with a bit of a twist in them. But very common among adolescents. Do they enjoy that? Is that entertainment? Why would it be entertaining? It's terrifying and it's disgusting. That's horror, terror and disgust. Those are very separate emotions, fear and disgust. Disgust is probably an even more primordial emotion than fear. If someone fears you, they respect you. If they're disgusted by you, you should make tracks.

8.109 Here's how you can predict divorce. You talk to a married couple, and if they roll their eyes at each other while they're talking, there's a 90 percent chance they'll be divorced within a year. Why? It's like, I think what you're doing with your eyes when you roll them is, like, you're picking the person up, inverting them, and throwing them into a trash can. It's something like that. But it's like, "I'm done with you." You've gone from human to parasite. That's not good.

8.110 The language Hitler used to refer to the Jews was not fear language. It was disgust language. And you destroy what's disgusting with no quarter. Fire and desolation. So horror, that's fear and disgust. Why experience that? Well, because you have to. And because maybe you want to master it. At least you want to experiment with it. You want to see, what does it do to you, and how can you control that? And do you have to look away? And what happens to people who are in situations where those things occur?

- 8.111** And you'll pay for it. You'll pay for the privilege of doing that. Well, how can you not see that as a developmental impetus? Why would you confront that? It's like an initiation. It's initiation rituals for young men in particular, because it's generally young men who are particularly viciously initiated, partly because women are initiated by nature. That's an encounter with what's terrifying and painful and disgusting. It's right to face what you've been protected from when you were a child.
- 8.112** What's the real world like? Well, at least in part, it's a realm of horror. How are you going to deal with that? Well, by looking away? Your friends will laugh at you if you go to a horror movie and look away. And they should. "The children are right to laugh at you, Ralph." That's the Simpsons' line.
- 8.113** OK, so that's Kali. OK, so what does she turn into? Well, this is Diana. This is a Greek goddess, so Kali doesn't turn into Diana, but this is the religious narrative. If you offer the best in the face of horror and terror, then the monstrous goddess reveals her positive face. That's the idea. That's the ritual. That's the dramatization. And that's right. It's right.
- 8.114** And so this is a positive feminine. That's Diana. Those are breasts, multiple breasts. Why? Well, because she nourishes the world. And you want to face the unknown in a manner that transforms the monstrous into the welcoming. That's what you hope for on a date, especially if you're terrified.
- 8.115** If you want to understand that more, I told you before, watch Crumb. Watch the documentary Crumb. You'll see exactly how that dynamic plays out. So the goal is to entice the benevolent out of the realm of the catastrophic. And it's an open question. And it's a question you have to contend with.
- 8.116** In the story of Job, Job is a good man. God himself thinks so. In fact, God's up in heaven, bragging about Job. And one of his sons comes along, God's sons, who happens to be Satan. And God's bragging up Job, saying, "I've got this guy. You just can't believe him. He's just everything you're hoping for in a man. You should take a look."
- 8.117** And Satan says, "I don't think he's that good." And God says, "Well, what do you mean? He's great. Everybody knows it. I know it. He's great." And Satan says, "No, he's just fortunate. Strip him of what he has, and you'll see his true colors. And if you don't believe me, give me a shot at it." And God says, "Yeah, I'll take your bet."
- 8.118** That'll happen to you. And so you want to be prepared. And what's the story? Well, you'll be doing the right thing, even. And yet, the rug will be pulled out from underneath you. And so, what do you do about that? Well, God, Job, he loses his sons and his daughters. He loses his fortune. And then that's not enough because Satan curses him with ill health in a disgusting manner. He develops a skin disease, and he's reduced to sitting in the ashes, scraping himself.

- 8.119** And then his friends come along and tell him it's probably his fault because God wouldn't be that arbitrary. So it's a brutal story. His wife says to him, "There's nothing left for you, except to curse God and die." And then God shows up. Why? Well, because that's when God shows up, in a way. It's because you're faced with that. You think, "What the hell is behind this? How can this be happening? How am I supposed to make heads or tails out of this?"
- 8.120** And Job, confronted with the full ambivalence of life, decides two things. Decides two things. He decides that, no matter what, he will not lose faith in his own essential goodness, knowing that he's flawed like other men. His decision is that, no matter what happens, he's to regard his own being as good. It's a decision.
- 8.121** It's a decision of faith, because what does the evidence suggest? His wife told him what the evidence suggests. "Curse God and die." Lose faith in yourself, lose faith in the world, perish. And the evidence is what suggests that. There's no evidence in the story that his wife didn't love him, by the way.
- 8.122** What about his attitude towards God? Because that's an equal question, and the story lays that out. It's like, God bets in relationship to a man who he knows to be good with Satan and then turns him over to him. What are you supposed to make of that? That's Job's decision. He refuses to budge from his insistence that the essential spirit of being is benevolent. That's a decision.
- 8.123** And what's the decision? Aim up, no matter what happens to you. Brutal. Well, that's a prodromal to the Passion story, right? Because everything that happens to Job, you could say, is magnified in the story of the Passion. Because the story of the Passion, this is Jung's take, it's an archetypal tragicomedy. It's a comedy because of the resurrection. It's a tragedy because of the crucifixion and the harrowing of hell.
- 8.124** The worst tragedy is the worst possible fate delivered on the least possible deserving person. So you can imagine, you took all the stories of unfair betrayal and catastrophe, and then you amalgamated them into a story that had all those elements, and you pushed it to its limit. That's what that story is. It's a limit story. And so it's the story of Job, but magnified.
- 8.125** It's like, well, death, death, painful death, painful, unjust death, painful, unjust death, young, in front of people you love, betrayed by the person who was your best ally, abandoned by your people under the thumb of a tyrant, despite your intrinsic goodness, recognized by all, chosen for death instead of a criminal who everyone knows to be a criminal, death in the most painful and humiliating possible way. It's a limit story. And then the harrowing of hell.
- 8.126** Well, that's all life has to offer. And so, Job's insistence and Christ's in the garden of Gethsemane is, "Come what may, I will not lose my upward orientation and faith." And so, then you think, look, catastrophe will come your way. Maybe mortal, a fatal illness. Well, you have children, and then you're left with the question, how best to face this?

- 8.127** Are you going to give up? Are you going to collapse? Are you going to become bitter and resentful? Are you going to die in hell? Are you going to bear it nobly as an example, especially for your kids, for your other family members? Can you do that? It's a lot to ask. It's a lot better than the alternative.
- 8.128** I've seen families face death. My wife's family, when their mother died, the siblings, pretty well constituted family, the siblings came together and they cooperated and they tightened their bonds with each other and with their father. And so when their mother passed away, which took about 15 years, the wounds healed relatively quickly because everyone comported themselves appropriately in the face of the death.
- 8.129** And then you see people die in the opposite circumstance, where everything around them is in chaos and flux, and the death precipitates the disintegration of the family and an influx of resentment, and something terrible is made far more hellish than it would have to be. And so, the story of Job, that's benefit finding, so to speak, in the most extreme conditions.
- 8.130** It's like, well, how are you going to face the worst? With resentful collapse into cataclysm? And what then? And what then? What comes out of resentment? Bitterness. What comes out of bitterness? The desire for revenge. And the kind of sadism that's justified by the nature of your suffering. If you want to turn mere tragedy into hell, that's a good pathway to take.

Lecture 9: The Hero's Descent

At a glance — The hero's descent and the emergence of the gods.

- 9.1** So that's the pattern, the pattern of the emergence of the gods, goddesses, in this case, you might say. Out of chaos comes the feminine as such, and it's bifurcated, in its bifurcated representation. So that's the negative feminine on the right-hand side and the positive feminine on the left-hand side. And that's the cataclysm of nature and the benevolence of nature.
- 9.2** The nature worshippers, the environmentalists, they think nature is the left-hand position there. It's right. "Everything's like a French impressionist painting," says every city dweller who's never been, what, bled to death by a plague of mosquitoes overnight. Right. Yeah. Nature. Red in tooth and claw. But it is the case that we're dependent as well on nature and its benevolence. So there's this terrible dichotomy, paradoxical dichotomy.
- 9.3** An object, an entity is only "one thing." That's the logical approach. It's like, well, nature is many things at the same time, many opposing things at the same time. So, complex objects are paradoxical in their intrinsic being.
- 9.4** OK, well, here's the developmental pathway, you might say, that leads to the hero. Out of chaos emerges the feminine. The positive aspect of that, well, that's Mother Mary. That's the eternal mother of the redeeming hero.
- 9.5** That's right. That's what a mother is. That's why the savior is born as a lowly infant, because every new infant is the possibility of the redemption of the world brought into the world. And every mother is the holy mother of the redeeming hero. That's the underlying archetypal story. And so that's Mary. And her maternal love strengthens, secure in the knowledge that her child has descended from heaven and his father is divine, offers the love and the support and the encouragement and the appreciation for destiny that allows her son to become everything he can.
- 9.6** It's Mary in the gospel account who precipitates Christ's confrontation with death and hell because she encourages him to perform a miraculous task at the marriage of Cana, and that's the beginning of the end. And she knows it. And so does he. And so what does that mean? It's like, well, what do you do if you're a mother? You nurture and then encourage.
- 9.7** And what's the encouragement? Well, what's your child going to face? Death and hell. And so what's the encouragement? "You could do it." So that's Hercules, that hero. And so let's look at Hercules. So there he is out in the unknown. That's the ocean. And he's in a container. So there's a maternal aspect to that. That's the maternal container of love. But it's also a ship. So it's security from the father and security from the mother. And that stops him from drowning in the sea of chaos.

- 9.8** And then, well, what's he wearing? The skin of a lion. What's a lion? A solar beast, right? King of the beasts, but also an animal that he overcame, which makes him more than the lion. And that's his skin. Out in the darkness, facing the unknown. And he has a weapon, his bow, which enables him to hit the damn target.
- 9.9** And he has a club. And what's on the club? Eyes. That's what is on the club. That's all those notches. Those are eyes because he's armed and awake. Right. Well, why? Well, he had a good mother. And that laid the foundation, right? And so, that's how the eternal goddess of the heavens gives rise to the hero.
- 9.10** Here's another representation, the walled city. Paradise is a walled city. The walls define the space. The garden is the abundance of nature that can exist in harmony with human beings within the walls. The wall is fragmented. The dragon that's been under the ground for centuries, that's eternal, has come back to fragment the walls and destroy.
- 9.11** What happens? A hero emerges to confront the dragon. What does he find the dragon guards? Gold and virgins. Why? Why virgins? Why maidens? Well, if you're the hero that can overcome the dragon, then you find the maidens. And that's sexual selection. And how old is that? That's as old as the proto-human who picked up the first stick to chase the first snake away from a mother and her infant, thus establishing the pattern.
- 9.12** And so, the hero descends into the depths of chaos to confront the dragon, to appropriate the treasure, to prolong life, and reconstitutes the state. That's exactly the pattern of Pinocchio going into the depths, chaos, down to the reptilian. "Well, whales aren't reptiles." It's like, don't be an idiot. They're also not fire-breathing, and there's no space inside them for a ship. So don't get too picky. And so he's down there, confronts the dragon. He frees his father.
- 9.13** Why would confrontation of the dragon free your father? It's because you figure out who you are. What does that mean? You are now a manifestation of the highest ancestral spirit. You've come into your own. You remember the imagery in the Lion King when Simba meditates on the pool and then his father reveals himself and unites with him.
- 9.14** So what's the promise? This is so remarkable. The bigger dragon you voluntarily confront, the more potential will be released within you. And that's right. Well, obviously, right? Everyone knows that. You don't gain in the gym by lifting the smallest weights that you can. You push yourself to your limit. And what happens? Who knows who you could become? If you are pushing, you have to push yourself in a manner that doesn't exhaust you.
- 9.15** Part of the utility of being 20 is that you can work to exhaustion. It's like, find out, how much can you do before you can't continue? Well, then back off a bit, because you got to manage it for 60 years. But when you're in your 20s, it's like, push yourself. Find out

how far you can go, and then find out what's sustainable. What's going to happen? You'll become so different from who you are that you won't even be the same person.

9.16 And that's what you should be doing. It's like, where's the meaning of life? It's like, well, find a challenge. And well, what challenge? One that you would be thrilled about if you overcame it. And so how do you find that? What bothers you? What bothers you about our goddamn world? What bothers you about the world? All of its troubles. It's like, that's your problem. That's why it bothers you. What interests you? Well, that's your calling. That's why it interests you.

9.17 So that's where you look. Where would you look? At what's shouting at you. How about that? And then you look at it and you think, well, what could I do about that? Could I do anything about that, that horrible problem? It's like, I don't know. Someone has to do something about it. Might be you, might be local. Maybe you put your family together. That's not so easy, to put your family together.

9.18 And God only knows what consequence that's going to have multi-generationally. Who knows where you're—maybe you'll make that perfect diner, and then that'll revitalize a whole neighborhood, because those things happen. Why not you? You're a son of God. You're a daughter of God. Why not you? That's the story.

9.19 Well, everyone knows this story. Castle. Keeps the barbarians out. The dragon comes back after being asleep for years. Well, that's chaos. That's Tiamat. Maybe the state has become a bit too corrupt and no one's watching. Out comes the dragon. What does the hero do? Well, the hero emerges from the confines of the, confines of safety, goes into the dangerous unknown, confronts the predator as such.

9.20 Because there'd be the proximal hero who fights off a wolf, and that's not nothing. That's a shepherd, by the way. But then there's the shepherd who fights off the class of all wolves. And that's the heavenly protector. That's how it would be represented symbolically. That's spiritual defense. Nothing can prevail against you. Well, he confronts the terrible predator. The bird lizard, the cat dragon, the cat tree lizard, the fire-breathing cat tree lizard. Cat tree bird lizard. That's what it is. Predator. That loop in its tail, very common representation of chaos dragons. It's a symbol of infinity.

9.21 A major frame of reference can collapse into chaos and then regenerate. Within a frame of reference, micro adjustments can take place with the frame holding. That's what you hope for. But there's still a small revolution. Like I said, every time you learn anything, a preexisting preconception dies. There's a small journey into chaos, and then there's a reconstitution. If you optimize that, mostly what that does is keep you alert and curious. If you do that a thousand times, in all probability, you'll smoothly transition to a much higher game without having to go to hell, so to speak, in one voyage.

9.22 And so, that's why you want to be awake and alert with an eye like a hawk and an eagle. Eagles have eyes, bald eagles, if I remember correctly, their eyes are as big as

ours. And they have two fovea. And an eagle can see a dime if it was standing on the—perching on the top of the Empire State Building—it could see a dime on the sidewalk. You want to have an eagle eye. That's why Horus is a falcon.

- 9.23** There's four gods in the Egyptian pantheon, essentially. Osiris. Osiris is the god of the state. Osiris is like George Washington. George Washington is becoming Osiris as the mythology progresses. All great heroes fall into the archetypal pattern as distance from them emerges. Why? Well, because maybe they were manifestations of the archetypal pattern, and the details don't matter.
- 9.24** And then you amalgamate the heroic pattern, and you turn that into a single individual, and you recast the heroes of old in that pattern, and that's how you remember. And it's the right way to remember, because it's always true, instead of being true just for that time and place. And that's the mythologization of memory.
- 9.25** Osiris is the god of the state. And when he was young, he was a great hero, a great culture-establishing hero. He's the entrepreneur that starts a new venture, and when it's thriving and expanding and still growing and animated by the proper spirit. But Osiris gets old and, worse, he starts to turn a blind eye. And who does he turn, what does he turn a blind eye to? Seth. Who's Seth? His evil brother, just like Scar. Scar in the Lion King is the Egyptian story, almost perfectly retold. Scar, that's Seth.
- 9.26** Seth, the word, that's set. That's the sun that sets. Because the dragon of darkness devours the sun at night, and then it fights the hero's journey through the, what would you say? Through hell and reemerges victorious in the morning. That's the solar mythology. Why? Well, because the night's a place of terror, and consciousness has to prevail through it and reemerge in the morning with the illumination.
- 9.27** So, Seth. Seth, the word, becomes Satan through the Coptic Christians. So Seth is an early manifestation of the spirit of evil, the spirit of the corrupt state. Seth is a usurper. He wants the position of his brother. So that makes him a Luciferian character. He wants what is not his by right. He is power-mad. And Osiris is blind to his machinations.
- 9.28** Well, that's how organizations become corrupt. They flourish, and then in come the predators and the parasites and the psychopaths and the narcissists. And it's more convenient, and they're very persuasive, and they're very well camouflaged, like the serpent in the Garden of Eden. They're very well camouflaged. Their false confidence is the camouflage of the psychopath, because confidence indexes competence, and the psychopath isn't competent, but he's confident.
- 9.29** And if you're not paying careful attention, you can't tell the difference. And once the psychopaths and the narcissists are sufficiently numerous, and it doesn't take very many, maybe 5 percent, 6 percent, you're done. Why? Because you were great once, and now you're old and you're not awake. And the Egyptians knew that was willful blindness.

- 9.30** They identified two contributing factors. Mere anachronism, because the world is transforming and that you have to update. That's what the Queen of Hearts says to Alice when she goes down the rabbit hole, right? Down into chaos. She meets the Queen of Hearts, the Red Queen. What does the Red Queen say to her? "In this kingdom, you have to run as fast as you can, just to stay in the same place." That's nature, right?
- 9.31** So, that's why things that ossify and cease changing deteriorate because the environment is chaotic. It's shifting. And to stay on top of it, you have to shift with it. You have to dance with it. And so, an anachronistic state is one that was once functional. That's Osiris, the once-functional great state, compounded by his willful blindness. It's just too much trouble to keep track of the trouble. Well, so the state deteriorates. So what happens?
- 9.32** Seth catches Osiris in an off moment and chops him into pieces. Those are the provinces of Egypt. The pieces of Osiris were literally portrayed as the provinces of Egypt, the fractionated pieces that the unity might fall into. So he chops them into pieces. You can't kill him. You can't get rid of him permanently. Well, because Osiris is the spirit of society. There's no getting rid of that. You can fragment it, you can isolate it, you can put it in hell, but it'll come back.
- 9.33** In any case, so Osiris is chopped into pieces and he's distributed everywhere, and so he can't come together. What does that mean? Things fall apart. That's what we say. "Everything fell apart." It's the same reference. What does that mean? There was a unity. It didn't hold. Something malevolent demolished the unity. The pieces are everywhere. No one knows how to put Humpty Dumpty back together again. Osiris vanishes.
- 9.34** Well, what should we predict? What's underneath order? Chaos. What's underneath the masculine order? Feminine. So who pops up? Isis, queen of the underworld. She makes herself present. Why? Because when the patriarchal state fragments and becomes weak, then the feminine potentiality and chaos reveals itself. So what does Isis do? She searches out the pieces of Osiris until she finds his phallus. Why? Because that's the origin of the seminal idea.
- 9.35** So you could imagine that a system is predicated on a principle, right? And that principle is the mustard seed that gives rise to the kingdom of heaven. That's why an idea is alive. And so Isis, the queen of the underworld, the bride of Osiris, the agent of chaos and potential, makes herself known when the state collapses under its own willful blindness and its anachronism. She zeros in on the seminal source and she makes herself pregnant. That's the possibility. And then she gives birth.
- 9.36** There are representations of Isis and Horus that are clear analogs of Mary and Christ. There's a line of stable continuation of representation. The queen of heaven and the divine child. That's Horus. Horus grows up outside the state. He's an outsider. He's

alienated from his culture. Well, of course, everyone's alienated from their culture. Well, why? Because it's willfully blind and anachronistic. Why? Because it was constructed by the dead.

- 9.37** And so, young people, since the '60s, that's as long as I've been around, have found themselves in an antagonistic relationship with the state. It's like, what do you expect? That all the problems are solved? You've been given an inheritance. "It's not good enough." Do it on your own. See how far you get. Why are you supposed to honor your mother and father? Because you're supposed to gaze at what they've done with a discriminating vision and separate the wheat from the chaff.
- 9.38** Horus grows up outside the state. He's alienated from the state. Like King Arthur, when the kingdom falls under the sway of the evil brother of his father. When he becomes of age, like Simba, he goes back to Egypt to have it out with Seth. Now, Horus is different than Osiris because he can see evil. That's why he's the eye. That's why he's the falcon. He's the god of attention and vision. He goes back to Egypt and he has a terrible battle with Seth.
- 9.39** In some variants, Seth rapes him. So attempts to impregnate him with the seeds of malevolence. This is an analog of what God tells Cain he's done when he's resentful and bitter. You invited the spirit of temptation in to have its way with you. That's what happens to Horus in one version. In another version, Horus fights with Seth, and during the battle, he wins. But during the battle, Seth tears out one of his eyes.
- 9.40** Well, why? Seth is the spirit of hell, is the spirit of malevolence. The probability that you're going to engage in conflict with the spirit that corrupts the state without damaging your vision is zero. It's an all-out battle. Horus prevails and he gets the eye back. Well, then what does he do? Well, you'd think he'd just pop his eye in his head, and now he's king, and end of story, and everyone lives happily ever after. But that's not what he does.
- 9.41** He takes the eye and he journeys to the underworld, where Osiris is laying latent. That's the story of Pinocchio, down into the depths to revitalize the father. He comes upon Osiris, who's living a quasi life in the depths of chaos, inanimate and blind. And he gives him the eye. So now tradition can see. Right. And that's the role of the hero, is to give tradition vision.
- 9.42** And that's the amalgam, you could say, of the conservative and the, not the revolutionary, the exploratory. It's that amalgam of the two. Tradition with vision that unites the dead and the living, that revivifies the dead. So Osiris can now see and he's reanimated. And that means that now Horus has allied himself with the foundations of the state. And so they go back to the surface together and rule together.
- 9.43** The Pharaoh is the soul of the conjunction of Osiris and Horus, and that's how the Egyptians conceptualize sovereignty. It's so brilliant. And remember, the Jews, the Israelites, came out of Egypt. These are foundational stories. So what does it mean?

The spirit of sovereignty is the conjoined union of the illuminated state and the voluntarily exploratory hero. That's the Pharaoh.

- 9.44 Then what happens in Egypt? The Pharaoh is the person who uses the symbol of that conjunction. Then the aristocracy start using it. Then the common people start using it. The notion of sovereignty cascades down the social hierarchy. It democratizes. And out of that emerges the imagistic foundation of the notion of the divine equality of all people. And that's a great example. Something acted out, something then represented an image, like dream, something then assessed philosophically, something distributed, and now something foundational.
- 9.45 That's a great story. Well, what does it mean that it's a great story? It animated Egypt for thousands of years. The vitality of a culture is dependent on the narrative that it's embedded in. And so, interestingly enough, these revelations of narrative that drive culture emerge at the beginning of the culture.
- 9.46 They're the impetus to enthusiasm that produces the cultural renaissance. And then the culture thrives on that energy for, well, what? Until it loses faith in its foundation or criticizes itself to death or transforms, or perhaps goes into the depths and reemerges with a more profound understanding and carries on, which is what I fervently hope we're doing. Right. Time to wake up and understand what has always been there, rather than merely acting it out or criticizing it foolishly.
- 9.47 So here's an interesting conceptualization that's embedded in this diagram. OK. Stable state, tyranny, collapse, new state. OK, what should the new state be? What if the new state was putting the thing that transformed states in the highest place? That's a whole new game, right? Because it's no longer a state. It's an interesting bit of jiu-jitsu or judo. It's like, OK, all states collapse.
- 9.48 Nietzsche observed this. He said, when the Europeans spread themselves out in the world, they encountered a serious problem. Other cultures had constituted themselves successfully using different sets of principles. And so the first question that would arise is: What makes you think your set of principles is right? And there's all these other potential sets of principles, and they seem to be functioning somewhat admirably. Rome, that's likely what happened to Rome as it expanded, is too many gods and no unity.
- 9.49 And then Nietzsche said, that's not the worst thing. See, the worst thing that happens is, if you think you're right, and then you find out there's a lot of people who think they're right, that are doing very many different things, and so your faith in why you were right, why is that solid? But then it's even worse because, if this was wrong, well, then this could be wrong, and so could this, and this. And so now you have a different specter, which is, all proximate systems are wrong. Nihilism or relativism, for that matter.

- 9.50** OK, so how do you rectify that? You don't put your faith in a static system. You put your faith in a dynamic process of transformation. What's that? Well, that's the pattern of voluntary death and resurrection. And that now becomes, it's not exactly a state, right? It's more like the spirit of a state. And it's a permanent, arguably, it's a permanent solution to the problem because it's a meta state. It's like a dance. The music can change, but you can still dance.
- 9.51** And so, you're not bound by—see, and this is partly what Christ is doing in the gospels constantly. He heals on the Sabbath, for example, which is this weird juxtaposition of the good, the act of healing, let's say, placed against the strictures of tradition— don't work on the Sabbath—which is a good principle.
- 9.52** There's a story, don't remember if it's apocryphal, in writings that aren't associated directly with the gospel. Christ is walking down the road. It's on the Sabbath. And there's a shepherd in the ditch, and in the ditch there's a hole, and in the hole there's a sheep. And the shepherd is trying to get the sheep out of the hole. The sun's hot, and the sheep isn't going to survive. He's trying to get the sheep out of the hole. And Christ says, "If you know what you're doing, you're blessed. But if you don't know what you're doing, you're a transgressor of the law and you're cursed." And then he walks on.
- 9.53** And what does that mean? It means, you have a sheep, and it's in a hole and it's going to die, but it's the Sabbath. And people need a break. And you shouldn't violate that. But if you're actually aiming up and you've got your act together and you feel that, in this particular instance, you're serving the spirit that created the Sabbath, then you're acting out a higher morality and good for you. And if you're careless and self-serving, and you violate the tradition, then watch the hell out.
- 9.54** And that's a representation of this. It's like, there's the state, the tradition, let's say, the law of Moses, even, that the Pharisees put forward, let's say, and that they accused Christ continually of violating. And then there's the spirit that gives rise to the law. And the uppermost service is not to the law or the tradition, but to the spirit that gives rise to the tradition. And Christ insists upon that continually in the face of Pharisaic objection.
- 9.55** And that's one of the things that ends up getting him crucified, because he insists upon healing on the Sabbath. And he tells the Pharisees that they purport to be upholders of the tradition, but in reality, what does he call them? They're like "whitewashed tombs." That's a hell of an insult, right? All pristine and attractive on the outside and full of rotting filth on the inside. It's no wonder he got crucified. And that was one of the insults that definitely did it.
- 9.56** And he tells them as well, during the same stream of invectives, that they purport to be the followers of the prophets and the law. But had they been there when the prophets they admired ruled, they would have been part of the mob that destroyed them. Right.

The Pharisees don't walk away very happy from that exchange. And that's not all the insults, by the way.

- 9.57** So there's the emergence of a new notion of stable state, right? It's a dynamic. It's a dynamic that involves love and mutual hospitality. Certainly, it involves courage in the face of death and hell. It involves this forswearing of power. What is the foundation, you might say? What is the foundational principle? The state that is predicated on the spirit that brings peace and abundance is the state that's predicated on the principle of voluntary self-sacrifice upward.
- 9.58** That's not power. That's not hedonism. That's not nihilism. It's not will to power. It's not creating your own values. It's the observation that you make sacrifices to what's highest, and that unites your psyche. It fills your life with meaning. It stabilizes the state, and it brings peaceful abundance. And that's right. That's right. It's obvious in a sense that it's right, because the alternative hypothesis would be that you serve your narrow self and its whims, and that makes the world work better. Right. No one that has an iota of wisdom believes that, even though people might try to get away with it. Right.
- 9.59** So what are you sacrificing toward? Well, the medium term, the long term, the future. And what's that? That's life eternal. So the longest possible span of time apprehended would be something like service to the pattern that brings abundance, peace, and fruitfulness over the longest possible span of time. And present orientation is subjugated to that.
- 9.60** No difference between that and maturity in the fundamental analysis. Well, that's how you serve your future self. That's how you serve your marriage. That's how you serve your children. That's how your family serves the community. Obviously, it's the basis. Try conjuring up a different principle upon which an abundant and peaceful society could be founded.
- 9.61** Being social is a sacrificial act. Why? Well, you're trying to teach your three-year-old to take turns. Why? So they can play a game with another kid. Why? Well, so they can cooperate with people and be invited to cooperate, so they can play, so they can have friends, so they can master their social milieu. OK, what's the cost? Well, your friend gets to play with your toys, too. Well, that's a sacrifice. They're your toys. Why does he have to play with my toys? Well, every child asks that, and it's a really good question.
- 9.62** It's like, well, you could say, "You'll like your toys better if you share them," which obviously turns out to be the case because if you're a wise child and you share your toys, which is a sacrificial act, because you don't get to have them— I remember my daughter's daughter. We were at her two, her second birthday, and there was a bunch of kids there, partying the way two-year-olds party, which is independently.
- 9.63** And this little girl, who's a really nice little girl and very well behaved, she went and gathered up all the toys and put them in a pile in front of her, which is classic two-year-

old behavior because two-year-olds aren't social. They're still trying to get themselves together. They can't be together with someone else. They're barely together themselves. This welter of primordial gods that inhabits them. They're trying to get that all together. And then maybe now they can take someone else's perspective. And that starts to happen around the age of three.

- 9.64 That's a sacrificial act, to take turns. Your turn first, then mine. And maybe it's even more than that. Maybe you err on the side of generosity, so that you get three turns for every four turns your friends take, and then you get a reputation for sacrificial generosity. And the sacrifice that you made in the forgoing of your own equality in turn, in turn is repaid by the plethora of friends that you gather around you. That's a good deal.
- 9.65 And then what? You don't get to be first in every game, but man, you get to play a lot of games, and the probability that you will rise up in one of them is extraordinarily high. Well, that's society, right? Society is sacrificial. Well, that's what the bloody Israelites were acting out with their altars and their, and their burnt offerings. It's like, what are we doing? What are we doing? What are we doing? Sacrificing. Why? To bring harmony.
- 9.66 Why is it sacrificial? What do we mean by sacrificial? Well, we're offering something of value. Well, thousands of years people were working on that conceptualization without being able to make it explicit. It's still barely explicit. Most biologists believe that it's the roughest, toughest primate who climbs to the top of the hierarchy. It's nonsense. It's certainly not the case for you. It's not even the case for chimpanzees. It doesn't even work for chimpanzees. It certainly doesn't work for us.
- 9.67 Tyrants reach a brutal end. And maybe it's better to be a power-mad tyrant than to be a cringing milksop. But that doesn't mean it's an optimized solution. And so, what we're looking here for are optimized solutions. And then you might think, well, the bully and the tyrant is more courageous than the coward, the moralizing immature coward. Fair enough. And a better model, which is why the hero often has to become a criminal before he's fully developed.
- 9.68 Where's the bravery in true heroism? Well, the archetypal hero faces death and hell. Right. So that's as courageous as it gets. And so there's no battle between the spirit of Horus that faces the malevolent state and revitalizes tradition with vision. There's no battle for primacy between him and the tyrant. The tyrant's nothing in comparison, even though he's more than the weakling.
- 9.69 I'll show you the symbolism of the masculine in parallel, and then we'll call it a day. Out of chaos comes order. That's God, the sun, over the city, which is in his hands. What's his polarity? The patriarchy. Tyranny, that's the patriarchy from the resentful feminist perspective. Security, order. Walls stop you from going outside, but they stop the

monsters from coming in. So is that good or bad? It's good and bad. Tyranny and security. That's the polarity of order.

9.70 And so the wise king offers security. And that's the wisest of security is the security that allows you to develop to the point where you can forgo the security or dare to establish it on more fundamental grounds. Because really, you offer your children security so they can become brave. And the security are permeable walls. The security is permeable walls that allow enough excitement and anomaly to come in to further their development until they can scale the walls and maybe establish their own territories. That's the plan.

9.71 Oh, what are the psychological implications of tyranny and security? Well, safety with security and stultification with tyranny. What's the downside to being a tyrant? How about boredom? Nothing changes in the kingdom of the permanently dead. You know the ideologue, the totalitarian ideologue, "all the problems have been solved." If you were in the Soviet Union in the 1930s and you dared to admit that you were in pain, then you got killed. Your own suffering was illegal.

9.72 Why? All the problems have been solved, don't you think? Well, I'm suffering. It's like, you're not suffering, you're a traitor. It's off to the gulag with you. Venezuela, the government made it illegal for doctors to mark starvation as the cause of death. That's how they stopped the starvation problem. Nobody dies in Venezuela—not of starvation. Why? Because that's illegal. Right. That's the stultification of tyranny. All the problems have been solved. Right? Yeah. God, here's what hell is. Hell is a place where you're punished for admitting to your own misery. How's that? Jesus. Brutal.

9.73 The wise king. Globe in hand. Cross on top. Interestingly enough, right? The symbol of proper order. What a symbol of proper order. What a paradoxical symbol of proper order. The voluntary encounter with the most horrifying possible means of death as the foundation for abundant order. Well, what does it mean? How are you going to thrive if you don't face the worst? How are you going to thrive if you don't face the worst with abundant faith?

9.74 It's a terrible thing to ask of people, but I don't see an escape from it because the alternative, as we said: shy away and prevail. No. If you're a father of a sick child, which you're likely to be, what, are you going to shy away from it? How is that going to help? And then what would happen if you didn't? Like, really didn't, really brought everything to bear on it, made all the sacrifices.

9.75 It's a dangerous line of argumentation because I'm not suggesting that people whose lives degenerate, even arbitrarily, like Job, are somehow at fault. But you have to balance that. Job admits to his inadequacy, but he insists on his essential goodness and virtue.

- 9.76** And so, maybe your loved one dies, but you make that the least amount of hell it could be. And that's not nothing. And who knows how much good that does? And maybe it doesn't save the person. Maybe it saves their soul and yours too. And that's something.
- 9.77** The wise king. What's his scepter? That's a magic wand. What's his scepter? That's Moses' staff. That's the staff of the shepherd who leads the sheep. That's the staff that Moses plants in the ground that blooms. That's the staff that turns into the serpent, chaos, the serpent that eats all the serpents of the Egyptian magicians. Why? Because Moses' staff of tradition is the living staff of tradition. We're going to find out what that is because I know the symbolic representation. And we'll do that in the next set of lectures. And that's really something.
- 9.78** Who's the evil king? The king who devours his own son. That's the male equivalent of the Oedipal problem. It's like, don't get out of place, kid. Right. The father who's jealous of his own child's prowess. That's a fractured relationship.
- 9.79** Maybe you're old and bitter because you're useless. Now you have a son and you can see all that possibility that you squandered. And so maybe you could confess and atone for that, or you could just torture him into the same kind of inadequacy that characterizes you, or worse. Right. Well, that's the tyrannical king. And you can imagine why people take exception to the pathologized patriarchy.
- 9.80** Chaos, masculine, that's Apsu, and then it's division, right? Positive and negative. And what's your goal? Make an alliance with the positive and master the negative. And out of that, well, the hero is the son of the divine father, like, he's the son of the holy mother. What does that mean? Well, the proper father offers the security that encourages and gives birth to the hero. And the hero always has two sets of parents.
- 9.81** Superman has two sets of parents. The Kents, their earthly parents, and the parents from his home planet. Harry Potter has two sets of parents. Why? Because everybody has two sets of parents. Their proximal parents, nature and culture, chaos and order. Because are your parents the cause of your existence? No, they're the proximal cause of your existence. You're a child of culture and a child nature as well.
- 9.82** And more fundamentally, one of Jung's insinuations was: you have to forgive your father for not actually being God. And that's an ambivalent request because that's what you hope, that he could have been all that he could be. But I suppose it's up to you to do better before you criticize too intently. And maybe if you were better, you'd have the gratitude that would emerge from being better that would enable you to honor what were given.
- 9.83** That's a spiritual exercise, to honor your mother and father. Make the discrimination. Find out what's good. Find out what's worth preserving and what can be cast away. And bring that forward in gratitude and embody it. And do that for your children. That's the basis of the social order.

- 9.84** Oh, I love this image. This is the vierge ouvrante. There are a number of these images made in about the 14th century. We'll end with this today. That's the world, closed. You see Mary and, what's the closed? See if you can find a closed image, vierge ouvrante, V-I-E-R-G-E. Ouvrante is O-U-V-R-A-N-T-E. See if you can see it closed. This is the open vierge ouvrante, a 14th-century carving.
- 9.85** So what do you see? Mary, the feminine, as the overarching reality. It's like, Mary with Christ on her lap. But here you see God the Father inside Mary, a very strange representation. And then God ensconced by Mary, holding the crucifixion up as the object of worship. Which, think about what we did in the Christian world. Think about what we did. We took this strange symbol, this strange representation, this crucifixion. What is that? Voluntary acceptance of the worst form of death. That's what that represents.
- 9.86** And then we put it at the center of the church. The church was built around that image of voluntary acceptance of the worst of all possible fates. And then we built our towns around the church. So there's the center. And what's the center? Well, that's what's represented by that willingness to encounter the worst. And we made that the foundation of our society, the divine principle.
- 9.87** And we acted all that out, with almost no idea of why, surrounded it with images, never understanding exactly what the principle was. I'll tell you a story in the next lecture. This will make this crystal clear. You'll see exactly how it works. It's the story of the brazen serpent in the account of Exodus and Christ's commentary on that some thousands of years later.
- 9.88** So that's the world. And then you see the people in the open doors of the statue, they're gazing on the crucifix, which is what Western culture has done for 2,000 years. Why? Why? Why? Well, it's the horror and the promise. The horror and the promise. And the confrontation with the horror and the promise, the voluntary confrontation, it's an upward-aiming acceptance as well.
- 9.89** It's done in the service of what's highest. That's exactly right. Willingness to undertake the suffering and malevolence of life in the transformative service of the highest. That's the principle upon which abundant and peaceful states are founded, obviously. How could it be otherwise?
- 9.90** If we experience emotion in relation to a goal, what is the psychological difference between a person with a goal that encounters something unexpected, views the unexpected as an obstacle, experiences negative emotion, and a person with a similar goal encounters a similar unpredicted event, but views it as a tool and experiences positive emotion?
- 9.91** Well, some of that's actually temperamental. If you're high in extroversion and low in neuroticism, you're going to tilt towards the opportunity side by default because you're tilted more in the positive emotion direction. Now, there's benefits and risks to that.

The benefit is, if there's an opportunity, you'll take it. The risk is, if it's a risk, then you're dead. Right, so the reason there's temperamental variability is because that sets a default response. And sometimes your default response is mismatched, and you die.

- 9.92** OK, but human beings are also cultural creatures, and we learn. So one of the primary religious practices is the practice of gratitude. Practice it. Practice it. So what does that mean? It literally means to make it a habit, to make it a skill, to look at what you have and what you've been given and what opportunities lie in front of you, and even maybe your burdens, if you can master that, and see how you can extract out what's positive. Remember and train yourself to do that. Become an expert at that.
- 9.93** Well, then when trouble comes along, you're primed and you're ready. And that's a deep practice. And it's a temperament-modifying practice. You have your baseline, which is your given temperament. But how do you modify yourself neurologically? That's easy. Repetition, repetition, practice, practice, practice, practice, until it becomes automatic. That's what prayer is for.
- 9.94** When Christ is tempted in the desert, Satan comes to him and tempts him in three ways. He's starving because he's been not eating for 40 days. And so Satan says, "Well, you're the son of God. Turn these stones into bread." Well, what does that mean? It means God is there to grant you a wish. It's like, well, you wandered into the desert. Why are you hoping that the rocks—I see, so this is your idea.
- 9.95** Because you put yourself in this position, you're going to ask the creator of the universe to violate the cosmic order so that you're not hungry now. That's your request. And so Christ rejects that. He's not looking for unearned gifts. So God isn't—who said, I don't remember who said it. "God's not a cosmic butler." He's not a genie in a lamp. He's not a wish-fulfilment machine.
- 9.96** Next, temptation. So Satan takes Christ to a high place and says, "Well, if you're the son of God, cast yourself off. Certainly he will catch you." Well, that's another form of corrupted prayer. It's like, I've done something cataclysmically stupid. Please save me. No, no. It's that—wrong. You might pray not to do anything cataclysmically stupid. That would be fine. But there's no wish-granting. That's not how it works.
- 9.97** Third temptation. Up to a height again. "Exert power and dominate the world." And Christ rejects that. He's not in the service of compulsion. He's not a tyrant at all, period, ever, no matter what. And that's really exemplified in the story. Because one of the critiques of the gospel Passion by naive people always is, well, if Jesus was the son of God—this is what all the people around him asked—like, bring an army. There's work to do. If you've got all that power, use it.
- 9.98** Well, turns out that, weirdly enough, that drama destroyed Rome, destroyed the pagan world, transformed the entire world. Well, that's an army. Took a while to make itself manifest. So what do you pray for? Well, sharper aim. How about that? What do you pray for? Humility, so that pride doesn't corrupt you. What do you pray for? Gratitude,

so you don't become resentful. That's the combat with the spirit of Cain. And what's the prayer? It's simple. It's simple.

- 9.99** Here's something. The spirit of your aim is the divinity that answers your prayer. That's a terrible thing. But obviously, it's true, obviously. You're having a fight with someone you love. Your aim is victory. What thoughts come to mind? And where do they come from? Well, you've conjured up a conversation with the spirit of power and force. And so that's what's going to respond and fill your head with revelations with regards to the pathway forward.
- 9.100** How do you know that you're communing with God? You're aiming high. What does that mean? Do your best. Aim as high as you can. If you move forward, your apprehension of what's high will increase. And that's what you pray for, that my apprehension of what's high would increase. That's a prayer that will be granted.
- 9.101** Here's another prayer: How am I an idiot? That's a prayer that will be answered. That's for sure. Well, that's humility, right? I've been going to the Catholic church and they have a prayer about being a grievous sinner and being saved from that. That always used to grate on me when I was a little kid. It's like, I didn't feel like I was grievously sinning that much. I probably was, but I didn't know what that meant.
- 9.102** But it means something very specific. It's like, if troubles are coming your way, why not look for where you've gone wrong? You've got that, right? That would work. No matter what it is, no matter what the—you have a terrible illness. You could think, is there a manner in which I could be handling this with more grace? God, help me identify my error. And you might say, well, it's no wonder you're suffering and terrible, because look what's happened to you.
- 9.103** It doesn't matter. You can handle it better or worse. This is what the story of Job indicates. It's like, no matter what happens to you, you're to aim up. Maintain faith in yourself, and the spirit of being itself, and aim up, no matter what, no matter what. Why? Because the alternative is hell. And that's obviously right. Obviously right. And you might say, well, that's brutal. Life's brutal. Life's brutal. So it could be somewhat less brutal, at least. That's something. And sometime that might be enough.
- 9.104** What's the most formidable dragon you've faced, and what was the treasure behind it?
- 9.105** Well, possibly, it's a tough competition, but it's possible that it was the illness of my daughter. She had the worst case of arthritis that the Toronto Sick Kids had ever seen. We took her in when she was about seven. And the prognosis was that she was going to dissolve, essentially. She had 38 affected joints. And by the time she was a teenager, two of them had to be replaced.
- 9.106** And that was the trajectory. And at one point, she was in a wheelchair and in severe pain, constantly. She really walked around when she was in her mid-teens on two

broken legs for two years. That's the benefits of socialized medicine, by the way. And so you don't pay, except with time and death.

- 9.107** What's the treasure? She figured it out. And she's helped thousands of people. And it might be revolutionary because it looks like her diet— there were other people working on it, but not very many.
- 9.108** We had her tested for allergies at one point, and she was allergic to everything we tested her for. And we thought, "There's no way she can be allergic to everything." It's like, you can be allergic to everything, as it turns out. She wasn't allergic to beef, and that's what she eats, and she has no symptoms. I eat that way, and my wife eats that way, and it works.
- 9.109** We've talked to hundreds of people, thousands of people, who've transformed their bodies. Weight loss, it's a stunning weight loss process. Fifteen pounds a month for everyone, just until it's all gone. It's unbelievable.
- 9.110** It mimics fasting, and it looks like fasting is where you repair yourself. It looks like—I interviewed a psychiatrist, Chris Palmer, who works at Harvard, at McLean's. They're using a carnivore diet to treat schizophrenia, manic depressive disorder, major depression. Treats epilepsy. That's been known forever, that ketogenic diet treats epilepsy. So it reduces neurological hyperactivity.
- 9.111** And so, we'll see how that unfolds. But she's doing great. She has three kids. She has a thriving business. She runs Peterson Academy very effectively. And then you think, well, is the suffering worthwhile? It's really something to be able to help that many people. That's worth something. Who knows what that's worth? That process hasn't fully manifested itself.
- 9.112** She's involved in a study now of people who are immunologically compromised. They're going to do a random assignation to group study, carnivore diet, keto diet, and ordinary diet. And that's mostly the way through the institutional review board, which required, tried to require that they warn people that one of the side effects could be death. Jesus. Institutional review boards. Oh, God, I hate them. They refused to do that, as they should have, because it was nonsensical. But that's a good example.
- 9.113** So there's others, many. We learned, I'll tell you one of the things we learned, because our family has been subject to a lot of attacks. They were attacks often by people whose aim, sometimes admitted later, was to twist the story so that my reputation was destroyed completely for the temporary credit of their reputation. The New York Times journalist admitted to that after she interviewed me. She was particularly good at camouflage, but I've encountered others like that.
- 9.114** What did we learn? If you stay on the track in the face of an attack, brutal as it might be in the short term, if you're patient, it turns around completely, and all you find is opportunity. And so, it took us quite a while to really learn that, probably five trips to

something approximating hell. And then we thought, oh, I see. Don't apologize. Don't cede ground. Make sure that you're aiming properly and wait, wait. That's what Job does, waits, and he gets everything back and more. And that's certainly happened to me. I'm still in quite a lot of pain, but c'est la vie.

Lecture 10: Compass of Conscience

At a glance — The compass of conscience within the narrative world.

- 10.1** So we developed a complete picture of the narrative world in the previous lectures. I'll reiterate using this slide. So the serpentine figure, a dragon, is a figure that uses predation or the notion of predation or predator as its core referent. And so that's a signifier of uncertainty, danger, and opportunity. And that's the unknown as such. And in the mythological world, that's the ground out of which all order emerges.
- 10.2** The order that's malevolent, if the aim of the hero who encounters the dragon is downward, and the order that's good or very good if the aim is upward. Enclosed within that realm of chaos, like a walled city is enclosed or is surrounded by a forest, is the unknown as such or the unknown as you encounter it. That is generally characterized in feminine using the feminine realm of symbolism.
- 10.3** Inside that, the known. Inside that, the knower. The knower has an adversarial element, too. And so this particular representation concentrates more on—it's one slice of the narrative world. So that's the world that we're attempting to explicate. And we laid out our analysis of the feminine and of the masculine and of the hero. And we're going to concentrate primarily today on core narrative of the hero.
- 10.4** And the hero's narrative defines the pathway forward to life eternal. That's a good way of thinking about it. That's the poetic way of thinking about it. What does that mean? Well, these are all minimal explanations in a way, because all of these concepts mean more than you can explain. But what that means at minimum is that if you walk that pathway, then you're walking a pathway that is timeless because it always works.
- 10.5** And it's the foundation of things. It's the proper beginning of things. It's the proper journey. And it's actually the goal as well, is to become the person who can continually make that journey. And so let's take a look at some images associated with this. This is a recap, so you can construe the hero, that's Hercules, out in the container, maternal or paternal—you can interpret it either way—that protects them from the absolute unknown, so that's the watery chaos.
- 10.6** Dressed in a lion suit, armed, forward-looking, lion skin on, club at the ready, covered with eyes. That's that exaggeration of vision that's very much characteristic of redemptive deities. Abstraction of that is careful, focused attention. Pay attention to everything. That's Hercules as the son of the great Father.
- 10.7** Out of chaos comes the great Father. What does he represent? Security, tyranny. That's the paradox of order. Too much order produces tyranny, too little produces chaos. The optimal amount allows for security. A child that's secure in the optimal manner can become an attentive, articulate, courageous sojourner into the unknown and establisher of order. And that's the goal.

- 10.8** You can think about that from the feminine perspective as well. That's the same representation. That's the emergence of the hero out of chaos, you could say, or out of the maternal embrace, or out of the matrix, or out of the virgin. And it's the same pattern out of that preexisting chaos that's formless because nothing has yet encountered it and given it form. That's why it's pure potential. Emerges the domain of the feminine. The positive aspect of that is the mother of the hero. Right. So that's why the hero has divine parents, both positive and negative.
- 10.9** OK, so representations of the encounter between the hero and possibility. Well, the most fundamental encounter is the story in Genesis, which is the creation story that presents Yahweh, God, or the Word. There's variants of it. And that's the story we'll tell, too, why that's the case.
- 10.10** In Genesis 1, God is represented as the spirit that hovers over the primordial water. It's a very strange narrative representation because the oceans are created later, and so that begs the question, what's the primordial water? But the water is a symbol of chaos, and the—see, you have to understand this by also noting that, as that initial chapter progresses, there's an insistence that men and women are made in the image of God, and that means something, and that Adam is a naming and subduing process. And so those things are all the same.
- 10.11** So what's the same? Well, in the Christian view, the word, that's the logos, that's God incarnated in man, is the same as the spirit that broods over the water that gives rise to the order that's good or very good. And that's the same as the essence of Adam who names and subdues. That's all a pattern. And you can think about that as a description of consciousness.
- 10.12** And that would mean, what would you say? That consciousness as such has a cosmic dimension. That's a way of thinking about it. The Word is held in the Christian corpus of belief to be outside of time and space itself. And that speaks to the hypothetically timeless nature of consciousness. And consciousness is exactly—this is technically the case—consciousness is that which encounters the unknown and casts it into form.
- 10.13** And there's an insistence throughout the biblical text, but even in the first chapter, and that's elaborated on by John, in the gospel of John, that there's an intent, yes, just as a perceptual frame is dependent on intent, there's an intent that has to exist in order for that interaction to make itself manifest in the optimized manner.
- 10.14** Now, you understand this already in a very fundamental way because you know that you can go to a party where you don't know anyone and you can conduct yourself badly or well. And the outcome of the party is going to be dependent on how you conduct yourself, within some range of your ability. And whether you conduct yourself well or badly is going to be dependent on your intent.
- 10.15** And so, what that means is that the manner in which the possibility in the new social situation makes itself manifest is dependent on your intent. And you know that,

because if you behave badly and things go terribly, then if you have any sense, your conscience will berate you when you return home. So what does that mean?

10.16 Well, it means that you'll receive a message, so to speak, from a higher source that informs you that your conduct was insufficient, and you failed to name and subdue things properly. Right. And so, when you know those pieces, it's obvious; and we'll flesh out the implications of that as we move forward today.

10.17 So what's the pattern of the heroic encounter? Well, we described some of it with Genesis 1 in an abstract form. But as I mentioned earlier, there are references in the biblical library, because it's a selection of stories, of God, instead of confronting the water as such, the chaos, the potential that's symbolized by water, he is the force who overcomes Leviathan. And Leviathan is a water-dwelling abysmal beast, like the whale in Jonah or the whale in Pinocchio, for that matter. Or he contends with Behemoth, which is the monster of the state.

10.18 That's the heroic pattern, to fight against tyranny or to fight against chaos. And that's how the world is ordered. We saw the same pattern with the story of Marduk, with the Mesopotamians, and that the Mesopotamian story is of the same narrative, geographical— it's the same geographical region from which the biblical narrative of Genesis 1 emerged.

10.19 And so, for the Mesopotamians, the god who made the world was a god who voluntarily faced combat with Tiamat, who is a feminine dragon of salt water. So you can see all the same ideas being portrayed there. And he encloses her in a net, and that's a conceptual net, or it can be a physical net, as you also make yourself and other people out of carcasses that you dismember. But there's an attempt to represent that abstractly, to get at the process as such. There's all these civilizations that are struggling towards this realization.

10.20 This is St. George, patron saint of England. That's why there's a cross on the on the flag, on their flag. And like St. Patrick, who chases the snakes, who confronts the snakes and establishes Ireland, St. George is a dragon slayer. And the dragon slayer is always the founder of a new order. And so, St. George is the appropriate patron saint for a country.

10.21 And so, this should start to hint at you because St. George is obviously a Christian figure. And so, that should raise the question; what's the relationship between St. George confronting the dragon and the figure of Christ? Why are those analogous? And you could say, well, Satan is the worst of all possible dragons, and Christ is the mortal enemy, by definition, the eternal enemy, by definition of what's evil.

10.22 Or you could say that St. George portrays the pattern of God resting on the surface of the water that's possibility and bringing the order that's good, or you could associate it with the crucifix as such, with that terrible death and descent into hell. And that's a more, that's a representation that's even more fundamental, you might say, than the

representation of the hero and the dragon. The dragon is what brings death. The crucifix is more like death itself. It's the worst form of death itself, so it's a lower abyss than the dragon.

- 10.23** And the treasure that's associated with that in the story is the resurrection. And what does that mean at minimum? It means through the darkness into the light. That's one of the things it means. It means that there's nothing that can't be transformed by love and attention. It means something like that. Nothing. That's the hypothesis. You think about that.
- 10.24** Now, one of the things that people take for granted, even if they don't necessarily conceptualize the world this way, is that there's nothing more real than pain. A materialist would claim that there's nothing more real than matter. But when push comes to shove, even for a materialist, there's not much that's more real than pain. And if that's the case, and it seems to be indubitably the case, then it's the case that whatever would overcome pain is more powerful and more real than pain.
- 10.25** And so, what's the idea? Meaning, commitment, sacrifice, love, truth. Those are more powerful than pain. Does that make them more real? Find out when you're in pain.
- 10.26** So St. George, he confronts the eternal dragon that always lurks everywhere, underneath everything. That's the abyss that's under every disagreement. And he frees, well, in this case, he frees the virgin. And that's an eternal story as well. An evolutionary story, an obvious evolutionary story, in my estimation.
- 10.27** What's the broader context of symbolic connotation around the figure of the dragon? Treasure, we know that. Remember, this is Kali. OK, so Kali, you can think of—now this is a transformation of the unknown as such into the feminine, like the relationship between the dragon in Sleeping Beauty and the evil queen. It's the same transformation.
- 10.28** The same thing happens in the Little Mermaid, right? Ursula, who's an octopus, which is a snake, essentially, it's eight snakes at the same time, and so she's the force that usurps and demolishes the king. She's also the force that deprives the little mermaid of her voice. And she steals the soul of the king. That's exactly right. That's exactly right. That duplicates the mythological pattern perfectly.
- 10.29** It's the same story as Snow White. Snow White faces the evil queen, and then, of course, she's redeemed at the end by the prince. That's a story that's true by definition. The man who redeems the virgin maiden from the evil queen is the prince. Yeah. And so in the Little Mermaid story, you see exactly the same motif. And the prince who restores the voice of the Little Mermaid is the hero that revitalizes the dead king. That's the standard mythological pattern.
- 10.30** OK, so what is it that the hero faces? Well, that's partly what this representation is attempting to portray. It's all of the elements of horror and terror and danger all

amalgamated into one image, so that the concept of danger can be portrayed so that a pattern that deals with danger as such can be extracted. And that's something like upward-striving voluntary sacrifice. Then the question emerges: Sacrifice of what? What's the highest sacrifice? What does the hero face?

- 10.31** This is an image I generated. It's a very coarse image. But I was trying to explain how your body—how you psychophysically set baseline stress level. OK, so imagine you've left a lot of things unattended to in your past. OK, those aren't gone. They're everywhere around you, those places of chaos that you have not transformed into appropriate order. There's a part of your brain that keeps track of that, because part of what your mind attempts to compute is the level of your competence, and it adjusts the confidence that's associated with that.
- 10.32** Some of that happens temperamentally. You might be more extroverted and less neurotic, which means you'd be more enthusiastic and less prone to negative emotion, or you might be the reverse. But there's an experiential overlay on top of that.
- 10.33** So, the more mess that's around you, then the more dangerous, the more threatening the mechanisms that set your emotional balance, presume the environment is, because you haven't mastered it very effectively, the more it tilts you towards negative emotion and away from positive emotion, and the more stress you experience. And the consequence of that is, you die faster. Right. So it's serious business.
- 10.34** Now, so one of the things you do with people in religious practice and in psychotherapy is to walk them through the errors of their past. Where did things go wrong? And so, you go back into your past and you assess all the memories you don't want to face. OK, why do you not want to face them? Because they are representations of territories that you did not master. They're holes, and they're alive. Because your mind presumes, your psyche presumes, at a deep and unconscious level, that anything you didn't master might happen again.
- 10.35** Right, right. So one of the things you want to do is you want to go back. This is what you do when you confess. And therapy is a form of confession. You go back over what happened with a fine-tooth comb and you think, "Where was my aim misaligned? And how could I adjust the manner in which I perceive the world now, so that the pit that I fell into because I was blind is now evident to me, so I could circumvent it?" And if you do that successfully, then the memory loses its emotional valence because you've solved the problem.
- 10.36** Why do you remember things? So you don't do the same stupid thing again in the future. It's not to represent the past accurately in the materialist way. That's not the point. The point is to extract from your experience the wisdom you need to move forward effectively. And you can do that by facing the demons of the past.
- 10.37** So the chaos, in a way, it's outside of time. It could be things you haven't dealt with. It could be problems you have now, in the present. And it could be an indeterminate

future, all of those things. One of the things that you can do to escape from being a slave, to start moving away from being a non-playing character, is to specify your biography explicitly so you know where the hell you are, lay out the dynamic between chaos and order in the present, and generate a vision for the future.

10.38 And that means that you transform. The way I tried to represent that in this, this image, it's just past, present, and future, the whole panoply of life span time. That's characterized by a ratio of chaos to order. And the more you tilt towards the order that's good in the representation, the more you're not the cat hiding under the porch.

10.39 And why would you be? Because if you've managed to master the past and you've come to terms with the present and you have a vision of the future, then the territory is explored and the world will unfold predictably in a benevolent manner and you'll move upward. And so, then there's no reason to prepare for everything. Right. So, this is partly why various forms of psychotherapy work.

10.40 So, a behaviorist will take your fear, defined by what you avoid that interferes with your movement forward, and break that into fragments, pieces, and have you expose yourself. So for example, if you have obsessive compulsive disorder, it's a disorder of disgust, that's a negative emotion pathology, maybe you touch something that is contaminating and you want to go wash your hands. And maybe you'll wash your hands and use a whole bar of soap and dry them out. And you're in the shower until you run out of hot water, can't leave the house, and it's a catastrophe.

10.41 I had a client who had terrible OCD, and what we did with her was, she was in the hospital. Whenever, when the garbage, when the janitors who collected the garbage walked by her, she would push herself up against the wall to get as far away from them as possible. That's how terrified she was of contamination. And so, I had her—she couldn't touch a garbage can. She couldn't touch a new garbage can with a new garbage bag in it, but she could touch a new garbage can with a new garbage bag in it with a pool cue.

10.42 So that was a start, right? Because your body, it's set up so that as soon as you use an extensive tool like a stick, your brain remaps your body so the stick is the end of your finger, essentially. We're tool users. So your car is your body as soon as you get in it. That's how you can drive. And so that's how she started.

10.43 And you find out where you can start when you're doing behavior therapy. It's like, oh, you're avoiding this. OK, how little of that can we chop that into so that you have a starting point? And that's a collaboratively empirical process. I don't know. Let's find out. Could you think about touching a garbage can with a new garbage bag with a pool cue? Could you think of that? Because that's exposure and imagination. That also works, by the way. That's a good thing to know.

10.44 If you're afraid of something and you're avoiding it, that's the thing to watch for. Because what you have is an obstacle. You've got a frame, you've got an aim, you find

an obstacle, but you're doing nothing about it. You're pretending it doesn't exist. You're avoiding it. You're not adjusting your aim, you're not adjusting the frame, and you're not circumventing the obstacle. That's a spiral. That's a bad idea. You're stuck in place.

- 10.45** And so, then you could imagine. Imagine it. Imagine making some step toward it, whatever it might be. I'll think about it for five minutes. I'll think about it for one minute. Bring it to mind. It turns out that, if you do psychophysiological studies of people who are doing exposure therapy in imagination, the more vivid they make the experience emotionally, the more psychophysiological response you can measure in their body, the faster they improve.
- 10.46** And this is true in extreme situations. So there's a woman named Edna Foa. She's one of the world's leading behavioral therapists, researchers. She dealt with women who had post-traumatic stress disorder as a consequence of violent rape. And it's perverse, in a sense, that voluntarily bringing the experience to mind, and becoming upset by that, cures. Right. An extraordinarily well-established psychotherapeutic doctrine.
- 10.47** Not surprising because it mimics the process of learning. When you learn, you are always on the edge of something that's challenging. So this is an, and you're doing it, you're doing it voluntarily. And so this is a, it's an elaboration of learning per se, although it's interesting that it works in extreme cases.
- 10.48** So the psychoanalysts, when they are concerned about suffering, so-called neurotic suffering, they walk people through their past. The behavior therapists tend to deal with exposure in the present. There are lines of research showing that exposure to the future does the same thing.
- 10.49** I mentioned in a previous lecture that I built this program called the Future Authoring program that helps people lay out a vision. It's a map, a map of the future. How am I going to navigate the future? Well, what's the future? The future is the new possibility that makes itself manifest within the confines of the present. The future is the dynamism of the world. That's a good way of thinking about it. You can think about the past as somewhat static.
- 10.50** And so, you encounter the future in the present. That's really what your consciousness does in many ways, because you're always attending to what's transforming. You need a map, a treasure map, that lays out a path that satisfies you. What does it mean, satisfy? It makes you sufficiently secure, and it makes you sufficiently curious. How do you know if it's sufficient? Because you'll move. Right. That's how you know.
- 10.51** Well, that's how the behavior is figured out, too. If they're working with a client, it's like, "Let's try this." The client goes home, comes back a week later, they haven't done anything. Wrong map. How do you know? It didn't have the motivational impetus. You have to design the map so it has the motivational impetus. And that's interesting because it means that the vision that you're called upon to conjure up, so to speak, has to be in alignment with your instinct, or it won't work.

- 10.52** You could say that that's the same as divine inspiration, I would say, as long as you haven't perverted your instincts too terribly. You have to design a vision that calls to you. And you can tell if it does because it fills you with enthusiasm, and it justifies your negative emotion, at least, even if it doesn't eradicate it. At least it justifies it. At least says, "This would be worth the risk."
- 10.53** And maybe that's good enough, because you don't want to be devoid of anxiety because anxiety alerts you and it keeps you awake. You want to be on your toes. But at minimum, that's the promised land, a vision of a future that's of sufficient quality, meaning, to produce impetus forward. Right. So you can map the past. That's know thyself. You can confront the present and you can envision the future, and then you're not a slave. Right.
- 10.54** And you're in dialogue with yourself. Dialogue. "Dia logos." You're using your own capacity for semantic evaluation to lay out a structure of order that's habitable. That's a garden of Eden. A paradise, a walled garden. A walled garden. Why a walled garden? Structure, that's order, that's the walls. Nature and possibility, that's the garden. Optimally balanced, that's the proper human environment. Paradise. Eden means well-watered place. Paradise is "pairi daiza", walled garden. So you make of the past, present, and future a walled garden.
- 10.55** Now, the more chaos in your life compared to order, the more unexplored territory compared to explored territory, the higher the allostatic load, that's the technical term, the more emotional disinhibition. Remember that? The more indeterminate chaos and the harder the slog. That's the hero.
- 10.56** OK, you remember this image? We were just reminding ourselves of the representation. Now you see it closed as well. Now, this is a very interesting image. Think about what this means. So it starts, what does it start with? It starts with Mary and Christ. So let's say mother and child. But in their ultimate abstraction, mother as such, child as such, she's holding the world. So the world depends on that relationship. Well, obviously. OK.
- 10.57** Now you open that up to see how it's structured. Now you have Mary, and Mary, as mother of the world, is the nature that gives rise to culture, patriarchy, stable order, society. So that's why God, in this image, is nested inside Mary. What does God support? That's the question. So in this image, God is holding the crucifix in front of the populace. Now, how can that be an image of proper order?
- 10.58** And the populace, including the kings on the left, the queens on the right, so the nobles of the world bow to the notion of the crucifixion. And that's the exemplar that's put forth by the society that's an emergent consequence of the proper relationship between the mother and the infant. So that's an image of harmony, of harmony at all levels, with the crucifix in the middle of it. This is a strange thing because that seems to be a very disharmonious imposition. That's what we're going to take apart.

- 10.59** Christ was portrayed as the son of man, as well as the son of God. The son of man is a strange concept, but I think the easiest way—that's da Vinci, by the way, a representation of man, as such. That's da Vinci, the crucified with the arms outstretched, an echo of the crucifixion. At least I'm using that, that parallel to make a point. What's man as such? Well, that's what da Vinci was investigating with his immense artistic vision.
- 10.60** That's an ancient representation of man as what? Hoisting the world on his shoulders. That's Atlas. What does that mean? What does that mean? How about responsibility? How about responsibility? So is that the essence of humanity? Responsibility? That's different than hedonism. That's different than power. You can certainly see in this portrayal an analog of the idea of Christ in the Passion, hoisting the cross down the road to his death.
- 10.61** So what's the highest responsibility? By necessity, the weight of the world. Fair enough. Your relationship to society and nature, the fact that you play a role in contributing to or undermining the social fabric itself, maybe the natural order as well. But what's past that in terms of the extremity of responsibility? Your life is bounded by mortality, and worse, by malevolence. And so you're responsible to conduct yourself appropriately in the face of not only death, worse than death. Right. So that, you could think about that as the heaviest possible burden.
- 10.62** Now, obviously, there's no question about that because we're all in the same boat in that regard. And the notion that being able to hoist that burden properly is the same as being able to live properly, it has to be the case because life is defined, as Adam and Eve discover, when they notice that they're naked and they wake up, and death enters the world, and they become self-conscious and they know the difference between good and evil.
- 10.63** The signal property of humanity, a signal property of humanity, is knowledge of mortality and the necessity to carry that forward. How? How? Well, Atlas carries the world on his shoulders. Christ is the redeemer who takes all the sins of the world onto himself. That's a definition. And what does that mean? Was it Alexander Pope who said, "Nothing human is foreign to me"? That's a hell of a thing to say. To take all the sins of the world onto himself, to recognize within him all the proclivities of all people, and to deal with that.
- 10.64** And so, for example, if you're studying atrocity and you want to understand it, the cardinal question is: If you were there, would have you enjoyed it? Because the way people look at the Nazi atrocities, the way they look at the concentration camp atrocities, is they invent a kind of person who perpetrated that who isn't them. It's like, I wouldn't be so sure.
- 10.65** It was a collective pathology, just like the Soviet Union. It's lovely to think Stalin, people struggling to be free. It's like, no, get rid of Stalin. You just get another one like him.

Why? Because the mob is calling that spirit forth. And who's the mob? Everyone who's participating in the lie. And who's that in a totalitarian state? Every single person. Right. That's hell, that's for sure. Yeah, rough, rough.

10.66 This is why, in the story of Abraham, when God tells Abraham that he's going to destroy Sodom and Gomorrah, he's willing to enter into a bargain with his faithful devotee Abraham. Abraham bargains him down. "If I find 50 men who are good, will you save the city?" "Yes." "40, 30, 20, 10, just 10." Why? Because a city where 10 people can still tell the truth and aim up could still stand.

10.67 Right. And then that's worth thinking about and knowing—knowing, not thinking about — knowing that's who you're called upon to be. And you might think, why should I take the risk? You're going to take all the risks there are. You can choose which ones to take. But there's no pathway forward without that. How could there be? How could there be? That's a preposterous idea.

10.68 And so people, they play this weird, they play this delusional and prideful game, which is, "I can remain silent and avoid the trouble." Try it. See how that goes. What's the alternative? You say what you have to say if you're aiming up, and you assume that whatever happens is the best possible thing that could happen. And then you watch and you wait, and things turn around. Right.

10.69 And so why would you prevaricate or lie or turn a willfully blind eye like Osiris and doom the state to possession by Seth? Well, it pays off in the immediate present. But you're not only confronting the immediate present. God only knows what you're confronting.

10.70 The deal that Abraham makes with God, the deal that God makes with Abraham, is that if Abraham aims up and makes the proper sacrifices, undergoes the proper transformations upward, that he will be—here's the deal. This is the covenant. OK.

10.71 He'll become a blessing to himself. So that's a good deal because it isn't often the case that people regard themselves as blessings to themselves. His reputation will grow in valid ways among his compatriots. So that's a good deal. You'll be thought well of and deserve it. You'll establish something of permanent value, permanent long-term value. In Abraham's case, he's promised the opportunity to become the father of nations. Your enemies will flee before you, and you'll do this in a way that will bring nothing but benefit to everyone else. Now, that's a hell of a good deal.

10.72 Now, Abraham does experience a succession of sacrificial transformations upward, each of them marked by a reaffirmation of the covenant, with a building of an altar and a sacrifice. Why? Change. As soon as you occupy a new position, you have to make sacrifices. You have to change. You have more responsibility. You have more authority. More is depending on you. You have to shed your immaturity. You have to sacrifice. If you do it properly, then another door will open. And if you sacrifice then, another door will open.

- 10.73** Abraham's sacrificial transformation upward culminates in the demand that he sacrifice his own son to God. Now it turns out, and this is an important part of the story, that because he agrees, he doesn't have to. And so I've tried to take that apart because that's a conundrum, that story. Why would God demand that his devotee sacrifice his son, what, upward?
- 10.74** Well, that's what parents do, if they have any sense, right? Because you're going to allow the world to break your child. Right. In what attempt? How about in service of what's highest? Well, what happens to Abraham when he agrees to sacrifice Isaac? He gets him back. And what does that mean? Encourage your children in upward sacrifice, and you'll get them back. Right. And we'll see that echoed in image as we progress.
- 10.75** Here's a story, Jonah. This is a story of conscience. Things invite you and things torment you. They're your problems. That's your conscience. Your conscience is the voice or the impulse or the intuition or the revelation of your problems. And those might be the things that bother you about you, or bother you about other people, or bother you about the world. There's lots of things that could bother you, and some do, and those are your problems.
- 10.76** And you might think, well, "I don't want any problems." It's like, there's treasures where there's dragons. And so, if you're asking for no problems, you might be foregoing all opportunity. Because maybe something quite profound bothers you. It's like, why would that bother you? Maybe that's your problem. Maybe you're called upon to solve that. And maybe if it is really something that you think is beyond you, who knows who you'd have to become to sort that out?
- 10.77** And why wouldn't who you could become call to you? You wouldn't have an instinct to develop, if that wasn't the case. If there was nothing in you that was attempting to unfold, there'd be no impetus into the future. The question is, how does that impetus make itself manifest in the present? And the answer to that technically seems to be, some things interest you. You don't know why. And there's not much you can do about it, except set your aim properly.
- 10.78** And some things bother you. It's like, there it is. There's the paradoxical—those are the markers, the paradoxical markers of the pathway forward through chaos. That's what they are. And so, that's worth knowing. See what obsesses you, see what concerns you, see what attracts you. And sharpen your aim.
- 10.79** Jonah, when we meet him, is an ordinary man, as far as we know, like so many of the Old Testament heroes. He's a good man, although not a lot is made of that, but that reveals itself in the story. So you don't get to feel morally superior to Jonah from the outset of the story, because he's a good man, and maybe you are, and maybe you're not.
- 10.80** And a voice comes to him and says, "There's a city that you know of, Nineveh. And I'm thinking," this is God speaking, "I'm thinking of taking it out because they've fallen off

the path. But I'm thinking maybe they have a chance, and I want you to go there and tell them that I'm not happy, and see if they'll sort themselves out."

- 10.81** And Nineveh is the city of the enemies of the Israelites. And so, Jonah would just as soon that God comes down and takes them out. And worse than that, as bad as that, he's an Israelite and they're Ninevites, and that's not going anywhere. And there's one of him, and there's 150,000 of them. And he can't really imagine that, if he goes to Nineveh, where he's not welcome, and tells everyone, including the king, that God sent him and said that he was unhappy and that the city was in danger, that the probability that that's going to go well for Jonah is very small.
- 10.82** And so you should have some sympathy for Jonah. But Jonah is attending to his conscience. And that's what it tells him to do. So he decides not to do that, because he's a sensible person, and he jumps on a boat and he heads for a place called Tarshish, which is as far away from Nineveh as you could get at that time.
- 10.83** And he gets on the boat, that's this image, and he falls asleep. Why? Well, because that's what you do when you run from your conscience, is you lapse into unconsciousness. You have denied the voice of destiny. And the easiest way to cope with that is to descend into unconsciousness.
- 10.84** Anyways, he's asleep on the boat and God's not happy. And so he conjures up a storm, and the wind blows and the waves rise and the ship is in peril. And the sailors are starting to throw things overboard and trying to contend with the waves and the wind.
- 10.85** But they have an intuition that there's someone on board who's not right with their god. So they cast lots, and the dice point to Jonah. So they go wake him up. Now, these are pagan soldiers, pagan sailors, as far as we can tell from the story. And so we don't know what god or gods they're worshiping, some local gods of the forest or gods of the ocean, or the Romans had gods even for doorways.
- 10.86** And they wake Jonah up and they say, "We have reason to believe—the storm is rising, you're asleep, the ship is in danger—we have reason to believe that you're the problem. And are you not on good terms with your god?" And Jonah says, being a good man and relatively honest, says, "Well, as a matter of fact, I got a message and I denied it and I'm running away."
- 10.87** And the sailors say, "Well, who is your god?" Thinking that it's some relatively trivial local god. And Jonah says, "Well, my God is the maker of the heavens and the Earth." And the sailors think, "You probably shouldn't ignore him." Right, and so, while this is happening, the storm continues to rise and the ship is more in danger. And Jonah, being a good man, tells the sailors, "Just throw me overboard. It's my fault. Just throw me overboard."
- 10.88** But the sailors, who also turn out to be pretty decent individuals, don't want to just toss him into the drink, even though he arguably deserves it. And so they do everything they

can to make for shore, and they strip the ship of all of its contents. But it doesn't matter because the waves just get higher. And Jonah finally convinces them that the only thing that might work, since they're all doomed, is to just throw him in the water.

- 10.89** And then you think, well, that's pretty much as bad as it gets, all things considered. You run from your conscience, and then you drown in chaos. OK, so what's the ship? Well, that's the ship of state. That's a good way of thinking about it. And how do you make the ship of state founder? How about by denying the revelations of your conscience? Right. And so what happens if you run? Well, then you put the ship and yourself and everything you love and value in peril. And then you end up in chaos and you're going to die.
- 10.90** And you think, "That's as bad as it gets." It's like, nope, that's where the story starts, because the next thing that happens, as you'd expect, into the water. The water has a feminine element, but we know what's underneath the feminine; that's the dragon of chaos. And that's what makes itself appear, the whale. Well, there's a representation of the whale. You see, that's a dragon.
- 10.91** People didn't know exactly what a whale was. Is a whale a shark? Is a whale a sea serpent? Is a whale a giant squid? It's like, a whale is a huge, terrifying thing that lives in the depths. That's a dragon. Up comes the whale, takes Jonah in its mouth, down to the bottom of things. Right. Three days, just like Christ after death, three days in hell. And that's what the story says. Says that. Three days in hell. Down in the abyss at the bottom.
- 10.92** So then you see, so that's the cataclysm, right? He ignores his conscience, and then he's punished by death. No, worse, he's punished by hell. What's hell? That's complicated. Hell is what you would happily die to avoid. How about that? Right, and so you might think, there's nothing more terrifying than death. It's like, use your imagination. See what you can come up with. There's plenty of things worse than death. No one would commit suicide otherwise.
- 10.93** So where Jonah goes is worse than death. Well, how do things fall apart? We know this. We know this already. How do societies degenerate into totalitarian hellholes? People don't say something when they're asked to. No one. And then everyone lies about everything all the time. Three days in hell, and Jonah repents and looks up, and God forgives him, and the whale emerges from the depths and deposits him unscathed on the shore.
- 10.94** And he goes to Nineveh, like he was asked, and he's convincing. And why might that be? Well, just like Moses, he went to the bottom of things. And so when he talks, people listen. And so the Ninevites put on sackcloth and ashes, which is a sign of mourning and repentance, including the king, and the king listens, and they sort themselves out, and God saves the city. Right.

- 10.95** Is that story true? Well, it depends on what you mean by true. Was there a whale that took a man in its mouth for three days? It depends on what you mean by whale. And you might think, well, you're avoiding the question. No, you misunderstand the story. That's really that. That's the proper diagnosis.
- 10.96** And so, it's also the case, interestingly enough, in the story of Jonah, is he's not that happy that it worked because he was quite, he would have been quite pleased if the Ninevites were just demolished. And the fact that he played that redemptive role actually irritates him. That's the denouement of the story, but we won't go into that.
- 10.97** So there he is, emerging on shore. That's a medieval representation. And you can see there that it's not exactly what we would think of as a whale. The whale is the abysmal creature that lives in the ultimate depths. That's the whale. It's half a mythological beast, at least half.
- 10.98** Now, this is an interesting image because Jonah comes out of the whale here with a halo. That's the sun. That's the gold coin. So that's a symbol of illumination. And so, he's illuminated. Well, why? Because he passed through death and hell. And now people listen when he talks. And the consequence of that is that the city is renewed, and the king repents, and people are transformed.

Lecture 11: Confronting the Serpent

At a glance — Confronting the serpent, via the Exodus narrative.

- 11.1** OK, here's a fun story. This is from the Exodus narrative. The Exodus narrative stretches across a number of books. So Moses is transformed by the encounter with the burning bush. He goes back to Egypt, faces down the Pharaoh. The plagues come because the Pharaoh doubles down. Moses' authority defeats the false magic of the court magicians who use smoke and mirrors to deceive the population, whereas what Moses brings is the real thing.
- 11.2** The Pharaoh's authoritarian supremacy is overridden. The Israelites rise. The Egyptians supply them with treasure. They cross the Red Sea. They wander through the desert led by the pillar of light and the pillar of darkness. They organize themselves into a functional society with many, many lapses, and they approach the promised land.
- 11.3** They're a fractious and whiny bunch, being all slaves. And even after they're reasonably well organized in the subsidiary fashion that we described, the difficulty of the journey makes them proclaim their victimhood. And they shake their fist at Moses and call him a totalitarian patriarch who's only out for his own self-advancement. And they lose their faith in what guides them forward, God, and they pine for the good old days of the tyranny.
- 11.4** And God, by this time, is somewhat tired of that, and he sends poisonous snakes into the desert to bite them. Why? Because if you're whiny, and if you're a whiny, directionless, resentful, self-aggrandizing, hedonistic, power-mad victim, no matter how bad the situation is, you'll make it worse. And so that's what happens. It's already bad, but it's not as bad as it can be. That's exactly what happens to the Pharaoh in the progression of plagues.
- 11.5** It's like, is this enough for you? No. How about this? No. How about this? Down the levels of hell until what? Until, like Jonah, well, maybe you die. Or like Jonah, you're on your knees in the belly of the whale and you decide to pay attention. That's the issue in this story. So the Israelites, they know Moses has a hotline to God. It's annoying to them, but they know it. And so finally, after putting up with the poisonous snakes for quite a long time, they think, OK, enough is enough.
- 11.6** So they go to Moses and they say, "Would you have a chat with God? He sent all these damn snakes, and maybe you could put in a good word for us, figure out what he wants, and we could come to some terms." And so Moses has a chat with God, and God says, "You know, I don't think I'm going to get rid of the snakes," which is how the story could end, right? That'd be an OK story.
- 11.7** The Israelites muck up, yet again, complain and whine and forget to aim up and don't take responsibility and fall prey to golden calf worship, which is like drunken hedonism.

And so they're punished, and then God intercedes, and the snakes disappear, and away they go. That's a fine story. That's not what happens.

- 11.8** It's like the story of Horus. Horus defeats Seth and he loses an eye, but he gets the eye back. He could just put it back in his head and rule. But that isn't what happens. He goes down into the underworld and he revivifies Osiris. And then both rule. Tradition and vision rule.
- 11.9** God tells Moses he's not going to get rid of the snakes. But he tells Moses to do something. It's so interesting. It's such an interesting story. It's so remarkable. He says, "Gather up all the bronze that the Israelites have and melt it." And see, they did that before, except they gathered up all their jewelry and they melted it. They made the golden calf. So it's an inversion of the golden calf story.
- 11.10** When Moses leaves to get the Ten Commandments, Aaron is left. Aaron is the political wing of the divine. Aaron is Moses' brother, and Moses can't speak. There's something wrong with the way Moses speaks. No one knows. Did he have a speech impediment? Was he introverted? It doesn't matter. He partners with Aaron, and Aaron is the one who delivers his message to the people. So Aaron is his political wing.
- 11.11** Part of the idea of separation of religion and state—it's an early manifestation of that. Anyways, at one point, Moses goes off to receive the Ten Commandments. This is after he's been judged for, like, forever. And Aaron's left. So there's only the political. There's no connection to the divine.
- 11.12** Immediately, Aaron gives the people what they want. Well, what do they want? They want to party naked in the streets and worship cheap materialism. That's the golden calf. It's literally what happens. They just, soon as Moses leaves, it's like they're all dancing naked in the streets and having a gay old time. And so Moses comes back and he's not happy about that. He grinds up the golden calf and he makes them drink it. And he establishes order again.
- 11.13** But this is an inversion of that. Moses gathers up all the bronze and God says, "I want you to cast a staff and I want you to put one of these poisonous serpents on it." Not the serpent itself, but something cast. And make it large. And then I want you to put it up, and I want all the Israelites to come and look at it. And if they look at it, then they won't be affected by the poison. And so Moses melts down all this bronze and he makes this staff with the serpent on it.
- 11.14** Now, this is a very complex idea because, you see, Moses has a staff, like you have a staff if you run a company. You have a staff that you rely on. That's the organization. So Moses' staff, like the magic wand of Gandalf, which is exactly the same thing, the magic wand of the wizard, for that matter, that's the staff of Moses, and the staff of Moses is his authority. It's the center point. It's a tree. It's the tree of life. That's a good way of thinking about it. It's what you plant in the ground to mark the center.

- 11.15** Now, Moses' staff is alive because when he puts it in the ground, it blooms. So it's a living tradition. And we know from our analysis of Egyptian mythology that a living tradition is the dead state plus vision. So that's Moses. He's got this dynamic tradition that's an embodiment of the spirit of God. Moses casts his staff on the ground and it turns into a serpent. And the court magicians do the same thing in the Egyptian court. But Moses' serpent eats all their serpents. And so there's that serpent-tree dynamism.
- 11.16** Now, that's a strange thing because there's serpent-tree dynamism in the story in Genesis as well. The tree has a snake, like the tree of Yggdrasil, the Scandinavian world tree. And the serpent, snake, snakes shed their skin. They are symbols of rebirth, death and rebirth. So the thing that's on the stake is a symbol of poisonous death and rebirth. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 11.17** Now, the Israelites are fortunate because if they look at this, then they're saved. OK, so let's take this apart, a lot. Well, there's another image of the same thing. You see this one, the staff is actually a cross. So that's hinting. That's a forward-facing hint. That's a symbol of healing. The physician's symbol of healing is the snake on the staff. Why? Because a little of the poison that kills you, fortifies you.
- 11.18** That's what "pharmacon" means. That's where the word pharmaceutical comes from. A pharmacon is a hair of the dog that bit you. A little of what's poison makes you resilient, the essence of healing, the essence of learning. That's what a vaccine does when crooked pharmaceutical companies aren't peddling them malevolently. That's what we do when we confront something in small doses to fortify us for when the real thing comes along.
- 11.19** That's what we do when we learn. We step out into chaos in an optimal way and we build our resilience. So that's the essence of healing. It's the essence of health. And there's a parallel development of the symbol of Asclepius and the staff of Moses and the serpent as the symbol of healing for thousands and thousands of years.
- 11.20** OK, now you see the image is starting to transform a bit. So now you have the snake coming out of chaos and draped on a cross. And so that's a hint. OK, because it's the same question that we talked about in relationship to this serpent in the Garden of Eden. Serpent is a predator that poisons.
- 11.21** OK, what's the most poisonous serpent? Well, could be a snake. It could be an enemy. It could be the evil in the heart of an enemy. It could be the enemy within. It could be the evil in your own heart. Right. That's a step up the ladder of evil, you might say.
- 11.22** And so the serpent is a proximal representative of ultimate evil. It took people thousands of years to figure that out. That accounts for the strange association of the serpent in the Garden of Eden with Satan. It's not an obvious connection, not in any way. It's a consequence of this exploration.

- 11.23** It's like, what is the most overwhelming danger? Well, you can see it in the story of Jonah because death is there. But death is not the worst danger. Because in death, Jonah descends to the depths because there are worse things than death. And so, the worst poison is the deliverance of what's worse than death. Well, that's the poison of hell. That's the right way to think about it.
- 11.24** And so, what are you looking at? What are you looking at? What do you have to look at to fortify yourself most comprehensively? What poison do you have to take in graduated doses, so the maximal resilience emerges? And not only to the poison of the serpent, a serpent, a snake, in a concrete way, but to the poison of the worst of all possible serpents.
- 11.25** And so you would think about that as abstract poison; and you could think about abstract poison as spiritual poison. And you could think about spiritual poison as the poison that destroys inspiration, or respiration. That's the poison that the evil queen feeds Snow White in the form of the poisoned apple, that stops her from breathing and damn near kills her. Right. OK. So, that idea develops.
- 11.26** Well, what do we have here? Christ, by tradition, is crucified on the place where Adam's skull resides. Why? Because Christ is the antidote to the fall. That's the reason. That's the technical reason. So what does that mean? Well, it means that the narrative is stable initial state, paradise, collapse into the fall.
- 11.27** Then in the Old Testament, you have a number of different patterns of sacrificial transformation that are aiming at fleshing out the story of redemption. How do you deal with the fallen world in the most effective way? You have the great patriarchs of the Old Testament. And their adventures aggregate, and out of that is extracted a pattern. The pattern is just about there with Jonah. The full pattern is just about there.
- 11.28** It's reasonable to consider Jonah as a foreshadowing of the Passion. In fact, that's a standard interpretation. And how would you understand that psychologically? Well, as the stories of great romantic adventure aggregate, the underlying pattern that makes them the greatest of romantic adventures, let's say, becomes clearer and clearer.
- 11.29** What's the idea that emerges in the New Testament? That pattern is incarnated or embodied. Someone lives it out. It's lived out fully. OK, so let's examine what that means, psychologically. Well, we touched on this before.
- 11.30** The pattern of tragedy is catastrophe. The pattern of comedy is catastrophe and redemption. So then you have a question which is, what's the ultimate pattern of tragedy and the ultimate pattern of redemption, if you got to the core? Well, a tragedy, tragedy occurs when someone, something terrible happens to someone undeserving.
- 11.31** So, to exemplify the pattern, you magnify the degree of undeserving and you turn up the heat under the suffering until you can't exceed it as a limit. So Jung knew this, Carl Jung knew this. He thought of the Passion as an archetypal story because you couldn't

push past it. It was a limit case. So that's why it's popularly known as the greatest story ever told. It's like, it's the limit case of stories.

- 11.32** OK, so what's the story? Well, you have, the story initiates with the divine infant. So there are Babylonian astronomers who study the configurations of the stars and who prognosticate that something new is about to emerge in the world. And they make their way to Bethlehem, and either are there for the birth, or search for the child later, because his birth is marked by the stars.
- 11.33** And so that's a reference to the conjunction of what's highest with what's proximal. And that's a representation, you could say, of birth itself, which is a miraculous occurrence marking the emergence, marking the emergence of something with redemptive possibility. And the person who sees that most clearly, God willing, is the mother, obviously.
- 11.34** So what happens to a mother who has her own child? She sees a baby for the first time. All the other ones, all the other babies, up till then, you could say they're generic. They're representations of presupposition and memory. At the birth, it's like, that's the burning bush. And so what does that catalyze? Well, with any luck, it catalyzes a relationship between the mother, who's now the bride of God, so to speak, and the child, so that the situation is optimized, so that the child develops, so that the world is redeemed. That's a good ambition for a mother, if she's not twisting it in a narcissistic manner.
- 11.35** Now, Mary has an inclination of what that means, and that keeps the narcissism under control, that's for sure. She knows she'll have to offer her child to be broken by the world, which is, I think, the female equivalent of the crucifixion. Because every mother's child dies. How? Well, in heroic combat with the forces of chaos and tyranny. There are worse fates.
- 11.36** So Christ's birth is marked by heavenly portents. And then it has the pattern of heroic birth that's common. Moses, when he's born, is threatened by the Pharaoh who has decided to kill all firstborns, if I remember; no, it's all Hebrew males under the age of two, three, something like that. Herod makes the same proclamation in Judea. And so, Christ is born threatened by the tyrannical state and in the lowliest possible place, amongst the animals.
- 11.37** Well, why? Because every person is born vulnerable, certainly under the thumb of tyranny to some degree or another in animal-like conditions and has to emerge from that. And so that's the pattern. That's the pattern of the birth of the hero. Out of nowhere comes what's great. It's Jesus of Nazareth, the most nondescript and out-of-the-way town in Judea. Right.
- 11.38** So, we know not much about his childhood or adolescence. A few scattered stories. One of him debating traditional knowledge with the elders of the church successfully, and then the baptism. What's the baptism? A return to the origin and a rebirth. Forty

days in the desert, temptation by Satan, which we discussed already, and then the beginnings of the ministry.

- 11.39** What do the ministries reveal? A pattern of miraculous healing. What's the narrative point? This is a man who, at minimum, is as good as anyone who has ever been. That's the story. As good across the board as anyone has ever been. That sets the stage for the story. Forgoes power; that's the temptation of Satan, the third one. Forgoes sacrificeless pleasure and wish, and serves the lowest, establishing a new conceptualization of sovereignty.
- 11.40** The shepherd keeps the wolves and the lions at bay and protects the innocent. Power, sovereignty, becomes not the ability to use compulsion and force to demand and require, but service—and not only service, sacrificial service to those most in need. As the principle of sovereignty itself, this is a complete inversion of the pagan order, the aristocratic order. It's not an aristocratic order, or it's an aristocratic order of a higher sort.
- 11.41** How do you identify the true leader? Because the true leader serves the most dispossessed. So, instead of power being the basis of authority and sovereignty, and power being the ability to compel and force in the service of personal whim, let's say, which is the aristocratic ethos, at least in part, especially when it's corrupt—and Rome, of course, was a nation of power—this is an entirely different principle of sovereignty.
- 11.42** Well, you can think about it as the principle of benevolent fatherhood. I mean, if you're a father and you have young children, then your authority is obviously portrayed most effectively by your willingness to engage in sacrificial service to your children. That's the father that you admire, who will do anything for his children. And so that's a valid marker of authority. But it's more than that because it's also a representation of the necessity for service, sacrificial service, to be at the foundation of community, by definition.
- 11.43** And so it's a clarification of the essence of the social itself. If you're married, what do you serve? Well, there's a husband and a wife. Does the husband serve the wife? Does the wife serve the husband? There's some of that. Do they each serve themselves? Well, if it's narrow self-serving, then heaven help the partner and God help the marriage. So the marriage itself is founded on—here's an indication.
- 11.44** I had a friend who was Swedish, a Swedish Canadian, and he happened to marry or become engaged to a woman who was a Swedish Canadian, and they went to Sweden to get married. And when they got married, the service, during the service, they had to hold a candle aloft between them. And the candle was a symbol of illumination, and the illuminated candle was a symbol of Christ, just like the candles that the Scandinavians put on the tree at Christmas during the darkest time to signify the rebirth not only of the sun, but of life and illumination itself.

- 11.45** Why did they hold the candle aloft? The candle was a representation of Christ. Why did they hold the candle aloft? Because they both served what it, if the marriage was to become appropriately sacred, which means deeply founded and profound, then both of them would enter sacrificial service to what was represented by the candle, which is the spirit of illumination.
- 11.46** How does the spirit of illumination make itself manifest in a marriage? Through dialogue. What's dialogue? "Dia logos." Right. Logos. So what's the logos that you're in service to if you're married profoundly? You tell your partner the truth. Why? Because the truth will set you free. Right, and so then both of the parties sacrifice towards the revelation of the truth that develops them both and binds them together. That's the sacrament of marriage. And it's exactly right.
- 11.47** OK, but there's more to it than that. Because the candle is illumination and it's logos, and that's communication, and that's the word that's there at the beginning of time that makes the order that's good from chaos and possibility. But lurking behind that candle, you might say, is the symbol of the crucifixion. Why?
- 11.48** Well, what do you think you're going to face together if you're married? What are you going to face? Death and hell. Right. And so how? Well, maybe badly, in which case, things will tilt pretty hard in the direction of hell, and often pretty hard in the direction of death. Successfully, well, who knows what you could manage, especially if you were religious in your adherence to that upward-striving aim and the mutual revelation of the truth, right?
- 11.49** So what does that do? That's this microcosm of society. Well, then that lays a platform, a foundation for children. And then they enter a world where there's no more confusion and chaos than there needs to be. And maybe a child can cope with that.
- 11.50** I mentioned to you, I think, earlier in this lecture series, that people don't generally develop post-traumatic stress disorder, which means they're physiologically damaged by stress; they don't usually develop that because they're hurt. Even if they're hurt a lot, they usually develop it because they've encountered something that wanted to hurt them. Right. So they encounter the, you could say, they encounter the spirit of the abyss. They encounter the spirit of hell that's aiming down, sometimes in their own actions and sometimes at the hands of someone else.
- 11.51** And so, it isn't obvious that we can cope with that, say, especially if it comes upon us unawares. But it is possible that we have within us the capability to take on the responsibilities and burdens of life, and life jointly, if we subordinate ourselves to the spirit of illumination and truth.
- 11.52** And of course that's what you'd hope for in a marriage, because a marriage is most fundamentally predicated on trust. And if you're lied to, that's why Dante put betrayers at the bottom of hell. Right. If you want your life turned upside down, that's the pathway to it. So you face the catastrophe of death and hell in sacrificial service to the

spirit of logos, illumination, redemption, and truth. That's good. That seems good. That seems right. That's what you'd want, if you had any sense at all. And I don't see a crack or a chink in that argument. I can't see how it cannot be true.

11.53 Marriage is very complex, partly because it's hard for two people who are different to unify. But it's also very complex because life itself is extremely difficult. And the hope is —this is the social hope. The social hope is that united we stand, divided we fall. And obviously, the foundation of the voluntary state has to be marriage because only two people are involved. You can't get a social state that's smaller than that. And so that lays the pattern and the foundation and the opportunity.

11.54 So how does the story go? Christ is archetypically good. He's the embodiment of the spirit of the prophets and the law. This is a very interesting idea. So the prophets, Elijah was a prophet. Let's talk about Elijah momentarily. Elijah—when Christ is transfigured on the mount, that's when his divinity is revealed. Two figures appear to the disciples along with him. Moses, of course, the law. Elijah. Well, who's Elijah? Turns out, Elijah was a very significant figure, psychologically, evolutionarily, I would say.

11.55 Elijah lived during the time of Ahab, who was arguably the weakest and the most corrupt king the Israelites ever had. The Israelites ended up with a king. They had a subsidiary state. They didn't need a king because everyone was taking responsibility, and there was nothing left for a king to do. But they got all jealous of all these people around them who had a king. And so they clamored to God for a king.

11.56 And God said, "You don't need a king and you don't want one." And the Israelites said, "We really want a king because everyone else has one." So they got a king. And some of their kings were good and some of them weren't. And so, better to take responsibility because then you don't need a king. And kings become tyrants. And so if you're sufficiently responsible, then you don't have a tyrant.

11.57 So, he's weak. Weak. He's Adam. You know, Adam kowtows to Eve's demand. That's Adam. Sad. And then he blames Eve. So that's resentful, man. And then he blames God. It's not good. That's Ahab. And Ahab is seduced by a foreign temptress. Now, sometimes in the Old Testament stories, a foreigner is good, like Jethro, Moses' father-in-law. When the state is corrupt, sometimes the foreigner is the only positive influence. But if the state is good, then a foreigner can be a corrupting influence. It depends on the context of the narrative, as you'd expect.

11.58 Ahab is seduced by Jezebel, and Jezebel is a foreign temptress, and she's a nature worshiper. And so what does it mean to worship nature? Well, the world is full of nature worshippers at the moment. The environmentalists are nature worshippers. They put a, literally put nature in the highest place. Jezebel is a nature worshiper. Her god is Baal, and Baal is a nature god. And she brings the prophets of Baal to Israel and displaces the worship of the one true God.

- 11.59** And really the only one standing up against that is Elijah, who remembers. And Elijah has a showdown with the prophets of Baal to see whose god is the real thing. And so, both Elijah and the prophets of Baal make altars at the foot of a mountain with a very large number of Israelites gathering for the battle. And they build a pyre for fire and they wait for their god to—and they offer a sacrifice, and they wait for the force of god to consume the sacrifice.
- 11.60** And so Elijah, as a show of faith, soaks the sacrificial pier with water. And the prophets of Baal pray, and Elijah prays, and the fire descends from heaven, and burns up the sodden wet pyre, and reduces the offering to ashes, and nothing happens on the side of the prophets of Baal. It's also the case, by the way, that during this time, because the Israelites have turned their attention away from the one true God to nature, that a drought occurs, which is also hard on the reputation of the prophets of Baal because they're supposed to be devotees of nature and its beneficence.
- 11.61** God consumes the sacrifice, and the prophets of Baal are humiliated, and the Israelites dispense with them. And Jezebel gets word of that, and she is not impressed. So she sends her men after Elijah, and he has to head for the hills and hide. And while he's hiding, he's in a cave and he sees a forest fire, an immense, impressive forest fire. And there were some forests in those days.
- 11.62** And he realizes that, as impressive as that is, as awe-inspiring as that is, that the essence of the divine is not to be found in the conflagrations of nature. And then he sees an earthquake. Same thing, awe-inspiring. Awe, awe is a very primordial emotion. You know, you get that tingle that goes along with awe, that's piloerection. That's a vestigial reflex that you see make itself manifest in cats that dance sideways when their hair puffs up when they see a dog.
- 11.63** So why does a cat do that? Because a cat with hair puffed up looks like a much bigger cat. And why does it dance sideways? Because a sideways cat is much bigger and more intimidating than a head-on cat. And you, and so what does the cat feel when it sees a large dog and its hair stands on it and it dances sideways? How about awe? And what's awe? How about a combination of negative and positive emotion that's overwhelming? Look the hell out and prepare.
- 11.64** That's that sensation we get when something moves us, right, and we're in the presence of something profound. And it's so interesting because it can be an abstract experience, one that's elicited by music, let's say. Or a profound emotion, which seems to be something associated with, literally, what's highest and most abstract. And yet the embodied emotion is so ancient that it developed when we still had bodily hair.
- 11.65** So, there's a reason that people substitute nature, let's say, for the one true God. Well, why? Well, because nature is awe-inspiring. And awe is a pointer to what's beyond us. We can be in awe of someone's character. And that's also an impetus to imitate and to

admire, which is also an impetus to imitate, to admire someone, to focus your attention on, to watch them, to want to be like them.

- 11.66** Forest fire, earthquake, hurricane. He draws the same conclusion. Whatever is in the highest, the God that Elijah has a covenant with is outside of nature itself. So it's an investigation so deep into the structure of existence that it plunges through the natural world and time and space itself, looking for what's fundamental, eternal, outside of everything that changes, and not a part of the material world, but the spirit that gives rise to the material world itself.
- 11.67** That's the hypothesis. That's the unity of all the, the unity of all that's good is identical with the spirit that gives rise to the material order. That's the hypothesis, and that a relationship can be established with it. Well, some relationship is going to be established with it, one way or another. There's no escaping from that necessity.
- 11.68** Elijah realizes in his cave that the true voice of God is the still, small voice within. So Elijah is the person who identifies conscience with the divine. This is a massive—Socrates did the same thing, by the way. He identified his daemon. This was the source of the revelations to Socrates that made him the wisest man in Greece, the father of philosophy, and the man who went to his unjust death voluntarily. Same pattern.
- 11.69** That's Elijah. And for a reward, he's taken up bodily into heaven. And so Cardinal Newman, attempting to define God, used the argument from conscience. It's a good argument. It's a good argument. It's a very good argument. It's like, why would you carry within you something that calls you out on your misbehavior and that's beyond your control?
- 11.70** And you might say, "Well, I don't believe in conscience." And the right thing to say to someone who doesn't believe in conscience is, "You stay as far away from me as you possibly can." Because the very definition of psychopath is no conscience. So what is that exactly? This is a psychoanalytic question. The psychoanalysts after Nietzsche, Freud and Jung, they started to understand that—because Nietzsche had set the circumstances up.
- 11.71** Maybe we can be self-created. Maybe we can create our own values. Maybe we're that autonomous. And the psychoanalysts began to delve into the nature of human experience, and they discovered that we were under the control of forces within us that weren't us. Not precisely. Well, you can think about them as instincts, but instinct isn't a good term. And instinct isn't a drive. It's not a biological entity in the reductive sense. It's a personality.
- 11.72** A motivation is a personality. It's got a viewpoint. It's got aims. It's got arguments at hand. It's got purpose. It philosophizes. And you're a collection of those subpersonalities. And maybe they emerge into something approximating a unity.

- 11.73** And then what would that unity be? Well, that would be the unity of maturity if things go well. And what's the unity of maturity? Is it the willingness and ability to wield power? Is it the subjugation of all those who are around you to the hedonistic gratification of your own immediate whims? That's a two-year-old; that's not mature.
- 11.74** Here's what happens to Moses. So Moses leads the people. Moses is the archetypal leader, so he's always the leader. That's a good way of thinking about it. He's always the leader. He's the pattern of the leader. Near the end of the Exodus story, when the Israelites are on the border of the promised land, so he's done it all successfully, they run out of water, partly because they're whiny and bitter and resentful again. They run out of water.
- 11.75** And the people go to Moses and they tell him to communicate with God about how some water might come forth. And God tells Moses to invite the rocks to deliver water in a particular location. And so Moses goes there with Aaron and he takes his staff, which is his rod of authority, and he hits the rocks, and then he hits them again, and the water comes forth. Why? Because you can make things happen with power.
- 11.76** What happens? God comes to Moses and says, "I commanded you to invite with your words, and you used force." And now Moses does this, this is his temptation. He's a leader. This is his temptation. He kills an Egyptian who he sees tormenting one of his Hebrew brothers. That's why he has to leave Egypt to begin with. And now and then, as he's leading the Israelites through the desert, his punitive hand is pretty heavy.
- 11.77** And he's very much tempted to become the judge of all the Israelites and the new Pharaoh. And he avoids all that, but it's narrowgoing; and just at the point of his ultimate success, he relapses. And God says, "You're not fit to lead the Israelites to the promised land, and you will die before they get there." And so, then that sets up the stage, doesn't it? If it's not power—and the biologists, they're complicit in this because they talk about, and I did this for years, dominance hierarchies.
- 11.78** And I had a graduate student, Daniel Higgins, partner of mine, business partner of mine, very bright man. He said to me one time, he said, "Don't use dominance hierarchy." I go, "What the hell do you mean?" He said, "Well, first of all, that's a Marxist idea." I said, "Why do you think that?" "Because it presumes that the hierarchy is built on power, on compulsion and force." It's like, it's not. It's not even among chimpanzees. It's built on competence and reputation. Otherwise, it's a tyranny.
- 11.79** And a tyranny can be based on force and power and economic dominion and oppression, all of that. But that's the tyrant. That's not the wise king. Well, the wise king's hierarchy is built on generous competence. And so, voluntary generous competence, and that's a sacrificial, that's a sacrificial ethos in service of those whose true need is greatest. Is that not the proper hallmark of a good leader?
- 11.80** What would you offer as an alternative? Power or the willingness to serve themselves? Those are the alternatives. Or what, some kind of nihilistic chaos, or bread and circuses

for the masses? Those are the principles. Those are the alternative principles. Those are the things that vie for predominance in the absence of something that unites them.

- 11.81** So, back to the story. So, Christ is laid out as the best of possible men. And so, what's the cataclysmic tragedy? The worst of all possible fates. So then you multiply the dimensions of tragedy. So death, young death, torturous death. Torturous death designed by malevolent tyrants to be exemplary in its torture. So it was designed for that purpose. Brought about by your friends, your community, the religious authorities, and the tyrants. While you're young, when you're blameless, in front of your mother, in disgrace.
- 11.82** Right, so where do you go from there? Well, the answer is: there's nowhere to go from there. That limits it. It's the sum total of all horrors. So here's the kicker. So Christ tells his followers that, for them to be redeemed, he has to be lifted up like the serpent that Moses cast in the desert was lifted up. Now, you think about that. You think about, that's so—there's no accounting for that story.
- 11.83** So there's thousands of years that separate those incidents first. So that's a commentary on a story that's thousands of years old. That story, by that time, had spawned or developed in parallel with the entire conception of healing and learning symbolized in the serpent, the staff-serpent symbol. And so what's Christ doing by that strange insistence that his pattern of life is the same as the serpent whose power was such that if you gazed upon it, you'd be immune from poison? What could that—
- 11.84** First of all, you have to ask yourself, who the hell would say that? Not only because it's so oblique, it's such a leap. It's such a leap. I can't imagine anyone writing it. And I've never seen those things linked in the context of interpretation of exposure. That's the crucial issue. What's the crucial issue? You become immune to what you attend to. That's the crucial realization.
- 11.85** OK, poisonous serpent, that's pretty bad. That's a form of painful death. It's not the worst form of painful death. So you have a meta serpent. Again, same issue. To get to the bottom of malevolent suffering itself, to get to the bottom of malevolent suffering itself. So you have the substitution of the crucifix for the brazen serpent. It's a deepening of the notion of exposure. And then, and try to account for this. I don't know how to account for it. What was the consequence of that? It's so perverse. It's so unlikely.
- 11.86** You had this terrible symbol of disgraceful and painful death that now became the centerpiece of attention and the most sacred object. How the hell did that happen? It's incomprehensible in its inversion. A Roman emperor was glorified and raised up in terms of dominions of earthly power, and obviously a much more attractive figure in every possible way, for someone naive and ambitious. "I would love to be dominant like him."

- 11.87** That's completely different than the crucifix image. It couldn't be more different. They're 180 degrees inverted. But the crucifix image is associated with the brazen serpent. And so, this is what we've been acting out, even though we didn't know it. It's like, look at what is poisonous. Look at what is poisonous with eyes guided by faith in the ultimate. That's exactly it. Look at what's most poisonous with eyes and tongue guided by what's ultimately good, and be redeemed.
- 11.88** And so, did we believe that? Constantine, the Emperor Constantine's mother, established the first church, the Church of the Holy Sepulcher in Jerusalem, on the site of the crucifixion. So the story goes. And the community grew up around that, and that set the pattern for European civilization. Crucifix, church, or cathedral. Highest point in the town, the center of the community. Why? Because voluntary self-sacrifice is the center of the community, obviously.
- 11.89** And so what's the ultimate extension of that? Well, that's the story. The Passion story is the ultimate expression of the principle of voluntary self-sacrifice. So what happened during the Christian revolution? The principle of ultimate voluntary self-sacrifice in service of soul and community became the foundation of the state.
- 11.90** Well, good. End of the pagan world, right? And really, end of the world of tyrants. Not that that's been entirely—what would you say? That success has not yet been propagated everywhere. We could say that. But it's certainly the case 100% of Catholic or Protestant majority countries outside of Africa are thriving, abundant, peaceful, Western democracies. 100%. That's not fluke.
- 11.91** Why? Because there's something about it, to speak minimally, there's something about the revolution in conception, which is a deep revolution, deeper than Elijah's revolution, deeper than Abraham's revolution or Moses' revolution. There's something about it that, I think, seems to me to be necessarily correct. Now, what does that mean in the final analysis? Well, I think it does mean that the world of order that's good or very good is predicated on the spirit of ultimate voluntary self-sacrifice. That seems to be right.
- 11.92** This is what John says at the beginning of the gospel. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was God, and the Word was with God." And then John describes Christ as the embodiment of that logos, and as the embodiment of the spirit of the prophets and the law, the incarnation of the spirit of the prophets and the law. The funny thing is, you see, because a hero is the incarnation of the spirit of the prophets and the law. That's the definition of hero.
- 11.93** Why? Tradition and dynamic vision. That's the law and the prophetic voice, the prophetic vision. That's the perfect, that's the perfect union of factors to make a hero. That's how Horus rules with Osiris. That becomes the soul of the Pharaoh. That becomes the immortal soul of the Pharaoh, the conjunction of Osiris and Horus. That's

the Egyptian conceptualization. Tradition plus vision. Tradition plus vision and the willingness to speak the truth. Yeah, well, that's the redeeming force.

- 11.94** So, what is someone like when they fully embody that? Well, that's a limit case, right? So, well, then you're the person who can triumph over death and hell. It's very hard to get underneath that story. At least I can't see how to get underneath it, given this approach to understanding it.
- 11.95** When I wrote Maps of Meaning, I probably wrote every sentence 40 times. And the rule was, I'd write variants until I got the best variant, and then I'd quit if I couldn't write a variant that I could see was better. I did that with all the sentences, and many times.
- 11.96** I wanted to do that because I was dealing with the problem of malevolence. I wanted to understand what perverted the guards in the concentration camps in Auschwitz and the trustees and sadists who ran the gulags. I wanted to understand that personally. How does that happen? It's not someone else. How does that happen? What weakness of character allows that to occur? That's a very serious question.
- 11.97** How does evil flourish? What's its nature? How do you overcome it? I wanted to establish a rock-solid foundation to address the issue, but also to, not academically, although conceptually, but in a manner that pointed to a solution. Because the issue of evil is an issue that should be addressed; not only understood, acted on. And so the upshot of that was the story that I'm telling you. And part of the upshot of that is, that's up to you. Seriously, it's serious.
- 11.98** Now, that's a terrible load. It's the world that's placed on Atlas' shoulders. It's the cross that's placed on Christ's back. It's death and hell itself. Can you manage that? Well, you're sons and daughters of God, that's the story. And if you understand the story, then it's clear.
- 11.99** What happens when good people remain silent? Hell dominates. How many people does it take to stop that from happening? Maybe one. Will you be in a position where that's your obligation? You're already in that position.
- 11.100** And I don't know if it's the tyranny of your country or the tyranny of your community or the tyranny of your friends or your boss or your wife or some fragment of you that's got you in its jaws. You're already in that situation. And the question is, how do you get out of it without inviting more poisonous snakes forward? And it has to be; how could it be other than that you would have to face it? What would you come up with as an alternative to that?
- 11.101** You got where you were by not facing it. You can't transform anything without facing it. And how could you live? How can you live in the shadow of death and evil and assume that you can do that without facing it? How could that be? And then how could you expect that the best of you would be compelled, compelled to come forward, unless

the challenge was sufficient to require that? And how could—because nothing happens without necessity.

- 11.102** Why wouldn't the most difficult work bring the most glorious rewards? Everyone believes that, unless you take the path of the criminal or the conman, and believe that everything is accomplished by some form of sleight of hand or theft, to valorize suffering.
- 11.103** I went to Australia and I went to an Orthodox Christian monastery, cathedral? I don't remember. There's a triptych there, which is a panel of three paintings that tells a story. And in the center, I should have taken a picture of it, there was an image of Christ standing in front of the cross with a crowd, inviting. It was a very strange image. If you see something like that and you really see it, it's striking because it's so preposterous.
- 11.104** What an invitation that is. It's an invitation to what? Is it an invitation to develop the faith that enables you to voluntarily confront the worst? That would be the optimistic interpretation.
- 11.105** You remember, even in echoes of this, in the Lion King, when Simba is still an adolescent and pathetic, with his pathetic friends, hiding from his destiny, and he's shamed by the anima, shamed by Nala, and is confused, is cast into confusion and doubt, the shaman shows up to show the way with his staff, just like Moses. And he invites him, where? Up? No. Down. Right. Down. Down the rabbit hole, down into the chaos, down into the chaos, to the bottom of things.
- 11.106** What's at the bottom of things? What's the story? The promise of eternal life. What does that mean? We don't know. We don't know. Things bottom out in a place that's beyond our comprehension. Everything we know taken far enough becomes shrouded in an impenetrable mystery. And beyond that impenetrable mystery, that's God. That's a definition.
- 11.107** And so, do we draw final conclusions? Well, I was forced in the course of what I learned to draw the conclusions that I presented to you in the course of this lecture series by logical necessity. Everything that I aggregated pointed in the same direction. There was no escaping that. And then I took all the things that I was thinking about and I tried to break them. Is there a way this could be wrong? Or is there an argument that I can muster that will shake my presumption that this statement is foundation?
- 11.108** All those sentences, I dispensed with. And what I was left with was what I told you in this journey of a dozen hours. Things I could not doubt. They seemed, by necessity, to be true. It's a completely different way of looking at the world, to look at the world as a place of chaos and order. Is that real?
- 11.109** Well, we talked about the hemispheric specialization. That's a tough one to ignore. And it's certainly the case that the man who developed the most sophisticated theory of

hemispheric specialization was Elkhonon Goldberg, who was the student of the greatest Russian neuropsychologist who ever lived, and the inheritor of a tradition that stemmed from psychophysicologists who discovered the instinct that responded to anomaly. Those were influential people. That's rock-solid, as far as I can tell. It's the best neuroscience, hands down. So there's no escape down that rabbit hole.

- 11.110** Do you have to face things that you'd rather avoid? Well, all of the largest collection of research on psychological transformation, done in the most scientifically valid manner by the behaviorists, demonstrates that a little of the poison that kills you, fortifies you. And they discovered this, you see, they discovered this.
- 11.111** The initial hypothesis of the behaviors was that you learned to be afraid by having something neutral paired with something terrifying. And that if you were exposed to that thing multiple times in the absence of the pairing, you would habituate to it and no longer be afraid. That was the theory. So what the behaviorists did was they took people and exposed them to the thing they were afraid of, while they had them relax. So they'd teach them to relax, breathing exercises, and then they'd put them in the frightening situation, and they'd relax.
- 11.112** And they would pair the relaxation with the stimulus—there's no such thing as a stimulus, by the way—with the stimulus. And then they got better, thus demonstrating the validity of the behavioral theory. Except you didn't have to teach people to relax. So someone who I can't remember figured that out. All you had to do was get people to expose themselves to the feared object, but not accidentally. If they accidentally exposed themselves to the feared object, then they got worse. They had to do it voluntarily.
- 11.113** So what did they learn? They learned the lesson of the pharmon—again, 4,000 years after it was established. If you look at what poisons you, you become resilient. This is the other thing the behavior therapists learned that was odd. See, the psychoanalysts believed that the root of these neurotic fears was deeper than the mere stimulus; and that if you treated a client with exposure, they would learn to— the fear of that stimulus would decrease, but the underlying fear would crop up somewhere else.
- 11.114** That didn't happen. So the behaviorists thought the psychoanalysts were wrong. But then the psychoanalysts noted that the targets of exposure didn't exactly become less afraid. They became braver. That's not the same thing. And that generalized. And that was the evidence, that they actually became braver.
- 11.115** If you're just relaxing because you're afraid of something and you've learned that that thing isn't frightening, some other thing that's frightening you will still be frightening. But if what you learn through exposure is that you're the sort of person who can voluntarily gaze on the abyss and prevail, then the next element of the abyss that comes along doesn't really matter.

- 11.116** One of the things the behaviorists noted that was somewhat upsetting was that many of the people who went through exposure therapy for agoraphobia, which is primarily a female disorder, started to fight with their husband and often ended up in some marital strife. Why? Because they got brave enough to say what they wanted to say.
- 11.117** Before that, they were so dependent on their husband to defend themselves from the terrible world that they wouldn't make their own needs, wants, and opinions known. They wouldn't rock the boat. Once they discovered that, what, the world wasn't frightening? No, not at all. That they were much more—there was much more to them than they had ever imagined. Then they had the courage to start taking on other challenges. And so it's a generalizable skill.
- 11.118** And so, is that rock-solid? It's the basis of psychotherapeutic transformation. Is there any difference between that and redemption from the religious perspective? It's a matter of terminology and depth. That's all. It's the same thing. And why wouldn't it be? How could it be that the pattern of healing wouldn't be permanent, right? Wouldn't be always there? What, we've learned something radically new about how human beings put themselves together? No, I don't think so. We've learned something that shakes, that has established a whole new mode of transformative learning? No, definitely not.

Lecture 12: Faith in the Future

At a glance — Faith in the future, closing with Mary's suffering alongside Christ.

- 12.1** Well, Mary suffers along with Christ. And that's part of the story that's very much worth attending to. If you're going to subject someone to the ultimate in torture, what do you do? You threaten their child. That's why Christ is a son of God, like Isaac, a child, because there's nothing more painful to sacrifice than a child. And that's what Mary is called upon to do. And what's the archetypal structure of that?
- 12.2** So, here's a reason not to have children. And it's a reason that people often turn to. Who would be cruel enough to bring a child into a world like this? Right. Well, what's that? A statement of benevolence? What is that exactly? What is that exactly, that statement? Is that a statement that's done in service of the unborn? I don't think so. It's a statement that redounds of cowardice and resentment and faithlessness in the future.
- 12.3** When Moses is on the border of the promised land, he sends a representative from each tribe to their target destination, Canaan. Now, Canaan is, by narrative tradition, the place of the unworthy. That's the way to understand it. It's the place in the future that's inhabited by people who are not conducting themselves in the proper manner. OK, so the elect have the opportunity to properly inhabit that future. Canaan is the place that's inhabited by the unworthy. That's a good way of thinking about it.
- 12.4** Moses sends the scouts to Canaan to see what's up. And they come back, and ten of them say, "The future is an apocalyptic catastrophe, and all hope is lost. The land we're moving to is inhabited by giants who will destroy us and forces that are beyond our control." They do not enter the promised land. Twoscouts report alternatively, Caleb and Joshua. Yeshua, right? That's a narrative precursor. That's the same name as Christ, and there's a reason for that.
- 12.5** Caleb and Joshua say, "The future is a challenge, but if we aim up and maintain the covenant, then there's no desert we can't make bloom." When Moses and Aaron die before entering the promised land, Caleb and Joshua lead the Israelites into the promised land. What's the moral of the story? You are required to maintain faith in the future. Right. Choose life.
- 12.6** And you say, well, given all its horrors, this woman with a starving child, let's take the alternative route. I talked to an anti-natalist philosopher who believed that the structure of being is such that suffering is so overwhelming that it would be best to endeavor to erase consciousness itself. That's the ethos of Mephistopheles in Goethe's Faust. The world is constituted such that suffering is unbearable. It's ethical to work for the annihilation of all experience.

- 12.7** OK, fair enough. That's your compassion. No more suffering beings. OK, what happens when you walk down that road? What do you mean, no more suffering beings? What about the ones that exist now? What are you planning to do with them? Where does that pathway lead once you lose faith in the essence of being itself? Where does that pathway lead?
- 12.8** Does it lead uphill to a Buddhist nirvana where there's no desire and no pain because there's nothing at all? Or does it lead to an absolutely catastrophic quasi-utopian hell? And that seems to be the case to me, is that you have a stark choice. You're either duty-bound to commit faithfully to the essential goodness of man and God, or you follow the pathway to cataclysmic perdition. And so that's worth—
- 12.9** Because what should you do when you lose faith in existence itself? How would you not work towards its eradication? And once you start working towards its eradication, how about no more babies? OK, what do you mean? Exactly what do you mean by that? Exactly. How does that work out in detail? What do you do? You demoralize women? Is that the next part of the plan? So that they're so terrified of the future that they don't dare to have a child because that would be immoral?
- 12.10** And once you do that, once you're deciding that the right pathway forward is to demoralize people, or maybe demoralize young men, which is happening in spades, maybe you demoralize young men, well, so what? You're working against the expression of their desire to make the order that's good and to thrive. And so now you're starting to work against what thrives. OK, well, how do you most effectively work against what thrives? Well, how far do you have to go down that pathway before everything you do is malevolent? Not very.
- 12.11** So, what's Mary's destiny? She knows from the beginning that her child will be broken cruelly by the world. And she says yes, anyway. And you think, well, how cruel. It's like, not compared to the alternative. In St. Peter's, which is maybe the greatest building ever built, it's something spectacular beyond compare, the Pietà sits. Michelangelo sculpted that when, I think he was 24. I don't know what you were doing when you were 24, but that's what he was doing.
- 12.12** And it has a place of honor. And I think it has a place of honor because it is, in a sense, the female equivalent of the crucifixion. I don't mean that women don't partake in the process that necessitates an encounter with death and with malevolence. Because Christ is viewed as a universal redeemer, regardless of sex, and that's correct. But there are still variations that are relevant to the sexes. And this is the female variation, I believe.
- 12.13** Because Mary's suffering is the suffering that a mother will have, certainly, when she has a child. And so, and she bears that with faith and dignity and encourages her son to be the handler of serpents. And that's the cure, right? It's not the eradication of the serpents. It's not the provision of a sterile security. It's the fostering of a courageous

ethos that can handle all things. And that's the medication. That's the medication for all things.

- 12.14** Down into the pit. This is what happens when Christ is crucified, right? Three days before the resurrection. What happens during the three days? Just like Jonah, descent into the abyss, harrowing of hell. What does that imply? The full confrontation with life is death and suffering, undertaken voluntarily, plus an encounter with the abyss itself. That's this, what, the spirit of malevolence, the essence of the underworld? Definitely true. Definitely true.
- 12.15** You know that as soon as you're not naive. If you're naive, you think there's nothing more terrifying than death. If you understand how the world works, you know that there are things far worse than death. And you know that you're called upon even more profoundly to master that than you are to master your fear of death; and that that is how the world is sorted out, not least because then you can see malevolence when it makes itself manifest. Instead of turning into Osiris and casting a blind eye and dooming everything to perdition, like Jonah did when he ignored his conscience.
- 12.16** Down the rabbit hole, all the way to the bottom, and then the new world. Well, and the new world is the worship of the process that makes that transformation possible. So there's no stable state. There's the elevation of the act of gazing upon the brazen serpent with faith and courage as the highest of all possible psychological states, permanently.
- 12.17** And then the resurrection. The resurrection. Well, that's a mystery that's unsolvable. What does it mean at minimum? Well, you could say, with no fear of contradiction, that the risen Christ destroyed Rome. Right. That's true. Now, what does that mean? Who knows? We don't know what any of this means at the bottom. That's for sure. But we know that's true, and that's not nothing. Demolished the pagan world, established the foundation for the freest, most abundant societies that ever existed by a large margin.
- 12.18** So what do you make of that? Well, biologically, what do you make of it? Biologically, it's like Elijah. Elijah, Moses, they're revolutions in cognitive conception. Humans evolved with cognitive transformation. That's what makes us unique. Biological evolution, yes, but conceptual revolution, equivalent to biological mutation in its power.
- 12.19** What's a conceptual revolution? The establishment of the law, certainly. The realization that the divine is equivalent to the voice of conscience; that's a discovery. The revelation that voluntary confrontation with what poisons, cures, and that that's the foundation of the world. Those are revolutions at minimum, and you can think about that.
- 12.20** I took Bret Weinstein along with me on tour a while back. Bret Weinstein is a very good evolutionary biologist, and I ran these ideas by him over days to see what he made of

them as an evolutionary biologist and what he made of them. And this has taken years, because I've been talking to him for a long time, was that this conclusion is inevitable. There's too many converging points of evidence. It has to be the case.

- 12.21** Now, I'm not claiming to know what that means, as I said, not in the final analysis. I can show you how it's represented. That's partly how it represents, it's represented. Triumph over death. What does triumph over death mean? That's a tough one. What does life eternal mean, or do you even want it? No. Eternity is a very long time. A life in the pattern of eternity. That's the Abrahamic life.
- 12.22** That's life conducted in the best possible manner, leaving the best possible, leaving the best possible consequences for those who come after you; is to triumph over death, to triumph over the fear of death? Is it to triumph over the cataclysmic effect of the fear of mortality on life itself? Is it a triumph that allows you to be an exemplar in the face of challenge?
- 12.23** These are hard questions, and I don't know the answer to them. I don't know what these things mean in the final analysis, but I know that what I know points to the fact that they mean something fundamental and that the deeper I've investigated the stories, the more they reveal. And so that's been inevitably the case and continually the case. I never get to the bottom.
- 12.24** That brazen serpent story, when I finally understood that, understood that it represented learning itself and the pattern of health and the process of progress through sacrificial exposure, and that that was associated with Christ's statements about his own crucifixion, that just knocked me over, I thought. Unbelievable. Who could invent that? Who could invent that? Who could write that? Very difficult to understand. Another representation, right? That's the illumination in the face of descent into death and hell.
- 12.25** I recently spoke to Douglas Murray. Douglas Murray, like Ayaan Hirsi Ali, was an acolyte of the four atheist horsemen— Dawkins, Hitchens, Harris, Dennett. Ayaan has converted to Christianity. Douglas has spent a substantial amount of time in zones of atrocity. And both of them have come to the realization that there's more to the story than meets the eye, dispensed with that reductive materialist atheism in favor of something far more foundational.
- 12.26** And what's that? A new dawn of understanding. For a very long time, we acted things out that we didn't understand. And then we woke up and realized we didn't understand them, and then we doubted them. But the time has come for their understanding and their repositioning at the center of things, or else.
- 12.27** There's a Buddhist representation. I like that a lot. See, that's a portal into the sky. And that's a bodhisattva, an incarnation of Buddha, you could say, who echoes through eternity. So that portal that opens up in the sky, that's a glimpse, a psychedelic glimpse, of the place beyond time where the archetypes themselves reside in eternity. That's a

way of thinking about it. The Platonic forms of being, and that illuminated mode of being.

- 12.28** See, Buddha, underneath his feet is the masses of people who are using his enlightened example as a pointer to the sky. And underneath that is an image of, I don't know if it's Kali herself or a goddess like her, and that you see the story. It's the catastrophe of life, the society on top of that, and then the illuminating spirit on which the society depends. And that's a sacred image, and rightly so. And then these divine figures around the Buddha, with him as the center of the cluster of what constitutes the admirable itself.
- 12.29** OK, we're going to close with this. There's a number of images like this. They're strange images. So let's look at this one, first of all. So what we see here is, we see the tree. It's the amalgamation of the trees in the story of Genesis. There's a tree of life and there's the tree of knowledge, of good and evil. Different dynamic forms, you could say. They're amalgamated here.
- 12.30** And Christ is, you could say, is crucified on the tree of life. And that's perfectly understandable. It's perfectly simple to understand what that means. The cross is made of wood. The cross is a tree. Life is death and malevolence. To be crucified on the tree of life, that's the situation of human beings. You have the serpent at the bottom, tempting Eve, who is delivering the poisoned fruit to humanity. Christ, in this representation, is also the fruit of the tree of life.
- 12.31** OK, so you have a perverse fruit, and that's the apple that Eve accepts from the spirit of usurping Luciferian malevolence to use as antithetical nourishment. But you have the tree that, in response, produces a new fruit, which appears poisonous, unlike the fruit that Eve was offered, which appeared perfect. She saw the fruit, that it was good to eat. This is not a fruit that appears good to eat. Do we eat it? That's what the Mass does. The Host is the antidote to the poisoned apple.
- 12.32** So what does that mean? We know what it means. In this image, this is how images are so powerful; all of this is in this image. You see the serpent at the bottom, but Christ hung on the tree is the brazen serpent transformed. So, in a perverse way, the tree of life has produced a fruit that's even more bitter than the one that was offered by Eve, offered to Eve by the serpent. But paradoxically, it's the fruit that is the antidote to the catastrophe of narcissistic pride and the fall.
- 12.33** What does that mean? It means that voluntary self-sacrifice in service of the highest goals is the proper orienting principle of the cosmos. The natural order of the social order of the psychological order, period. Which is why John insists that it was the Word that was incarnated that's there at the beginning of time. What does that mean? The beginning. It's the beginning. It's not the beginning of time. It's the beginning. What should the beginning be? What should the beginning be?

- 12.34** Well, in that marriage ceremony that I described, with the candle aloft, what was the beginning? The willingness to subordinate the participants in the ceremony to the spirit of the logos. Why? To make the order that was good or very good. That's what has to be there at the beginning. What could I do in this endeavor if I put all I had into it? If I offered everything? What could you produce?
- 12.35** God tells Cain, when he's bitter and resentful, that if he did well, he'd be accepted. What does it mean to do well? Well, when God casts Adam and Eve out of paradise, he puts an angel to bar the way who's accompanied by a cherub, a monstrous angel, who's accompanied by a flaming sword that turns every which way. Well, what's a flaming sword? Well, it cuts and it burns. It cuts away everything. It burns away everything. And there's no escaping it. Why? Well, because only what's perfect can enter the kingdom of heaven, obviously, because it wouldn't be heaven.
- 12.36** What does it mean to offer your best? It means to sacrifice everything unworthy, so that the heavenly city can be established. If you did that, would you be accepted? That's the promise that God makes to Cain, the bitter, resentful, malevolent, murderous father of genocidal villains. That's a hard one to dispense with. "Be ye therefore perfect, as your Father in heaven is perfect." That's what that means. Through the shadow of death and hell, into the light of the resurrection. Rough.
- 12.37** Now, this image transforms. You see here again that, more clearly in this image, that the tree of life has two fruits. There's the fruit that Eve takes, and then there's Christ as the fruit of the tree. What does that mean? What's the fruit of the tree of life? A conceptualization. How about that? How about that?
- 12.38** There's a direct concordance between what we ingest and incorporate and understand. Why? We act on our understanding. We exchange understanding. Why do we exchange understanding? So that we can remain fed. What is understanding? It's the food that produces food. Understanding is a meta food. The most miraculous understanding is the manna that God delivers from heaven.
- 12.39** Christ multiplies the loaves and the fishes because the pattern of voluntary self-sacrifice instantiated produces the polity that's abundant. Right. Man does not live by bread alone. Why? Because there are forms of food that are more effective than bread. Right. What's the most effective form of food? The trust that enables the construction of a society that works towards abundance forever. Well, that's a tough one to put a crowbar under and lift up to, and we know this.
- 12.40** High-trust societies are abundant. The end. Right. A little more elaboration. Here you see the idea more fully fleshed out. Eve on the left. And I think this is the church as mother on the image left. So you see Eve naked, vulnerable, delivering the fruit of the tree, which is skulls. So it's the death that's part of the fall. But on the opposite side, you see the feminine, so that's the negative and the positive feminine, the feminine providing the food that eternally nourishes.

- 12.41** And on the tree, you see a cross in the middle. And then there's other fruits, and those fruits are the Host that's used in the Mass as the antidote to the poison, the poisoned fruit. Why? So Christ is the incorporation, the embodiment, the incarnation, of the spirit of the law and the prophets. And the mass is a ceremony that concretizes or dramatizes the pattern of the incorporation of that pattern, as the antidote to the poison of pride that produces the poison of pride and bitterness, the desire to usurp, all of that Luciferian hell.
- 12.42** It's the antidote to that, and these images portray that. See, when I mentioned earlier, much earlier in the lecture series, that first we act things out and then we represent them in image and then we derive some understanding, these are examples of that. The entire biblical narrative is in that image. You could elaborate on it indefinitely.
- 12.43** How did it get there? That's a question. How does wisdom make itself manifest? How does unknown wisdom make itself manifest in dreams? How can a dream reveal to you something you don't know? Because the dream is the image of the world. And the world has far more in it than you understand. If you dream of the interactions between people, if you extract out the pattern of the interactions between people, there's no reason whatsoever to assume that you could verbalize that understanding.
- 12.44** No more than a child who's acting out being a father when playing house can describe what he's doing philosophically. He acts it out. There's an image. There's the image of the father that he's representing in his behavior. But the knowledge is procedural, it's active, and then it's imagistic. And only later is it translatable into words. And maybe that takes forever, forever, thousands of years, but that's what that image represents.
- 12.45** And you see, if you understand that the Host, the wheat that is planted and then grows and is harvested after the chaff is separated from it, if you understand that that is a representation of the willingness to take on the form of the spirit that will confront death and malevolence voluntarily, you understand the image.
- 12.46** And now people were acting that out, obviously. That's what the Mass does. It acts that out in a most concrete way, in a cannibalistic way. You become what you eat. God, that's an old idea. It's an old idea. But it has this unbelievably profound substrata that motivates the play.
- 12.47** And then we'll close with this. That's the best indication of this that I've seen. So you see Eve on the left-hand side of the image this time, distributing the poisoned fruit that's death itself. That's the skull. That's part of what the tree of life makes manifest as its fruit.
- 12.48** And then you see the redeeming feminine on the alternative side, passing out the Host. That's a representation of the willingness to die and confront hell in faith as the antidote to the fall itself. That's Western, that's Judeo-Christian civilization in one image. And that's the potential of the psyche. You can master what you confront. There's no promise better than that.

- 12.49** And you know it's true. You know it's true because your soul itself tells you when you encounter someone you admire, because if you're not perverse and you encounter someone who's worthy of admiration and you're wise enough to see it, you see someone who's confronted the worst, voluntarily, and prevailed. Your own instinct for imitation, which is the imitation of Christ, let's say in the Mass, is the grip of your attention by the admiration for that pattern.
- 12.50** And so, instinct and the highest calling dovetail. The instinct for development itself that moves a child up the ladder as they imitate tells exactly the same story. So the deepest impulse of the biological and the highest calling of the divine are the same thing. That's how you feel good about yourself. That's how you become a blessing to yourself now, isn't it?
- 12.51** When you know, even in your memory, that something overwhelming made itself manifest in front of you, and you dealt with it nobly and with courage. And that's a memory that will get you through many a dark night and a hope for your future conduct, and a pattern that you would like to leave your children if you love them, and the pattern that, if your children imitated, would propagate them endlessly.
- 12.52** That's why Abraham is the father of nations. Right. And what does that imply? Raise your children properly and transform the world. And God only knows how long that might take. But maybe you wouldn't love them as much as you do if the best part of you didn't see their great value.
- 12.53** So I used to encourage my students in Maps of Meaning, my students, period, like, bring your objections to the fore. If there's anything that leaves a shadow of doubt in your critical imagination, lay it out.
- 12.54** I told you what I did with these ideas. I attacked them from 25 different angles, trying to knock them over; and anything that would fall, I dispensed with. And I haven't stopped doing that for 40 years. And so this is the wheat that remains when the chaff has been dispersed. Right. So, did it make sense? Isn't that terrifying?
- 12.55** You encouraged us to start this journey, this map, with humility. Then you warned against prideful usurping intellect. Then we did see that, as you mapped things out with different figures. And then the last major figure you talked about was Moses, who didn't enter the promised land because of his, maybe it was his prideful usurping intellect. So my question is what—
- 12.56** It was because he defied a direct—see, he defied a developmental order because there is a scene in the Exodus narrative where Moses rightfully strikes a rock with his staff to have water bring forth. But at that point in his journey, he's supposed to be using his words, and not a show of force. That's really what that means. And so he's violated the spirit of the endeavor at a crucial point. That's a good way of thinking about it.

- 12.57** And I guess that's part of—there's a problem, as you progress, which is that your field of opportunity expands as you progress, but the responsibility that you have to conduct yourself appropriately expands in the same manner. And so, there's more on the upside, but there's a sharper cliff on the downside. You can think about that as a form of appropriate justice, is that, from those who have much, much will be required. Yes, exactly that.
- 12.58** That's how you atone, in a sense, for your abundance. You've been given much. Act appropriately or suffer the consequences. This is the right attitude towards the intellect. It's a gift, a talent. It's something that should be used in service. It's not something to take pride in and elevate and then to worship. It's a cataclysm. And that's a good example of how the best of all things can be the worst things when they go wrong, which is what you'd expect, right, of the most powerful things.
- 12.59** And the humility is always something like, you could think of humility as the search for a better path forward, right? This is why the fool in fairy tales, the foolish brother, the foolish younger brother, is always the one that triumphs over the arrogant older brothers, who are admired by their peers and the social world, whereas the fool is dispensed with. And he goes to the forest in The Water of Life, for example. The fool goes to the forest.
- 12.60** The older brother goes to the forest to look for the water of life, and he doesn't know where he's going because who knows where the water of life is? But the older brother is full of confidence, and a dwarf shows up, a magical dwarf, and asks him for a favor and suggests to him that he might be able to provide guidance. But the older brother is too arrogant to take advice from a dwarf, and so doesn't get the message.
- 12.61** And what's a dwarf? Well, we know in some ways a dwarf is an ordinary, competent, hardworking man, something like that. And so the arrogant usurper, the arrogant intellect, doesn't attend to the voice that would orient him, because he won't admit to his ignorance. He's off to find the water of life to save his father, the king, who's dying because of its lack. That's The Water of Life structure.
- 12.62** The dwarf appears. He's a magical figure of transformation. We know about these things now. And he offers his advice, but the arrogant son is too prideful to admit to his ignorance. He doesn't know where to look. Well, the fool goes out and he stumbles across the dwarf, and he knows he doesn't know anything or where he's going. And the dwarf not only tells him where to find the water of life, but arms him with the implements necessary to undertake the task.
- 12.63** Right. Well, that's perfect. It's great fairy tale, The Water of Life. I wrote a screenplay about the water of life. That's a musical that I hope to do something with at some point because it's a great fairy tale. And that's one of its sub-themes, the holy fool. Well, who's the fool? The person who doesn't know.

12.64 That's Socrates. Socrates proclaimed that the Delphic oracle noted his wisdom in consequence of the fact that he was firmly aware of his own ignorance. Well, that's a great thing to know, because if you're lost, you could think of your ignorance as an infinite wellspring of possibility. How much don't you know? A lot. That gives you a lot of places to look. Right, so it opens the door. And it's really useful to think of humility not as that kind of cringing milksop apologetics for even existing, but as the antithesis of the pride that makes you a tyrant.

12.65 It's like, maybe I could find something. Maybe there's a place that I haven't looked. Right. That's what you'd pray. There's a prayer. "Help me find a place I haven't looked." That's a prayer that will be answered. There are prayers that will be answered; and prayers to discover the breadth of your own ignorance, that's a prayer that will be answered.